

USING COLLABORATION AND TECHNOLOGY TO ENHANCE VIETNAMESE STUDENTS' ENGLISH LANGUAGE WRITING SKILLS

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Abstract

This study was contextualised in a tertiary second language (L2) class in Vietnam. The study utilised action research methodology to investigate participants' expectations of and reflections on using collaboration and technology to enhance students' English language writing skills. It also focused on specific writing stages through face-to-face and wiki collaboration to engage students' participation in L2 activities through a writing project. The thesis is theoretically grounded by socio-cultural perspectives which argue that collaborative learning using wikis can lead to an enhancement in L2 writing skills. In this study, the enhancement was observed through participants' understanding of the cognitive process-genre of each stage of writing.

The findings show that the influence of traditional pedagogy was still observed: students encountered difficulties in collaboration due to lack of skills for negotiating and generating content of writing in face-to-face meetings. In wiki collaboration, although comments on global areas of writing including content and organisation were more frequent than comments on local areas (including grammar structures, vocabulary, spelling and punctuation), comments on local areas were more likely to be acted upon. In addition, students preferred individual writing, teachers' comments, and summative feedback to collaborative writing, peers' comments and formative feedback.

Despite these difficulties, participants reflected positively on the writing project. It was reported that L2 collaborative writing using wikis challenges traditional writing pedagogy in four important aspects. First, it facilitated shared knowledge and skills

among teachers, students and peers around global areas and local areas of writing. Accordingly, students were allowed more authority in their learning: teachers were not the only authority in class. Second, it highlighted the importance of including formative comments in addition to the teacher's summative assessment, because formative comments provided teachers and students with a way to discuss what students needed to do to improve their writing. Third, collaborative writing through wikis facilitated platforms for an inclusion of process writing, which considers more about *how* students develop their writing rather than *what* students write. Forth, collaborative writing using wikis established the link between writers and readers, and offered the potential of opening up the readership in L2 writing class to wider audiences outside the classroom.

The dominance of teacher-centred pedagogy, summative assessment and students' unfamiliarity with collaborative and process writing was observed in the class. This fell short of the requirements of the Vietnamese educational policies for teaching and learning L2 for communicative purposes.

The study contributes practical knowledge about the affordances and constraints of collaborative writing using wikis. It also suggests practices to L2 writing practitioners who might consider implementing collaborative writing in a traditional so-called Confucian heritage context such as Vietnam.

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Statement of Original Authorship

The work contained in this thesis has not been previously submitted to meet requirements for an award at this or any other higher education institution. To the best of my knowledge and belief, the thesis contains no material previously published or written by another person except where due reference is made.

QUT Verified Signature

Signature:

Date: 24/09/2015

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List of Abbreviations

CLT: Communicative language teaching

EFL: English as a foreign language

ELT: English language teaching

FGI: Focus group interview

ICT: Information communications technology

L1: First language

L2: Second language

MoET: Ministry of Education and Training

NAS: Needs Analysis Survey

RS: Reflection Survey

SSI: Semi-structured interview

ZPD: Zone of Proximal Development

Chapter 1: Introduction

This study investigated an innovative approach to writing in an L2 class in a Vietnamese university, deploying collaborative learning and technology. This chapter introduces the research problem in six sections. The first section provides the background of the study, depicting the researcher's personal experience of teaching English language writing to a class of English majors in a Vietnamese university, and articulating the rationale for researching new teaching approaches to enhance the quality of teaching and learning English in an L2 writing class. The second section describes the context of the University, and emphasising the necessity of applying new teaching approaches to improve the quality of teaching and learning English writing in the University. The third section introduces the central research questions. The fourth section highlights the purpose of the study. The fifth section describes the significance and scope of the study. The sixth section includes an outline of the remaining chapters. The chapter ends with a summary in Section 1.7.

1.1 BACKGROUND TO THE STUDY

This study asks: **what strategies using collaboration and technology could enhance students' L2 writing skills?** My interest in the topic resulted from my employment as a teacher of English at a Vietnamese university for over ten years. I taught non-English major students for four years before teaching English majors for the past six years. During these years, I taught the skills of English writing to the students majoring in English.

My pedagogical approach to the teaching of writing, prior to this study was guided by the University curriculum, and was divided into four main stages. In stage 1, I introduced the structures or genres of writing followed by examples or text models. For example, when teaching students how to write a descriptive paragraph, I told them what a descriptive paragraph was and then asked them to read some sample paragraphs. The second stage involved controlled practice, allowing students to imitate models. The third stage was peer assessment: during this stage, students had the chance to give oral feedback on other students' writing. The fourth stage, homework, was then assigned so that students could consolidate the structures that they had learnt.

Directed by summative examinations, which students sat twice per term, my goals in teaching the skills of L2 writing were to assist students to produce effective written texts in exams. Due to limited class contact time, I had little time to give students feedback on their learning performance. Asking peers to give oral feedback was what differentiated my pedagogy from the product-focused writing of other teachers. Although the time for me to facilitate peer feedback activities was limited, students reflected that they were more motivated when working with others: this could help them learn not only from me but also from their peers' strengths and weaknesses.

My students' preferences for learning together can be contextualised by the feature of constructed collectivism awareness, which is prominent in Vietnamese culture. Regarding this feature, Kramsch and Sullivan (1996) noted that Vietnamese students value cooperation through group work in class. They, like other Asian students, have a preference for working together in groups to achieve common goals (Littlewood, 2001). Kramsch and Sullivan (1996) also suggested that Vietnamese students

traditionally like working verbally and creatively through literature (see Sub-section 2.1.2). Students' preferences for working together were also attributed to the fact that in the large classes common in Asian universities, interactions between students and teachers were limited, which made it hard for students to receive formative comments from teachers on what they wrote.

My students, however, did not always seem satisfied with what they did in pairs or groups. My conversations with them demonstrated three reasons for their dissatisfaction. First, working together in class required such skills as clarifying each other's points and reaching a consensus from different points of view, which took most of the class time. In some cases, when students had fully understood the lesson content and started to know how to help one another, class time was over. They did not like their collaborative work totally unsupervised by the teacher either. This was perhaps because they believed, based on tradition, that teachers were the "fount of knowledge" (Littlewood, 2000, p. 3); therefore, they valued teachers' involvement in their peer work at the final draft so that they would know if their writing could be validated by an authority. Teachers' attention, meanwhile, could not focus on the work of all of the pairs or groups in such a short period of allocated class time. Third, they did not want to confine working together to only the third stage. They wanted to share learning experience with their peers from the first stage to the end of the writing processes. They enthusiastically stated that it would be very useful to know how their peers brainstormed, developed their ideas, or finalised their writing products.

I took my students' preferences for writing together into consideration when conceptualising this study. I assumed that joint-writing could assist students to help

each other, which might result in more effective learning in a context where teachers were typically considered the only resource of knowledge to students. The students' desire to share the *process* of writing was also taken into account. Overall, my students' preference for sharing learning with one another was the primary motivation to investigate the potential of collaborative writing for students' L2 learning.

I started my research by reviewing the literature on students working together in L2 writing classes. I first read Storch's studies on English as a second language writing classes (Storch, 2005, 2007). She found that although the quality of writing did not significantly improve in her research class, most students responded positively to having the chance to share their writing work with others. Another study by Watanabe and Swain (2007) also showed that differences in learners' proficiency did not detract from students' collaborative learning because both more proficient and developing students benefited from working together. The positive findings from these studies initially encouraged me to introduce collaborative writing into my own teaching context.

Although the ideas of the authors above closely linked to my students' preference for collaboration in the context of students' mixed levels of proficiency, I speculated that just deploying the face-to-face collaborative mode that the authors above used might not work well in my context. The first reason was the large number of students in the class, which made it difficult for teachers to assist students while they were collaborating. The second reason was the limited class contact time allocated for both teachers' lecturing and students' practice. This could hinder any pair or group work activity using face-to-face meetings only from being effective.

Thinking about another mode, in addition to face-to-face, for students to work together in order to meet their learning preferences led me to research online learning spaces. My choice of using virtual space, as well as physical space, for L2 learning was timely, since it was supported by Vietnamese education policies (1400/QD-TTG, 2008; MoET, 2014). In order to improve the quality of teaching and learning English in Vietnam, the national Ministry of Education and Training (MoET), has provided facilities and multimedia technology resources for L2 classrooms (see Section 2.4 for more information). The overarching research question that I posed was what strategies using collaboration and technology could enhance students' L2 writing skills?

Among many online applications, I chose wikis for my students to collaborate in addition to class time. My priority in choosing wikis was ease of use: wikis require few technical skills to set up and use (Ferriter, 2009). This is especially important in my context, where networked learning has not commonly been used, so accessibility and ease are crucial in student acceptance. Moreover, wikis are an effective platform for collaborative writing. The posts on wikis are easy to edit, update or remove (Lin & Yang, 2011). Third, wikis can act as tools to evaluate the process of developing L2 students' writing (Trentin, 2009). They can help teachers to identify how students contribute to group work. Equally important in my teaching context is the fact that wikis provide an autonomous and asynchronous environment for the students to learn outside the class (Alshumaimeri, 2011). As a result, "contact time" can be extended to encompass teachers' and students' convenience. My choice of wikis for L2 writing was also supported by literature on wiki learners' feedback. Studies have reported that wiki learning received positive evaluations from English as a foreign language

(EFL) students across tertiary teaching contexts including Brazil (Franco, 2008), Saudi Arabia (Alshumaimeri, 2011), Taiwan (Shu, 2012) and Vietnam (Nguyen, 2011).

In summary, there are two guiding principles behind my choice of a blended model of collaboration as the preferred learning approach for the teaching of writing in this study. It first came from my response to the students' group work and process learning preferences in my classes. As studies have shown, students' preferences should be taken into consideration when designing a project so that they can be more highly motivated (Brogan & Nguyen, 1999; Burns, 2010). More importantly, collaborative writing links to the development of students' L2 writing in contexts similar to mine have been evidenced in empirical L2 writing studies. Therefore, it was important to conduct a study on how the teachers and students in my University evaluate collaborative writing through face-to-face and wiki modes, and how these collaborative modes engaged students with L2 writing. The findings of my study will contribute practical knowledge of collaborative learning to practitioners including the current teachers of my Faculty, and the students who will become teachers of English after graduation, as well as to academic staff in other Vietnamese universities.

1.2 CONTEXT OF THE STUDY

This section describes the context of the study, focusing on the location, the L2 writing programme, teacher quality and learning resources, as well as the influence of traditional pedagogy on L2 pedagogy.

1.2.1 The University and Faculty

The University where this study was conducted is located in the North of Vietnam. The University has traditionally been a teacher training provider. To the present, there have been 10 majors for undergraduates: mathematics, literature, biology-agricultural technology, chemistry, history, political education, physical education, information technology, primary education, and foreign languages. The University's mission is to train teachers, scientists, and technicians at graduate and postgraduate levels. The University is also a centre for scientific research and technological transfer services to develop education, the economy and culture for the country and its international integration.

The Foreign Language Faculty was founded in 2005 when the University recruited the first English major class. Since then it has developed two programmes: English for non-major students and English for major students.

1.2.2 English study for non-English majors

English is taught as a compulsory subject for non-English majors, as across the whole higher education system in Vietnam (Hoang, 2007). The teachers for non-English major students were non-English majors themselves: they originally taught Russian during the period when the Russian political system influenced Vietnam. The rapid growth and expansion of English to take the place of Russian resulted in their retraining in a two-year course to become teachers of English. The transformation from teaching Russian to English created many difficulties for these staff, as Pham (2001) argued:

They [the teachers of Russian] started the training programme as beginners or false beginners in English. A few made fast progress in learning English

and have become confident with their new positions. The majority of them, however, despite their background in language teaching and learning, have reported that they have barely benefited from the two years of training in terms of English language skills and new teaching methodology. Many former teachers of Russian lack confidence and consider themselves not qualified to teach English. (p.2)

Therefore, although they have more experience of teaching than the English major teachers, they only teach the non-English major students. Younger and less experienced teachers are responsible for teaching the English majors.

According to the University's syllabus (2010), non-English majors have to undertake seven out of 50 credit hours in their second year for the "General English" and three credit hours in the first term of the third year for "English for Specific Purposes." The goals and objectives of teaching the subjects are to focus on four macroskills: reading, listening, speaking and writing. However, the reality is far from that rhetoric since "the traditional grammar-translation method has prevailed for a long time in ELT and the focus of English teaching in Vietnam has been on reading skills" (Kam, 2006, p. 13). This has an impact on the pedagogy of teachers, who were relatively new to teaching English themselves. For example, when teaching L2 writing, teachers would mainly focus on checking students' grammar through exams, at the expense of communicatively-oriented writing.

1.2.3 English study for English majors

English is also taught as a major. Most graduates will become teachers of English after graduating. In this sub-section, the goals and objectives of the English major

course, the students, the writing programme and technology-supported learning are described.

Goals and objectives of the English major course

The purposes of the courses for English majors are to “train teachers, translators, interpreters, or researchers in English language teaching or in linguistics” (Foreign Language Faculty, 2005). Each course lasts for four years. From its formation to the present, the Faculty has trained four Bachelor of English cohorts. Anecdotal evidence indicates that the majority of the graduates become teachers, while some are employed as translators.

National University Entrance Exam for English majors

The student who wants to pursue tertiary education in Vietnam must sit the university entrance exam taking place annually in late June and early July. Le (2011) noted that the National University Entrance Exam is organised in four Categories – A, B, C, and D – with different examinations based on the major the student has taken. Table 1.1 presents the categories and the examinations.

Table 1.1

University entrance examination categories

Categories	Examinations to be taken
A (Maths, Sciences, Technologies, Economics, Teacher Education, etc.)	Maths, Physics, Chemistry
B (Maths, Medical Education, Pharmacy, Biological Studies, Economics, Teacher Education, etc.)	Maths, Chemistry, Biology
C (Teacher Education, Journalism, Social Sciences, and Humanities, Literature, etc.)	Vietnamese Literature, History, Geography
D (Teacher Education, Economics, Laws,	Maths, Vietnamese Literature, Foreign

Social Sciences and Humanities, etc.)	Language (English, French, Chinese, Russian, or Japanese).
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Source: (Le, 2011)

As can be seen from the table, English is important to those who choose category D, which includes three examination subjects: Vietnamese Literature, Mathematics and English. The multiple choice test on English language consists of 80 items covering phonetics, grammar, vocabulary, and reading comprehension. The scores of the test are converted into a scale of 1– 10; thus if a student answered 8 out of a total of 80 items correctly, he/she would get 1 scaled mark.

In general, the entrance proficiency levels of the students who were selected to study at the University are varied. The table below describes the converted marks and the results of the students participating in this study.

Table 1.2

The second year students' entrance proficiency results

Correct items/ 80	24-30	32-38	40-46	48-54	56-62	64-80
Converted score/ scale 10	3-3.75	4-4.75	5-5.75	6-6.75	7-7.75	8-10
Number of students	6	8	9	6	1	0

Source: Students' entrance examination results compiled by the Foreign Languages Faculty (2011)

In order to improve students' learning performance, it was important that the variety of students' language proficiency levels be considered in the choice of pedagogy. This required that students gained knowledge and skills not only from teachers, who found it hard to provide feedback on students' learning in a large class, but also from peers.

Description of the English classes at the research University

At the University, the first English classes started in 2005 with 55 students. In 2007, the University administrators decided to reduce the number of students in each class to 30 so that the class size was not too large. Since then there have been two classes annually. While only one new teacher is recruited each year, the number of classes has doubled. Most of the experienced teachers coordinate two subjects, for example, one teacher teaches L2 reading and writing, while another teaches L2 speaking and phonetics.

With regard to students in English major classes, before they enter university, they learnt English at high school for at least seven years, and some students studied it for ten years. However, there is a mismatch between the goals and objectives set in the curriculum and the real practices of teaching and learning English in general and the teaching and learning of L2 writing in particular. As stated in the high school curriculum, L2 writing was one of the four major language skills, which students needed to study. However, in reality, the focus of ELT at high school in Vietnam is grammar and reading oriented. The real goals and objectives of teaching were around this orientation, and L2 writing was not a focus. Neither students nor teachers considered writing important (see Sub-section 2.1.2 for more detail).

The focus on mastering grammar did not help students write in L2 effectively, as grammar items were taught de-contextualised from communicative writing. For example, when students learnt about the passive voice, they might be asked to do exercises such as conjugating verbs from active into passive voice. Or they could be guided to write separate sentences using the passive voice. Students therefore found it difficult when they had to use what they learnt from separate and de-contextualised

sentences like these to construct extended written discourse. In addition, most of the topics included in the English textbooks in their high school were either uninteresting or unfamiliar to the students' existing vocabulary and cultural knowledge. For example, a topic like *the main feature of a desert* was reported to be less motivating to the students who live in a tropical climate (Hoang, Hoang, Dao, Vu, Do, & Nguyen, 2011). As a result, the teaching and learning of L2 writing at high school was not sufficient for students to have a sound basis for the study of writing in their tertiary majors.

Description of the English writing programme

The teaching of English as a major at the University includes both language skills and language knowledge. Students' language skill training is allocated in the syllabus from the first year of their major study with the focus on listening, speaking, reading, and writing. The training continues from semester 1 to semester 6. Each semester has 30 class hours for one skill. The information about the L2 writing programme can be seen in the table below.

Table 1.3

The English writing programme for English majors

	Year 1	Year 2	Year 3
Term 1	Writing 1 Punctuation and sentence types	Writing 3 Paragraph types + letters	Writing 5 Describing graphs + citation, quotation, summary
Term 2	Writing 2 Sentences in a paragraph	Writing 4 Essay	Writing 6 Introduction to writing graduation paper

When discussing students' level of proficiency, Le (2002) highlighted that because of students' low levels of proficiency, foreign language training in universities often has to prioritise the improvement of linguistic knowledge and language skills. According to the training syllabus of the Faculty, the focus was also on how to improve students' language skills of listening, speaking, reading and writing (Foreign Language Faculty, 2005). Four out of the allocated 20 class hours were for L2 writing. The writing programme considered learners as beginners regardless of the years they learnt L2 writing at high school. This was why it was designed to start with the very basic elements, for instance, punctuation, phrases or sentences taught as drills.

Nevertheless, the writing programme for English majors seems unfeasible in the current context of teaching and learning at the University. This is because of the application of credit learning and the influence of cultural factors on pedagogy. Before 2010, the semester-based system of learning was applied. In this system, the students were prescribed the subjects of learning every year, and no flexibility was allowed. Since 2010, the L2 writing programme in the University has implemented the 'credit' system "whereby students can complete their study at their own pace by fulfilling the required credits and have more freedom on course options" (Tran, 2011, p. 20). However, the results of some studies synthesised by Tran, Griffin, and Nguyen (2010) reflect the unwillingness of teachers, students and administrators to adopt the system. They emphasised that the transformation from yearly learning to credit learning was not fully realised in practice, and thus it did not improve the quality of education as expected.

Similarly, the implementation of credit learning has not been effective in the context of the research university. Although there has not been any published research conducted on how administrators and teachers have adapted to the change, it can be assumed that they have not found it easy to accommodate. One of the difficulties that teachers encounter is that class time has been cut while other curriculum elements, for example, learning outcomes and teaching methodology, have not changed accordingly. Additionally, physical learning spaces and learning facilities need upgrading to allow more flexible delivery of teaching and learning.

On the surface, the focus of learning has been designed to be on students' autonomous study, as can be shown in the Table 1.4, in the following page, an extract from the syllabus for the students of the second year.

Table 1.4

An extract from the writing syllabus for the second -year students

	Contents	Credit hours	Requirements
Teacher's lecture time		1.66	Students learn about the thesis statement of the opening paragraph
Students' practice in class time	Thesis statement and opening paragraph of an essay	0.33	Students' practice to identify and write the thesis statement
Students' self-study time		4	Read relating documents and practice writing thesis statement at home (at the minimum of 4 class hours)

The table demonstrates that the total time allocated for teachers' lecturing and students' practising in class (1.66+0.33 credit hours) is half of the time that students are required to self-study outside class (4 credit hours). This requires that students work autonomously outside class time. However, Vietnamese students are culturally rooted in traditional learning methods which support teacher-centred approach, a physical class space and a structured curriculum (Dudzik, 2010). On the one hand, teachers have not been able to provide learners with opportunities to negotiate in learning and choices to learn independently (Dang, 2010). On the other hand, lack of comprehensive changes in terms of the teaching content, teaching methods, infrastructure conditions and resources makes autonomous learning implementation difficult (Tran et al., 2010). In the case of the class under study, changes to more

learner-centred approach – including virtual space and giving students choices to negotiate in their learning – were expected to result in more effective learning.

Technology-supported learning, library resources and internet access

Each classroom in the University is equipped with one projector, and one computer. The Faculty also has a lab of 30 audio carrels for listening sessions. Other technological devices such as videos, audio tapes, and speakers are not available. Besides the shortage of audio or visual technology, the University lacks appropriate resources for learning. For example, in the library there are about 70 books for students of English majors. These books are either out of date or of limited cultural relevance.

On a more positive side, the University has computers in the library, a free wireless network available for both students and teachers, and a room for distance learning. This makes online learning possible even though these facilities are shared across the University, which means they must be booked in advance.

Teaching experience and allocation

With regard to the importance of teachers in education, Le (2002) stated that the quality of teachers is a major factor in improving education. It impacts on general curriculum reform and teaching methods in all educational establishments. In this regard, the Faculty lacks the necessary number of quality teachers to teach the English majors, for the reasons given above and below.

In terms of quantity, there were only five teachers teaching English majors when the Faculty was founded. At present, there are L2 teachers of English majors, but only eight have responsibilities for teaching the students majoring in English. The other

four new teachers teach non-English majors and will need one or two years more before they are allowed to teach English majors.

In terms of professional development, Le (2002), Pham (2006) and Dudzik (2010) were concerned that ongoing teacher professional development opportunities in Vietnam are inadequate: teachers rarely have chances to exchange ideas or experiences with other colleagues. Nor do they have opportunities to learn new teaching methods. Moreover, they face difficulties such as large class sizes, and a serious shortage of teaching materials and resources. The teachers in the Faculty occasionally have the chance to observe teaching from newly-recruited or experienced teachers. However, these occasional observations have not been sufficient for them. Additionally, a culture of research on English language teaching and learning has not developed. The University and Faculty encourage the teachers to do research or publish papers, but it is not compulsory for everyone. Lack of time, materials and opportunities to disseminate results and contextually inappropriate training lead to a the lack of motivation to conduct research (Pham, 2006). Accordingly, teachers have not been provided with satisfactory professional development.

In summary, Section 1.2 provides the detailed picture of teaching and learning L2 writing in the context of the research university. Such difficulties as large classes, students' mixed proficiency levels, lack of qualified teachers, and insufficient learning facilities and resources hinder effective learning. The current approach of teaching writing does not seem to facilitate effective learning. A new way of teaching to enhance learning is an urgent necessity, which was part of my motivation for this timely study.

1.3 RESEARCH QUESTIONS

As discussed above, the traditional teacher-led pedagogy impacts on teaching and learning English in the Vietnamese context. As a result, students find it hard to use English outside of the classroom. This has not met the requirements of the MoET for ELT in Vietnam. In the University where this study was conducted, the situation of teaching and learning English was similar to that of the wider Vietnamese context. It was thus imperative that a new teaching method be applied to improve ELT teaching and learning and meet the requirements of the MOET.

This study used action research in a writing project lasting for eight weeks with the focus on the overarching research question: **what strategies using collaboration and technology could enhance students' L2 writing skills?** To address the overarching research question, an investigation of the teachers' and students' experiences of L2 writing prior to the implementation of the writing project and their expectations of and reflections on collaborative writing using technology. Specifically, there were three sub-questions:

1. **What are teachers' expectations of and reflections on the use of face-to-face and online strategies for the teaching of L2 writing?**
2. **What are students' expectations of and reflections on the use of face-to-face and online strategies for the learning of L2 writing?**
3. **What specific teaching and learning stages (pre-writing, drafting, feedback, revision or publishing) can enhance students' participation and engagement in learning L2 writing through face-to-face and online collaboration?**

Because the data collated from teachers' and students' responses were interwoven and inseparable. The sub-research questions address the following themes:

- Participants' expectations of L2 collaborative writing using wikis (research questions 1 and 2)
- Participants' reflections of L2 collaborative writing
- Effective strategies to enhance students' collaboration

For more information about themes and coding see Section 4.5.2

1.4 PURPOSES

This first chapter has introduced my personal experience as a teacher of English writing at a university in Vietnam. Students' L2 collaborative writing preferences and the obstacles to effective writing have been discussed. This chapter has also outlined the context of the study. Such important elements in this context as the syllabuses, the students, the facilities for learning and teaching L2, the quality and quantity of the teachers, all suggest that the traditional approach to learning neither satisfied students' learning styles nor leads to learning development of effective communication in English. A new approach using collaboration and technology to enhance students' writing skills was proposed. The approach was not only to satisfy students' collaborative learning preferences, but also address the requirements of the MoET for communicative and technology-supported learning.

The main purpose of this study was to investigate the participants' expectations of and reflections on the writing project at the University. Following on from the findings of the investigation, the research investigated how effectively face-to-face

and wiki collaboration could engage students' participation with L2 writing strategies. From the collated reflections, suggestions and implications for teaching and learning L2 writing using collaboration and technology in the traditional contexts were proposed.

To address the research questions, an action research methodology following Kemmis and McTaggart's (1988) and Burns's (2010) suggestions was utilised (see Section 4.1).

1.5 SIGNIFICANCE AND SCOPE OF THE STUDY

My study is contextualised by the situation of teaching and learning L2 writing at my University and informed by existing studies on collaborative writing using wikis.

The study significantly enriches the existing knowledge on (1) learning L2 process writing through collaboration, (2) affordances of wikis for collaborative writing in the Vietnamese context.

At a more specific level, the outcomes of my research impact on both teachers and students who participated in the study. The experience gained from participating in the research project may be useful for their own professional practices as they recognise the value of collaborative writing in their teaching practice. At a broader level, my study provides insights on how to implement collaborative writing projects using wikis in traditional L2 teaching and learning contexts such as Vietnam. The insights include both the affordances and the constraints in each specific stages of writing. The study is suited to a learning environment where students' L2 writing proficiency levels are varied and technology has not been widely applied to teaching and learning.

One of the constraints that action research practitioners commonly encounter is a lack of literature on the research topic (Park, Wang, & Kuroshima, 2010). An action research investigation – has not previously been conducted on how collaborative learning works in a language learning environment in tertiary education in Vietnam. In addition, in EFL online classes, the adaptation of an action research approach “might be a promising way of maximizing the benefits of using internet-based interactive learning for process-oriented writing classes” (Suzuki, Watanabe, Yohihara, Jung, & Chang, 2009, p. 28). This study provides understandings on how action research involving collaborative, online and process learning was conducted.

The next section provides an overview of the chapters of this thesis.

1.6 OUTLINE OF THE STUDY

This study is structured as follows. Chapter 1 positions the study by recounting the background of the researcher, followed by details of the research site. The research questions and the significance of the study are also introduced.

Chapter Two reviews the literature relevant to the research problem, commencing with a discussion of the positioning of English in the foreign language education context of Vietnam. In particular, the discussion reviews the influences of two important factors affecting L2 development: political and cultural awareness. Following this section is the literature review on collaborative learning, emphasising the advantages of online collaborative writing through face-to-face and wiki modes to improve L2 writing skills.

Chapter Three describes the theoretical framework constructed from the perspectives of the Zone of proximal development, Communities of Practice, the L2 process

writing approach, and the collaborative affordances of wikis. The theoretical framework constructed from these theories will support the premise that combining face-to-face and wiki modes has the potential to enhance L2 collaborative writing.

Chapter Four provides details regarding the research design. This chapter includes the rationale for choosing action research as the method. The participants, collaborative project, data instruments, data analysis, procedure and ethical issues are described.

Chapters Five, Six and Seven report and analyse the findings of the study. Chapter Five provides the participants' reflections on their L2 teaching and learning methodology prior to the implementation of the writing project, and their expectations of the upcoming collaborative writing project. It states that the pedagogy was impacted by the dominance of the teacher and summative tests.

Chapter Six analyses how the researcher considered the participants' expectations to tailor the writing project. It details participants' collaboration in Cycle 1 and their suggestions for more effective collaboration in Cycle 2.

Chapter Seven discusses the participants' reflections on the affordances and constraints via each stage of writing. Participants' evaluation of the project and suggestions for future projects are described.

The study ends with the Conclusion in Chapter Eight. This chapter includes a summary of the main findings, their relations to the literature and theoretical framework, suggestions and implications for teaching and learning L2 writing and future projects, and, finally, the limitations of the study.

1.7 SUMMARY OF THE CHAPTER

This first chapter provides the rationale behind the researcher's choice of conducting research on improving students' L2 writing skills through collaboration. It describes the background of the researcher as a teacher and the context of the study. Embedded through the description of the English major class, the writing programme and the University facilities is the necessity of applying a new teaching approach from the traditional teacher-fronted method in order to improve teaching and learning quality. The chapter also introduces the research questions, and the purposes of the study. The significance of the study is highlighted.

Chapter 2: Literature Review

This chapter provides a review of the relevant literature, and focuses on collaborative learning using technology to enhance students' L2 writing participation to clarify the research problem. It begins with the historical background of English language teaching in Vietnam (Section 2.1), stressing the impediments to the application of communicative learning and teaching. Section 2.2 discusses the potential benefits that collaboration can offer to learning, especially featuring the importance of collaborative learning to improve L2 writing quality. Section 2.3 focuses on face-to-face and online collaborative modes which have an established link to L2 writing development. This section also highlights the applications of online learning through wikis, with a review of both the strengths and weaknesses of wikis in the teaching and learning of L2 writing. Section 2.4 provides a description of technology-enhanced learning development, specifically describing the development of L2 online learning in Vietnam. The section suggests that although online learning is new in the educational context of Vietnam, it is feasible and productive. Section 2.5 summarises, and discusses the implications from the literature, then links to the development of the theoretical framework in Chapter 3.

To address Section 2.1, the historical context of English language teaching (ELT) in Vietnam, literature regarding the history of English language development in Vietnam under the influence of cultural values will be reviewed. The section argues that there is a mismatch between current teaching approaches and the goals and objectives of teaching and learning English set by the governing educational bodies

in Vietnam. Following this section, a range of studies that report the theoretical as well as practical support of collaborative learning will be discussed, focussing on the benefits of collaboration to facilitate L2 learning. In Section 2.3, the development of teaching through online modes to enhance students' learning in international contexts will be reviewed. This section also discusses L2 learners' attitudes, and the efficacy of certain successful writing projects through wikis. The potential pitfalls of wiki learning are also canvassed. A comparison between the advantages and disadvantages of wikis is made to provide a broader understanding of the issues involved. Following this is the description of technology-enhanced integration in the Vietnamese context, emphasising the applications of L2 online learning. This section also highlights the importance of adopting new but easy-to-use online technology in order to introduce positive changes into current L2 pedagogy at the tertiary level in Vietnam.

2.1 ENGLISH LANGUAGE TEACHING IN VIETNAM

This section describes the ELT context in Vietnam so as to draw attention to the need to apply writing strategy approach and technology to improve the quality of English writing. It starts with a review of current ELT practices in Vietnam, stressing the impediments to the applications of communicative language teaching, which was set by the MoET as the mandated pedagogy in foreign language education. The impediments arise due to the influence of politics and culture.

2.1.1 English as a second/foreign language in Vietnam

English was formally introduced into Vietnam during the American involvement in Vietnam from 1954 to 1975. As a consequence of this involvement, Vietnam was divided into two different political systems and separated territories: the communists in the north and the capitalists in the south. In the north of Vietnam, English was

considered the language of the “enemy” and thus strongly resisted. In the south, nonetheless, it “gained the second status, after Vietnamese” Do (2006, p. 4). As Wright (2002) noted, the Southern Vietnamese people of all classes, including politicians, bureaucrats, soldiers, drivers, shop keepers and servants, utilised English. During that period, English was taught to Vietnamese people by the Americans employed to work in Vietnam or volunteers like linguistic specialists, professional educators, university graduates, civilians and military officers (Do, 2006).

After 1975, with the withdrawal of the USA from the south, Vietnam started the process of reunification. That time marked the “dominance of Russian as the main foreign language and the decline of English as well as other languages in the educational system” (Do, 2006, p. 1). The change reflected the impact of political relations because at that time Vietnam followed the USSR’s model.

After reunification, the country suffered from severe hardships resulting from the destruction of the war and financial difficulties. Shapiro (1995) states:

The ten year period following reunification resulted in devastating economic problems for this small developing country and a continued isolation from the western world. The American Trade Embargo made it difficult for other countries to work with Vietnam for fear of political reprisal from the United States. Accurate information regarding Vietnam became increasingly difficult to obtain and the country continued its economic downfall, becoming one of the poorest nations in the world (p. 2).

Facing such difficulties, in 1986 the Sixth Party Congress of the Communist Party took a decision to implement radical reforms, which were considered “the most dramatic set of reforms ever outlined in the country’s history” (Shapiro, 1995, p. 3). The reforms were to “entail economic liberation only, accepted as a necessity after a

disastrous period of incompetent government and economic isolation that had brought the country close to famine” (Wright, 2002, p. 238).

Under the implementation of these policies, “Vietnam decided to expand its relations with every country despite different political systems” (Do, 2006, p. 7). As a result, “the early 1990s witnessed exchanges between Hanoi and non-communist regimes on an unprecedented scale” (Wright, 2002, p. 238). The exchanges could be recognised not only in the economic sector but also in tourism, with the rapid growth of visitors to Vietnam. Foreign languages became a “key factor” in the renovation. (Dang, Nguyen, & Le, 2013) The need to use foreign languages for internal and external communication in the country led to training in foreign languages within the educational system. Especially after Vietnam joined the Association of South East Asian Nations (ASEAN) and the World Trade Organisation (WTO), the need and motivation to learn English increased rapidly in all aspects of life. Since its introduction, English has mostly been used as a second/foreign language in Vietnam, and the term L2 in this study refers to English as both a second or foreign language.

2.1.2 Influence of traditional pedagogy on language education

The development of ELT in Vietnam has been affected by traditional pedagogy. This sub-section describes how important elements in the curriculum, that is, the teacher, the examination and the textbook, traditionally exert their influences on pedagogy, which is also affected by long-lasting ideologies. Vietnam was under the domination of China for almost a thousand years, so it is clear that the impacts of Chinese ideologies, especially Confucianism, on Vietnamese society and education were unavoidable (Ellis, 1994; London, 2011; Rao, 2002). The teachers, teaching methodology, learning environments, textbooks and assessment are reviewed to consider their impact on current ELT.

Roles of teachers

The teacher plays a central role in traditional education in Vietnam: “the tradition is that a teacher is honored and respected” (Kramsch & Sullivan, 1996, p. 206). In the past, the status of the teachers was ranked equal to the king and one’s parent. This is reflected in the following saying taught to children:

Vua, thầy, cha ấy ba ngôi

Kính thờ như một trẻ ơi ghi lòng

[Translated: The king, the teacher, the father occupy three different positions; but children remember that you should venerate them equally as one unified person (Phuoc, 1975 cited in Ellis (1994)]

The important role of the teacher is nowadays still felt in the following saying:

Không thầy đố mày làm nên

[Translated: Without the teacher, you can do nothing (Pham & Fry, 2004)]

Respect for teachers is reflected in the fact that a teacher in Vietnam is considered to be an all-knowing “fount of knowledge” (Littlewood, 2000, p. 34) and a moral role model (Phan, 2004). He or she is a wise person who has gained knowledge (Kramsch & Sullivan, 1996): their knowledge is like a full bucket of water, while what they give students only amounts to a bowl of water (Pham, 2008). Teachers are also authority figures whose word has great weight (Kramsch & Sullivan, 1996; Nguyen, Terlouw, & Pilot, 2006). They are considered role models of “good moral quality, ethically and ideologically” (Nguyen et al., 2006, p. 5) that students should follow.

Respect for teachers is also illustrated by the reality that students are socialised to value “the absolute authority” of the teacher (T. M. H. Nguyen, 2011, p. 7). Knowledge is transmitted by teachers, and students act as receivers (Nguyen, 2011;

T. M. H. Nguyen, 2011; V. C. Le, 2004). Students are not encouraged to think independently, contradict teachers' knowledge or draw their own conclusions (Pham, 2008). Neither are they supposed to seek knowledge from other resources than teachers. What the teacher says is always correct and cannot be challenged. Communication between teachers and students is generally one-way because arguing and discussing with teachers, parents or elders is often considered as rude and disrespectful (T. M. H. Nguyen, 2011). All of these factors make teachers an absolute authority in the class.

It should be noted that students' respect for teachers as the only authority of knowledge is a natural feature of Asian students, including Vietnamese students. Littlewood (2001) conducted a study on students' attitudes to classroom learning across eight East Asian countries, including Vietnam, and three Western countries. He found that most students from both Western and Eastern cultures expressed that they did not want the teachers to be the only authority of knowledge in the class. They would like learning to involve more sharing. However, teachers' dominant roles in the classroom are still seen. Accordingly, learning in such an environment discourages students from creativity and independence, although they are capable of both (Littlewood, 2000, 2001).

Roles of examinations

Examinations have had an important role to play in Vietnam. In the past, "success in the test meant that one was a member of a pool of scholars" (Sullivan, 1996, p. 27). This successful, scholarly person then enjoyed admiration from society and privileges from government. It was thought that passing examinations, especially Imperial Chinese exams, was the only means for the individual and his family to rise to a new level in society (Pham & Fry, 2004; Pham, 2008; Woods, 2002). Pham and

Fry (2004, p. 201) add that even people with limited education could “participate in important ancestor worship rituals”, which was “a source of pride for many individuals.” It was also believed that when students succeeded in examinations, they could bring honour to their families. This is to say, educational achievements are essentially important for not only students but also the communities around them.

Nowadays, Vietnamese parents, children and society as a whole still hold the belief that success in examinations is a “ticket to ride” towards a better life and upward social mobility (Le, 2011). Consequently, parents encourage and support their children in their schooling while the students try as hard as they can to achieve as high a level as possible in the educational system, especially to gain a place at the university, which is highly competitive (Tran et al., 2010). Parents are typically “expected to sacrifice everything for the sake of their children’s education” (Latchem & Ryan, 2013, p. 60). Thousands of high school leavers sit for the National University Entrance Examination annually, but only 10 percent are admitted. This emphasises the importance of examinations in the current society (Le, 2011): unless students do well in them, they are unlikely to progress their studies.

Roles of textbooks

The curriculum in Vietnam is based on prescribed textbooks. In fact, the textbook “becomes the curriculum” and “instruction is largely, if not completely, textbook-driven” (Le, 2011, p. 19). Duggan (2001, p. 208) discusses the predominant features of textbooks in Vietnam:

[T]he curriculum is based on students and teachers working their way through a large number of textbooks in a lock-sequenced series of lessons (which are numbered to coincide with each section of the textbook). In this

respect, the structure, sequence and content of a textbook provide the content and flow of the syllabus.

Vietnamese students are accustomed to traditional pedagogy. Specifically, they engage in learning which involves following the text to the letter and memorising the knowledge gained from texts (Latchem & Ryan, 2013). It is because of such heavily textbook-dependent practices that anything not included in the textbook is not perceived as “learning” for Vietnamese students. This also reflects the fact that ELT pedagogy in Vietnam has typically focused on grammatical rules and vocabulary which students memorise from textbooks, and neglected communicative skills like speaking or writing (see Sub-section 2.1.3).

Students’ preferences for “class-as-family”

Researchers on Vietnamese students’ preferences have indicated that the context of teaching and learning in Vietnam leads students to consider classmates as “families”. Kramsch and Sullivan (1996) observe:

In Vietnam, students are placed into classes of approximately twenty to thirty when they enter the university. Members of these classes often live, study, and play together. The associations students form are more akin to Western notions of “family” than “classmate.” In many cases students in the same class will continue close relationships throughout their lives, forming ideas that encompass financial, familial, and social obligations. (p. 203)

Similarly, Tomlinson and Dat (2004, p. 204) report: “Many learners enter the classroom with a desire not only to improve their language proficiency but also to socialise and be accepted by the classroom society.” Accordingly, these researchers suggest that classroom methodology should encompass students’ preferences for a collective orientation to teaching and learning. Teachers need to adopt approaches

which promote social integration and at the same time enhance the L2 proficiency of students.

2.1.3 English language teaching in the current school system in Vietnam

So far, it has been demonstrated that ELT in Vietnam is affected by traditional values and practices. In this sub-section, how English is currently taught in contemporary Vietnam will be described, emphasising two main points: how traditional pedagogy influences ELT and why ELT in Vietnam falls short of the requirements of the MoET. Embedded throughout this sub-section is a focus on the need for implementing a communicative teaching approach to improve ELT quality.

Communicative language teaching in the current school system

Currently, teaching English as a second/foreign language is emphasised in curriculum at all levels in the educational system in Vietnam. The formal educational school system in Vietnam is divided into five levels: primary education from grade 1 to grade 5, lower secondary education from grade 6 to grade 9, upper secondary education from grade 10 to 12, undergraduate education and postgraduate education. Primary education starts when children are age six. In some larger cities, English is an optional subject taught to students from grades 3 to grade 5, and it is a compulsory subject in all the other upper levels.

In the early 1990s, English language teaching practices in Vietnam, reflected the dominance of the grammar-translation method (Denham, 1992). The focus of teaching was on developing students' reading skills. The class size was, on average, 50 students. Teachers had a relatively poor command of spoken English. There were limited opportunities for English learners to communicate with L1 English speakers. Since 2002, the high school English language curriculum has undergone a process of

renewal. The aims of this are to move towards a more communicative approach (Tran, 2009; V. C. Le & Barnard, 2009).

A communicative language teaching (CLT) approach emphasises the use of language to communicate. This approach is based on the beliefs, that given the right conditions, “language learning will take care of itself” (Harmer, 2007, p. 52) and “language is learnt through meaningful language use” (Klapper, 2003, p. 52). The main function of a language is to communicate; therefore, we can learn language by exposure to it and using it to communicate authentically. Learning activities in CLT are designed to “engage learners in meaningful and authentic language use” (Richards & Rogers, 2001, p. 72). For example, if learners are learning about how to shop in a supermarket, they will be taken to “real” supermarkets to be served as customers. In short, the focus of CLT is learners’ using English in realistic contexts (Butler, 2011; Richards & Rogers, 2001; Savignon, 2007).

Since CLT’s introduction, both its strong and weak versions have been theorised (Butler, 2011; Howatt, 1984; Klapper, 2003; Littlewood, 2007; Richards & Rogers, 2001). In strong CLT, an authentic context for learners to communicate is important. By exposure to such a context, learners are able to actively frame language use themselves. Knowledge is gained through the social negotiation between teachers and learners: the teacher’s role is to provide learners with authentic communicative activities. By contrast, the weak version of CLT advocates teachers’ involvement in the learning process through their provision of language structures. Language accuracy and fluency are equally important.

Compared to strong CLT, the goals of weak CLT are the same: to encourage students to communicate in English. The differences are methodological: strong CLT will use students’ immersion in English both as the means and ends of learning. It is

imperative that classroom practices are made authentic and meaningful to learners (Pham, 2007). English is used as the language of instruction. The attention to linguistic accuracy, for example, grammar or vocabulary, can be absent (Spada, 2007). Meanwhile, weak CLT uses teachers' instructions, which can be L1, to guide students' learning (Klapper, 2003). Linguistic forms are explicitly presented by teachers (Spada, 2007).

Like many Asian countries where CLT has become the dominant approach in ELT (Butler, 2011; Kam, 2006; Littlewood, 2007), Vietnam has advocated CLT through policy. This is observed through the high school curriculum renewal in 2000 as discussed above, and this has clearly been documented in the MoET's recent policies (1400/QD-TTG, 2008; MoET, 2006, 2014). For example, for secondary education, the MoET requires that "communicative skills are the goal of the teaching of English at the secondary school while formal knowledge of the language serves as the means to the end" (MoET, 2006, p.6 translated by Barnard and Nguyen (2010)). In a more recent policy, the government issued Decision 1400/QD-TTG (2008) to implement the Vietnam's National Foreign Language 2020 Project. The main mission of the project is to build a framework to evaluate teachers' and students' English competencies by, for example, establishing regional foreign language centers, building action research capacity, improving curriculum and using digitalized textbooks (NFL 2020 Forum, 2012).

To respond to this Decision, the MoET published the Common Framework of Levels of Foreign Language Proficiency, including six reference levels to assess L2 competencies for Vietnamese students. This framework is based on the Common European Framework and used as the driving reference for (1) all educational levels in Vietnam, (2) curriculum design and lesson plans, and (3) methodology and

assessment (MoET, 2014). The following table describes the common reference levels for Vietnamese L2 learners.

Table 2.1

Framework of Levels of Foreign Language Proficiency for Vietnamese L2 learners (based on the Common European Framework of Reference for Languages)

Basic User	Level 1	Can understand and use familiar everyday expressions and very basic phrases aimed at the satisfaction of needs of a concrete type. Can introduce him/herself and others and can ask and answer questions about personal details such as where he/she lives, people he/she knows and things he/she has. Can interact in a simple way provided the other person talks slowly and clearly and is prepared to help.
	Level 2	Can understand sentences and frequently used expressions related to areas of most immediate relevance (e.g. very basic personal and family information, shopping, local geography, employment). Can communicate in simple and routine tasks requiring a simple and direct exchange of information on familiar and routine matters. Can describe in simple terms aspects of his/her background, immediate environment and matters in areas of immediate need.
Independent User	Level 3	Can understand the main points of clear standard input on familiar matters regularly encountered in work, school, leisure, etc. Can deal with most situations likely to arise whilst travelling in an area where the language is spoken. Can produce simple connected text on topics which are familiar or of personal interest. Can describe experiences and events, dreams, hopes and ambitions and briefly give reasons and explanations for opinions and plans.
	Level 4	Can understand the main ideas of complex text on both concrete and abstract topics, including technical discussions in his/her field of specialisation. Can interact with a degree of fluency and spontaneity that makes regular interaction with native speakers quite possible without strain for either party. Can produce clear, detailed text on a wide range of subjects and explain a viewpoint on a topical issue giving the advantages and independent disadvantages of various options.
Proficient user	Level 5	Can understand a wide range of demanding, longer texts, and recognise implicit meaning. Can express him/herself fluently and spontaneously without much obvious searching for expressions. Can use language flexibly and effectively for social, academic and professional purposes. Can produce clear, well-structured, detailed text on complex subjects, showing controlled use of organisational patterns, connectors and cohesive devices.
	Level 6	Can understand with ease virtually everything heard or read. Can summarise information from different spoken and written sources, reconstructing arguments and accounts in a coherent presentation. Can express him/herself spontaneously, very fluently and precisely, differentiating finer shades of meaning even in more complex situations.

According to this framework, the level for primary education is level 1, secondary education level 2 to 3. For tertiary education, the graduates of a non- English major have to reach level 3 to 4 and the levels for English majors are 4 to 5. The MoET's (2014) policy aligns with the previous policies and practices to highlight the importance of communicative competence in ELT. It details the expected outcomes of teaching and learning and requires specific changes in terms of goals, methodology and assessment in the educational system to meet CLT's demands.

Under these guidelines, CLT has officially been advocated in the Vietnamese context since the renewal of the curriculum in 2002, and positive results have been observed. First, the authors of textbooks have adopted the learner-centred approach to design lessons with four integrated skills. Classroom activities are organised through individual, pair/ group work interaction (Barnard & Nguyen, 2010; Nunan, 2003). CLT workshops, seminars and conferences have been organised to train teachers to implement CLT in their own classrooms. Second, teachers and students have reflected positively on the implementation of CLT (Ngoc & Iwashita, 2012; Pham, 2007; Phan, 2004). Studies have indicated that teachers can succeed in not only getting their students' involved in communicative activities but also maintaining Vietnamese cultural practices. For example, Phan (2007) and Phan and Phan (2006) reported that the teachers in their studies organise free and stimulating discussions for students to develop both linguistic and communicative competences. At the same time, the teachers were "role models" who guide students in their moral behaviours. Most importantly, teachers have implemented CLT because they really value the communicative function of language, which is reflected in the findings of Pham's (2007) study:

[M]any teachers embrace CLT, not simply because CLT represents a modern and progressive way of language teaching. Neither do they embrace it simply because they want to please the educational policy makers. The teacher in this study espouse firmly the primary goal of CLT – to teach students to be able to use the language – believing that this is consonant with the students’ ultimate goal of learning English in their context (Pham, 2007, p. 200).

Despite the positive outcomes of implementing CLT, there have been concerns about the challenges that educators and learners have to face. Le (2013, p.66) reflects on the proficiency of Vietnamese students after years of learning English at high school:

[T]he language proficiency of students [of lower secondary schools] is just limited within some basic tasks such as introducing oneself, describing some simple objects in the house etc. [...]. Many school leavers [of high schools] cannot read simple texts in English nor communicate with English speaking people in some most common cases.

Similarly, at tertiary level, ELT pedagogy was directed to focus on eliciting knowledge on grammar and skills in reading and writing rather than oral communication. Dudzik (2010, p. 198) states:

As a result of a traditional, teacher-centered model of information transmission, English language learners in Vietnam ... are often more able to read and write than they are to communicate orally in English. These teacher-centered language classrooms often produce students who are proficient in grammar, vocabulary, comprehending information and writing papers. However, students are often less able to ask questions, disagree, interrupt, or extend a discussion of ideas.

Faced with students' low levels of proficiency, many tertiary institutions have to redesign English programmes for students as beginning English learners. However, recent studies have demonstrated that tertiary students' language proficiency has not improved and is still very far from the requirements of their future jobs. Explanations of why strong CLT has not successfully been implemented will be discussed in the next sub-section.

Resistance to CLT

As established in the previous section, CLT is considered the centre of English curriculum renewal in Vietnam, but in reality there is a gap between the policies and pedagogy. Ellis (1994) concludes that the communicative approach in its strong form is unsuitable in the Vietnamese context. He found that the resistance lay with institutional, curriculum, assessment and belief constraints. More recent studies (Barnard & Nguyen, 2010; Kam, 2006; Pham, 2007) have shown that the implementation of strong CLT remains a challenge in Vietnam. Difficulties in CLT implementation, synthesised from the reviewed studies, lie in five main factors: teachers, teaching pedagogy, textbooks, learning environments and facilities and assessment. They will be discussed in order below.

Teachers

To implement CLT in the classroom, teachers are required to assume a new role. They should be the facilitator and guide rather than a model for correcting speech and writing (Richards, 2006). In Medgyes' (1986) sardonic view: "the communicative classroom requires a teacher of extraordinary abilities: a multi-dimensional, high-tech, Wizard-of-Oz-like superperson – yet of flesh and blood" (p. 107). However, in Vietnam, research has shown that teachers can be an obstacle to implementing CLT. This is reflected through the fact that "a number of Vietnamese

educators questioned whether the school system and its teachers were ready for such a radical change from more traditional methods and approaches” (Barnard & Nguyen, 2010). V. C. Le and Barnard (2009) in their research conducted with the teachers of English in a small high school in the north of Vietnam, found:

The teachers ... appeared to be primarily concerned with how to cover the syllabus by finishing the textbook, which is the normative way of teaching in Vietnam. Hence, they emphasised reproduction of knowledge instead of creating opportunities for people to use target language for genuine communication. (p.29)

Specifically, Bock (2000) indicated that the difficulties result from teachers’ inadequate English proficiency, lack of training in ELT, and the inability to assess communicative resources. Nunan (2003, p. 607) in his study across seven countries in the Asia-Pacific region, including Vietnam, asserts that “the English language proficiency of many teachers is not sufficient to provide learners with the rich input needed for successful foreign language acquisition”. Dudzik (2010) and Ngoc and Iwashita (2012) add that teachers’ reluctance to modify from grammar-based to communicative-based approach due to the washback of testing. Vietnamese ELT teachers have a dilemma following the educational policies, which support CLT, and mandated exams, which do not measure students’ communicative competences (see *Assessment* below for further discussion).

In sum, L2 Vietnamese teachers experience many challenges when implementing CLT, especially the strong form, in their classrooms.

Teaching pedagogy

Research has shown that traditional teaching pedagogy is also a hindrance to CLT in Vietnam. The common ELT method in Vietnam is characterized by (a) teachers’

dominance (b) exclusive focus on grammar rules and reading, and (c) emphasis on students' reproduction of linguistic rules or structures of the language (Duong & Nguyen, 2006; V. C. Le & Barnard, 2009). Le (2011) describes the typical pedagogy in an English lesson:

[I]t has been commonly observed that the pedagogy in the English language classrooms in Vietnam models the hierarchy of first listening to the teacher, then repetition, then copying linguistic models provided by the teacher on chalkboard [...]. Such an analytical learning and teaching style informs both the teacher and learners that it is safe to learn and memorise rules, and limits other types of practice activities (p. 21-22)

Even though CLT has been advocated in textbooks and curriculum, and teachers have been required to implement it in their own classroom, there have been mismatches between teachers' actual pedagogy and students' preferences in both strong and weak forms of CLT.

In its weak form, the teaching method has not changed much compared to that before the introduction of CLT, and students have not been satisfied with the pedagogy. V. C. Le and Barnard (2009, p. 29) reflect in their study:

Teachers focused on explaining the rules of grammar in Vietnamese and placed their emphasis on the extraction of explicit information provided in the textbooks. There was an absence of restructuring activities, and little attention was paid to developing individual thought processes or the negotiation of meaning among pupils.

In addition, the findings of a study with 100 university English majors indicated that among many factors, "teaching method had the highest frequency in demotivating students" (Tran & Baldauf Jr, 2007, p. 94). Specifically, the students in the study

responded that the teaching method was uncreative and boring. In another study conducted by Tomlinson and Dat (2004) with 300 adult learners, the students reflected that the teachers were not fully aware of what their students felt and thought about their teaching methodology (Tomlinson & Dat, 2004). Learners would welcome changes to a new teaching pedagogy.

However, in the strong form of CLT, there is a need for explicit grammar and error correction, although teachers considered these practices to be an obstacle to implementing this pedagogy (Ngoc & Iwashita, 2012). It is this misalignment between teachers' and students' perceptions in both its strong and weak forms that makes CLT less effective in Vietnam.

Textbooks

The ELT textbooks used in Vietnam can be two types: (a) L1 English adopted textbooks, (b) L2 locally-written textbooks (Dat, 2008).

Adopted textbooks are those written by L1 English writers. They are believed to provide strengths that local textbooks cannot have. Four main benefits accruing from L1 adopted textbooks are: (a) linguistic accuracy, (b) communicative language use focus, (c) diversified resources for teaching and learning, and (d) variety of interesting and entertaining content- genres (Dat, 2008). However, the weaknesses of adopted textbooks are: (a) misalignment with L2 assessment by examinations, and (b) hard-to-implement instructions (Dat, 2008).

First, while communicative use of language is included in L1 textbooks, most of the examinations, especially annual national exams, do not assess students' communicative competence (see sub-section below for further information). Second, as Dat (2008, p. 266) explains: "instructions on how to carry out classroom activities are not always easy for learners at a variety of English proficiency levels to

understand.” Obviously, many communicative instructions in L1 textbooks cannot be carried out in L2 classrooms due to differences in context, language proficiency, cultural beliefs and learning-support facilities.

Due to the unsuitability of the internationally adopted textbooks, locally-written textbooks, especially in secondary education, have been used. The use of L2 textbooks written by Vietnamese writers brings three problems: (a) uncommunicative and inaccurate use of language, (b) inflexible teaching approaches and (c) a mismatch with the assessment (Dat, 2008; M. T. T. Nguyen, 2011). The first two problems, uncommunicative and inaccurate use of language, will be discussed here. The third problem, mismatch with the assessment, will be reported in Sub-section *Assessment*, after the section about *Learning environments and facilities*.

To begin with, textbooks written for L2 teaching and learning written by Vietnamese writers have been criticised for their lack of linguistic accuracy. Dat (2008) in his study on the course books of South East Asian countries including Vietnam demonstrates that the weaknesses of these books include “linguistic inaccuracy, unintended effect and vague content” and they were “less than ideal for skill-based courses” (p.267). Another study on the evaluation of the pragmatic contents of three textbooks for Grade 10, 11 and 12 was conducted by M. T. T. Nguyen (2011). The findings indicate that these textbooks “do not always constitute an accurate and adequate source of pragmatic models” and “need to provide realistic pragmatic models” (M. T. T. Nguyen, 2011, p. 26). It is the inaccuracy of the linguistic content in textbooks that leads to students’ difficulties in L2 communication.

In addition, Vietnamese textbook writers have to compromise between communicative content and time allocation. This occurs because content, time allocation and pedagogy have to conform to the curriculum prescribed by the MoET:

a teacher is supposed to finish all content of each lesson in accordance with the pedagogy and time prescribed. This is why the teaching approach cannot be flexible but rigidly depends on textbooks (Dat, 2008; Le, 2011). Also, teachers prefer to transmit all knowledge from textbooks, which will be assessed in high-stakes exams, rather than encourage students to discover knowledge themselves. This implies a misalignment between the MoET's requirements for ELT for communicative purposes, teachers' support for CLT, and textbook reliance.

Learning environments and facilities

The term “environments” refers to both inside and outside classroom space, and “facilities” refer to resources and equipment-supported learning. Both can be factors that inhibit CLT. First, large classes cause difficulties for CLT methodology and assessment. Any communicative pedagogy such as pair and group work is difficult to organise in a class of 30 to 50 students (Kam, 2006; Pham, 2007; V. C. Le & Barnard, 2009). V. L. Nguyen (2010, p. 216) describes typical CLT lessons:

Vietnamese teachers of English also complain that the use of CLT results in troubles for over-sized classroom management when all students, usually around 35-50, start pair/group work. The situation becomes detrimental. The class may turn out to be very noisy, disturbing the formal educational environment and leading to complaints from other teachers in neighbouring classrooms.

The teachers in Le and Barnard's (2009) study added that any class activity like game playing or listening to tape/video records was difficult to include in their lessons. They feared that the noise could interfere with other classes. In addition, the lack of learning support facilities in the classroom environment also accounts for poor communicative learning performance (Bock, 2000). In L2 classes in big cities,

many classes are equipped with technology-based equipment such as videos, radios, tapes. However, these learning devices are neither sufficient nor effective for large groups of students (Le & Barnard, 2009; V. L. Nguyen, 2011). Further discussion of technology-supported learning in the Vietnamese context will be canvassed in Section 2.4.

Second, the environment outside the classroom also restricts learners from using L2 to communicate. Vietnamese students share a common language so there is no urgent need for them to use a language other than Vietnamese to communicate (Kieu, 2010; Pham, 2007; V. L. Nguyen, 2010). Studies on the use of Vietnamese in L2 teaching (Kieu, 2010; V. C. Le & Hamied, 2013) showed that teachers supported the use of Vietnamese in their lecturing. Codeswitching, “the combined use of mother tongues with the target language” (Tien & Li, 2013, p. 24), occurred when teachers wanted to explain grammar, vocabulary and check students’ comprehension (Kieu, 2010). In a case study, the teacher participant switched from L2 to L1 because she was concerned about the students’ low language proficiency (V. C. Le & Hamied, 2013). Although not many studies on codeswitching have been conducted in Vietnam up to the present, it can be concluded that the strong version of CLT, which requires only English to be used as the language of instruction, is hard to implement in a learning environment where both teachers and students share the same language. Moreover, it is hard to find places where students can talk to L1 English speakers or Vietnamese English speakers (Pham, 2005). This means that students are not exposed to a real English language context. Instead, they rely on the simulated or “false” activities inside classroom, most of which are teacher-centred.

Assessment

Assessment plays a very important role in teaching and learning: it is considered one of the drivers of education and can direct teachers' and students' behaviours (Cheng & Curtis, 2004; Shohamy, Donitsa-Schmidt, & Ferman, 1996). Test content can change teachers' and students' activities to meet its requirements. When tests and curriculum align, "there is an opportunity to claim that teachers are covering the necessary material to achieve desired educational goals" (Fulcher, 2010, p. 82). On the other hand, if tests and curriculum do not align, there is the real possibility that some content of the curriculum is narrowed or ignored to focus on what will be tested. The relation between test content and actual pedagogy can be described by the term "washback," referring to the negative or positive influence of testing. Particularly in L2, washback is defined by Messick (1996, p. 241) as "the extent to which the introduction and use of a test influences language teachers and learners to do things they would not otherwise do that promote or inhibit language learning." In other words, washback can impact positively or negatively on teaching and learning. In Vietnam, there is a misalignment between test content and the curriculum in ELT. This can be observed both in secondary and tertiary education. As discussed above, L2 teaching is oriented to follow CLT and curriculum is designed with communicative tasks. Nevertheless, in ELT in high school, tests are composed of multiple-choice questions. Cheng and Curtis (2004) consider that multiple-choice tests "have had mainly negative influences on the quality of teaching and learning" (p. 3). Specifically for L2 writing skills, White (1995) was concerned that assessing writing by multiple-choice question tests is artificial. This is because multiple-choice tests set the questions and answers, and ask test-takers to choose one right answer

among sets of wrong answers. This is contrary to the nature of writing, which is to write, not to choose from other people's suggestions or guess the "right" answers.

It is because of the misalignment between the test content and the L2 curriculum that the negative washback on L2 pedagogy in secondary education can be observed: "[communicative] course objectives as quoted in the course books will soon be abandoned to give way to test content" (Tran, 2009, p. 279). This is also exemplified by Tomlinson and Dat's (2004) survey in Vietnam. They found that because of negative washback, many teachers did not wish to change from their traditional grammar focus method to a more communicative method. Similarly, Le (2013, p. 3) conclude that in L2 teaching in Vietnam, "testing and assessment do not implement their role of directing learning" to a CLT focus. In other words, testing and assessment cannot produce positive washback on CLT in Vietnam. This explains the mismatch between L1 adopted or L2 locally-written textbooks mentioned above.

In L2 tertiary education, specifically on writing skills, summative assessment, in the form of traditional timed-impromptu essay writing, is commonly used. The main aim of summative assessment is to evaluate students' progress at the end of a certain time, for example, after a semester or a year (Davidson & Leung, 2009). Timed-impromptu writing tasks require students to respond to a given topic in the test. There are five characteristics of this type of examination (Weigle, 2002): (1) test-takers write at least one continuous text, (2) a set of instructions or prompts is given for test-takers to understand topics being discussed, (3) feedback on the test is often expressed as percentages or grades, (4) time for testing is restricted, often between thirty minutes and two hours, (5) topics are unknown to test-takers in advance. Timed-impromptu writing is typical in Vietnam for English majors.

The washback of timed-impromptu exams is unavoidable in L2 writing. It is seen through the focus of teaching and learning on “those skills which will be most useful in the examination” and narrowing down other skills (Caudery, 1990, p. 124). In international assessment literature, timed-impromptu writing is criticised for two main reasons. First, test-takers are deprived of reflections on and revisions of their writing due to time constraints. This makes students consider the first draft as final (White, 1995). As a result, the processes of writing are considered less important than the product of writing. Second, impromptu writing restricts readership to teachers or examiners. They are the only ones who read and give feedback, usually in the form of percentage or grades. The influence of timed-impromptu writing in the class under study will be canvassed in Section 5.1.2.

For the scope of this study, I have reviewed here and further articulate in Section 5.1.2 that formative assessment through feedback should be used to complement summative assessment to assess students’ L2 writing skills. Formative assessment is undertaken to show the gap between students’ actual learning performance and what they need to acquire to reach the set objectives (Taras, 2005). In formative assessment practice, teaching is seen as a progressive process in which teachers help students cumulatively construct understandings. Learning also requires students to gradually integrate what they already know with new knowledge. Black and William (2009) suggest that formative assessment include strategies to inform learners about *where the learner is going, where the learner is right now, and how to get there.*

The same practices and procedures of formative assessment are seen in teacher-based assessment, alternative assessment, classroom or school-based assessment (Davidson & Leung, 2009). Chen, May, Klenowski, and Kettle (2013) identify that “in the formative assessment process, it is both teacher and students who are actively

participating in evaluating learning, and engaging in giving and receiving feedback” (p.3). Black (2009), Davidson and Leung (2009) and Sadler (1998) add that formative assessment requires that (a) students are involved in the assessment process, (b) teachers give immediate and constructive feedback on students’ work, and (c) formative assessment complements other forms of assessment.

It is obvious that formative assessment in L2 writing provides learners with opportunities to receive comments on their learning performance so they know what and how to improve their writing. This type of assessment, however, has often been neglected in L2 pedagogy in Vietnam. This study argues that including formative assessment in teaching and learning, which can be conducted through using collaboration and technology in learning, is a necessity (see Sub-section 5.1.2)

2.1.4 Conclusion

To summarise, Section 2.1 details the situation of teaching and learning English in contemporary Vietnam. Traditional values have exerted a profound impact on current pedagogical practices despite efforts to develop language learning to a more communicative approach. Under the impacts of these two factors, the CLT version in Vietnam is a weak form, which focuses exclusively on language accuracy rather than fluency in authentic communication.

2.2 COLLABORATIVE LEARNING EMPIRICAL STUDY REVIEW

This section reviews literature on L2 collaborative learning. It highlights the importance of sharing information about how to approach new knowledge and skills.

2.2.1 Collaborative learning

In Section 2.1, the major difficulties of teaching English communicatively were detailed. In this second section, the potential for collaborative learning using

technology to provide a new and effective approach to L2 teaching will be discussed. This section also reviews the practical advantages of collaboration, narrowing down from general collaborative learning to L2 learning, and focusing on the effectiveness of online modes.

Collaboration in learning through different modes has increasingly been supported by teachers, students and educational researchers because of its considerable benefits to learning (Bradley, Lindstrom, & Rystedt, 2010; Bruffee, 1984; Dillenbourg, 1999; Gilles & VanDover, 1988; Storch, 2005, 2007). In general, collaborative learning can offer such benefits as a better level of achievement, a higher level of critical thinking skills and increased motivation. Specifically, the advantages of learning by collaborating, as abbreviated and amended by Roberts (2005), fall into three categories: namely, academic benefits, social benefits, and psychological benefits.

Table 2.2

Advantages of collaborative learning on the field of general education

Academic benefits	Promotes critical thinking skills.
	Involves students actively in the learning process.
	Improves classroom results.
	Models appropriate student problem-solving techniques.
Social benefits	Develops a social support system for students.
	Builds diversity understanding among students and staff.
	Establishes a positive atmosphere for modelling and practising cooperation.
Psychological benefits	Increases students' self-esteem
	Develops positive attitudes towards teachers.

Source: adapted from Roberts (2005)

Although a number of studies have noted some drawbacks of collaborative learning which lead to ineffective group work (Roberts, 2005), it is a marked trend that current educational practices are changing in the direction of collaborative learning (Muukkonen, Hakkarainen, & Lakkala, 2004).

2.2.2 Collaboration in the field of L2 learning

Similar to studies investigating the benefits of collaboration in the field of general learning, studies in the field of L2 collaborative learning have been widely advocated. Pica and other colleagues (1987), in a study on the interactions of 16 L2 students, found that the input of the target language could be better perceived by the learners through confirmation, comprehension checks and clarification requests by peers (Pica, Young, & Doughty, 1987). That collaborative tasks could also extend to learners' syntax and morphology was concluded in Swain's study (2001), conducted on the output of French writing with analysis of students' dialogues in an immersion class.

From the perspectives of collaborative input and output achievements, it can be said that L2 learning can be facilitated by interactions between learners. With regard to pedagogy, recent studies have shown that collaborative learning in L2 is said to enhance students' language scaffolding. Scaffolding is a concept that develops from the ZPD concept of Vygotsky (1978) (for more details see 3.2.2). It originally refers to teachers' or facilitators' assistance which helps build a structure through which learners are helped to acquire new schema of knowledge, skills and attitudes. In L2 learning, studies have confirmed that scaffolding happens not only through teachers' assistance but also through peer support (Donato, 1994; Guerrero & Villamil, 2000). Interactions between teachers and students and between students can lead to students' L2 writing development.

2.2.3 Collaborative learning through online modes

Online learning activities were introduced to education as a revolutionary mode of learning in the late 1980s. Although it has been a relatively new realm of education, online learning has quickly grown in popularity: it is no longer considered as a “fad” or a domain of the computer “nerds” (Chin & Williams, 2006, p. 2). The term *online* variously refers to the delivery of course materials and learning resources through the internet. Also, it may refer to the use of computer-mediated technology to facilitate communication or a means to blend with other modes to supplement learning (Fung, 2007).

In the field of collaborative learning, students learn primarily by communicating among themselves via the internet (McInnerney & Roberts, 2004) to afford a new dimension to learning. It has been reported that collaborative learning is one of the most frequently adopted instructional design strategies for online learning (Tu, 2004). The ultimate goal of online learning is to provide learners with social interactions and meaningful contexts through which learning is facilitated and developed.

Among web tools, blogs, wikis, and journals are the most common functionalities included in online education. These tools can be used for communication and collaboration among classmates or between students and professors (Bowman, 2010).

2.3 COLLABORATIVE WRITING THROUGH FACE-TO-FACE AND WIKI MODES

In section 2.2, it was seen that collaborative learning, through face-to-face or wikis modes, is an effective approach to enhance general and L2 learning. This section contains an in-depth discussion of collaborative writing with the distinction made

between it and cooperative writing. It also reviews studies on face-to-face and online collaborative writing, and outlines the benefits as well as the pitfalls of these modes, especially of wiki collaboration. Finally, it explains the decision to use wiki to improve L2 writing quality.

2.3.1 Collaborative writing

In general, *collaborative writing* is writing that results from joint activities such as writing groups, the partner method, helping circles, or a teacherless writing class (Gere, 1987). In its broadest sense, collaborative writing refers to the co-authoring of a text by two or more writers (Storch, 2013). Through this process, writers can assist one another to enhance all stages of writing and to engage their peers in more productive and active learning (Chao & Lo, 2011). Accordingly, their writing skills are enhanced.

Three salient features of collaborative writing are highlighted by Allen, Atkinson, Morgan, Moore, and Snow (1987). The first one is the *function of conflicts* within the groups. Conflicts, when supported by experienced collaborators, play a decisive part in collaborative learning because they contribute to the creativity and quality of final products. By contrast, a failure to reach final consensus may lead to an ineffective group effort. The second is the *shared document* created by (a) substantial interactions among members, (b) joint-decision making power, and (c) collective responsibility for the document. The individual contributions cannot be traced back in final collaborative products. The last characteristic is *the typology of the group*. The types of group formation in collaborative work are classified according to the size, time, scope, and goals of the tasks. Each group type offers some advantages to help students complete the work.

Although the concepts of *collaborative* and *cooperative* learning both refer to students learning together, and hence are sometimes used interchangeably; there is a distinction between these two concepts. Dillenbourg (1999) suggests that in cooperative learning, learning tasks are split, each student solves sub-tasks individually and the partial results are assembled to the final output. Meanwhile, in collaborative learning, learners do all tasks together. In other words, in cooperative learning there is a division of responsibilities between individuals to complete a writing task. The group product is a combination of the work of individual writers (Stahl, Koschmann, & Suthers, 2006; Storch, 2013). Therefore, the most distinctive difference between collaborative and cooperative learning is the division of labour. Although both cooperative and collaborative refer to students' working in groups to achieve common goals, students' individual contributions can be traced back through the process of cooperative writing but cannot be separated in collaborative writing.

In this study, substantive interaction via stages of process-genre writing was at the core of the project designed to enhance students' writing skills. When interacting, in certain stages, such as in the pre-writing phase, students shared responsibilities, which means that *collaborative writing* was more emphasised. After each collaborative stage, there was a division of labour, which means that students worked more on cooperative writing. In other words, collaborative and cooperative stages were conducted successively. The design was based on the fact that for students to completely collaborate, too much work involving substantive sharing are required (Haythornthwaite, 2006). The withdrawal of students from collaboration to make way for cooperation in this study was expected to reduce sharing in some stages during which students could work individually. Significantly the wiki component which involved asynchronous contributions could only be cooperative. However, it

was noted that the cooperative stages were reliant on the collaborative stages: students' mutual sharing in the collaborative stages was the guidance for them to work in cooperative stages. The students worked collaboratively in the pre-writing stage to generate ideas, which guided them in their individual writing in the drafting stage. Similarly, the results of collaborative writing in the feedback stage guided students' individual editing in the revising stages via the wikis (See Table 4.3).

The procedure of students working together in my study was similar to Chao and Lo's (2011). In their study, there were five stages: collaborative planning, partitioned writing, peer-revising, peer-editing, and individual publishing. Their study was supported by Zammuner's (1995) findings: individual drafting (partitioned writing) was followed by dyad revising (peer-revising and editing) which resulted in the greatest revisions; compared to individual-individual drafting or dyad-dyad drafting only.

A substantial body of studies on L1 and L2 collaboration has reported the advantages accrued from collaborative writing in both face-to-face and online learning. However, the disadvantages of collaborative writing have also been highlighted in some studies. Further discussions on the advantages together with the disadvantages of the two approaches will be detailed in the sub-sections below.

Collaborative writing through the face-to-face mode

The previous and existing research on face-to-face collaborative writing has mainly covered learners' attitudes, group formation/ functions and benefits of feedback and collaboration (Shehadeh, 2011). This sub-section will firstly focus on benefits of face-to-face collaboration in both L1 and L2 writing. It then briefly raises areas of concerns so that collaborative learning can be approached from different angles.

Research on face-to-face collaborative learning in both L1 and L2 writing has revealed the numerous benefits of this approach to the development of writing quality. For example, in the case of a ninth-grade classroom in the USA, L1 students' collaborative interactions and negotiations had the potential to engage students in more active learning, because the learners productively prompted each other to pool, develop and discuss ideas (Dale, 1994). The learners also evaluated their peers' choices at the word level, and at the organisational level of text creation.

The benefits of L2 collaborative writing have also been researched. The nature of collaboration was studied with an ESL class of intermediate language proficiency in Australia (Storch, 2005). Twenty-three international students with different language backgrounds, and language proficiency, were divided to work in pairs or individually. The students were asked to compose a short text of one or two paragraphs by commenting on given graphic prompts. Their dialogues during collaboration and the final writing products were analysed. Collaboration in pairs provided students with the chance to pool ideas, and give feedback on their partners' work. Pair groups produced shorter but better texts in terms of task fulfilment, grammatical accuracy and complexity. Another study, with 48 pairs and 48 individuals of international participants, was conducted by Wigglesworth and Storch (2009). The students were asked to write an argument essay discussing the disadvantages of exam-based assessment. The results of the study showed that although writing collaboration did not significantly affect fluency and complexity, it impacted positively on accuracy. A more recent empirical study on the effects and students' perceptions of collaborative writing in L2 in the United Arab Emirates by Shehadeh (2011) showed that a significant improvement in quality regarding content, organisation and vocabulary could be seen in the post-test of the control group,

whose English entrance proficiency levels were considered as low-intermediate by the university.

Besides reviewing the benefits of face-to-face collaboration, consideration should also be given to its disadvantages. Thus course designers, especially those who come from teacher-fronted settings, can co-design and troubleshoot problems before they decide to set up any collaborative project. The difficulties of implementing face-to-face collaboration, as suggested by Panitz (1999), relate to two important elements of the curriculum: teachers and students. Teachers may feel that they cannot manage classes when authority is shared with students. Teachers could lose confidence in themselves when new knowledge or skills are gained through students' sharing; they could also be concerned about the shortage of learning materials to guide students' independent work. With regard to students, they are not used to cooperating to achieve common goals. They have been accustomed to being knowledge receivers, competing for individual grades, so the shift from passive learning into active learning can be both mentally and physically tiring to them. In my teaching context, as discussed in Chapter 1, these difficulties are real obstacles that need to be solved before the introduction of collaborative learning (see Sub-section 2.3.2).

Collaborative writing through online modes

The development of writing has aligned with that of technology, from the primitive time of writing by carving on stones to the modern era of computer networking (Penrod, 2005). As with face-to-face collaborative writing, it has been widely acknowledged in literature that online collaborative learning can offer considerable advantages to language teaching and learning. For teachers of L2 writing, the rationale and motivation for integrating online learning technology into lessons are largely the same as their first language counterparts (Warschauer, 1997). While face-

to-face collaboration benefits students in terms of writing quality, recent studies on writing collaboration through online modes have also confirmed these benefits.

2.3.2 Collaborative writing through wikis

The wiki, or more exactly WikiWikiWeb, one of the Web 2.0 tools, was first created by Ward Cunningham in 1995. Wikis are, in essence, collections of interlinked documents and pages which are developed, modified and edited by other users with a forms-capable Web browser client (Klobas, 2006; Leuf & Cunningham, 2001). There are many thousands of wiki pages, but the basic design of these wikis is simple. Essentially, every wiki page has an 'Edit Page', where writers can add or edit the contents. They can post written texts, videos, or images. With regard to collaboration, wikis have a 'Discussion' tab, which allows contributors to discuss, negotiate and construct community knowledge. Wikis have become popular in the classroom because they make it possible for teachers to see the history and process of how much students contribute to collaborative work.

The advantages that wikis offer to collaborative writing fall into two main categories: positive motivation and quality development. With regard to perceptions, L2 writing learners have reported positive responses to the experience of using wikis. In a study with 51 English majors who had already used wikis in their previous semester, Chao and Lo (2011) also found that a high percentage of EFL majors in a university in Taiwan showed positive responses to each stage of scaffolding in the programme. In the USA, a study with eight students in an advanced Spanish class was conducted by Elola and Oskoz (2010). The results showed that students still expressed their preference for working individually because they wanted to handle their writing in accordance with their own learning styles and schedule. However, they acknowledged that working collaboratively was advantageous to them, for the reason

that their peers could collaborate to construct better structures and organisation for their essays. In Vietnam, in a technology-enhanced class using the wiki for asynchronous collaboration and Yahoo for synchronous collaboration, Nguyen (2011) found that 30 English majors, despite their limited computer skills, enjoyed the collaborative experience in the subject *American Culture*. The students said that they would suggest the mode of an online learning community to future students. Miyazoe and Anderson (2010) carried out a blended learning implementation of forum, blog and wiki with 61 upper-intermediate level sophomores in a university in Tokyo. The researcher found that students expressed their satisfaction with blended online writing. Among the three web tools, wikis were the most favourable platform because “any learner can take advantage of wikis, regardless of his or her proficiency in terms of acquisition of the target language” (Miyazoe & Anderson, 2010, p. 194).

With regard to the quality of writing, studies report that learners can develop their writing quality through wikis. Franco (2008) conducted a study with 18 young digital learners, i.e., those who spent most of their time connected to the internet, aged from 13 to 17 in a private school in Brazil. Their proficiency was heterogeneously estimated at low-intermediate. They worked with the wiki writing programme during a whole semester. Franco concluded that students learning through the wiki gained a higher degree of motivation, interest, autonomy and social cooperation. Franco considered it a “gratifying achievement” (p.55), from which students could benefit to develop their writing skills. Wichadee (2010) researched wiki summary writing development programme with 35 Thai EFL beginner students working together for eight weeks. The students were asked to form groups and construct wiki pages by themselves. They read assigned articles and wrote summaries of these articles. There were significant differences in the results of the writing tests before and after the

course. Seeing other students' work and discussing with their peers helped students improve their own writing work. Alshumaimeri's experimental research (2011) was conducted in Saudi Arabia with 42 male students, 22 in the experimental group and 20 in the control group. The purpose of the English preparatory programme was to provide students with the essential language proficiency and skills needed for academic study and future professional life. The results of the six-week-wiki writing programme indicated that the accuracy, organisation and cohesion in the post-test results of the experimental group improved significantly compared to the control group. Wikis also helped raise students' awareness of their audience in a course of English academic writing in Stockholm University (Kuteeva, 2011). The purpose of the course for students of diverse L1 backgrounds was to develop students' overall language proficiency, emphasising developing paragraph and argumentative writing tasks. The two wiki engines, MediaWiki and Wikipedia, facilitated students' collaboration. The findings showed that the application of a wiki provided them with feedback from their friends as genuine readers. As a result, their awareness of the reader increased and made them pay closer attention to grammatical correctness and text organisation, which the students regarded as being of utmost importance in determining writing quality.

While it is clear that wikis can be an effective platform for organising collaboration and sharing knowledge, an aversion toward this collaborative tool, however, has also been noted in literature. Several studies on foreign language writing learning through wikis show students' uncertainties over their writing development after experiencing wiki learning. Elola and Oskoz (2010) compared students' individual work and collective work, and Nguyen (2011) compared students' technology-enhanced learning with traditional teacher-fronted learning. The students in both studies

thought that their writing, in terms of fluency, accuracy and complexity (Elola & Oskoz's study) and grammar, vocabulary and quality (V. L. Nguyen's study) was not noticeably improved. Some researchers, despite users' positive perceptions, question whether wikis can essentially improve students' learning development (Elgort, Smith, & Toland, 2008; Wheeler, Yeomans, & Wheeler, 2008; Witney & Smallbone, 2011). The pitfalls impeding the use of wikis for L2 writing achieving desired results include: technical and collaborative skill issues, students' discomfort, and assessment difficulties.

First, students' knowledge of wiki skills and how to collaborate effectively play a decisive role in encouraging students' participation. Although wikis are reported to be a relatively easy tool to learn and use, students' dearth of prior experience or formal training with this tool can account for low participation. Students, especially the novices at online learning, can be confused and feel ambivalent about the potential of wikis (Allwardt, 2011; Guo & Stevens, 2011; Ramanau & Geng, 2009). Additionally, wikis have been argued to be a slow platform for collaboration for two main reasons: the first is the missing functionality, for example, lack of more socialised discussion space and the limited formatting features like copying, pasting, inserting, or editing (Elgort et al., 2008; Kear, Woodthorpe, Robertson, & Hutchison, 2010; Minocha & Thomas, 2012). The second reason is the slow response from learners: they may do collaborative work only at the last minute, or they may find asynchronous collaboration difficult and time-consuming (Allwardt, 2011). In Allwardt's (2011) study conducted with L1 writing students, Allwardt reported:

Among discussion group participants, time management was the most problematic issue reported. Some students were frustrated that groups were

inactive just before the due date approached and that group members did not reply to their postings in a timely manner. (p. 600)

Most important of all, learning in a wiki environment is not merely about how to create the content. It also involves learning online collaborative skills, for example, how to build consensus from conflicts, communicate ideas in a networked asynchronous environment, and create “explicit knowledge from tacit understanding” (Bruns & Humphreys, 2005, p. 27). Promisingly, the later generation of wikis can solve technical issues. However, the problems of how to collaborate actively and effectively remain, especially in a learning environment where collaboration is relatively new, as in Vietnam. Taking into consideration these obstacles, it was my hope that this study would have sufficient time for both the students and teachers to become familiar and comfortable with collaborative wikis.

My study used blended modes: both face-to-face and wiki collaboration. The use of blended mode was supported by cultural factors. Latchem and Ryan (2013) reviewed studies on factors influencing online learning in Asia. The authors conclude that “it is clearly important for distance teaching to provide both a sense of ‘teaching presence’ ..., and ‘social presence’ through interaction with tutors and other students” (Latchem & Ryan, 2013, p. 62). The pre-writing stage was conducted through face-to-face meetings, and the other stages through wiki platforms.

A second issue is students’ unwillingness to edit and to be edited by others and their focus on individual work, which may make collaborative learning through wikis less effective than teacher-edited work. It has been reported in some studies that students most frequently added content to a wiki, while they less frequently edited, or elaborated the existing posts of others, especially when the posts were the first drafts (Kear et al., 2010; McPherson, 2006; Witney & Smallbone, 2011). Also, students

tend to feel resistant to having their own posts edited or deleted by their peers (Wheeler et al., 2008). Due to the long-term embedded culture of individual authorship, which is thought to go hand in hand with credits or grades, the students did not appreciate communal and collective work. Two discouraging consequences can be seen from this unwillingness: the students would divide the tasks into equal subtasks and the collaborative work becomes a “series of vignettes by individual authors”, or the students felt discouraged if the grades were equally assigned (Weingarten & Frost, 2011). Unfamiliarity with wikis and unwillingness to participate in wiki projects may make learning through wikis not so advantageous when compared to that of face-to-face collaboration.

Third, the assessment of learning through wikis continues to be an issue of concern to wiki advocates (Bruns & Humphreys, 2005; Judd, Kennedy, & Cropper, 2010; Trentin, 2009). Up to the present, four main types in both qualitative and quantitative forms have been used as wiki assessments: *quizzes*, *rubrics*, *peer assessment*, and *wiki usage data* (Pusey & Meiselwitz, 2011, p. 61). The research on learning writing emphasises the use of peer assessment and wiki usage data. Peer assessment is commonly used as a way not only to improve students’ learning opportunities but also to reduce teachers’ assessment workload. The validity, reliability of rating scores and students’ satisfaction with peer assessment of writing were extremely high (Wever, Keer, Schelens, & Valcke, 2011; Xiao & Lucking, 2008). However, to make peer assessment a satisfactory mode, much needs to be done. This is due to the fact that in most cases, students did not want the negative or “too vague to be of any use” comments on their work from their peers (Gehring, 2008, p. 6). In addition, when working together, some students might make more superficial contributions than others, but the credits or grades were equally assigned among members in the group

(Judd et al., 2010). These really make collaboration less effective. The second popular way of assessing co-authoring work is by using wiki data. Wikis have functions in which teachers or instructors are provided with the tracks of the individual posts. This type of assessment can help grade students individually according to their contributions while they are collaborating. Students consider wiki data usage, reflecting their individual contributions, a fairer means than peer assessment. It is not a perfect tool for assessment, however. As the quality of contributions is more important than the quantity, frequent posts in wikis should be evaluated according to how they help to construct the final content rather than number of posts (Pusey & Meiselwitz, 2011). To do that, the automated wiki function system which records user activity, and analyses the contents, supports both formative and summative programmes of assessment and both need to be used (Trentin, 2009). This system, however, is either still “beyond our immediate reach” (Judd et al., 2010, p. 352) or difficult to implement because it requires radically rethinking traditional evaluation techniques (Swain, Shen, & Hiltz, 2006).

Taken together, the three main disadvantages aforementioned in this sub-section mostly relate to wiki technical issues and learners’ perceptions of collaboration. Although they are considered as impediments to wiki learning success, solutions can be suggested. First, recent wiki generations facilitate a more effective platform for collaborative and assessment tasks. Second, teachers’/instructors’ perceptions of and preparations for wiki collaboration can contribute to the success of wiki learning.

2.3.3 Choice of wikis from the advantages and disadvantages

On the one hand, the benefits of learning through wikis to promote learning in general and learning L2 writing in particular are theoretically and practically strong. Although concerns regarding the use of wikis remain, wikis are noticeably on the rise

as a favoured Web 2.0 platform to enhance learning collaboration so as to lead to writing development. This can be explained by the fact that the advantages of wikis in promoting learners' participation, such as raising students' motivation, and improving writing quality in terms of accuracy, fluency and complexity, outweigh the disadvantages of wikis including some technical or functional difficulties for social interactions, as well as teachers'/learners' discomfort or unfamiliarity. It is also because that the technology is relatively new and further studies, like my own, will enhance knowledge in the language education field. The next section, which describes technology-enhanced learning in the Vietnamese context and emphasises the practicality and efficacy of L2 writing wiki applications, will further support this viewpoint.

2.4 TECHNOLOGY-ENHANCED LEARNING AND ONLINE LEARNING IN THE SCHOOL SYSTEM IN VIETNAM

As mentioned in Section 2.2, a change in traditional pedagogy to meet the requirements of communicative English teaching in Vietnam is considered an urgent necessity. Section 2.3 argues that CLT through online modes, especially wikis, can impact positively on L2 learners' perceptions as well as writing quality. This section describes the picture of information communications technology (ICT) and online learning in Vietnam, focussing on the potentials and difficulties of L2 online learning. It starts by citing the goals and efforts made by the MoET to implement technology into the education system. It then reviews the studies conducted on the potentials of EFL technology-enhanced learning in the Vietnamese context. It then canvasses the discussions of the gaps between the goals/objectives set in the curriculum, the considerable benefits that technology can offer, and the current practices of using technology. The last part of this section, aligning with the previous

sections, reemphasises that using online learning, especially through wikis, is one practical solution to improve L2 writing quality.

In Vietnam, the implementation of technology into education has always been encouraged by the government, the MoET, and educational institutions. To illustrate, in 2008, the government issued Decree 64/2007/ND-CP to instruct the applications of information technology in education for a period from 2008 to 2011 (1400/QD-TTG, 2008). Under the guidelines of this Decree, the MoET launched a movement of ICT applications in school systems at all levels. The school year 2008-2009 was named “ICT applications school year” to mark the initiation of the movement. Educational institutions, especially at the tertiary level, have invested in facilities in order to take advantages of the potential that technology can bring to teaching and learning. Accordingly, online learning facilities such as LAN, ADSL (broadband), online learning centres, open source software, and server-based software have been investigated (Brine & Johnson, 2008; Hoang, Tong, Hoang, & Nguyen, 2010). Technology enhancement in foreign languages learning has also been the centre of attention of educational budget policies. In 2006, a huge investment of 16,000 billion VND (approximately equivalent to US \$80 million) was made. The project, named the National Implementation Plan of Foreign Languages Education, aimed to improve foreign languages teaching in the public formal education system from 2008 to 2020. In this plan, English ranks first before other languages such as Chinese, Russian and French. The provision of learning and teaching facilities such as classrooms, multimedia labs, and library resources was prioritised at the initial stage of the project (1400/QD-TTG, 2008). The integration of information technology through regular ICT training for teachers and technology-enhanced lessons were also established as equally important.

Together with considerable investment, technology-enhanced learning in Vietnam has also been supported as an effective mode in L2 learning by research in the field. From local as well as international studies conducted in the Vietnamese tertiary setting, it can be concluded that online learning has brought advantages that traditional face-to-face learning has not. First, the internet can provide EFL teachers and learners with valuable, authentic and up-to-date language resources and materials (Le & Lin, 2008; V. L. Nguyen, 2008). As mentioned in Sub-section 2.1.3, the limited, inauthentic and out-of-date textbooks are one of the five hindrances to CLT. With the availability of learning resources from the internet, some of these difficulties can be overcome.

Second, technology-enhanced learning sets up a convenient platform for communication between teachers and students, and collaboration between students and students (Le & Lin, 2008). As a result of these communication and collaboration strategies, the teaching and learning of English can shift from the teacher-centred method, which is currently the weakness of traditional pedagogy, into a more learner-centred approach. Third, Vietnamese teachers expressed positive attitudes towards learning with the assistance of technology. In a quasi-experimental study conducted with four Vietnamese teachers of English, Luu (2011) reported that the teachers showed changes in their attitudes towards the implementation of computer-based activities into teaching English listening. The teachers had negative attitudes towards computer-assisted language learning before the intervention of the researcher. However, they reflected more positively when the research finished. This was because the technology teaching experience helped the teachers gain better skills in teaching L2 listening. For example, they could select effective sources from the internet for their listening instruction. The teachers' positive attitudes increased when

the listening scores of the pilot groups improved significantly. Bui (2006) recommended that technology could be used to enhance students' speaking skills. Dang and Robertson (2010) conducted research on the impacts of the adoption of Moodle, a Web 2.0 Learning Management System, on learner autonomy. The discussion forum was technologically based to facilitate university students' collaboration in a 16-week Listening-Speaking course. The researchers then interviewed four students among 240 attendants. They found that EFL learner autonomy with regard to the initiation, monitoring and evaluation of their learning progress increased.

As facilitated by the enhancement of technology learning, some development of English online learning has been reported. Le and Lin (2008) in their exploratory study, which analysed data collected from books, internet, journal and conference papers, reported that there are some Learning Management Systems currently used in supporting L2 learning in Vietnam. They are EduNet, Blackboard/WebCT (BlackCT) and Moodle. EduNet is the education network provided by the MoET to share textbook sources, an e-learning portal and information management systems. Blackboard/WebCT software has many convenient collaborative functions for learning, for example, Assignment, Chat, and Whiteboard sections. However, because the price of Blackboard/WebCT is high, only a few universities in Vietnam can afford this system. Moodle is the most popular learning management system in Vietnam because it is open source and license free. Brine and Johnson (2008) reported on the use of Moodle blended with FLAX and showed that blended software could help EFL teachers select different exercise types in order to develop different language learning tasks in accordance with specific classroom needs. All of these

applications, however, are rather limited when compared with the targets set by the MoET.

More specifically, the uptake of technology-enhanced and on-line learning in tertiary education in Vietnam is not as encouraging as expected despite the support mentioned above. There is still a gap between rhetoric and reality. It has been reported that “no educational revolution [in technology adoption] is taking place in Vietnam yet” (Peeraer & Petegem, 2010, p. 922). Research also indicates that “a big investment into technology infrastructure and the top-down approach of implementing technological change in English teaching is not a guarantee for the adoption of technology by English teachers in their classroom practice” (Dinh, 2009, p. 99). A case study conducted in a well-known foreign languages training university in Hanoi by Dang (2011) illustrates the whole picture of the current use of ICT facilities in teaching L2 in Vietnam:

In general, teachers use ICT to prepare for lessons and to deliver those lessons in class. For lesson preparation, the results show the following common pattern of ICT use. Teachers search the internet; download relevant materials; design practice activities with word processing; prepare presentations with Microsoft (MS) PowerPoint. Email is used for exchange of communication with other colleagues and/or students. Such programmes as audio editing, mindmapping, video editing, e-lecture making, photo editing, Hot Potatoes, screencasting, and VoiceThreads are often viewed as difficult and consequently rarely used by teachers. (p.2)

Studies have been conducted to seek the answers as to why ICT adoption is not a widespread success in Vietnam. A study of 783 teacher educators in five teacher institutions in North and Central Vietnam conducted by Peeraer and Petegem (2010)

showed that Vietnamese teachers and educators showed positive attitudes towards ICT for education, because they were aware of the potential benefits that ICT could bring to their teaching practices. However, the lack of teacher ICT confidence was identified as the main cause of the slow progress of technology adoption into education. Their findings suggested that ICT integration should not have started with the mere provision of top-down infrastructure. Educating teachers in terms of ICT skills training as well as pedagogical training was of more importance. Another study by Dinh (2009) was conducted with L2 Vietnamese novice teachers, who were new university graduates and had taught for less than six years. The researcher found that the main difficulties lay in such variables as pedagogical, professional and technical factors. The findings align with those of Peeraer and Petegem (2010) with regard to the necessity of integrating the training of teachers' ICT skills as part of their professional development. When the teachers were confident of their ICT skills, they were ready to apply them into their teaching practices. When they were professionally trained, they found it easier to give up traditional teacher-dominated pedagogy and to employ more teacher-facilitated learning. In Dang's (2011) case study with language teachers, senior leaders and ICT experts at a university in Hanoi, findings indicated that teachers were one of the main inhibitors to ICT integration. Teachers believed that ICT integration into teaching would increase their working hours and load. First, they would have more workload with one hour of ICT-enhanced lessons than the traditional lessons: for one class hour of a technology-enhanced lesson, three to four preparation hours were needed. Second, the teachers could not borrow computers to take home, so if they wanted to work online, they had to buy computers and connect to the internet by themselves, which was costly in Vietnam. As a result, they preferred to retain traditional face-to-face pedagogy.

From the review above, it can be seen that although the integration of ICT into learning has been both financially and practically supported in Vietnam, there are considerable obstacles to overcome before technology-based learning can become effective in Vietnam. The pitfalls result from inappropriate top-down investment, lack of ICT and professional skills training, and teachers' fear of adopting new teaching modes. These difficulties make integration of ICT a slow process.

Linking this section with the previous sections, which discuss the context of English learning in Vietnam (section 2.1), the advantages of collaborative learning (Section 2.2) and online collaborative writing through wikis (Section 2.3), it is predicted that collaborative writing through wikis may be difficult to introduce because of teachers' initial reservations concerning giving up their traditional teaching preferences. However, the MoET's support for technology-enhanced language learning is crucial to an environment where wiki writing programmes can be potentially successful in Vietnam.

2.5 SUMMARY AND IMPLICATIONS

This study follows the previous studies on L2 writing collaboration through wikis to investigate teachers' and students' expectations of and reflections on collaborative learning through face-to-face and wiki collaboration. It also discusses how these collaborative modes can enhance students' participation in and awareness of L2 writing strategies. This chapter started with the background of ELT in Vietnam and ended with the suitability of applying collaborative writing through face-to-face and wiki modes in Vietnam. The chapter reviewed a wide range of literature, focusing on the strengths as well as the weaknesses of face-to-face and online collaborative writing, more specifically on collaborative wikis. Embedded through this chapter is

the premise that collaborative learning can enhance L2 teaching and learning in contexts such as Vietnam.

A proposed theoretical framework for the application of collaborative learning to enhance L2 learners' participation with strategies of process writing will be presented in the next chapter.

Chapter 3: Theoretical Framework

The primary purpose of Chapter 3 is to construct a framework which provides a theoretical base for the central idea that collaborative learning through face-to-face and wiki modes can lead to students' L2 writing development. Hence, this chapter begins with a discussion of the salient features of theories about collaborative learning, in contrast to the studies on collaborative learning advantages and disadvantages considered in the previous chapter. These theories about learning through collaboration are then examined in the context of socio-cultural perspectives, which relate to the concepts of “zone of proximal development”, and “community of practice”. Similarly, collaborative learning in the field of L2 learning and the L2 process writing approach in particular, are supported by social constructivist theory. An examination of the affordances of collaborative learning as a tool in general education (Kirschner, Strijbos, Kreijns, & Beers, 2004), and specifically of wikis in this study, lead to the explanation of the potentials of wikis as an effective platform for L2 collaborative writing in Section 0. Section 3.4 provides the overall conceptual framework of the study. The chapter ends with a summary in Section 3.5.

More specifically, in Sub-section 3.2.1, the notion of the zone of proximal development, proposed by Vygotsky (1978, 1981), emphasises the facilitation role of teachers and more knowledgeable peers in learning development through collaboration. Consistent with Vygotsky's emphasis on mutual interactions, the concept of communities of practice, suggested by Lave and Wenger (1991), explains the process of “legitimate peripheral participation” through which a novice learner

constructs knowledge through social interactions with an expert (Sub-section 0). In the field of L2 learning, the followers of Vygotsky extend social constructivist theory to the point that collaboration among learners of similar levels of proficiency can develop L2 learning; this is covered in Sub-section 3.2.1. Sub-section 3.3.2 highlights social perspectives in the L2 process writing approach. It points out that learning scaffolding is embedded in the interactions among learner writers through each stage of the process writing approach. Wikis can be effective mediating objects to facilitate students' L2 writing involvement; this underpins the role of mediation in supporting learning, canvassed in Section 0. A synthesised theoretical framework for this study is presented in Section 3.4; the summary follows in Section 3.5.

3.1 COLLABORATIVE LEARNING AND SOCIAL CONSTRUCTIVIST THEORY

In the previous chapter, studies in collaborative learning have been reviewed to support the argument that collaborative learning can lead to learning development. In this section, the prominent characteristics of collaborative learning and the theory underpinning this approach to learning are discussed. Collaborative learning describes the interactions between learners in a mediated learning environment (Vygotsky, 1978). This also aligns with the notion of communities of practice where learning development is ascertained by the gradual but active participation of the novice into a community through shared repertoires (Lave & Wenger, 1991, 1998).

3.1.1 Collaborative learning characteristics

The history of collaborative learning can be traced back to early times when human beings informally grouped to learn from others in their community. Formally, collaborative learning in the field of general education was introduced, experimented with and concluded to be a successful mode of learning in the late 18th century

(Roberts, 2004). However, collaborative learning remains a complex concept which has not been clearly defined (Resta & Laferrière, 2007). In its broadest sense, this kind of learning refers to any activity or situation in which two or more people work together to learn, for example, exploring a topic, or improving a skill to create new knowledge (Dillenbourg, 1999; Harasim, Hiltz, Teles, & Turoff, 1995). In school learning, “two or more” refers to either students in pairs or small groups within a class. In its simplest form collaborative learning can be defined as social interactions between students to discover and attain new knowledge and skills (Chai, Chin, Koh, & Tan, 2013). The definition may still be contested, but in collaborative learning, the novice is expected to learn from the expert. I will later argue that peers of the same/similar proficiency levels also benefit in collaborative learning. In addition, learners are encouraged to inspire and depend upon one another in order to share knowledge and maximise their own and others’ strengths (Bruffee, 1999; Tu, 2004). Therefore, both the expert and novice benefit in collaborative learning.

Collaborative learning also implies that the knowledge acquisition process is constructed in a similar manner to that of the social communities in which students will participate or engage after graduating. These real communities, for example, in a company or a university, require their members to frequently work collaboratively (Bruffee, 1984; Bruffee, 1997; Bruffee, 1999). Whatever the ways of collaborating are, the final results that collaboration needs to produce are twofold: “the emergence of new knowledge and growth for the group” (Donato, 2004, p. 285). In other words, both individuals and groups benefit from collaborative learning.

Collaborative learning can be enacted in two modes: face-to-face and online. The latter is further subdivided into synchronous and asynchronous forms (Dillenbourg, 1999). These two modes are not necessarily distinct: a blended approach of face-to-

face and online modes can be used. This study will combine both face-to-face and online learning as will be explained in the sub-section about communities of practice (see Sub-section 3.2.2).

Four features are cited as predominant characteristics of collaborative learning. They are *knowledge sharing*, *authority sharing*, *teachers' mediating*, and *students' diversity* (Tinzman, Jones, Fennimore, Bakker, Fine, & Pierce, 1990). First and foremost, new knowledge is constructed through the experiences, strategies, and cultures that students bring to the class. This knowledge is combined with the teacher's expertise in content, skills and instruction. So, on the one hand, students' autonomy is centralised; on the other hand, the respect for teachers' expert knowledge is not lost. Second, the authority in the class is mutually established between teachers and students in specific ways: teachers' authority is reflected through their framing goals and specific objectives. Based on these, students establish their own goals and objectives, and importantly, assess what they can learn on their own or through peers. Third, teachers have the role of (a) mediators to facilitate students' learning and (b) providers of necessary assistance to connect students' existing and new knowledge. The teacher's main function in the class is to help students to self-discover knowledge by learning how to learn. Fourth, in collaborative learning, students are engaged in a process through which everyone can learn from one another. Ideally, all contributions made by any member in the group should be respected and considered vital to success in the collaborative work (Tinzmann, et al., 1990). In this study, students' diversity refers to the variety in students' language proficiency levels: in each collaborative group, there were both low and high proficiency level students.

A comparison between traditional and collaborative learning approaches stresses that the benefits of collaborative learning outweigh those of traditional learning (McInnerney & Roberts, 2004). This is mainly because of the differences in teachers' and students' roles within the two approaches. In collaborative learning, teachers' roles shift from the "sage on the stage" to "guide on the side", hence students are not passive individual receivers of knowledge (Jones, 2006). Collaborative learning requires that the teacher mainly functions as a mediator: he/she becomes less an authority figure, and more a resource and facilitator and a learning designer for the group learning activities (Harasim et al., 1995). It also requires that students work autonomously within groups both inside and outside the classroom. All in all, knowledge is, in essence, co-constructed through social interactions between teachers, students and peers. As a result, collaborative learning highlights the relationship between learning and the social situations in which learning occurs. It particularly emphasises how individual interactions contribute to build up community knowledge. It is the mutual interactions between learners that make collaborative learning far different from traditional learning. Thus, collaborative learning promises potential changes when introduced to traditional contexts such as the University in this study.

In short, in collaborative learning, learners co-construct new knowledge by mutual interactions and active participation, sharing and exchanging ideas while teachers function as facilitators to support students' learning. In the following sub-sections, I will discuss how social constructivist theory underpins and supports collaborative learning.

3.1.2 Social constructivist theory and collaborative learning

Social constructivist theory is a theory of knowledge which is largely attributed originally to Lev Vygotsky (1978, 1986). It has been argued that Social constructivist theory can provide us with a theoretical framework for collaborative learning (Guerrero & Villamil, 2000; Lantolf, 2000; Ohta, 2001). The foundation of sociocultural theory holds that learning is socially and culturally *mediated* (Donato, 2004; Guerrero & Villamil, 2000; Lantolf, 2000). That is, learning and development “emerge and are shaped by the social, cultural, and historical contexts in which individuals engage in meaningful and purposeful joint activity” (Donato, 2004, p. 295). Primarily evolved from Vygotsky’s (1978, 1986) proposal of the zone of proximal development, sociocultural theory also encompasses Lave and Wenger’s (1991) concept of communities of practice (Chai, Lim, So, & Cheah, 2011).

Zone of proximal development

Vygotsky’s social constructivist theory of learning has been one of the theories that provided much impetus to drive collaborative learning (Chai et al., 2011). Vygotsky (1978, 1980, 2012) especially emphasises interactions between the novice and the expert to create understanding: “learners participate in a broad range of joint activities and internalize the effects of working together; they acquire new strategies and knowledge of the world and culture” (Palincsar, 1988, pp. 351-352). Vygotsky argues that the interactions between teachers, learners and peers will lead to the development of the “zone of proximal development” (ZPD). This zone is defined as:

The distance between the actual development level as determined by independent problem solving and the level of potential development as determined through problem solving under adult guidance or in collaboration with more capable peers. (Vygotsky, 1978, p. 85)

More specifically, the ZPD can be explained through the gap created by what students can learn alone and what students can potentially achieve if they work with more knowledgeable others. What students can know is indicative of their *actual developmental level*, that is, the level of students' biologically matured mental development as a result of certain prior, completed, developmental cycles. The actual developmental level can help students solve problems independently and by themselves without the assistance of the expert. What the student potentially knows, their ZPD, is determined through problems that students cannot solve independently. Instead, they need assistance from teachers or more experienced peers. Therefore, interactions between the novice and the expert in learning are essential to assist the student to advance through his or her own ZPD (Lund, 2008; Warchauer, 1997). This is because social interactions in the ZPD will also help a variety of students' internal developmental processes to be activated (Vygotsky, 1987). It can be said that central to social constructivist theory is the notion that "higher forms of thinking and the ability to perform certain complex skills originate in and are shaped by social interaction" (Villamil & Guerrero, 2006, p.24).

Vygotsky's ZPD in the field of general education has been associated in literature with the metaphor of "scaffolding" (Chai et al., 2011; Guerrero & Villamil, 2000; Wood, Bruner, & Ross, 1976). It must be noted that Vygotsky himself did not use this term in his work. The term was first coined by Bruner (Wood et al., 1976). It originally refers to the role of a tutor to assist a student in fostering and enhancing learning. Wood and colleagues (1976, p.90) defined scaffolding as: "Those elements of the task that are initially beyond the learner's capacity, thus permitting him to concentrate upon and complete only those elements that are within his range of competence."

Scaffolding is now widely used in the literature to describe the assistance needed to help learners proceed from a lower to a higher level of performance (Bodrova & Leong, 2003; Guerrero & Villamil, 2000). In other words, scaffolding is the assistance which helps learners to proceed in the ZPD. Learners' competence is developed to solve complex problems beyond the capacity of individuals if they learn alone (Vygotsky, 1978(Bakhtin, 2010)). In addition, scaffolding should be offered when students need it and withdrawn when learners show signs of being able to perform independently (Lantolf & Aljaafreh, 1995). This is an important point that I took into consideration when designing my research. The research is guided by collaborative, cooperative learning characteristics and process-genre approaches which highlight the importance of both learners' co-construction of knowledge and teachers' input. The procedure of scaffolding in my study follows two steps: providing scaffolding in pre-writing and feedback stages and removing scaffolding in drafting, revising and publishing stages.

My study emphasises the importance of students as central to learning, and also considers that teachers' expert guidance plays an essential part before the students successfully collaborate. Teachers' roles are vital in cases where students' levels of proficiency and the language knowledge they bring to class are varied (see Table 1.2). The study also emphasises students' sharing and exchanging understanding to gain new knowledge and skills. "The novice" refers to students with low L2 writing proficiency levels and "the expert" to more capable peers. In this study, students' advance in their ZPD was observed through their engagement in each stage of writing. The study also demonstrated that teachers' expert scaffolding was important for students during their initial collaboration. The scaffolding gradually decreased to facilitate students' independent learning.

Communities of practice

As discussed, the notions of ZPD and scaffolding emphasise the importance of mutual interactions, expert assistance and mediated tools to create learning development. The concept of a community of practice can provide us with insights to understand collaborative learning more deeply (Hara, 2009). In essence, a community of practice can clarify the learning environment and activities that novice learners should participate under the guidance of the expert to advance their learning. In their simplest form, communities of practice are groups of people informally bound together by shared expertise for a joint enterprise (Wenger & Snyder, 2000).

It should be emphasised that a group of people having the same interest or passion is not always a community of practice. Only those groups which share expertise and interest interact through *a practice* are called “communities of practice.” *The practice* refers to shared resources including experiences, stories, tools, and ways of addressing problems among the members in the group (Wenger, 2008). To associate practice in a community who have the same domain, three dimensions should be considered: *mutual engagement*, *joint enterprise* and *shared repertoire* (Wenger, 2008). Mutuality is the foundation of a community of practice: community members need to engage, interact and negotiate with one another to solve problems and make learning happen. Without mutual interactions, a community of practice does not exist. This links to collaborative learning: without social interactions, collaborative learning cannot occur. Joint enterprise embodies the shared interest of community members and the goal of the community as a whole, and symbolises what the community is about (Zhang & Watts, 2008). It also means that group members have not only their shared domain but also the same goals and objectives of doing something. A shared repertoire “includes routines, words, tools, ways of doing

things, stories, gestures, symbols, actions, or concepts that the community has produced or adopted in the course of its existence, and which have become part of its practice” (Wenger, 1998, p. 83). In collaborative learning, the concept of shared repertoires is reflected through the mediation of artefacts and private dialogues. In L2 collaborative language learning, shared repertoires can be language inputs that students bring to class, their ways of exchanging and sharing information or tools such as wikis to mediate learning. From the definition and characteristics of a community of practice, it can be seen that such a community of practice offers an effective environment for collaborative learning, which, as discussed above, also requires participants to work jointly with the support of mediated objects to share ideas in order to co-construct new knowledge.

A specific community of practice requires that members act in a participatory frame. This frame specifically emphasises the importance of learners’ gradual participation. Lave and Wenger (1991, 1998) name this process “legitimate peripheral participation.”

Legitimate peripheral participation’ provides a way to speak about the relations between newcomers and old timers, and about activities, identities, artefacts, and communities of knowledge and practice. It concerns the process by which newcomers become part of a Community of Practice. A person’s intentions to learn are engaged and the meaning of learning is configured through the process of becoming a full participant in a sociocultural practice. (Lave & Wenger, 1991, p. 29)

According to Lave and Wenger (1991), legitimate peripheral participation is not a simple inactive participation framework. A novice learner (or a newcomer) will be situated to become a part of a learning community, accessing the experts in that

community. When a learner first joins in the community, he/she will observe others, be absorbed in the existing culture of practice, and make the culture of practice become their own. The process of learning in a community of practice requires that when the novice becomes an expert through practice and participation in the community, he/she will become the new “expert” to mentor others. With the participants of this study, who are novices to collaborative writing and wiki learning, it can be assumed that the learner participants may not learn effectively if they do not have gradual participation in the collaborative learning environment in the presence of an expert. This will be further discussed in the design of the collaborative writing programme (see Section 4.3).

Besides the requisite of gradual participation, legitimate peripheral participation emphasises learners’ shifting roles. It means that the novice does not merely occupy a fixed role in the entire process of learning. In contrast, he/she is engaged in several roles. These roles may involve “status subordinate, learning practitioner, sole responsible agent in minor parts of the performance, aspiring expert, and so forth – each implying a different sort of responsibility, a different set of role relations, and a different interactive involvement” (Lave & Wenger, 1991, p. 20). The success of a community of practice is cultivated through “a set of regulations among persons, activity, and world, over time and in relation with other tangential and overlapping communities of practice” (Lave & Wenger, 1991, p. 98). Mutual interactions of learners are considered “an intrinsic condition for the existence of knowledge” (Lave & Wenger, 1991, p.98). Lave and Wenger (1991) also implied that circulation of information among peers suggests that students are actually engaging in practice. Therefore, the active roles of learners when participating in a community of practice should be evaluated through repertoires that the students share with one another. A

blended community that integrates online learning and face-to-face meetings is suggested as an effective mode for collaborative learning because (1) the deeper the personal relationships between learners, the richer the collaborative learning experience; and (2) relationships between learners may be strengthened through structuring group interactions (using technology) before and/or after a face-to-face training event (Kaplan, 2002). Based on Kaplan's viewpoints, the community of my research will be blended: face-to-face meetings for the pre-writing stage, and asynchronous online learning through wikis for other stages of the L2 process writing (see Section 4.3).

It can be seen that from social constructivist perspectives, a community of practice with students' legitimate peripheral participation through practice, including shared learning and legitimate participation, sheds light on the process of collaborative learning: the novices come to a community or small group as the newcomers; in order to gain new knowledge, they need to change their roles actively from observers to partially practitioners and, finally, full participants.

Working from a community of practice perspective, collaborative learning applied in this study becomes more effective when the processes of students' participation in the L2 collaborative writing community using wikis were taken into account. Besides mutual interactions between low proficiency students and more capable peers, students' gradual and active participation into the community through shared repertoires is important to learners' development in terms of their engagement in L2 writing activities.

3.1.3 Summary of the conceptual framework for collaborative learning in the field of general education

As discussed above, social constructivist theory with the concepts of ZPD and communities of practice provides insights to understand collaborative learning. It can be seen that active interactions and sharing in a community makes collaborative learning different from the traditional views of learning. Collaborative learning is situated in a community, and students gradually moving from marginal participation to full participation. Assistance of more able peers can enable the novice to advance in the ZPD. Shared repertoires among learners in the community and teachers' facilitation are also seen as important factors to mediate students' development.

In the next section, social constructivist perspectives in the field of L2 learning and particularly in L2 writing will be outlined.

3.2 SOCIAL CONSTRUCTIVIST THEORY AND L2 PROCESS-GENRE APPROACH TO TEACHING WRITING

This section aims to investigate collaborative interaction in the field of L2 learning and, more specifically, L2 writing. The section begins with a discussion of the notion of ZPD and the scaffolding in L2 learning that is suggested by Vygotsky followers. It also reports the collaborative aspects of the L2 process-genre writing approach. Highlighted in the section is the development of L2 learning and L2 process writing skills which can be seen through the interactions and practice in small groups of students.

3.2.1 Social constructivist theory in the field of L2 learning

In the field of L2 language learning, the shift from individual acquisition to artefact-mediated collaborative participation (Lund, 2008), has emerged: the interactions between the expert and the novice in a community of practice to create learners'

scaffolding can be applied to explain the process of L2 language learning development (e.g., Lantoff, 2000, 2006). Highlighted in the theories on second language learning is also the importance of social interactions among learners to facilitate language learning. Among many social constructivist theory followers, Ohta (2001) worked on Vygotsky's definition and reformulated ZPD in L2 learning. In Ohta's refined definition, Vygotsky's concept of ZPD is also considered the zone in which L2 learners interact, collaborate, and acquire the target language in order that they can bridge the gap between what they actually know and what they potentially know:

For the L2 learner, the ZPD is the distance between the actual development level as determined by individual linguistic production, and the level of potential development as determined through language produced collaboratively with a teacher or a peer. (Ohta, 2001, p. 9)

Similar to Vygotsky's ZPD in the field of general education, in this adapted definition for L2 learning, students' language development is based on supportive behaviours. Appropriate assistance "enables learners to successfully accomplish interactive tasks pitched just above their independent ability" (Ohta, 2001, p. 10). However, if in Vygotsky's ZPD the assistance of the adult or more knowledgeable peers is more noticeable, Ohta's definition highlights that assistance in L2 learning is provided not only by teachers or more capable peers but also peers of *similar* levels of proficiency. This can be explained because, on the one hand, the expert can act as the observer, guide, or supporter to shape the knowledge-gaining process of the novice. Taking into account that "teaching" a less capable peer also refines your own knowledge, the novice, in turn, can help the expert internalise and scaffold their strategic process (Donato, 1994). On the other hand, even when peers are grouped

according to the similarities of their proficiency levels, each member still has his or her different strengths and weaknesses because of the fact that no two learners have the same complement of strengths and weaknesses. Therefore, “peer learning has the potential of allowing performance that is of a higher level than that of any individual involved” (Ohta, 2001, p. 74). Donato (1994) studied the progress of three L2 novice learners who collaborated to mutually construct scaffolding. He suggested that “in the process of peer scaffolding, learners can expand their own L2 knowledge and extend the linguistic development of their peers” (p. 52) despite the fact that they are all the novice learners in the L2 learning field. Therefore, scaffolding can occur when L2 students of similar levels of proficiency interact with one another. Similar to the field of general education, learners’ ZPD in the L2 field is developed through dialogic negotiation between learners and the mediation of artefacts and teachers (Lantolf & Alijaafreh, 1995).

From Ohta’s (2001) extended definition, Donato’s study (1994), and Lantolf and Alijaafreh’s concepts (1995), it can be argued that interactions among L2 learners, regardless of their difference in levels of proficiency, and mediated artefacts, may facilitate students to advance in their ZPD. This is an important foundation for my study as it applies social constructivist theory in the field of L2 learning to investigate the interactions between novice learners through wiki platforms. In particular, in the next sub-section, the application of social constructivist theory in L2 writing will be discussed.

3.2.2 Process-genre approach to teaching L2 collaborative writing

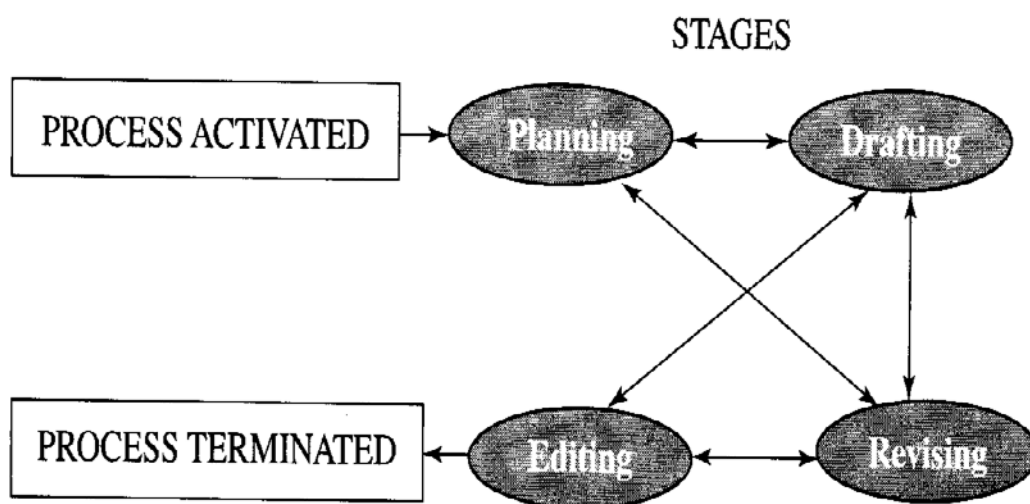
Generally, in the field of L2, writers need to develop four kinds of knowledge. Tribble (2001) described these as (a) content knowledge – the concept involved in the subject area, (b) writing process knowledge – the most appropriate way of

carrying out a specific writing task, (c) context knowledge – the social context in which the text will be read, and (d) language system knowledge – those aspects of the language system necessary for the completion of the task. The process and genre approaches to writing reviewed below have their strengths and weaknesses in developing the types of knowledge that Tribble mentioned. The connection of process-genre pedagogies provides the underpinning approach for this study.

Process writing approach to teaching L2 writing

In its early development, the process writing approach is constructed on the insight that writing is an individual cognitive process (Hayes & Flower, 1987). The approach rests on the idea that to write effectively, learners should be aware of how to write by seeking answers to the questions: where ideas come from, how they are developed, and what stages of writing are (Zamel, 1982, 1983).

To respond to such questions, learners need to be provided with writing knowledge process. The pedagogies for process approach involves four main stages, namely, *planning/ prewriting, drafting/ composing, revising, and editing* (Seow, 2002; Tribble, 1996). The figure on the next page describes the relation and the processes of these stages.



Source: adapted from Seow (2002)

Figure 3.1 Stages of the process writing approach

As can be seen from Figure 3.1, the process writing approach will commence with students' planning and drafting, and end with their editing and revising their writing. The four stages are not necessarily linear or sequential. It is actually an iterative approach focusing on the recursive activities or techniques that learners use when writing. This means that "at any point in the preparation of a text, writers can loop backwards or forwards to whichever of the activities involved in text composition they may find useful" (Tribble, 1996, p. 39).

The approach emphasises learners' exploring, discovering and generating what and how they want to write. Its strategies "shift the focus of attention from texts to writers" (Johns, Bawarshi, Coe, Hyland, Paltridge, Reiff, & Tardy, 2006, p. 244). Learners develop their writing skills by "creating and extending meaning, rather than merely conveying pre-conceived information" (Barnard & Campbell, 2005, p. 77). Writing is considered as a skill that was "essentially learned, not taught", and teachers' roles are "non-directive" with "minimal interference" to students' learning

(Hyland, 2004, p. 7). In sum, the process writing approach emphasises different stages of learners' thinking to construct their writing.

Recently, the L2 process approach has considered writing not only as an individual cognitive process but also situates it in social activities (Barnard & Campbell, 2005; Lantolf, 2000). Students' interacting with teachers or peers in each stage of writing is believed to enhance their writing development. Each stage of writing in Figure 3.1 (above) is extended to include activities that (a) students do together, for example, co-brainstorming, responding to peers' writing, joint publishing or (b) with the assistance of teachers, for example, conferencing or providing feedback on students' writing. These activities can be conducted via face-to-face meetings or technology-based platforms like wikis in my study.

As the process writing approach includes teachers' or peers' involvement in each stage of writing, it fits within perspectives of sociocultural theory as discussed in Sub-section 3.2.1. However, this approach has a limitation, especially in the context where language, the tool for cognitive development, is not learners' first language. According to the approach, learners are the centre of learning, and are presupposed to know the key genres in writing. Teachers' roles in process pedagogies are "by-standers with little to say about the ways texts are conventionally structured and used" (Hyland, 2004, p. 8). Teachers' scaffolding of types of texts and linguistics correction are postponed until the revising stage, which causes difficulties for L2 learners who cannot fully be exposed to or effectively control their language resources. Because of this limitation of the process writing approach, structural aspects of the genre approach have also been considered in the pedagogical approach to this study of L2 writing.

Genre approach to teaching writing

Underpinning the genre approach is the premise that languages are acquired only through social interactions with other human beings. All languages, whether L1, L2 or additional languages, have social semantic functions (Halliday, 1978). Although my study is not a purely Systemic Functional Linguistics-based thesis, I derive some of the perspectives arising from that field to conceptualise the genre writing approach I took in this writing class.

Systemic Functional Linguistics thinkers consider that “any language is a huge system with a great number of choices available to its users, depending on the meanings they wish to make” (Butt, Fahey, Feez, & Spinks, 2012, p. 3). Therefore, when texts written have the same purposes, for example, to persuade or to apologize, they share similar structural elements or genres (Butt et al., 2012). These genres are socially recognised by readers based on their experiences of reading previous texts which have similar purposes. Accordingly, genre is social-oriented (Hyland, 2004; Johns et al., 2006): it reflects the writers’ awareness of responding to readers’ social expectations of reading certain text types. Johns et al. (2006) discuss the importance of the social contexts of writing for readers:

[...] members of a community usually have little difficulty in recognizing similarities in the texts they use frequently and are able to draw on their repeated experiences of particular contexts to read, understand, and perhaps write the text that occurs in them relatively easily. (p. 237)

In contrast with the process writing approach, teachers have central roles in genre pedagogies, especially in providing scaffolding to students. Hyland (2004, p. 128) states that according to the Systemic Functional Linguistics, teachers’ scaffolding is a cyclical process including five stages:

- *Setting the context* – revealing genre purposes and the settings in which a genre is commonly used
- *Modelling* – analysing the genre to reveal its stages and key features
- *Joint construction* – guided, teacher-supported practice in the genre
- *Independent construction* – independent writing monitored by the teacher
- *Comparing* – relating what has been learned to other genres and contexts

Teachers' roles diminish gradually after each stage of genre approach: from controlling to guiding, but teachers' involvement in students' learning is observed in most stages. From the perspectives of sociocultural theory, teachers as experts can help learners develop writing skills within their ZPD.

There is a concern, however, regarding students' roles in learning genres. Badger and White (2000) state that teachers' providing students with model texts makes students' learning become a so-called process of analysing and imitating the texts. The explicit teaching of how to write certain texts makes students focus more on the form to express meanings rather than strategies of writing. Therefore, proponents of the approach argue that genre teaching can inhibit students' creativity in writing (Hyland, 2004).

Towards a connection of process-genre approach

It can be summarised that each writing approach has its strengths and weaknesses. The process approach focuses on learners' roles via stages of writing and postpones teachers' intervention until final stages. Learners who have sufficient knowledge of linguistic resources will find process approach effective. In contrast, learners in L2 context whose linguistic resources are limited will find this approach incomplete because they are in need of teachers' assistance in terms of linguistic input.

When combined these two approaches can supplement or round each other out so that learners can develop their knowledge of language and context of writing (genre approach) and develop strategies to produce texts (process approach) (Badger & White, 2000; Hyland, 2004). The process-genre approach used in this study is based on such a blend.

I consider the following important to conceptualise the framework of this study: teachers' providing input and scaffolding, stages of writing, students' working together via collaboration and cooperation. Teachers' roles are seen through training students on stages of writing, explicit instructions on genres, and facilitating students' working. Stages of writing involve pre-writing, drafting, feedback, revising and publishing via face-to-face and wiki platforms. Students' collaboration is in the pre-writing, feedback and publishing stages, and cooperation in drafting and revising stages. Table 3.1 in next chapter provides more details regarding teachers' and students' roles and stages of writing.

3.3 AFFORDANCES OF WIKIS TO SUPPORT L2 WRITING

The previous section showed that sociocultural theory provides an explanatory framework for collaborative learning by facilitating scaffolding in learners' ZPD when practising in a community of practice through shared repertoires. In this section, the social perspectives will be viewed in L2 learning in general and the process writing approach in particular. Highlighted in these sections is the importance of social interactions between the experts and the novices and among the novices themselves through shared repertoires to mediate learning. The mediation of artefact tools is also discussed.

In this section, the importance of mediated objects, specifically wikis, will be discussed. This section is firstly developed in accordance with aspects of social constructivist theory, which emphasises the importance of tools or objects to facilitate learning (see 3.1.2). This part is also based on Warschauer's (1997, 2010) reviews of a wide range of research investigating the relationship between technology and L2 learning. He pointed out that "the diffusion of computers and the Internet is likely to be as important for the development of writing as was the earlier advent of the printing press" (Warschauer, 1997, p. 164). As a Web 2.0 interactive tool, wikis have the potential to be one of the effective affordances to facilitate the development of collaborative learning as well as L2 process writing.

Historically, the term "affordances" was coined by the perceptual psychologist Gibson (1977). Affordances are used to denote a mutual relationship, for good or for ill, between a life form and other organisms in the same environment. Gibson's (1977) definition discusses the real relationship between the tool and the actor (animals or people). The affordances of a tool explicitly refer to the tool's physical attributes that can be compatible with the actor. Affordances, in this sense, exist independently of the actor's perception. It means that affordances "exist naturally: they do not have to be visible, known or desirable" (Norman, 1998). Norman (1998), from the design perspective, suggested quite a contrasting definition of affordances: he says that the affordances of a tool involve both the actual properties, which exist outside the perceptions of users, and perceived properties, which are determined by the experience, knowledge or culture of users. Both the real and perceived properties will determine the potential usability of the tool. My research sits in the collaborative context culture, and highlights the importance of the knowledge that learners bring to class, with the emphasis on the teacher needing to assist at the initial stage of

collaboration. Therefore, I adopt Norman's (1998) viewpoint, which considers that learning affordances include both physical and perceived attributes of a tool. The physical properties of a tool combined with the culture and experience of learners can help learners perform learning tasks in a situated learning environment, as presented in the figure below.

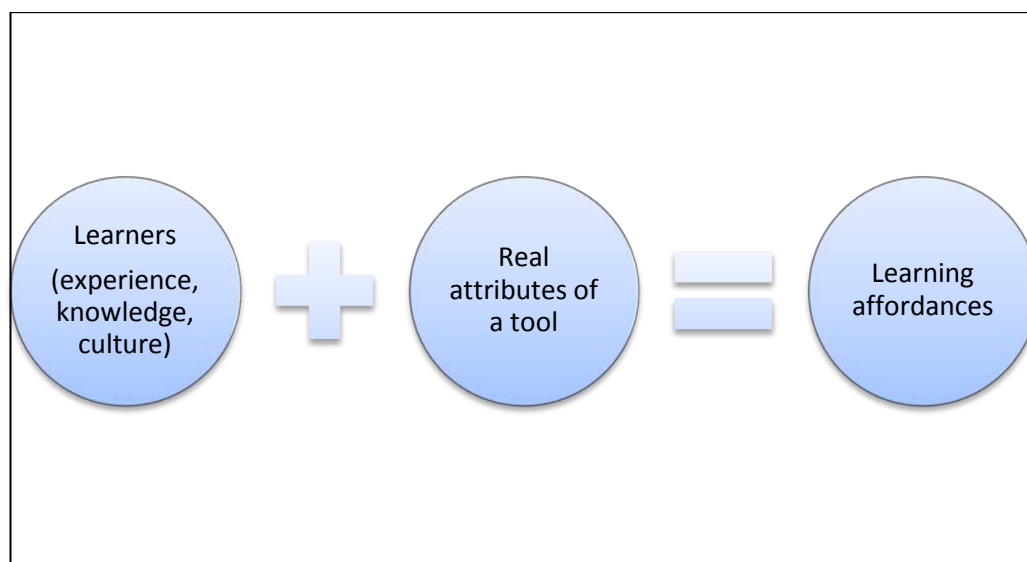


Figure 3.2 Characteristics of learning affordances of a tool applied in this study

With the advent of the internet, perspectives on the affordances of networking technologies to facilitate collaborative learning have evolved from Gibson's (1977) and Norman's (1998) definitions. Kirschner et al. (2004) synthesise and differentiate three types of affordances necessary for collaborative learning: educational affordances, technological affordances and social affordances. Educational affordances describe the relationship between the characteristics of an artefact and a particular learning behaviour in a particular context. Technological affordances emphasise the usability of a tool/object. Usability connotes that the tool allows the user to effectively perform tasks (Kirschner et al., 2004; Norman, 1998). Social affordances are seen as the relationship between the artefact and the social learning contexts, which can facilitate the learner's social interactions. From Kirschner and

colleagues' (2004) perspectives on affordances of collaborative learning through technology, wikis can be considered affordances of collaborative writing if they can mimic the characteristics of collaborative learning, that is, *knowledge sharing*, *authority sharing*, *teachers' mediating*, and *students' diversity* (see 3.2.1).

It can be seen that the real and perceived attributes of wikis can *match* the characteristics of collaborative learning. First, wikis are physically designed as “open” to promote collaboration among groups of writers and readers. People in different locations can work at different times with wikis. The fact that wiki users can add, elaborate, edit or even delete previous and existing contributions, while the recently modified or changed parts of the texts can still be stored or notified, make wikis more effective for collaborative writing than other asynchronous Web 2.0 tools. For example, the reader of blogs and threaded discussions may be invited to read, comment on or elaborate on the existing entries, but they typically have no opportunities for editing or deleting previous posts (Klobas, 2006; West & West, 2008). Wikis also offer students opportunities to write using nonlinear text structures. Students can come back or forward to the processes that they think necessary for their writings. Wikis, therefore, can promote revision, tracking of drafts and open editing (Bradley et al., 2010), which makes them an effective platform for social writing such as in the collaborative process approach. Second, wikis' perceived properties can facilitate social interactions in collaborative writing. Wiki writings require students to acquire the skills of negotiating and cooperating, and to respect others' work and thoughts (McPherson, 2006; Richardson, 2010).

Knowledge in wikis is not built up individually. By contrast, it is gradually constructed through people's collaborative interactions. The building up of entries on Wikipedia, one of the most popular internet sites, an example of the collaborative

power of wikis. Wikipedia is a free encyclopaedia that anyone can edit. It contains a huge body of articles in different languages and is considered to demonstrate the amazing sum of human knowledge (Richardson, 2010). Wiki entries are contributed and moderated by thousands of people from all over the world. There are many entries developed from the joint work of hundreds of people. Without collaborative skills, which are negotiating, cooperating, and respecting others' work, wiki entries cannot be built or developed from contributors to construct joint work. Furthermore, wikis provide chances for writers to publish their work, which enhances audience/reader awareness. When students post onto wikis, they need to consider who their potential readers are. This helps build the mutual interactions between readers and writers, and makes writing purposeful. Wikis afford students opportunities to express themselves by using multiple modalities. For example, students can insert music, graphics, video, and photos in their writing, and communicate meanings that were once inaccessible or not fully expressed through the printed world (McPherson, 2006). In this way, writing becomes more of an interactive design process than simply textual presentation.

To sum up, because wikis are interactive platforms that can be asynchronously accessed and that have a useful tracking facility, they enable and promote an effective platform for collaborative learning.

3.4 THE OVERALL CONCEPTUAL FRAMEWORK FOR THIS STUDY

The predominant feature of collaborative learning is the importance of students actively sharing knowledge with one another to co-construct new knowledge. The theory supporting collaborative writing is based on social constructivist theory. The framework for this study is constructed around the concepts of ZPD, communities of practice, and collaborative learning affordances. Vygotsky (1980) proposed that the

interactions between the novice and more knowledgeable peers will help learners to develop in their ZPD through dialogic interactions and mediated artefacts. Social constructivist theory in the field of L2 learning proposes that the interactions between peers of the same levels of proficiency also lead to learning development. Communities of practice principles highlight the essence of students' gradual participation in a learning community through shared repertoires, tools or experience. Kirschner and his colleagues' (2004) perspectives imply that social software tools such as wikis can satisfy collaborative affordance requirements, which include educational affordance, technological affordance, and social affordance. The L2 process-genre writing approach emphasises students' interaction and teachers' scaffolding through stages of writing including pre-writing, drafting, feedback, revision and publishing.

Synthesising from the theory, concepts, and approaches mentioned in this chapter, students' L2 writing skills developed when students gradually participated in a community of small groups using collaboration and wikis in their learning. Interactions among learners through shared knowledge are facilitated through five stages of writing. This synthesis is presented in Figure 3.3 and Table 3.1.

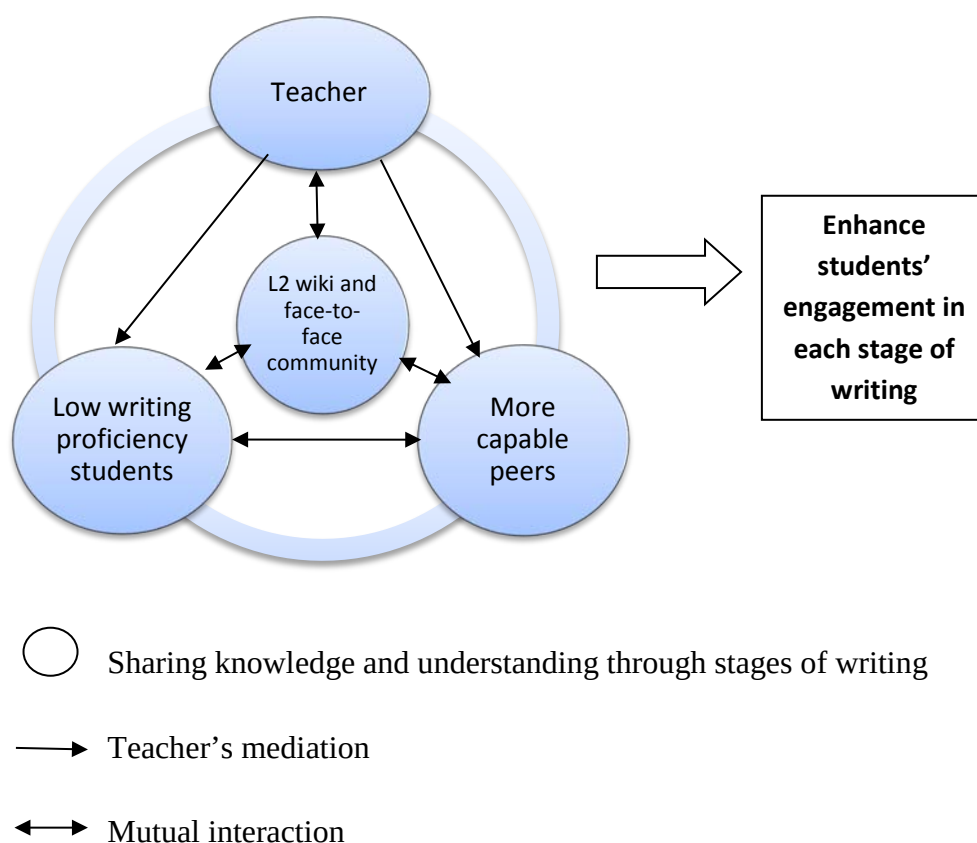


Figure 3.3 Ideal environment for collaborative learning using wikis

Figure 3.3 suggests that in a community of face-to-face and wiki collaboration, with teachers' scaffolding, mutual interaction between low proficiency students and their more capable peers could lead to an enhancement of students' engagement in each stage of writing. More capable peers can also benefit from collaborative learning: when they share knowledge with peers, they are able to revise or reshape their own thinking. Teachers' and students' activities via five stages of writing are presented in Table 3.1 on the following page.

Table 3.1

Stages of writing, teacher and students' roles in the project

Stages of writing	Mode of collaboration	Teachers' roles	Students' roles
Pre-writing	Face-to-face	Providing input on genres by contextualizing and modelling texts Facilitating students' collaborative working	Students worked collaboratively in groups to identify purposes/audiences, appropriate genre, vocabulary and structure of written texts.
Drafting	Wikis	Withdrawing assistance to allow students' cooperative writing	Students worked cooperatively. Each student was responsible to write one part of writing Individual students posted their writing in the group wikis
Feedback	Wikis	Facilitating students' giving feedback to peers Providing feedback if necessary	Students worked collaboratively to provide feedback on peers' contributions
Revision	Wikis	Withdrawing for students' cooperative revising	Students worked cooperatively. Each student acted upon comments he/she received from peers and teachers to revise writing
Publishing	Wikis	Facilitating students' collaborative publishing	Students worked collaboratively to link individual parts to make completed writing Students used illustrations, like pictures and music to publish their final product.

The pre-writing stage was conducted through the face-to-face mode, and the other stages through the wikis. The analysis of effective collaboration in each stage of writing will be discussed in Sub-section 4.5.3.

3.5 SUMMARY OF THE CHAPTER

This chapter constructed the theoretical framework to support collaborative learning in the fields of general education, L2 learning and L2 process-genre writing using technology. Based on the foundation of students' collaborative and cooperative participation in an L2 wiki and a face-to-face collaboration community which is mediated by teachers' initial control and gradually decreasing guidance, students are expected to increase their participation in each stage of process-genre writing. In the next chapter, the design of the research to initiate collaborative writing through wikis in accordance with the L2 process-genre writing approach will be discussed.

Chapter 4: Research Design

This chapter describes the research method, participants, data instruments, data analysis, and ethical considerations involved in the study, which was located within the context of ELT in a Vietnamese university. The literature on learners' attitudes and L2 collaborative writing through both face-to-face and online modes sits within a multi-layered framework guided by social constructivist theory (Chapter 3). Highlighted in the preceding chapters is the potential for introducing technology-based and social activities into the current L2 teaching situation to enhance students' writing. The research design in this chapter has been underpinned by the literature review and theoretical framework aforementioned. The research design presented in this chapter addresses the overarching research question **what strategies using collaboration and technology could enhance students' L2 writing skills?**, which is divided into three sub-questions:

1. **What are teachers' expectations of and reflections on the use of face-to-face and online strategies for teaching L2 writing?**
2. **What are students' expectations of and reflections on the use of face-to-face and online strategies for the learning of L2 writing?**
3. **What specific teaching and learning stages (pre-writing, drafting, feedback, revision or publishing) can enhance students' participation and engagement in learning L2 writing through face-to-face and online collaboration?**

This chapter discusses the research design in eight sections. Section 4.1 introduces a working definition, typical features and rationale behind the choice of action research for this study. This section also clarifies an action research model specifically applicable to the research questions above. Section 4.2 provides background information about the teachers and students participating in the study. Section 4.3 describes the writing project proposed to enhance students' participation and engagement in L2 writing. Section 4.4 details the instruments used to collect data and Section 4.5 reports the process of data analysis. Section 4.6 discusses the ethical considerations and limitations of the study and the chapter ends with a summary in Section 4.7.

4.1 ACTION RESEARCH

This section describes the working definition of action research methodology, the rationale for choosing this methodology and the specific model of action research utilised for this study.

4.1.1 Definition and features of action research

Action research has been widely recognised as an effective approach for conducting deductive research in pedagogical fields (Burns, 2010; Nolen & Putten, 2007). Many researchers have shaped action research concepts, and suggested different definitions; among them, the definition by Kemmis and McTaggart (1988) is the most basic and commonly cited (Burns, 2010):

Action research is a form of *collective*, self-reflective enquiry undertaken by participants in social situations in order to improve the rationality and justice of their own social or educational practices, as well as their understanding of these practices and the situations in which these practices are carried out. Groups of participants can be teachers, students, parents, principals, parents and other community members - any group with a

shared concern. The approach is only action research when it is *collective*, though it is important to realise that the action research of the group is achieved through the *critically examined action* of individual group members. (Kemmis & McTaggart, 1988, p. 5)

This will be referred to as the working definition of action research in this study.

The distinctive features of action research are highlighted to establish guidelines for this study. First, action research highlights teachers' reflective processes. In these processes, teachers act as researchers to critically and systematically investigate issues arising in their own "problematic" teaching context. It must be made clear that the term *problematic* do not imply that teachers' practices or investigated situations are ineffective. Instead, the terms indicate that teachers are consciously of particular areas of their teaching that they can improve. Through these self-initiated investigations, teachers/researchers are more conscious of problems encountered in their teaching situations in order to make appropriate adjustments. Above all, action research is a practical way for teachers to investigate their own teaching situation, resulting in reflective practices (Burns, 2010; McNiff, 2002; Nolen & Putten, 2007).

The second characteristic of action research involves the introduction of sets of actions to deliberately improve situations (Kemmis & McTaggart, 1988). The intention to bring about change differentiates action research from other kinds of research. By changing and then learning from the results of these changes, teachers and researchers can improve the quality of teaching and learning. Collaboration is the third distinctive feature of action research. Action research can be conducted through the collaboration of stakeholders, action researchers and participants to form joint-learning processes. The perspective of collaborative research is based on the primary characteristic of action research: "to bring about change in social situations as the

result of group - problem solving and collaboration” (Burns, 1999, p. 12). In education, action research brings about change in teaching and learning in classroom. Furthermore, when processes of action research are carried out collaboratively, research results will be reflected in teaching and learning situations more critically and substantially. Teachers working in similar teaching situations have a chance to share common problems and cooperate in a research community to examine “their existing assumptions, values and beliefs within the socio-political cultures of the institutions in which they work” (Burns, 1999, p. 13). In this study, the collaborative teaching aspect was reflected through the participation of one Vietnamese L2 teaching colleague and the researcher. We were both teachers and observers who cooperated during the cycles of action research initiated by the researcher (see Section 4.2).

The name action research itself reflects that this approach has two main functions: *action* – to bring about changes in a certain programme, and *research* – to increase the understanding of researchers or members of a collaborative community about their situations. In some forms of action research, primary emphasis is on practical changes. In others, the focus is on theoretical change (Dick, 1993). My stance on action research is based upon the belief that “theory can be and should be generated through practice,” and “theory is really only useful insofar as it is put in the service of practice” (Brydon-Miller, Greenwood, & Maguire, 2003, p. 15). This study aims to facilitate “a form of practice which involves data gathering, reflection on the action as it is presented in the data, generating evidence from data” (McNiff, 2002, p. 16), and acting on that evidence. The findings of this study potentially help not only the researcher but also my colleagues at the research site to understand more

thoroughly the teaching situation being investigated. Thus, some problems that current L2 learners are experiencing can be addressed in future to effect change in teaching and learning.

4.1.2 Rationale for choosing an action research approach for this study

Action research is widely accepted as one of the most efficient methods to implement changes in L2 education fields (Burns, 2010; Nunan, 1992). Any resultant changes from action research projects are practically implemented, evaluated, and re-evaluated into current teaching practices for ELT. Action research is also considered one of the most successful approaches for teachers to extend their L2 teaching skills: it has the potential to provide teachers with more understanding about their own teaching practices, classrooms and students (Burns, 2010). Teachers' thorough understanding and immediate implementation of changes needed in their teaching situation is a foundation for any teaching and learning improvement. Finally, action research is always considered "a work in progress" approach (Brydon-Miller et al., 2003, p. 11). One implementation of changes can be conducted in cycles linking to one another. One complete cycle of action phases will open up another cyclic action until new implementations can enhance teachers' self-reflections. The end of one action research project for a particularly problematic situation may lead to research on other situations, which enables research and new implementation cycles to continue.

There were compelling reasons behind my choice of action research to specifically address the research problem: the most important was that "the road to action research also requires changes in our teaching practice" (Brydon-Miller et al., 2003, p. 19). As argued in previous chapters, changes from a traditional teacher-centred to

a more student-centred approach in Vietnam are necessary. Through changes, the MoET's requirements of ELT in Vietnam (Sub-section 2.1.3) and students' preferences for learning together at the University (Section 1.2) can be met.

Taking into account the working definition, distinctive features, and the widespread use of action research, it was an appropriate method for this study. It was expected to bring about changes as it enabled reflections on teaching and learning practices. As previously stated in Sub-section 4.1.1, this study was undertaken with cooperation between the researcher and another teaching colleague, and two main benefits were anticipated. Regarding building a community of practice, the outcomes of the study potentially brings about changes not only for my own practices as a teacher, but also for other teachers' practices. Moreover, this study investigated the teaching colleague's expectations of and reflections on collaborative writing using wikis (research question 2). The teaching colleague gained firsthand experience of how collaborative writing (face-to-face and wiki) works and which mode, the current teacher-focused model or the collaborative model, was more effective. Her reflections, together with mine, on this collaborative project have the potential to benefit the practices of teaching and learning L2 writing at my University.

To conclude, this study was conducted with three clear purposes. The first purpose was to investigate difficulties that the L2 writing teachers and learners at the research site encounter. The second was to implement changes through the application of wiki technology to enhance L2 writing collaboration. The third purpose was to contribute to knowledge of how collaborative writing through wikis in particular, and other internet applications in general, can work effectively in the Vietnamese context. These three purposes were then interpreted according to current theoretical

considerations of sociocultural perspectives, L2 process writing and technology affordances.

4.1.3 Action research model used in this study

In this study, the model for action research in the ELT field suggested by Burns (2010) has been deployed. In essence, her model is based on the model suggested by Kemmis and McTaggart (1988), and later,– Kemmis, McTaggart, and Retallick (2004). This model “summarises very succinctly the essential phases of the action research process” (Burns, 2010, p. 9). The cycles and phases in each cycle of action research model are presented in Figure 4.1 on the following page.

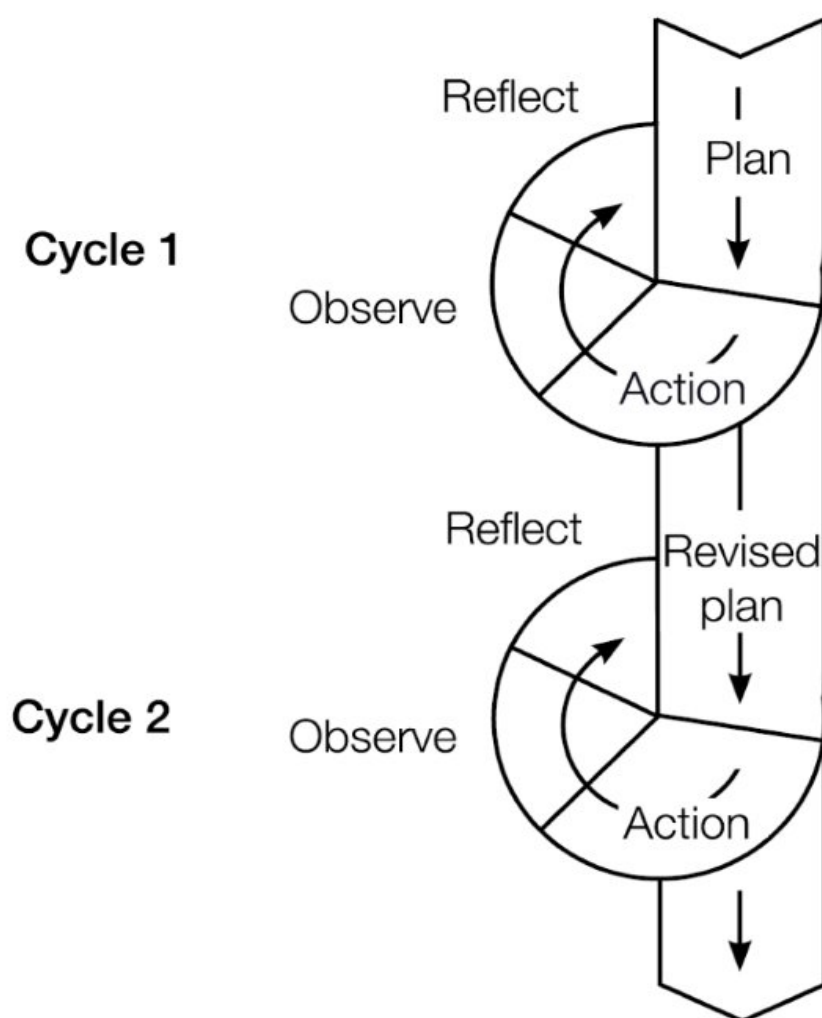


Figure 4.1 Cyclical action research model (Burns, 2010) based on Kemmis and McTaggart (1988)

According to this model, action research in ELT involves four main phases in a cycle of research: *Planning*, *Action*, *Observation* and *Reflection*. The end of one cycle of research may open up another cycle if necessary. In the *Planning* phase, researchers identify existing problems or issues in their teaching and learning situations, and develop plans for improvement. After these plans have been carefully considered, deliberate interventions into teaching situations will be put into the *Action* phase over an agreed period of time. In the *Observation* phase, systematic observations of

effects of the interventions will be conducted. The research context, participants' actions and reflections will be documented. Researchers then reflect on, evaluate and describe the effects of these actions in order to make sense of what has happened and to understand issues that have been investigated more clearly in the *Reflection* phase. Action researchers can conduct further cycles of action research to improve situations or to share their experience with other teachers/researchers as part of ongoing professional development (Burns, 2010).

The action research of this study closely followed four phases. Due to time limitations, only two cycles were implemented. The stages of these two cycles and action points in each stage used in this study are presented in the Table 4.1 in the Sub-section *The sequence* below.

4.2 PARTICIPANTS

The participants in this study were 30 Vietnamese English majors and two Vietnamese teachers of L2 writing, one of whom was the researcher.

The second-year students who participated in the study included 1 male and 29 females from 18 to 21 years old, all of whom came from rural or mountainous areas in northern Vietnam. Prior to the commencement of my study, the students had studied L2 writing at the University for three semesters. They had learnt how to write different types of paragraphs: narrative, process, compare and/or contrast, and cause and/or effect essays. They had also learnt how to write the introductory, body, and concluding paragraphs of an essay. The inclusion of student participants enabled me to collect data about the students' experiences of learning L2 collaborative writing and their expectations of collaborative writing using wikis, as well as their reflections on collaborative writing (research questions 1 and 2). They also participated in the

writing project and helped the researcher-teacher by reflecting on the writing strategies that were effective in their own collaboration (research question 3).

In addition to student participants, the study involved two Vietnamese L2 writing teachers: one teaching colleague and the researcher. The teaching colleague taught L2 writing to the English major students at the University. Although she only had one year of experience in teaching L2 writing, she had four years of experience in teaching “Speaking” to the English major students. Therefore, she understood the teaching and learning context for English major students at the University. She was willing to collaborate with the researcher in this project as she anticipated that the experience would be helpful for her future professional teaching. She reflected on her experiences of the collaborative class prior to the outset of the L2 writing project, based on her existing teaching method, understanding of the teaching context, and anticipation of students’ achievement in the coming project (research question 2). The teaching colleague also attended two face-to-face discussion sessions in class, presented by the researcher, and observed students’ collaboration in these sessions. Additionally, she observed students’ collaboration through the wikis. From these observations, she reflected on which stages of L2 process writing could enhance students’ involvement in writing. Her reflections addressed research questions about teachers’ expectations (research question 1) and effective strategies to enhance students’ performance (research question 3).

The researcher, as discussed in Chapter 1, had five years’ experience of teaching L2 writing, and participated in online learning projects organised by the American Embassy. In this L2 writing project, the researcher established the writing project, introduced it to the teaching colleague and students, collected data and reflected on

the project as per the standard action research model. From this point, the researcher will be referred to as researcher-teacher to distinguish her from the teaching colleague and teachers who had taught L2 writing to the class prior to the project.

4.3 THE COLLABORATIVE WRITING USING WIKIS

In this section, the collaborative writing project using wikis is described. It focuses on the sequence of collaboration in accordance with each stage of the L2 writing processes used in the project.

4.3.1 The sequence

Since the student participants in this study were unfamiliar with both collaborative writing and wikis techniques, the writing project began with two weeks of assisting students to become familiar with these. To begin with, the researcher-teacher met students in two sessions in order to introduce them to creating their own accounts and using the functions in wikis. After that, the students were divided into six groups of five to design their own wiki group pages. For first practice, the students were asked to co-write a short paragraph to introduce their groups. They were also asked to create individual links so that each member had their own space for their writing and for peers' comments. After two weeks, all groups had their wiki pages in which they wrote together. It also meant that they already knew how to use wikis and collaborate with one another via their wiki pages.

The first two weeks were also time for the researcher-teacher to conduct the Planning stage of Cycle 1 (see Table 4.2): to collect information about the teaching and learning situation as well as participants' expectations. The needs analysis survey and the first-focus group interview with the students, and the first semi-structured interview with the teaching colleague, were conducted. With the needs analysis

survey, the researcher met the students after the first week of induction and explained the questions and all technical terms relating to the five stages of L2 process writing. The surveys were collected one week after delivery so that the students had time to respond, especially for the open-ended questions. Thirty surveys were administered, and all were returned. For the focus group interview, six volunteer students representing the six groups were invited. The meeting with them helped the researcher to compile information about their current learning situation and their expectations of the coming project. The researcher-teacher sent the guiding questions to the teaching colleague two days before the meeting. We then met in a room at the University campus. All technical terms were explained in Vietnamese so that she could understand all questions before the interview started. The interview lasted for one hour and was audio-recorded. The data collected from the students and teaching colleague, especially their expectations, were used to tailor the writing project.

After two weeks of induction, the students collaborated to write three types of essays: argument, compare and/or contrast, and cause and/or effect essays. When the students finished the argument and compare and/or contrast essays, the second focus group interview with the volunteer students was conducted to gather information about the students' reflections and suggestions for Cycle 2 (see Table 4.2). In this interview, six volunteer students were invited. The researcher-teacher intended to invite those who had already attended the first-focus group interview so that they could report both their expectations (focus group interview 1) and reflections (focus group interview 2). However, due to time constraints, three students from the earlier interview agreed to participate and the other three were new.

After the students finished the cause and/or effect essay, the third focus group interview was conducted with six volunteer students, all of whom attended the second focus group interview. Also, reflection sheets on the entire project were distributed to the students. Thirty surveys were administered and returned (Appendix 2). The students had one week to complete reflection sheets. With the teaching colleague, the second semi-structured interview lasting 90 minutes was arranged. The data collected from the interviews and reflection sheets were used to reflect on the entire processes of the writing project.

The sequence, data collection instruments and focus of data are summarised in Table 4.1 in the following page.

Table 4.1

The sequence of the project, instruments and focus of data

	Action research stages	Instruments	Participants	Data focus
Cycle 1	Planning	Needs analysis survey	30 students	Teaching and learning experiences of L2 writing prior to the implementation of the project
		First semi-structured interview	Teaching colleague	Expectations of writing using wikis
		First focus group interview	6 volunteer students	(research questions 1 and 2)
	Action	- Introduce the writing project to the class - Students collaborated to write the argument essays		
	Observation	Wiki data	30 students	Reflections on students' collaboration in the first essay
		Second focus group interview	6 volunteer students	Suggestions for modifications in Cycle 2 (research questions 1 and 2)
	Reflection	Reflect on students' collaboration. The results of the wiki data and focus-group interviews were used to make adjustments in Cycle 2		
	Action	- Introduce the adjusted project - Students collaborated to write the compare and/or contrast and cause and/or effect essays		
		Wiki data	30 students	

Cycle 2		Third focus group interview	6 volunteer students	
	Observation	Second semi-structured interview	Teaching colleague	Reflections on the entire project
		Reflection survey	30 students	Suggestions for future projects
	Reflection	- Reflect on the entire project		
		- Analyse and report the findings		

The stages to write an essay followed the L2 process-genre writing approach with five stages as mentioned in Table 3.1: pre-writing, drafting, feedback, revising and publishing. The pre-writing stage was conducted through face-to-face meetings, each of which lasted for 90 minutes. These other stages were conducted through the wikis asynchronously.

According to the university's syllabus, the second semester lasted for 15 weeks, focusing on developing students' essay writing skills. The researcher started to collaborate with the teaching colleague in the fourth week, and the writing project commenced in the sixth week of the semester. The students learnt each type of essay in two weeks: the first week for the pre-writing stage via face-to-face meetings and the second week for the other stages (drafting, feedback, revising and publishing) via wikis. The teaching focus for Cycle 1 was the argument essay and Cycle 2 focused on compare and/or contrast and cause and/or effect essays. Based on the Faculty's

writing syllabus, timing, stages of the action research, and teaching focus during the Action stages of Cycle 1 and Cycle 2 are presented in the table on the table below.

Table 4.2

Teaching focus, L2 writing stages and modes of collaboration

Research cycles	Teaching focus	L2 writing strategies	Modes of collaboration	Participants
Cycle 1	Argument essay (collaborative and wiki skills)	Pre-writing Drafting Feedback Revising Publishing	Face-to-face Wiki Wiki Wiki Wiki	Researcher-teacher
				Teaching colleague
				Students
				Researcher-teacher
				Teaching colleague
Cycle 2	Compare and contrast essay and cause and/or effect essay	Pre-writing Drafting Feedback Revising Publishing	Face-to-face Wiki Wiki Wiki Wiki	Students

The table on the next page describes specific procedures that the researcher-teacher established for teaching and learning each type of essay. These actions would be modified after each essay based on participants' reflections.

Table 4.3

Teachers' and students' activities in each stage of L2 writing approach

L2 writing strategies	Action points	
	Teacher/ instructor	Students
Pre-writing stage	1. Distributed copies of sample essays and asked students to identify: - What are the social purposes of each type of essay? - Who are the potential readers of each type of essay? - What are the main ideas of each paragraph in the essay? How the main ideas are supported? - What are the typical, structures, vocabulary and grammar of each essay?	1. Students read the sample essays and worked together to identify: - The communicative purposes and potential readers of each type of essays - The series of main points in the thesis statement of the introductory paragraph and in the topic sentences of body paragraphs. Also, how the main ideas are supported - The linking words and grammar tenses which each type of essay may use
	2. Gave each group a topic and asked students to - share views on the issue - list the main ideas - order the ideas and supporting ideas - point out the language features, structures, grammar may be useful	2. Students worked together on the given issues - state the issue - list the main ideas - identify and record points for main ideas - make a plan for language features, vocabulary or structures that may be used in drafting stages
Wiki drafting	- Asked and instructed students to conceptualise and write first draft	- Students conceptualized around the given topic and wrote their drafts on their groups' wiki pages
Wiki feedback	- Asked and instructed students to give comments on other writings with regard to content/ ideas, vocabulary, structures	- Students gave feedback on other students' drafts focusing on: - Do the written ideas make sense? Has the writer's voice been clearly communicated? - What changes (in terms of content, grammar, vocabulary, structures, spellings, punctuation)

might improve the quality of the writing?		
Wiki revision	- Asked students to revise and edit their writing basing on comments from their friends	- Revised and edited writings based on the comments
Wiki publishing	- Asked students to post the completed essay of the group	- What other codes (images, pictures, sound, or colour) should be used to support the text?

4.3.2 Wikis

Pbworks hosted service (www.pbworks.com) was used as the wiki platform. There were three reasons for choosing pbworks; primarily, it was a free webpage for any wiki user, so the project was not costly. Furthermore, this web space allowed the users to use a password to secure their writing: only peers and teachers could edit their writing. More importantly, pbworks has three main tabs (View, Edit and Comments), which made it easy for the students to use. The students could see other students' writing by using the View function. They posted their writings using the "Edit" button, and commented on other writing in the "Comments" space.

The researcher designed a wiki page and the students were asked to build their own group pages. These pages were linked to the Front page. In each group's page, different links were created so that each member could write their own paragraph; for example, one student wrote the introductory paragraph, and the others wrote the body paragraphs or concluding paragraph. After finishing the first version of his/her paragraph, the student would get the comments from their group's members or the researcher. Based on these, they would revise or edit their writing for the second or third version. There were links in each group for individual paragraphs to be combined into the completed essay.

For security reasons, the class wiki pages were protected by the researcher's password. Only the researcher, as administrator of the pages, could invite students to become readers or writers. For management reasons, the researcher used the "create class accounts" function in the wikis so that she could assign accounts and passwords for each student. This was necessary in case the students forgot their accounts or passwords so that the researcher could easily recover them.

4.4 DATA COLLECTION INSTRUMENTS

As demonstrated in Table 4.1, several sets of data were utilised to address the research questions. To make it clear, the sets of data in accordance with each stage and cycle of the action research are summarised as follow.

Table 4.4

Instruments to collect data

	Action research stages	Instruments	Participants	Data focus
Cycle 1	Planning	Needs analysis survey	30 students	Teaching and learning experiences of L2 writing prior to the implementation of the project
		First semi-structured interview	Teaching colleague	
		First focus group interview	6 volunteer students	Expectations of collaborative writing using wikis
	Observation	Wiki data	30 students	Reflections on students' collaboration during the first essay
		Second focus group interview	6 volunteer students	Suggestions for modifications in Cycle 2
Cycle 2	Observation	Wiki data	30 students	Participants' reflections on the entire project
		Third focus group interview	6 volunteer students	
		Second semi-structured interview	Teaching colleague	
		Reflection survey	30 students	Suggestions for future projects

Detailed descriptions of the instruments are provided in the following sub-sections.

4.4.1 Needs analysis survey

In this study, a needs analysis survey (Appendix 2) was conducted with the students during the Planning stage of Cycle 1 prior to implementation of the writing project.

The purpose was to establish students' expectations of the upcoming collaborative writing project. The analysis had three sections: Section 1, *Biodata*, collected information about students' ages, gender, and years of learning English. This section was in the cover sheet of the survey and was used for the researcher to keep track of participants' names. The researcher-teacher would use pseudonyms rather than the students' real names in the subsequent analysis. Section 2, *Collaborative learning experience*, investigated students' familiarity with learning through online and collaboration modes. Section 3, *Expectations of the coming project*, explored what students expected of the L2 writing project. The expectations were sub-divided into *students' goals for writing*, and *advantages of collaborative writing* (see Appendix 2). Each question had both closed and open-ended parts. This was to help students best voice their views. The closed questions were designed with *Yes/ No/ Not Sure* options. The students could further explain their responses in the section for comments accompanying each question. Vietnamese was used in the needs analysis since it was hoped that using L1 could enable students to fully express their opinions. The findings from the needs analysis would help the researcher establish students' needs and refine the writing project.

4.4.2 Interviews

Interviews are defined as conversations between researchers and participants in a study (Mertler, 2012). Interviews can provide participants with opportunities to voice their experiences while minimising the researcher's perspectives or previous research findings (Creswell, 2008). Interviews appeal to qualitative researchers who are interested in eliciting real experiences from their research participants (Norton, 2009). Interviews can be classified into structured, semi-structured, or unstructured.

Interviews are effective instruments for this study, which aims to elicit the teachers' and students' expectations of and reflections on collaborative and online learning. In this study, three sets of focus group interviews were conducted with students and two face-to-face semi-structured interviews with the teaching colleague. To help participants of this study freely express their points of view, Vietnamese was used in all interviews. The interviews were then transcribed and translated for analysis (see Sub-section 4.5.1).

Semi-structured interviews

Semi-structured interviews are conducted with some guided questions and sets of probe questions (Burns, 2010; Hinchey, 2008; Koshy, 2010). Probe questions are necessary only if interviewees do not elaborate on their responses or move away from the topic (Norton, 2009). In general, in a semi-structured interview, the researcher and the interviewee should engage each other in a free-flowing discussion in order to express each other's perspectives about a given topic. When following his or her own line of thinking, an interviewee may reveal a new perspective that the researcher has not considered beforehand (Hinchey, 2008). Hence, the interviewer should avoid imposing his/her own perspectives on interviewees. Instead, the interviewee's perspectives will shape what the interviewer will follow up on. The freedom that a semi-structured interview gives to participants should help them to express their attitudes and beliefs.

In this study, two semi-structured interviews were conducted to explore the teaching colleague's expectations of and reflections on L2 collaborative writing. The researcher prepared some guided questions and probe questions. The first interview was conducted at the initial stage prior to the start of the project. The questions were

to investigate (1) *her current method of teaching L2 writing to the students*; and (2) *her expectations of the potential of collaborative writing*. The schedule for the first semi-structured interview is in Appendix 3.

The second semi-structured interview with the teaching colleague was conducted in the Observation stage of Cycle 2 when the writing project finished. The data were collected around the teacher's reflections on the effectiveness, appropriateness, and shortcomings of collaborative writing as well as her suggestions for the improvement of future projects. The schedule for the second semi-structured interview with the teaching colleague is in Appendix 4.

Each semi-structured interview lasted about 60-90 minutes. Vietnamese was used as the language in the interview. For translation and transcription purposes, the interviews were audiotape-recorded. For the convenience of the researcher and teacher, the interviews were conducted at the University campus.

Focus group interviews

A focus group is "a carefully planned discussion designed to obtain perceptions on a defined area of interest in a permissive, non-threatening environment" (Krueger & Casey, 2000). Focus groups interviews involve "engaging a small number of people in an informal discussion (or discussions), 'focused' on a particular topic or set of issues" (Wilkinson, Joffe, & Yardley, 2004, p. 48). The number of participants in each group can range from four to twelve. Discussions in focus group interviews are informal. This is why focus group interviews can "provoke a kind of creative synergy when a comment from one person sparks an entirely new line of thought then followed by someone else" (Hinchey, 2008, p. 82). Furthermore, focus group interviews allow the researcher to collect shared understandings from a group of

people, while also eliciting perspectives from individuals. It is this potential that makes focus group interviews different from individual interviews: the explicit goal of the former is not to reach a consensus of the participants' views. Instead, they encourage interviewees to express different viewpoints as much as possible (Creswell, 2008). Therefore, the researcher should generally act as moderator by posing questions, encouraging group members to fully interact, and more importantly, keeping discussion flowing, rather than posing his/her own perspectives on the interviewees (Wilkinson et al., 2004). Focus group interviews can be used in qualitative studies to investigate participants' reflections on new instructional applications. They can be used to elicit a great deal of information in a short period of time from participants.

In this study, three focus group interviews were conducted with six volunteer students selected from 30 student participants. The sequence for developing questions for the focus group interview is suggested by Krueger and Casey (2009) including five categories of questions: *opening questions*, *introductory questions*, *transition questions*, *key questions* and *ending questions*.

The first focus group interview aimed to establish (a) students' current methods of learning, and (b) their expectations of each stage of writing (pre-writing, drafting, feedback, revising and publishing) prior to the start of the project. The schedule of the first focus group interview is in Appendix 5.

The second focus group interview was conducted to elicit students' reflections on what had happened during their participation in the project and their expectations of the coming essays. The interview questions focused on students' reflections on Cycle

1 with regard to the effectiveness, shortcomings, and suggestions for improvement for the next Cycle. This interview schedule is presented in Appendix 6.

The third focus group interview was conducted at the end of the writing project. The purpose of this interview was to reflect on the completion of the entire project. The central questions for the interview were on the students' reflections with regard to effectiveness, shortcomings, and suggestions for future projects. All students who attended the second focus group interview agreed to participate in the third interview. The questions are documented in Appendix 7.

The researcher-teacher acted as moderator to facilitate the interviews. Vietnamese was used as a means for students to exchange their reflections in order that they could freely express themselves. The interviews were both audio and video-recorded. However, the video recordings were only utilised to help me to keep track of the participants' contributions to the interviews because the number of participants was big. The data collated was transcribed and translated into English for analysis.

4.4.3 Wiki data

The data from the wikis including students' writing, their frequencies of logging in, peers' and researcher-teacher's comments were used to ascertain which stages in the process writing approach (pre-writing, drafting, feedback, revision, and publishing) were effective in enhancing the students' participation. Students' writing includes the writing of six groups for three types of essays. In each group, each student was responsible to write one part of the essay. I utilised both students' individual writing and their group essays as data. The data from wikis were used to supplement the students' focus group interviews and the teaching colleague's semi-structured interview to address research question 3.

4.4.4 Reflection survey

The reflection survey was the last instrument used in this study to collect data. It had four parts for students to evaluate the project (see Appendix 8). There were four parts in the Reflection Survey: *students' evaluation of each stage of writing, difficulties that students encountered when collaborating, their suggestions for future projects and their overall evaluation of the project*. Each part had both close and open-ended questions. Vietnamese was used in the survey.

4.5 DATA ANALYSIS

This research used the model of six steps proposed by Creswell (2008); (Creswell, 2012) as a general guide to analyse the qualitative data.

Table 4.5
General steps to analyse qualitative data (Creswell, 2008)

Step 1 Organising the data	Translate and transcribe interviews and arrange the data into different types depending on sources of information
Step 2 Read through all the data	Obtain overall meaning of information. Such questions as <i>What general ideas are participants saying? What is the tone of the ideas? What is the impression of the overall depth, credibility, and use of information?</i> should be used to make sense of the data
Step 3 Coding the data	Organise information into chunks or segments of texts. Then the texts will be organised into categories labelled with a term – often a term based in the actual language of the participants (called an <i>in vivo</i> term)

Step 4 Generating the description	Describe detailed information about people, places, or events in the research setting. - Generate codes for descriptions by dividing them into small number of themes or categories. The themes depend on the scale of the research, but from five to seven categories should be sufficient. These themes will appear as major findings in qualitative studies and are often used to create headings in the finding sections of the studies. The generated themes should reflect multiple perspectives from participants. They should be supported by diverse quotations and specific evidence to ensure the validity of information.
Step 5 Discuss the description	Present the description in a narrative way to convey findings of the analysis. Detailed discussion of themes or interconnecting themes with subthemes, specific illustrations, multiple perspectives from individuals, with quotations.
Step 6 Making the interpretation	Interpret detailed discussions by bringing the researcher's own personal perspectives, or comparing with what he/she has found in literature or theories. In this way, the researcher can confirm or contrast findings with previous findings. The researcher can also suggest new questions for further research from the interpretation.

The steps in the table above can be used as a general procedure for all qualitative data analysis. In this section, I will discuss the steps from 1 to 4, which include organising, reading through coding and generating of the data. Step 5 and 6 involving discussing and interpretation of the data will be canvassed in chapters 5, 6 and 7.

4.5.1 Transcribing and translating interview data

This sub-section describes how the interview data were transcribed and translated from Vietnamese to English. The reasons and limitation of the translation process is discussed.

Transcribing data

Two audiotape-recorded semi-structured and three focus group interviews were transcribed. I used the Express Scribe Transcription Software, available for free online, to assist me. This software enabled me to replay the recordings at my own pace so that I could easily follow the interviews. To ensure the validity of the data, I firstly transcribed exactly the entire interviews. Then I listened to the recordings three times to check the final transcripts. The transcription was then edited by selecting substantive elements of the interviews. That is to say, excerpts relating to the research questions were highlighted. Unnecessary parts such as repetition and pauses, which are quite common in spoken language, were reduced.

Translating data

My study was a bilingual project which involved collecting data in Vietnamese and presenting the findings in English; hence, translation was an essential step. All of the translation was conducted by me for three main reasons.

First, as a partial fulfilment of my professional training, I attended courses for translation and had experience teaching translation to students for more than one year. Therefore, I was an accredited translator in this project.

Second, since I was both a researcher and translator, I was able to understand the research more than anyone else could. Birbili (2000) states that the quality of translation is impacted by the translator's knowledge of the people and the culture embedded in the study. With regards to this, Temple and Young (2004) argue that the researcher acting as translator has advantages:

The researcher/translator role offers the researcher significant opportunities
for close attention to cross cultural meanings and interpretations and

potentially brings the researcher up close to the problems of meaning equivalence within the research process. (Temple & Young, 2004, p. 168)

Here is an example from the focus group interview with the students responding to the question about their L2 learning experience. This example is to show the advantage of the researcher performing the dual role of translator:

Trước giờ lên lớp nếu có thời gian thì cô sẽ phô tô tài liệu liên quan đến chủ đề Viết mà mình sẽ học. Em sẽ nghiên cứu tài liệu đó. Trong giờ lên lớp cô giảng lý thuyết bằng cách sử dụng slides về lý thuyết. Cô cũng cho thêm 1 số bài tập liên quan đến chủ đề hôm đó. Có thể làm luôn tại lớp và cô sẽ chữa cho một số bạn làm mẫu cho cả lớp. (Sinh viên 3- Phòng vấn nhóm 1)

(Translation: Before the class hours, if the teacher has time, she will give us copied materials regarding topics we are going to learn. I will read them. During class hours, she will present theories with slides. She also gives us some exercises around the topics. We can do them at class and she will give feedback on some students' writing).

Being the insider in the teaching and learning context where this study was conducted, I understood that the teachers made copies from their textbooks and distributed them to the students before class, so that students would use these materials as reference documents for their upcoming lessons. This illustrates the fact that L2 pedagogy in the class under study was impacted by textbooks. This understanding can be difficult for outside translators who do not have a deep understanding of the context.

Third, both the teaching colleague and students participating in my study were able to read in English. After I had finished translating, I sent the translated transcripts for them to double check and ensure that the translation reflected their perspectives.

However, there was an issue regarding the influence of Confucian values on the relationship between me and the students. The students respected most of my translation as I was considered to have more power than the students. Despite that, the awareness that the translation would be member checked enhanced the validity of the translation.

However, I acknowledge that when translating by myself, more or less, my perspectives impacted on the trustworthiness and validity of the data. This will be mentioned as one of the limitations of this study (See Section 8.7).

Based on the transcripts, I began to translate the data. The lexicon and conceptual equivalences (Newman, 2011) were carefully considered when I translated the transcripts.

Lexicon equivalence refers to the “similarity of words or phrases to express their identical meaning in a different language or in the translation from one language to another” (Newman, 2011, p. 500). For example, in my study, the students used the word “các bạn”, which literally means “friends”, but in the project, the word should be translated as “peers.”

Conceptual equivalence refers to the accuracy of the technical terms that participants used. In this study, the language used in the interviews was translated from English to Vietnamese, and then participants’ responses were translated from Vietnamese to English. For the interviews, I made careful explanations to the participants’ of the technical terms used in the interview, such as, “collaborative writing,” “process writing,” and the stages of writing: “pre-writing, drafting, feedback, revising, and publishing.” The explanations were conducted both through face-to-face meetings between participants and me, and also through the wiki pages. Here is an extract

from the wikis explaining the terms regarding the stages of writing to the participants.

PROCESS WRITING APPROACH

Adapted from Graham Stanley, British Council, Barcelona
<http://www.teachingenglish.org.uk/articles/approaches-process-writing>

- It is a myth that all it takes to write is to **sit down** in front of a blank page, to begin at the beginning and write through to the end, with NO planning, break, editing, or changes in between.
- Good writers **plan** and **revise, rearrange** and **delete** text, re-reading and producing multiple drafts

What is process writing?

- Process writing approach treats all writing as a **creative act** which requires **time** and **positive feedback** to be done well.
- Students should be encouraged to think about audience: *Who is the writing for? What does this reader need to know?*
- Students also need to realise that what they put down on paper can be changed: *Things can be deleted, added, restructured, reorganised, etc.*

What stages are there in a process approach to writing?

Pre-writing

- Students need to think how to approach a writing topic.
- The flow of ideas is the most important
- It is **not** necessary that students produce (if any) written work

Drafting

- Students write **without** much attention to the accuracy of their work or the organisation.
- The most important feature is **meaning or content** of the writing. *Is it coherent? Is there anything missing? Anything extra?*

Revising

- Focus more on **form** and on producing a finished piece of work.

Post-writing

Now the writing will be read by real target readers. Your work should catch readers' attention so they are attempted to read what you have written.

Figure 4.2 An example of explanation of technical terms on the wikis used in interviews

As a result, when I interviewed the participants, they did not have any difficulty in understanding the key concepts in the interviews.

Nevertheless, I encountered certain difficulties when translating participants' responses to the interview questions from Vietnamese to English. Below is an

example of the concept “theory” which is often mentioned in the interviews. The equivalence of this concept is quite different from its literal meaning.

Trước giờ lên lớp bọn em có được cho tài liệu môn Viết, em sẽ đọc qua tài liệu, xem phần lý thuyết và phần bài tập. Sau đó tìm hiểu những ý tưởng, hoặc những thứ mình cần cho một chủ đề mà mình sẽ học. Trong giờ lên lớp giáo viên sẽ trình bày phần lý thuyết, giảng phần lý thuyết và đưa ra bài tập. (Sinh viên 1- Phòng vấn nhóm 1).

And the paragraph is literally translated:

*Before the class time, we will be given the reference documents. I will read through them, look at the **theory** and exercises. Therefore, I get some ideas relating to what is going to learn. At class, our teachers will present the **theory** and then give us some exercises.*
(Participant 1- FGI 1)

In the above paragraph, the word “theory” appears twice. However, it implies the explanation of the reference documents around a given writing topic (the former case) and the teachers’ presentation (the latter case).

To consider the lexicon and conceptual equivalences, I sought for assistance from my supervisors and QUT language advisors/proofreaders: I explained to them what the participants meant, and they helped me to come to equivalences. The Vietnamese translation versions of the surveys and interviews are in Appendices from 1 to 7. An extract of the translation from the interview with the teaching colleague is included in Appendix 11.

4.5.2 Coding and themes for interviews and surveys

This sub-section describes the coding and themes of the data collated from the interviews and surveys addressing the research questions 1 and 2:

- 1. What are teachers' expectations of and reflections on the use of face-to-face and online strategies for teaching L2 writing?**
- 2. What are students' expectations of and reflections on the use of face-to-face and online strategies for the learning of L2 writing?**

The data addressing the teachers' expectations and reflections (research question 1) and students' expectations and reflections (research question 2) are interwoven and difficult to be separated. For analysis, these two questions are divided into two parts: participants' expectations and participants' reflections.

For participants' expectations of collaborative writing

Participants' expectations of collaborative writing were collated through the first semi-structured interview (SSI 1) with the teaching colleague and first focus group interviews (FGI 1) and the Needs Analysis Survey (NAS) with the students. Data were categorised into the following themes:

- Teachers' and students' roles in L2 teaching and learning writing prior to the implementation of the project
- Participants' purposes in learning L2 writing
- Participants' perceptions of potential benefits of collaborative writing.
- Participants' expectations of each stage of writing: what their expectations were of the roles of teacher and peers.

To illustrate how the data were coded into themes, Table 4.6 in the next page includes some examples of participants' responses, which were categorised into themes.

Table 4.6

Examples of the themes

Themes	Examples
<i>Teachers' and students' roles in L2 teaching and learning prior to the implementation of the project.</i>	We often learn [L2 writing] by listening to teachers' presentation. Then the teachers will give us some topics for us to practise or discuss at class. (Participant 1- Focus group interview 1)
<i>Participants' purposes in learning L2 writing</i>	When I learn L2 writing, what I want to achieve most is to write the correct forms for different types of essays. For example, what the ideas of the topics are, how to introduce, develop and conclude them so that the reader can understand. (Participant 3 – Focus group interview 3)
<i>Participants' perceptions of potential benefits of collaborative writing using wikis</i>	After seeing the plan of the project, I think collaborative writing might be effective in our teaching context. As [traditionally] happened, the interaction time between students and teachers was limited and both students and teachers had to work really hard. We had a lot of work to do during the class time. If we use collaborative writing using technology, teachers can assign some work for students to do at home, and students will post their work for teachers to evaluate. (Teaching colleague – First semi-structured interview)
<i>Participants' expectations of each stage of writing in the project</i>	I think if the teacher asks us to write about one topic, we can share with one another, list the main ideas and write the introduction together. If there is something that we do not know, the others in the group can help us. I want that when we work together, we can get many ideas so our writing can improve. (Participant 5 – First focus group interview)

For reflections on collaborative writing using wikis

Participants' reflections on students' collaboration and their suggestions for modification in Cycle 2 were reported through the second focus group interview with six students and the students' writing for the first essay in the wikis. The themes were around:

- Students' reflections on the affordances and constraints in each stage of writing in Cycle 1 and Cycle 2
- Suggestions for modifications in Cycle 1 and future projects.

For reflections on the effective stages of collaborative writing using wikis

Reflections on the entire project were collected through the third focus group interviews (FGI 3) with six students, the Reflection Survey (RS) with all students, the second semi-structured interview (SSI 2) with the teaching colleague and the students' writing for three types of essays. The data address research question 3:

What specific teaching and learning stages (pre-writing, drafting, feedback, revising and/or publishing) can enhance students' participation and engagement in learning L2 writing through face-to-face and online collaboration?

The themes included:

- Participants' overall evaluations of each stage of the project
- Affordances of collaborative writing in each stage
- Constraints in collaborative writing in each stage
- Suggestions for future projects.

4.5.3 Themes for wiki data

The students' essays were archived in the wikis, which facilitated the analysis of the students' collaboration in each stage of process writing.

McKensie and Tomkins (1984) suggest a checklist to evaluate students' activities in each stage of writing. These criteria include:

Table 4.7

Evaluation checklist for each stage of process writing (McKensie & Tomkins, 1984)

Pre - writing	Can the student identify the specific audience to whom he/she will write?
	Does this awareness affect the choices the student makes as he/she writes?
	Can the student identify the purpose of the writing activity?
	Does the student write on a topic that grows out of his/her own experience?
Drafting	Does the student write rough drafts?
	Does the student place a greater emphasis on content than on mechanics in the rough drafts?
Revising	Does the student share his/her writing in conferences?
	Does the student participate in discussions about classmate writing?
	In revising, does the student make changes to reflect the reactions and comments of both teachers and classmates?
Editing	Does the student proofread his/her own papers?
	Does the student increasingly identify his/her mechanical errors?
Publishing	Does the student publish his/her writing in an appropriate form?
	Does the student share this finished writing with an appropriate audience?

McKensie and Tomkins' checklist is for individual writing following the process writing approach. My study investigated students' collaborative writing using face-to-face and wiki modes. In addition, as mentioned in Section 3.2.2, five stages in the process writing approach were identified: pre-writing, drafting, feedback, revision, and publishing. Hence, I adapted McKensie and Tomkins' checklist with the following modifications.

The Pre-writing stage

In the pre-writing stage, besides identifying audiences and purposes of writing, the students also needed to identify suitable main ideas, organisation, grammar, vocabulary and structures. This was to ensure an important principle of collaborative writing: students' writing was a joint process (Sub-section 2.2.1). To analyse the audiences and purposes of writing, the students responded to the questions: who would potentially read their writing and what were the purposes of their writing? The students' consideration of their readers was also reflected through their usage of metadiscourse in their writing. This will be further discussed in the Publishing stage below. With regards to the main ideas, organisation, grammar, vocabulary and structures, I looked at their outlines to see whether their outlines could guide their peers in individual writing: were the main ideas clearly identified and developed? Were the grammar, vocabulary and structures appropriate for each essay genre?

The Drafting stage

In the drafting stage, students wrote individually. First and foremost, they were asked to employ what had been discussed in the pre-writing stage to elaborate their points. Otherwise, the discussions with their peers would not be effective. Second, students' management of their postings influenced peers' writing. For example, if students

posted their writing according to their timed schedule, their peers had sufficient time to write their parts.

The Feedback stage

In the feedback stage, the quantity and quality of students' comments were important. Although the quantity of feedback did not always correlate with the quality of comments, it showed the extent to which students were involved in group writing. With regards to the quality of comments, I used the analysis suggested by Liu and Sadler (2003) for peer feedback in electronic modes. In their analysis, both general and focused comments were important. Two areas of comments were considered: global areas (comments on content and organisation of the writing) and local areas (comments on grammar, vocabulary, structures, punctuation and/ or spelling). These two areas were further divided into (1) revision comments, which could help the peers to revise their writing and (2) non-revision comments, which did not result in the peers' revisions of their writing.

The two areas of peers' and researcher-teacher's comments were further described as providing direction in four different areas: evaluation, clarification, suggestion and alteration. Specifically:

1. Evaluations: comments on effective or ineffective features of writing;
2. Clarifications: comments probe for explanations and justifications;
3. Suggestions: comments point out directions for changes
4. Alterations: comments provide specific changes.

The table in the following page demonstrates Liu and Sadler's (2003) grid for analysing data and examples taken from students' writing in the research project.

Table 4.8

Analysis of focus of comments made by L2 Vietnamese students in the project (adopted from Liu and Sadler (2003))

	Global		Local	
	Revision-oriented	Non-revision-oriented	Revision-oriented	Non-revision-oriented
Evaluation	The development between the first and second paragraphs is not logical.	Your paragraph is good	I do not understand this sentence	Your quote in this sentence is interesting
Clarification	Will you develop your paragraph by point-by-point?	(No example)	What does this expression "financial difficulties" mean?	(No example)
Suggestion	I think with your topic sentence the supporting sentences will have to explain the reasons why people rush to cities.	(No example)	Future in the past tense for the house of your dream please	(No example)
Alteration	Look I have re-written your paragraph	(No example)	It's not "nowaday" but "nowadays"	(No example)

The Revision stage

In the revision stage, students considered and acted on all the comments they received. Hence, students' revision behaviours were observed. I used the students'

individual revised paragraphs to analyse how their paragraphs were revised according to areas of comments. This is described in the following table.

Table 4.9

Areas of revision-oriented comments

Areas of revision-oriented comments	
Global	Content
	Development/Organisation
Local	Grammar
	Structures
	Vocabulary
	Spelling
	Punctuation

The Publishing stage

The last stage was the Publishing stage, and required that the students used illustrations to supplement their essays. The purpose of Publishing was to show how students considered their audience. Hence, besides looking for the answer to the question: “Did the students develop their writing?” I analysed the metadiscourse used in their writing to evaluate their use of language tailored to a specific audience.

As discussed in Section 0, Hyland and Tse (2004) suggest that metadiscourse devices include *interactive resources* and *interactional resources*. The former is used to guide readers through the text, and the latter is used to involve readers in a writer’s arguments. They categorised metadiscourse resources as presented in Table 4.10.

Table 4.10

A model of metadiscourse in academic texts (Hyland & Tse, 2004)

Category	Function	Examples
Interactive resources	Help to guide reader through the text	
Transitions	express semantic relation between main clauses	in addition/but/thus/and
Frame markers	refer to discourse acts, sequences, or text stages	finally, to conclude, my purpose here is to
Endophoric markers	refer to information in other parts of the text	noted above/see Fig/in section 2
Evidentials	refer to source of information from other texts	according to X/ (Y, 1990)/Z states
Code glosses	help readers grasp functions of ideational material	namely/e.g./such as/ in other words
Interactional resources	Involve the reader in the argument	
Hedges	withhold writer's full commitment to proposition	might/perhaps/possible/ about
Boosters	emphasise force or writer's attitude to proposition	in fact/definitely/ it is clear that
Attitude markers	Express writer's attitude to proposition	unfortunately/ I agree/surprisingly
Engagement markers	explicitly refer to or build relationship with reader	consider/note that/ you can see that
Self-mentions	Explicit reference to author(s)	I/we/my/our

In my study, I used both (a) interactive resources, which are used to guide readers through texts and (b) interactional resources, which involve readers in arguments. However, because the students were provided with scaffolding on the use

of transitions, frame makers, attitude markers, engagement markers and self-mentions in writing lessons of previous terms, I focused on these categories. Thus, the categories of metadiscourse in my study include:

- Transitions (develop ideas among sentences e.g., *and*, *but*, *thus*, etc.)
- Frame makers (develop ideas among paragraphs, e.g., *First*, *Second*, *Finally*, etc.)
- Attitude markers (express writers' attitudes to an argument, e.g., *I agree that*, *I believe that*, etc.)
- Engagement markers (address readers of the wikis, e.g., personal pronouns, *you* or *we*)
- Self-mentions (refer to the writer(s), e.g., *I/my/we/our/ us*, etc.)

I also analysed the following categories in the analysis of students' metadiscourse:

- Code glosses (help readers to understand functions of ideational materials, e.g., *for example*, *for instance*, *such as*, *in other word*, etc.)
- Hedges (reduce writers' commitment to an argument, e.g., *might*, *could*, *perhaps*, etc.)
- Boosters (strengthen writers' commitment to an argument, e.g., *it is clear/obvious that*, *in fact*, *definitely*, etc.)

Nevertheless, because they were not explicitly taught to the students, they were used as examples of suggestions of scaffolding in writing for future projects.

Integrated framework for analysis of effective stages

From all discussed above, a checklist in Table 4.11 on the following page was devised to evaluate stages of L2 collaborative writing in the action research project as follows. This checklist also follows the conceptual framework canvassed in Section 3.4.

Table 4.11

Integrated evaluation checklist for stages of collaborative writing process

Process writing stages	Analysis
	- Main ideas that could guide students' individual writing were listed.
Pre-writing	- Development of writing was clearly proposed - Purposes and audience of writing were identified: * Who would potentially read their writing? * What were purposes of writing in the essays? - Structures and vocabulary related to the writing genre were listed
Drafting	- Students consistently followed their discussions in the pre-writing stage - Students added more ideas, vocabulary or structures - Students posted their writing in a timely manner to proceed group work
Feedback	- How many comments were given in each type of essays? - What were the areas of students' comments: global or local areas? - What was the focus of students' comments: evaluations, clarifications, suggestions and/or alterations? - What were the differences between students' comments and researcher-teacher's comments?
Revision	- How did students employ feedback to revise their writing: * Areas of students' revisions: global or/and local revisions * Focus of students' revisions
Publishing	- How did students use illustrations besides words in their completed essays - What metadiscourse was used to show students' consideration of their audiences?

The checklist above was utilised to analyse the affordances and constraints of each stage of writing in Chapter 6 and 7.

4.6 ETHICAL CONSIDERATIONS

Ethical considerations are an important part of any research, especially in those with human participants. In qualitative research in general, several issues involving *research purposes, data collection, participants' rights, data usage and data analysis* should be carefully considered prior to the conduct of the research (Creswell, 2009). The first issue is the research problem. It should have potential benefits not only to individuals being studied but also to others besides the researcher. Second, research purposes as stated need to align with what the researcher actually does, and how the participants can acknowledge that. The next issue is in data collection: participants and the research site should be respected so as not to be put at risk under any circumstance. Fourth, issues concerning where, how and when the researcher stores the data may arise. The data will not be released or used for other purposes but only to serve purposes of research. Last, the qualitative researcher makes sure that final research findings are not invented, suppressed or falsified and that the research procedures are open to readers so that they can check credibility of studies.

This study was conducted taking into account all of the previously stated ethical considerations. The benefits of this research were not only for the researcher but also the teaching colleagues and students at the University where the study took place. The research also aimed to contribute both practical and theoretical knowledge to the Faculty, the University under study, and universities in Vietnam. With regard to the research purposes, the researcher informed the Rector of the University, the Dean of the Faculty and all other participants that the sole purpose of the research was to improve the quality of teaching and learning L2 writing by applying a new writing approach through face-to-face and online collaboration. In addition, data collection

strictly followed the curriculum and the syllabus of the Faculty. The researcher did not intervene to make changes in the system outside the research class. This explains the reasons why the researcher-teacher did not ask to increase time for collaboration despite students' suggestions after Cycle 1 of the action research. Additionally, the writing project was not included in the testing grades to keep the University assessment format intact.

Participants' rights were protected. Before the research began, the researcher obtained the written approvals from the QUT University Human Research Ethics Committee numbered EC00171 (see Appendix 1). I also got the approval from the Rector and the Dean of the University to conduct the research in the research site. The researcher then prepared the Consent Forms for the students and teaching colleague for the collection and usability of data. It was highlighted in the Consent Forms that participation in the research was not compulsory. Specifically, the participants' rights were protected through their signing of the informed consent forms in which their confidentiality was assured. In addition, they had the option to withdraw from the research at any time if they felt uncomfortable. If the students did not wish to participate in the research classroom, they could choose to participate in other classes, which were organised by other teaching colleagues. Participants' identities were protected by pseudonyms. In the interviews, I used initials to stand for students' names. When I used students' writing from the wikis, students' real names were replaced or deleted.

Similarly, informed consent was gained from the teaching colleague, who reflected on her teaching experience and students' collaboration in the writing project. When collaborating with the researcher, the teaching colleague had to adjust her timetable

to fulfil her regular teaching and the research project at the same time, which meant extra workload for her. Meanwhile, she was not given academic credit for conducting this research. Nor was she eligible for promotion for helping the researcher. Her consent was a priority in terms of ethics in this study. This was why I decided to change her roles in the project. Initially, I intended that after my lecture, she could teach the students the second essays. In this way, we could have taken turns to be both teachers and observers of the lessons. Also, I had proposed that she might have commented on the students' writing. My initial suggestions would enable her to engage in in-depth reflections on the project. However, she reported that to carry out the project in accordance with my suggestions, she would have to spend time changing her current teaching pedagogy, which she would rather not do. As a result, I invited her to participate in the project as an observer to reflect on my own and the students' activities in the project. The change was unexpected, but necessary to ethically protect her rights. Her participation, only as an outsider to observe, was a limitation of my study. Although her perceptions of L2 writing, and her reflections on my activities and the students' activities were important to this study, a greater level of involvement on her part would have led to deeper reflection (further discussed in Section 8.1).

Finally, the data was secured safely. The analysis, interpretation and synthesis of the results would be on the basis of the collected information. These processes were monitored by the researcher's supervisors to avoid any false or invented findings.

4.7 SUMMARY OF THE CHAPTER

This chapter discussed the research design, including the methodology, instruments, participants and ethical concerns involved in the study. Detailed explanations about

the reasons that action research was chosen to be the research methodology for the study were highlighted. Aligning with the literature review and theoretical framework in the previous chapters, the research was designed to address the research questions, which are the participants' expectations of and reflections on collaborative writing, as well as students' participation and engagement in L2 collaborative writing. The design of the project, data analysis and the limitations of the study were also discussed in this chapter.

Chapter 5: Participants' experiences of L2 writing and perceptions of collaborative writing using wikis

This study, based on an eight-week L2 writing project, aimed to collate and analyse the teachers' and students' perspectives on collaborative learning. It also investigated the affordances of wikis for teaching and learning writing in a traditional class context. The participants of this study included 30 students, one L2 writing teaching colleague and the researcher. The teaching colleague participated as class observer and helped the researcher to reflect on the project. The researcher was the teacher/facilitator of the project. The project followed a collaborative L2 writing course focusing on three types of essays: argument, compare and/or contrast, and cause and/or effect essays. Action research following Burns' model (2010) with two cycles was used.

The study addresses the overarching question: **what strategies using collaboration and technology could enhance students' L2 writing skills?** which is sub-divided into three questions:

1. **What are teachers' expectations of and reflections on the use of face-to-face and online strategies for teaching L2 writing?**
2. **What are students' expectations of and reflections on the use of face-to-face and online strategies for the learning of L2 writing?**
3. **What specific teaching and learning stages (pre-writing, drafting, feedback, revision or publishing) can enhance students' participation**

and engagement in learning L2 writing through face-to-face and online collaboration?

The data addressing the teachers' expectations and reflections (research question 1) and students' expectations and reflections (research question 2) are interwoven and difficult to be separated. For analysis, these two questions are divided into two parts: participants' expectations and participants' reflections.

This chapter reports the data collected during the Planning stage of Cycle 1 prior to the implementation of the project, and responds to the first part of research question 1 and 2 about participants' expectations. The instruments deployed to collect data for this chapter included (1) the initial Needs Analysis Survey (NAS) with all students, (2) the first semi-structured interview (SSI 1) with the teaching colleague, and (3) the first focus group interview (FGI 1) with six selected students. The findings in this chapter reflect on (a) the reality of teaching and learning L2 writing and (b) participants' perceptions of L2 writing prior to the implementation of the writing project.

For analysis, the teaching colleague's reflections were coded as "Teaching colleague – SSI 1/SSI 2", which stands for semi-structured interviews 1 and 2. Six students who participated in three focus group interviews were coded as "Participant" and their assigned number, for example, Participant 1 – FGI 1, Participant 3 – FGI 2, Participant 4 – FGI 3, in which the participant numbers from 1 to 6 represent each of the six students participating in the interviews. Initial letters of students' names were abbreviated to code for students participating in the Needs Analysis Survey and Reflection Survey, for example, Student NVA or Student LAV.

This chapter addressing participants' expectations has two sections. Section 5.1 describes the participants' experiences of teaching and learning L2 writing in the class under study prior to the implementation of the project. The findings indicate that L2 writing methodology was influenced by traditional pedagogical factors such as dominance of the teachers, summative assessment and a preference for "rule-based" language learning. The state of L2 writing in the class under study fell short of the requirements of the MoET's policies, which advocates for developing Vietnamese L2 students' *communicative* competence. This provided the foundation for the creation and implementation of the project: a new teaching approach was needed to enhance teaching and learning of L2 writing.

In Section 5.2, participants' perceptions of L2 collaborative writing using wikis are described. The findings of Section 5.1 will explain participants' purposes for L2 writing and perceptions of the new teaching approach in Section 5.2. These two sections highlight the importance of the project. Analysis in this chapter is supported by the literature on ELT in Vietnam in Chapter 2, and principles of L2 process writing and affordances of wikis in Chapter 3.

5.1 PARTICIPANTS' TEACHING AND LEARNING EXPERIENCES OF L2 WRITING PRIOR TO THE IMPLEMENTATION OF THE PROJECT

This section discusses the way in which traditional pedagogy has influenced L2 writing in the class under study. As established, language education in Vietnam is impacted by the traditional pedagogy. With ELT in particular, the pedagogy features the primacy of teachers, assessment by timed exams and resistance to CLT. These impacts had been observed in the class under study prior to the outset of the project.

5.1.1 Influence of teachers in the class under study

As discussed in Section 2.1, traditional pedagogy in Vietnam has been characterised by the dominant role of teachers and the dependent role of students. Similarly, in the ELT field, pedagogy focuses on teachers' roles: teachers typically impart knowledge to students, and there are relatively few spoken or written interactions during class time.

Prior to the project, in the class under study, teachers had assumed a central role in the writing class. This was explicitly observed through (a) teachers' presentation time, (b) interaction in the class and (c) students' seeking exclusively for teachers' monitoring and feedback.

Teacher's presentation time

In the class under study, lessons usually followed three steps: teacher presentation, student practice, and a review of students' homework if time is available. The teaching colleague described the teachers' and students' activities in typical lessons:

The L2 writing teachers [prior to the collaborative project] often divided one teaching session into three parts. The first part was the teacher's presentation [...]. Then the teachers assigned some exercises so that the students could match what the teachers presented with "real" sample writing [...]. The teachers gave the students homework to do too. **(Teaching colleague – SSI 1)**

Following this pattern, teacher presentation and student practice took place in class time, and the students completed the homework in their own time. The teaching colleague commented in the first semi-structured interview: "the time that the teachers spent on class presentation accounted for most of class time." The student participants in the first focus group interview also agreed that time for teacher

presentation was often longer than student practice time. The teaching colleague explained why it had taken her so much time to present a writing lesson:

Time for one L2 writing lesson was restricted to ninety minutes per week. There was a lot of knowledge that the students were not able to discover themselves, so I had to present it to them. This took me so much time that there was little time left for the students to write on their own. **(Teaching colleague – SSI 1)**

The teaching colleague also added that increasing class time was impossible because the L2 writing programme was fixed by the University's policies. As a result of the time that teachers spent presenting, it was difficult to organise interactive writing activities, which will be discussed below.

Interaction in and outside class time

As established in Chapter 3, interaction both between teachers and students and among students is important in L2 learning (Hall & Verplaetse, 2000). Specifically, interaction between the novice (the student) and the expert (the teacher or more capable peer) in a community can lead to learning development (Lave & Wenger, 1991). It can help the novice to advance in their ZPD (Vygotsky, 1979; Lund, 2008; Warchauer, 1997).

In the class under study, prior to the collaborative project, interaction between the teachers and students had been limited. The teaching colleague explained:

The weaknesses [of the current L2 writing pedagogy] were that the students were not able to interact actively with the teachers: they mainly listened to the teachers' presentation, did some exercises and were given homework. **(Teaching colleague – SSI 1)**

The time spent on teachers' presentations resulted in insufficient time for students' participation in lessons. Moreover, there was barely any contact between students

and teachers outside class hours. The teaching colleague reflected on why interaction between her and the students was restricted:

Outside class hours, it had been difficult for me to give feedback on the students' writing: I had other classes with large numbers of students to teach. I could not devote my time outside class hours to assisting the students. Thus, it was rare for me and the students to have contact outside class hours. **(Teaching colleague – SSI 1)**

In sum, due to limited class time and limited outside class hour contacts and the demands of teaching several classes, interaction between the teacher and the students was restricted.

Students' seeking exclusively for the teachers' monitoring and feedback

As discussed, in the class under study, the traditional teaching approach followed the pattern of presentation – practice – homework. There was little time for students to practise writing on their own in class, and homework was supposed to be the activity when students actually wrote independently.

According to the results of the first interview with the teaching colleague, the students' completion of homework relied on their teacher's monitoring and feedback as a follow-up activity. In fact, students would normally not do their homework if its completion was not strictly monitored by teachers in following lessons. This was noted by the teaching colleague:

Unless homework was checked in next lessons, most of the students would not do it as required. This really means that without the teachers' supervision, the students would have less motivation to learn. **(Teaching colleague – SSI 1)**

Taking a different viewpoint, the students reported that they had completed homework because they were aware of the importance of actual writing when time in

class was limited. However, from the reflections of one student in the first focus group interview, reliance on the teacher's feedback was evident:

At home, I often did my writing homework. However, it was not really helpful for me to improve my proficiency because no one helped me with feedback on it. Thus I did not know whether my writing could improve or not. **(Participant 2 – FGI 1)**

The reflection above indicates that the student was only confident about writing if it had received the teacher's feedback. The negative side of the students' respect for the teacher's knowledge and authority was that the students' writing would ultimately be influenced by the teacher's suggestions: the students would automatically apply the teacher's suggestions to their texts. So "ownership" of their writing was not developed. This was acknowledged by the teaching colleague in terms of what she usually did to give feedback on the students' writing. She reflected:

Sometimes during lessons, I made suggestions for the students in terms of, for example, ideas. The students noted them down and what I said became their written language. They respected all that I had said. They might think that the teacher's ideas were the best. This was sometimes ludicrous. What I said was just spoken language in a moment of time. It should not have been the students' written language. People who read their writing might think it was ridiculous. **(Teaching colleague – SSI 1)**

One of the student participants in the focus group interview agreed that she had usually respected all of her teacher's feedback. She reported:

The teacher's styles or ideas strongly influenced the students' writing. For example, I often used all of the teacher's suggestions or feedback in my writing. That was why sometimes most of the students in my class developed writing in the same way. That was also why the writing was not "mine." **(Participant 3 – FGI 1)**

Participant 3's reflection in the above quote relates to the notion of "face" and "power distance" in Vietnamese culture. The educational context of Vietnam reflects Confucian values and practices, where "allowing a person to save face is more

important than telling the truth” (Nguyen et al., 2006, p. 7). This is also embedded in the culture, which says that conflicts, especially with people of a higher level in the hierarchy, should be avoided. Accordingly, it is rare that students question teachers. In the case of Participant 3, she simply adopted the teacher’s suggestions.

In short, the length of teacher presentations, students’ lack of autonomy and their respect for teacher’s knowledge and authority above their own reflected the influence of teachers on how L2 writing was approached in the class under study.

5.1.2 Influence of writing assessment in the class under study

Besides teachers, writing assessment also impacted on the teaching and learning of L2 writing in the class under study. As established in Chapter 2, assessment can direct pedagogy to focus on test content. Traditional timed-impromptu examinations are typically used to assess L2 writing in Vietnam. The tests features feedback limited to a grade, limited writing time, and topics unknown in advance. This type of timed writing test produces negative washback on L2 writing for two reasons (1) students are deprived of revisions and reflections (see Section 2.1.1), and (2) readership is restricted to teachers/examiners (see Section 3.2.2). In contrast, it was argued in Section 2.1.1 that formative assessment through teachers’ or peers’ feedback can diminish the washback of timed-impromptu writing (Weigle, 2007). In this section, the washback of timed-impromptu writing and the need to integrate formative assessment will be discussed.

In the class under study, traditional-timed examinations were used to assess students’ writing proficiency. The students’ writing performance was assessed through (a) classroom attendance, (b) a mid-term written exam and (c) an end-of-term written

exam. Classroom attendance accounted for 10 percent, mid-term exam 20 percent, and the end-of-term exam 70 percent of the final grade.

Classroom attendance was marked through the students' presence at the class and their contributions in lessons. The teaching colleague explained how she assessed the students' participation and contributions:

In every lesson, I would check students' attendance. [In addition], whenever students responded to my initiated questions during class time, which would be recorded for their contributions. **(Teaching colleague – SSI 1)**

The mid-term and end-of-term exams were timed-impromptu tests which would usually last for 60 and 90 minutes respectively. Essay topics would not be known in advance. The exam papers would not be returned to the students, and neither would they be informed about their results until three or four weeks after their exams. There would be no opportunities between conferences for the teachers and students to discuss the students' exam progress or performance.

Naturally, given that they accounted for a higher percentage of the students' overall grade, mid-term and end-of-term exams were more important than class attendance. However, the class under study demonstrated the washback of assessment. This was seen through (a) students' focus on genres of writing and neglect of processes of writing and (b) students' lack of awareness of audiences and their purposes in writing. The students' neglect of processes of writing will be discussed below. Their lack of audience awareness will be discussed in Section 5.1.4, which reflects the resistance to communicative writing in the class under study.

The students' neglect of the processes of writing was one aspect of the washback of the timed writing tests. In the first semi-structured interview, the teaching colleague confirmed that according to the writing curriculum, strategies of L2 process writing

such as brainstorming, gathering data, and listing main ideas had been taught to the students. However, the students had not actively used these strategies. One of the students recounted how she had approached writing an essay in response to the question on whether they followed the process writing approach with attention to audiences:

[Before the collaborative project,] prior to writing, I had not done anything like identifying audiences, purposes or organisations of the essays. I just wrote whatever came to my mind in the restricted time. **(Participant 3 – FGI 2)**

It was obvious that the students had realised that strategies of writing were irrelevant to the mid-term or end-of term exams, which required them to write a timed essay. Naturally, the students only focused on what was needed for timed essays and neglected the processes even they were included in the writing curriculum.

To diminish the negative washback of such assessment, formative assessment through feedback should be included (Section 2.1.3). The collected data reveals that in the class under study prior to the project, formative assessment through feedback was infrequently utilised. The teaching colleague reflected that her class had had few chances to receive feedback from their teachers:

Typically, the teachers had brought the students' writing home to mark. However, they had not been able to do so often [...]. It was impossible for the teachers to feedback on all the students' work each week. Each student's writing was hopefully corrected once a term. **(Teaching colleague – SSI 2)**

Likewise, the majority of students (22 out of 30) in the initial Needs Analysis Survey responded that they had written their work individually and rarely received feedback from their peers. The teachers had selected the writing of one or two students, giving

either written or spoken feedback in each lesson. All of the students had been expected to learn from the teacher's feedback on these few selected papers. In contrast to this expectation, the teaching colleague was concerned that learning from an analysis of other students' mistakes did not always lead to students' writing improvement:

Any student's writing which the teachers had selected to comment on was only one example. Different students made different mistakes which also needed the teachers' comments. So in one term, if the teachers were just be able to comment on some students' work, it would not be sufficient to lead to learning improvement of the selected students themselves, let alone of all the students. (**Teaching colleague – SSI 2**)

From the reflections above, it could be seen that more frequent feedback, especially peer feedback, was needed to improve the quality of teaching and learning in the class under study.

5.1.3 Unfamiliarity with communicative writing

The influence of traditional pedagogy in the class under study was also observed through resistance to L2 communicative writing. As established, CLT is the recommended approach to ELT in Vietnam under the MoET's policies (Section 2.1.3). Specifically regarding L2 writing skills, communicative competence is realised through students' attention to the purposes of and audiences for their writing.

According to the data collated from the interviews with participants, however, resistance to communicative writing by neglect of audiences and purposes of target texts was observed. In response to the question on whether they had identified an audience before their writing prior to the project, one of the student participants from the first focus group interview reported:

If, instead of academic essays, I had to write letters or reports, identifying audiences and purposes of writing was important. But for me, audiences or purposes of writing of the types of essays are not essential to identify.

(Participant 3 – FGI 1).

By contrast, some of the students in the focus group argued that it was important to pre-determine the readers of their writing. The problem was that the students were not used to doing this. One of the students reflected:

I do not agree with Participant 3 [the above quote]. It [identifying audience or purposes of writing] was important to writing [...]. However, we had been used to writing with the focus on ideas, organisation or grammar. That was why we had not cared much of the audiences or purposes of our writing. **(Participant 5 – FGI 1)**

The students' neglect of readership prior to the project was due to the restricted range of readers in the classroom environment. Kusel (1992) reflected on some of the issues affecting students' approaches to readership in both L1 and L2:

In principle, essay writers need to enjoy the sense that they are creating interesting and original text that will present something new to the reader. But this sense of readership is normally diminished by the knowledge that only the tutor will read their work. Of course, if the essay is used as part of the assessment for the award of a qualification it may be read by one or two other examiners in addition. In all cases, the readership is very restricted and somewhat knowledgeable. (p. 459)

In classroom writing, teachers only simulate outside readers, and in the case of exams, they are the only readers. This constraint means that the importance of context and readership is lost in L2 writing in a traditional classroom. Therefore, to teach L2 communicatively, teachers need to persuade students of the reasons for identifying readers before writing.

To summarise, while knowledge and awareness of readership regarding the L2 writing make the result work more communicative and conforming to the principles

of CLT, unfamiliarity with communicative writing was observed in the class under study due to restricted readership and the impact of timed writing tests.

5.2 PARTICIPANTS' PURPOSES OF LEARNING L2 WRITING AND PERCEPTIONS OF COLLABORATIVE WRITING USING WIKIS

Section 5.1 described participants' reflections on L2 writing in the class under study prior to the implementation of the project. In common to ELT in Vietnam more broadly, L2 writing pedagogy in the class under study had been influenced by the primacy of the teachers and summative assessment, which resulted in resistance to communicative writing. This section explores participants' purposes of learning L2 writing and their beliefs about collaborative writing. These perceptions indicate the influence of L2 writing pedagogy described in Section 5.1. They will also be used to articulate participants' expectations of each stage of process writing in Chapter 6. Finally, consistencies and contradictions between participants' perceptions prior to the project and their reflections after the project will be analysed in Chapter 7.

5.2.1 Participants' purposes in L2 writing

Students' purposes in L2 writing were explored through question 3.1 of the needs analysis survey: *what are your purposes in learning L2 writing?* The question prompted the students to consider content, organisation, structures, grammar, vocabulary, punctuation and spelling mistakes. The responses to the closed part of the question showed that global areas including content and organisation of essays were the focus of the students' writing. Local areas or linguistic accuracy including grammar, vocabulary, punctuation and spelling ranked second in importance in their learning L2 writing. This can be seen from the figure below.

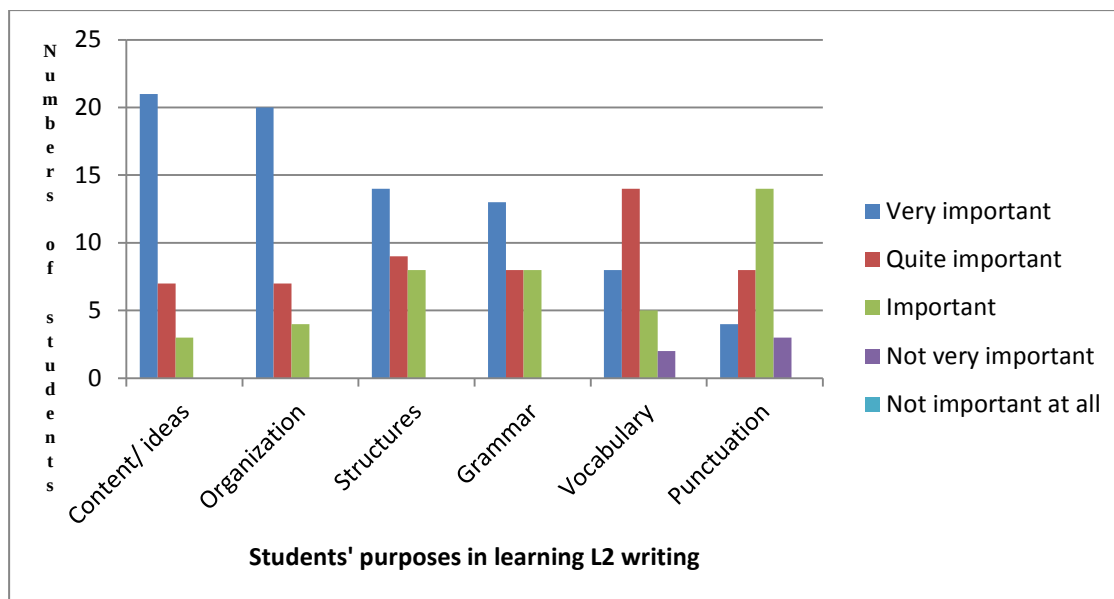


Figure 5.1 Students' purposes in learning L2 writing (Needs Analysis Survey)

The students further explained the importance of content to their writing. Especially, they linked attention to content and audience awareness. The following are some of the students' typical responses:

In writing, the most important parts are ideas and organisation. If writing content is interesting and its organisation is logically developed, it can attract readers' attention. It does not mean that grammar, structures, vocabulary and punctuations are not important. However, they should be taken as the second priority to complete my writing. **(Student BN – NAS)**

When I learn L2 writing, what I want to achieve most is to write correct forms for different types of essays. For example, what the ideas of the topics are, how to introduce, develop and conclude them so that readers can understand. **(Participant 3 – FGI 2)**

However, while content/ideas and organisation were the most important in students' responses to the closed part of the question, attention to linguistic accuracy was highlighted in the open part. The students' explanations focused on two main points: both global (fluency and cohesion) and local areas (language accuracy) were

important in writing, and linguistic limitation prevented them from writing effectively. Below are some responses from the students:

In my writing, I usually make mistakes in grammar, words and structures. So I expect that after the coming project, my grammar, vocabulary and structures can improve so that my writing can improve. **(Student TH – NAS)**

The success of writing depends on not only content/ideas but also grammar, structures and vocabulary. It is typical that when content is well developed, grammar, structures or vocabulary have already been effectively used [...]. I really expect that my writing will improve in terms of vocabulary and structures because my vocabulary is limited and I often have difficulties when using structures. **(Student TP – NAS)**

I often make grammar mistakes so I want to improve it. And listing ideas is not much a matter to me. **(Participant 4 – FGI 2)**

The students' attention to linguistic accuracy aligns with the findings of Tomlinson and Dat (2004) in their study of Vietnamese English language students learning oral skills. In their study, many students, especially those with a low proficiency, emphasised that linguistic accuracy was an indispensable component of language courses. These researchers suggested that classroom methodology cater for this need.

Literature shows that collaborative writing and L2 process writing approaches can help to address the students' preferences for linguistic proficiency. International research has shown that through collaborative writing tasks, such as dialogues (Swain & Lapkin, 2001), text reconstruction (Storch, 2001) or dictogloss (García Mayo & María Del Pilar, 2002), both global and local areas can improve. In the L2 process writing approach, pre-writing stages are designed for generating tentative ideas and gathering information for writing (Seow, 2002, p. 316). This means that content will be highlighted first. Attention to language form will then be considered in the revision stage. From the foundation of these two teaching approaches, I decided to tailor the collaborative project so that writing content would be the core of

discussion in the face-to-face meetings, and grammar and vocabulary would be discussed later through the wikis. In Chapter 8 on the implications of this study, further pedagogical suggestions regarding students' meaning-focused and form-focused expectations will be discussed.

5.2.2 Participants' perceptions of collaborative writing using wikis

The class under study had never experienced a project with a combination of both face-to-face and online collaboration. My questions then were divided to explore (1) whether they had experienced face-to-face/online collaborative writing or not, and (2) if so, what had been the benefits. In general, participants had positive attitudes to both separated and combined modes. The teaching colleague emphasised the strengths of wikis as platforms for asynchronous teaching and learning. The students focused on peer feedback to share and gain knowledge. They all believed that collaborative writing could lead to students' deeper understanding of process writing.

With regard to face-to-face group work, the teaching colleague had previously facilitated high school students to write together through pair or group work activities. Nonetheless, she had not implemented this strategy with undergraduate students. When asked about her evaluation of joint writing from the previous experience, she reflected positively by listing the advantages of students working together:

I had already organised for the students of a high school to write in groups of five. They had written a letter to their pen friends together in fifteen minutes. I observed that writing in groups had benefited the students. The predominant advantage was that the students had been able to learn from one another so that they could come up with diversified ideas. To write the final letters, the students had negotiated and chosen the best [ideas] for their writing. The second advantage of writing in a group was that there had been more interaction in the class. So besides writing, students'

communication skills [L2 speaking skills] had improved. **(Teaching colleague – SSI 1)**

With the students in the class under study, prior to the collaborative writing project, most (23 out of 30) had learnt writing individually. Eight of them had had the chance to write in pairs or groups with their peers. They had composed their own writing and asked for peer feedback. Although the peer feedback was mainly on linguistic accuracy, the experience was reported to be useful for them. One of the students reflected:

Writing together through face-to-face collaboration had helped our group to learn ideas from peers. We were able to help one another find and correct grammar, spellings or expression mistakes. **(Student GT – NAS)**

With regard to online writing, prior to the collaborative project, the teaching colleague had never attended or facilitated any online writing project. Meanwhile, half of the students had previously attended one L2 writing project using blogs organised by one student for her graduation paper. The blog facilitator student had investigated students' attitudes to peer feedback. Participants had been asked to post their individual writing on the blogs and received comments from their peers. The participants had not been asked to revise their work after receiving comments. Although the blog writing project had been voluntary, conducted by a student, and lasted for only two weeks, the students participating in the blog expressed positive attitudes to the project, in particular regarding feedback on linguistic accuracy:

Writing through the blogs helped me to recognise my mistakes [on grammar or spelling] easier: I could find out how to correct them. In addition, I could give feedback on the others' work. **(Student KL – NAS)**

Writing through the blogs had helped me improve my English writing skills. I could learn from the other students' mistakes. In addition, I felt more comfortable when my mistakes were corrected through the blog than the mistakes were corrected in face-to-face meetings. **(Student AH – NAS)**

With regards to the project, in which both face-to-face and online collaboration would be used, participants believed that the project would be beneficial to them. The students expected that shared knowledge among the students could help them improve writing skills:

This is the first time I have known about collaborative writing and wikis. This is quite a new learning approach to me. I think if the teacher asks us to write about one topic, we can share with one another, list the main ideas and write introductions [of essays] together. If there is something that we do not know, others in groups can help us. I want when we work together, we can get many ideas so our writing can improve. **(Participant 1 – FGI 1).**

In my opinion, collaboration will be helpful for us to pool more ideas and correct one another's grammar and spelling mistakes, which helps us to write in L2 more effectively. **(Student GT – NAS)**

The teaching colleague added that besides the benefits of the students helping one another, face-to-face and wiki collaboration could offer the teachers a platform for teaching other than teachers' dominant presentation in class:

After seeing the plan of the project, I think collaborative writing might work effectively in our teaching context. In my class, interaction time between the students and teachers is limited and both students and teachers have to work really hard. We have a lot of work to do during class hours. If we use collaborative writing asynchronously, teachers can monitor students' doing homework by asking them to post their writing. Or the teachers can facilitate some activities in class and leave other activities outside class. So interaction between teachers and students can increase. **(Teaching colleague – SSI 1)**

The teacher's and students' perceptions of collaborative writing were grounded on the limitations of traditional L2 writing methodology: limited class time, dominant roles of teachers, and restricted interaction in class.

First, as discussed in Section 5.1.1, class time for one writing lesson was 90 minutes. Both the teaching colleague and students reflected that it was insufficient for interactive activities to be organised. The teaching colleague added that it had been almost impossible for her to assist the students outside class hours. The teaching colleague stated that learning L2 writing through online modes could solve the time problem for the teachers:

In the class, time is limited and both the students and teachers have a lot of work to do [...]. If learning can be conducted through internet applications, the students will post their writing online and the teachers can give feedback. Or the teachers can implement certain writing activities in class and others online. It will not be necessary that all teaching and learning happen inside classroom. **(Teaching colleague – FGI 1)**

The teaching colleague added that the students would benefit if time for learning was not restricted:

When writing in class, the students have to finish their work in a limited time. With such a shortage of time, they cannot come up with many ideas for their writing. If learning is online, the students can have more time to think about what they are going to write. **(Teaching colleague – FGI 1)**

Second, participants believed that collaborative writing would shift the dominant roles of the teachers to encompass more independent roles for the students. The teaching colleague explained:

I expect that through the writing project, students will be able to learn from one another. There will be different or even contradictory ideas from the students. So in order to finalise their collaborative products, the students need to negotiate. This helps them learn from one another. Second, when learning collaboratively, there will be more interaction among the students.

All of these can lead to students' learning development. **(Teaching colleague – SSI 1)**

Students' responses show that they expected online writing could offer them a platform for collaboration. One student reported:

I like that we can learn with the support of internet applications so that we can help one another. For example, we can chat to exchange our writing [...] or share knowledge with one another. Thanks to that, our writing skills can develop. **(Participant 1 – FGI 1)**

Participants did not mention the importance of collaborative writing to writing assessment prior to the implementation of the project. However, they discussed it in their reflections. This will be reported in Chapter 7.

In short, although writing through face-to-face or online collaboration was not completely new to the students, it had not been officially included in the L2 writing curriculum of the class under study. Despite that, participants expressed quite positive attitudes to collaborative writing. This was observed by the fact that 60 students volunteered to participate in the writing project. As each class could have no more than 30, the researcher-teacher invited 30 of these students to participate in the project.

5.3 CONCLUSIONS

This chapter began with the reflections on participants' experiences of teaching and learning L2 writing in the class under study. The experiences featured the influence of the teacher-centred approach, summative mandated assessment, and unfamiliarity with L2 writing for communicative purposes. The chapter also described participants' purposes in learning L2 writing and their perceptions in the collaborative writing project through face-to-face and wiki modes. The findings from this chapter show that participants' perceptions of collaborative writing align with

the potential benefits that collaborative learning can offer to teachers and learners as reviewed in Chapter 2. The findings also represent participants' expectations, which the researcher-teacher used to tailor the next stage of the action research project. Details of the participants' expectations of each stage of writing and how the project was tailored will be described in next chapter.

Chapter 6: Participants' expectations of and strategies for collaborative writing

In the previous chapter, the influence of traditional pedagogy on L2 writing in the class under study was analysed. The data show the influence of a teacher-centred pedagogy and unfamiliarity with communicative writing. The findings of the previous chapter also reflected that prior to the implementation of the writing project, the participants had positive attitudes to L2 process-genre writing approach. They assumed that collaborative writing would probably result in more shared learning and less dependence on teachers in the class.

This chapter documents what actually happened when Cycle 1 of the project was implemented. Each section starts with descriptions of participants' expectations of each writing stage, and an explanation of how the researcher-teacher took this into account when tailoring Cycle 1. The students' reflections on Cycle 1 are then described. These reflections were subsequently utilised for adjustments to the project in Cycle 2.

6.1 PRE-WRITING STAGE

It has been found that pre-writing stages are important in L2 writing (Section 3.3.2). Skilled L2 writers are reported to spend more time on pre-writing stages than unskilled writers (Sasaki, 2000, 2002; Zamel, 1983). In general, pre-writing tasks include any activity that can help writers generate ideas, or refine or shape writing development (Bloom, 2008).

Prior to the implementation of the project, in the class under study, pre-writing tasks had often been neglected. Two of the students reflected:

Before this project, whenever I wrote, I did not do any pre-writing activities: I did not brainstorm or develop topic sentences either. Neither did I identify what I needed to write beforehand. **(Participant 5 - FGI 1)**

I did not identify or make outlines before writing. I just wrote whatever came into my mind. One of the examples of my way of writing was about listing ideas: I did not often use the internet or references as sources to gather new ideas. Neither did I consult other students in the class. Mostly I used ideas suggested by the teachers. So I felt that the content of my writing was not very creative. **(Participant 4 - FGI 1)**

The students' reflections are consistent with the findings in the previous chapter: the teacher-centred approach was prominent and the students realised that planning L2 writing required time and effort.

Regarding the question about participants' expectations of the pre-writing stage, the findings from the needs analysis survey and first semi-structured interview reveal that the students expected their peers would assist them. In contrast, the teaching colleague highlighted the facilitating role only of the teacher. The students detailed their expectations of their peers:

I expect that we [peer students] will have face-to-face discussions to pool ideas, vocabulary, structures and organisations for writing later. Especially, discussions should be helpful for low proficiency peers. **(Student NP - NAS)**

I hope that face-to-face meetings in class will help each group member to discuss and work more effectively in terms of generating ideas to develop our writing than when we work individually. **(Student MT - NAS)**

Theoretically, this can be interpreted as the students' implicit understanding of Vygotsky's ZPD (Vygotsky, 1978, 1980, 2012). The teaching colleague had different expectations from her students. In terms of pedagogy, she expected that during the

pre-writing discussions, the teacher would have more time to provide the students with scaffolding regarding the content and development of the essays. In other words, the teacher's instructions needed to be made explicit to students. This expectation aligned with the principles of the genre approach, and arose from the fact that in traditional classes, the teachers normally had limited contact time in class as discussed in Chapter 5. With the support of the wikis, the teaching colleague expected that she could conduct some activities in class and leave other activities outside class so as to have more time to guide the students. She described the teacher's roles in the pre-writing stage as follows:

Face-to-face meetings will be a chance for the students to understand more clearly how different types of paragraphs or essays function If they do not understand, the teachers can explain to them generic features of each type of essay The students may have difficulties in gathering ideas, especially with difficult or unfamiliar topics. In face-to-face meetings, the teachers can guide the students to generate or organise ideas. **(Teaching colleague – SSI 1)**

Based on participants' expectations, the researcher-teacher considered how these expectations informed and influenced participants' roles in essay writing sessions. The teaching colleague's expectations were reflected through (a) the researcher-teacher's scaffolding and (b) the researcher-teacher's discussions with the students. Students' expectations were observed through peer discussions. The perspective underlining the researcher-teacher's scaffolding was the sociocultural theory of L2 writing. As established in Chapter 3, Ohta (2001), Donato (1994) and Lantolf and Aljaafreh (1995) argue that scaffolding interaction between the novice-student and expert-teacher can assist students to move to improve their performance.

In the class under study, the teaching colleague specifically emphasised the importance of the teacher's scaffolding when interviewed about the teacher's roles in the writing project. She stressed:

The teacher's scaffolding is needed. For example, if the students identify the main ideas, the teacher can help them by asking some questions to guide them so that it can be easier for the students. **(Teaching colleague – SSI 1)**

In the light of the participants' and also the genre approach perspectives, each writing session was designed to start with the researcher-teacher's scaffolding. Table 6.1 presents in detail the implementation of the stages of scaffolding in the project.

Table 6.1
Activities in the pre-writing stage

Activities in the pre-writing stage		
Stages	Tasks	Time
Stage 1 Teacher's modelling	- The teacher gave three sample essays, plus questions to elicit content and knowledge (see Table 6.3).	20-30 minutes
	- The students read the sample essays and discussed the teacher-initiated questions in the groups.	
	- The students responded to the teacher's questions.	
Stage 2 Students' working collaboratively	- The teacher assigned one topic to each group -The students discussed with their peers how to generate the content/ideas, vocabulary and structures which they might use.	50-60 minutes
Stage 3 Discussions between the researcher-teacher and students	- Each group discussed their final outlines with the teacher.	10-20 minutes

In Stage 1, the researcher-teacher provided the students with three sample essays for modelling. The essays had the key words, structures or ideas bolded and italicised. An example of the sample essays for modelling is on the next page.

COMPARE HIGH SCHOOL TO COLLEGE LIFE

High school, as well as college is just another part in tertiary students' lives. Almost everyone goes through such a transition between two very diverse and different worlds. These diverse worlds can be compared and contrasted by everyone; however, not all are aware of the possible similarities and differences between them. ***The purpose of this essay is to compare the students' high school and college life in terms of the level of academic responsibilities, time schedule, as well as the culture practiced by each student.***

First of all, high school is the first step to a higher level of learning [...]

College, ***on the other hand***, is a different story [...]

People can really see the distinctive difference these two phases in life; however, ***there are also some similarities*** you will carry on during your transition into college lives [...]

We can compare that college is much more challenging and complex than high school.

This is a higher level of learning, thus, requiring more time, effort as well as devotion to studies. Even though college is very tiring at times, ***I still believe*** that college is much more enjoyable and exciting. To have that kind of freedom in your schedule is very rewarding; however, proper judgment is a must since we are all mature students now.

Source: <http://englcomc39tamura.blogspot.com.au/2009/12/comparison-and-contrast-essay-high.html>.

Figure 6.1 An example of the teacher-researcher's sample essay for modelling

The bolded and italicised parts helped the students to recognise the generic structures, vocabulary and organisation of compare and/or contrast essays. Along with the sample essays, the researcher-teacher provided the students with questions designed to elicit content and knowledge of the sample essays. The table on the next page presents the initial questions for argument essays.

Table 6.2

Teacher-initiated questions to elicit content and knowledge of the sample essays

Argument essay

1. What is the purpose/s of the sample essay?
 2. Who will be the potential readers of this essay?
 3. What is your stance on the issue given?
 4. What words/structures/ tenses are used for argument essays?
-

In Stage 2, the teacher gave one topic to each group. In the first essay, they used the initial questions in Table 6.2 above to discuss their own topics. After Cycle 1 of the action research, the researcher-teacher and the teaching colleague observed that the students still encountered difficulties, especially in generating ideas and content. The researcher-teacher decided to give them more detailed guidelines specifically relating to their own essay topics. These guidelines, which addressed the questions in Table 6.2 above, were in the form of the outlines for the essays. The table on the following page presents the model for the cause and/or effect essays given to group 2.

GROUP 2: Why I became an English major student

1. The purposes of this essay are to:

2.may read this essay

3. Reasons for your choosing to become the students of English

3.1.....

3.2.....

3.3.....

Detailed outline

1. Introductory paragraph

General statements: (how do you lead your readers to the topic of your choice?)

Thesis statement:

.....

2. First body paragraph (discuss the first reason)

Topic sentence

.....

3. Second body paragraph (discuss the second reason)

.....

4. Third paragraph (discuss the third reason)

.....

Words and structures should be used

Figure 6.2 Detailed guidelines for cause and/or effect essays (group 2)

In essence, according to the process-genre approach, teachers' explicit instruction of writing is considered important in L2 writing. Bloom (2008, p. 108) proposes that

guidelines are considered as one of the most useful resources for independent writers at pre-writing stages. In this research project, the data collected from the wiki pages did not obviously indicate that these more detailed guidelines reduced the degree of difficulty experienced by the students in generating ideas and content. Despite that, literature has shown that teacher guidelines can provide “the prompting missing between a writer and blank sheet of paper,” and assist writers to “envisage what is needed to express their purposes effectively and to anticipate the possible reaction of an intended readership” (Hyland, 2007, p. 159).

Hyland’s (2007) guidelines for L2 writing show that teachers’ scaffolding does not necessarily mean that teachers dominate the whole learning process. Teacher scaffolding should include interventions or tasks which represent the gradual decrease of teacher control. As teaching and learning progress, the teacher’s control should gradually be reduced. In Stage 2 of the activities for the pre-writing stage in Table 6.1, the topic for each group was given to the students. The students then discussed and shared knowledge and content in their groups. In this way, the researcher-teacher’s close control was gradually replaced by the students’ gaining of the new knowledge and skills. This is also the stage in which students’ collaboration occurred.

In the pre-writing stage, three adjustments were made for Cycle 2 after the researcher-teacher considered participants’ reflections on Cycle 1. These changes were related to topic, discussion platform and grouping. First, regarding the topics, the researcher-teacher attempted to connect the Vietnamese cultural context to the writing topics. The topics were about personal experiences, or recent social or political events in Vietnam. For example, the topics required the students to discuss

recent policies issued by the Department of Traffic (see Appendix 10 for the topics initiated by the researcher-teacher for argument essays). The findings from the second focus group interview with the students revealed that the students preferred topics discussing personal experiences to those discussing social/political events. For example, in the argument essays, group 3 asked for the topic to be changed from the following social topic:

To solve the problem of traffic jams, the Department of Traffic and Transport has proposed that traffic vehicle users must show that they are real owners of the vehicles; otherwise they will be fined. What are your opinions on this proposal?

to the following topic, which they initiated. So their second topic was:

Nowadays, it has been observed that many young people live together before their marriages. What are your opinions on this trend?

Participant 5 in group 3 explained why they asked for a topic change from the social topic to a topic related to personal experience:

My group had difficulties with the first topic that you gave us: It was something “social”. We had little background knowledge about it so we struggled with developing ideas. With the second topic, we found it easier to generate ideas because it was related to our lives: something we know more than the first topic. **(Participant 5 – FGI 2)**

Research both in L1 and L2 has shown that students’ schema (or background knowledge of subject matter) is related to writing performance. In L1, Chesky and Hiebert (1987) found that students with a higher level of prior knowledge wrote quantitatively more and qualitatively better. Similarly, in L2 writing, background knowledge has been linked to writing proficiency (Weigle, 2007). Based on the

literature and students' reflections, the researcher-teacher decided to use topics relating to personal experiences in the third essays.

The second related to the platforms for the students' discussions in the pre-writing stages. For the argument essays, the pre-writing discussions were conducted through students' face-to-face meetings. The students had written down what they discussed in their notebooks or on paper. Then the students reflected that after the face-to-face discussions, they might not have been able to reach an agreement: they needed to have more time for further discussion. It also happened that not all students actually did exactly what they had agreed upon in the face-to-face discussions. The following students in the second focus group interview reflected:

When discussing in class, we agreed on what each of us would write later on our wikis. However, when we worked at home, some of the members in my group did not follow our agreed arrangement. They reported that they forgot what had been discussed. **(Participant 5 – FGI 2)**

In the face-to-face meetings, we could make the outlines with the main and supporting ideas. We divided work among the group's members. But some of the members still asked the other students in my group what they had to write. **(Participant 6 – FGI 2)**

In the second focus group interview, the students suggested that all of the groups needed to post their discussions for the face-to-face meetings on their wikis in accordance with the writing guidelines that the researcher-teacher gave them (see Table 6.2). Accordingly, besides face-to-face meetings, the wikis became the platforms for the groups to further develop their face-to-face discussions. Also, consistency between the group pre-writing stage discussions and individual drafts on the wikis was maintained. The examples of the outlines of the pre-writing discussions will be presented in Section 6.2 below.

The third modification of the pre-writing stage after Cycle 1 was the change in members of each group. At the beginning, the researcher-teacher grouped the students randomly. After two essays, besides the positive feedback on the students' collaboration, Participant 3 recounted that some peers in her group did not contribute much to the face-to-face discussions. She commented:

The difficulty that I found was that some students were not really engaged in the group work. For example, there were things that we discussed and they did not understand but they did not ask us to clarify. They kept silent and seemed to agree with every decision that some of the other members made. **(Participant 3 – FGI 2)**

In response to the question about what alteration needed to be made for the peers to engage more actively in the discussions, participants suggested changing group members. They proposed that each group would include the students who had close social relationships in the class. Some of them explained:

You [teacher-researcher] should let us to choose the members in our group in the next lesson. Regrouping is more effective than letting the current groups work without much improvement, which might demotivate us In class we often have friendship groups, with whom we feel more motivated to work collaboratively. **(Participant 2 – SSI 2)**

When working in a friendship group, I will feel it easier to ask my peers to do, for example, "this" or "that" It will be more difficult to ask peers who are not my close friends to do something because they might think that I "control" them. **(Participant 5 – SSI 2)**

Considering this viewpoint and students' preferences, after the second focus group interview with the students, the researcher-teacher allowed the students to select the peers they preferred working with when writing the third essay.

In the first focus group interview, the students commented that if possible, English needed to be used not only in the teacher's instructions but also the students'

discussions. However, classroom observations showed that the students often switched from English to Vietnamese in oral discussion.

6.2 DRAFTING STAGE

After students' collaborative discussions in the pre-writing stage, the students allocated their work among the members in the groups: each individual student would be responsible for writing one cooperative part/paragraph of the essays on their wiki pages. The students labelled the wiki pages using their real names. The individual parts/paragraphs were linked to the other pages of the same group's members. This means that students worked cooperatively in this stage.

As discussed in Section 6.1, one student was asked to post the pre-writing discussions in the form of an outline. In this way, other members in his/her group could maintain consistency between the pre-writing stage and drafting stage. In other words, students' cooperative writing in this stage was based on their collaborative discussions in the pre-writing stage. The wikis subsequently became the platforms for the students' further discussions of their outlines.

Figure 6.3 presents one of the outlines posted on the wikis.

PRE-WRITING FOR TOPIC "An online class to a traditional class"

1. The purpose of this essay:

This essay will show the readers see the differences between online classes and traditional class in 3 main aspects: time schedule, The effect of learning, making social relationship

2. The audience:

Students, Teachers, Parents

3. Idea:

- *Our present has 3 mains points to support this topic:*

1. *Time schedule: Online class has flexible time while traditional class has to fix time*

2. *The effect of learning*

In traditional classes, most material are provided by the school while in online classes, you would be the one to provide all your materials need

3. *Making social relationship*

In traditional classes, students have more chance to build great relationship while In online classes, it is limited

4. Word:

Online classes, traditional class, Time schedule, differences, simillarity, Learning, social relationship,...

5. Structure:

-The first/second way in which online class and traditional class are different.....

- In contrast,...

Figure 6.3 An example of a student's outline posted on the wikis

It was observed that if in the pre-writing stages the students had reached agreement on content, vocabulary, structures and grammar, they did not need to have further discussions through the wikis. Otherwise, they had to use the wikis to further develop their outlines. Below is an outline by students who did not need to have further

discussion. There are some L2 language surface feature errors here, but the transcript is verbatim.

Topic: Talk to your parents and talk to your friends

1. The purpose of our essay: to discuss about the differences and the similarity between talk to your parents and talk to your friends

2. The audience of our essay: children

3. Ideas:

- **The differences:**
 - ◆ Using words:
 - parents: + use formal words
 - + can't use slang, non-verbal communication àmisunderstand, impolite
 - friends: + can use informal words. Ex: use slang words --> communicate efficiently, quickly and create fun, humorousness
 - + can use non-verbal communication such as gestures, postures,...
 - ◆ Attitudes:
 - parents: + have to politeness, express your earnest when you mention the topic which you want to talk to your parents
 - + don't have offensive attitude or against your parent's advice
 - friends: + talking to friends more comfortable than talking to parents because of the same age and generation
 - + Sometimes, can tease each other
- **The similarity:**
 - talking purpose (share feeling, gain experience, get advices, reinforce relationships)

4. Words

Polite, impolite, respect, formal, familiar, informal, respect, earnest

5. Structures:

- The first difference is...
- Another difference is...

Figure 6.4 An example of the outline after students' discussion

One student explained why her group's outline did not require any further discussion on their wikis:

The first person to write [through the wikis] posted what we had discussed in the face-to-face meeting on our wikis: We had carefully discussed all [the content, vocabulary and structures] in the class.... So he/she summarised them and posted them on our wikis. This was not a difficult task to do.

(Participant 1 - FGI 2)

There were some groups that had further discussions of their outlines because they needed to add more ideas or develop their essay organisation. The following is an example of an outline (from group 2) that required further discussion through the wikis.

Topic: Teacher training should last for 5 years instead of 4 years. Do you agree or disagree?

1. The purpose of our essay: to confirm and persuade the students and teachers that 4 years for teacher training is enough.

2. The audience: students, teachers, education managers...

3. Ideas:

Teacher training should be 4 years for 2 reasons

- There is no strong relationship between the quality of the education and the time we spend.

- Wasting time and money of the students

Against: - Students will have more time to practice teaching.

Conclusion: despite of the advantage of 5 years, it isn't necessary for students.

4. Words:

should (shouldn't), last, good for, experience, quality, method, waste, need, facility, job, time, necessary, university, solve, face to, future, waste, education, money...

5. Structures:

- Being a student of Teacher Training College, I strongly believe that 4 years is enough for Teacher Training.

- First of all, there is no strong relationship between the quality of the education and the time we spend.

- Another major reason is adding 1 years will waste time and money of the students.

Figure 6.5 An outline that needed further discussions through the wikis

The discussions of outlines were initiated in the *Comments* part of the wikis. Figure 6.4 below describes an example of the students' comments on their outline for the topic mentioned in Figure 6.5. For ethical reasons, the names of commentators have been deleted. One student in group 2 suggested changing the development of an idea; however, the other students did not agree with that. They discussed and redrafted their outline. Their negotiation was as follows.

Comments (5)
[Delete all comments](#)

D H said

at 4:28 pm on Apr 27, 2013

[Reply](#)
[Delete](#)

I thinks that this is a good one,but the second idea should be replaced by losing chance to find job.because it is just a small subset and make difficulty in deploying.

H L said

at 1:38 am on Apr 28, 2013

[Reply](#)
[Delete](#)

I don't think so, I think that losing chance to find jobs is a supporting I idea for the main idea "waste time"

T. H. said

at 10:28 pm on Apr 28, 2013

[Reply](#)
[Delete](#)

I agree with H L

D H said

at 10:45 pm on Apr 28, 2013

[Reply](#)
[Delete](#)

oh right,it's up to u.I just think that someone may not consider money and time is important when you invest it to be educated,so your ideas will be defeated:)).

I. S. said

at 7:01 pm on May 1, 2013

[Reply](#)
[Delete](#)

Very good for pre-writing.

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Figure 6.6: An example of the students' further discussions of the outline through the wikis

The individual students started to write their allocated parts, based on the outlines. In general, the students followed the outlines they had discussed in the pre-writing stage. This means that there was an effective cooperation in the drafting stage. For example, in the above outline (Figure 6.5), the group had discussed the idea that an increase in the duration of teacher training courses from four to five years does not ensure improvement in learning. The student who wrote this part followed the idea which had been agreed on by her group. Figure 6.7 below shows her writing and editing based on peer feedback.

The first thing I want to mention is that there is no strong relationship between the quality of the education and the time we spend on it. As we can see, nowadays, many students do regist more courses per one semester in order to finish their education in 2.5 or 3 years, but they still have a nice transcript and a good result while most of students need 4 years to do the same thing. It shows that this is no matter how much time we spend on studying, the essensial thing we need to know is how to take advantage of time to learn. 4 years or 5 years is just a number, it does not mean anything because if you have 5 years at school without an orientation or a right attitude in learning, you will not be able to study well. You just waste your time and money when you wait the time goes by for the day you graduate with no effort. Therefore, the time is not the only one which decide the quality of the education, the most important thing is the effort of a student, so no one can be sure that increasing the time of educate teacher will bring a better result.

Edited:

The first thing I want to mention is that there is little evidence to show that the longer time we study, the better quality we can get. As we can see, nowadays, students are permitted to do more courses per one semester, so they can finish their education in 2.5 or 3 years. Inspite of this, they still get a nice transcript and have a good result while the others need 4 years to do the same thing. It shows that this is no matter how much time we spend on studying, the essensial thing we need to know is how to take advantage of time to learn. 4 years or 5 years is just a number, it does not tell us

Figure 6.7: The student's draft following the outline of the pre-writing stage

The fact that the students mostly followed their outlines reflects the participants' expectations prior to the implementation of the project. In response to the guiding question about participants' expectations of the drafting stage, the students anticipated that what they discussed in the pre-writing stages would be fully utilised. In the first focus group interview and needs analysis survey, the students explained:

I anticipate that in the drafting stage, I can use all the ideas that our group has previously discussed. **(Participant 1 – FGI 1)**

The addition of vocabulary and ideas is important. However, first of all, it is more important that all ideas and vocabulary discussed previously [in the face-to-face meetings] should be used. This can create consistent contributions of all the members in the group. **(Student TP – NAS)**

The teaching colleague confirmed that the students needed to follow the discussions that they had previously had in the face-to-face meetings. She stated:

In the drafting stage, at least the students should use all that they have discussed in the pre-writing stage: the audiences, purposes, structures or vocabulary. **(Teaching colleague – SSI 1)**

In some groups, however, the students did not follow what they had discussed in the pre-writing stage. In other words, the cooperation was not very effective in this stage,

in spite of the earlier collaborative phase. The teaching colleague and one student reported:

In the drafting stage, I observed that some students did not consistently follow what they discussed in the pre-writing stage. [For example,] the idea discussed in the class was A, but when they wrote, they changed it into B.

(Teaching colleague – SSI 2)

In the drafting stages, we tried to follow the outline about purposes, audiences, grammar or structures [which they had discussed in the pre-writing stage]. But when it came to individual writing, there were some parts, which had already been discussed in class that were not included. So in the drafting stage, it was sometimes not the same as what had been discussed in the pre-writing stage. **(Participant 3 – FGI 2)**

Explaining the reasons why some students did not follow the group's outlines, the teaching colleague and two students specified two reasons: (a) lack of discussion notes and (b) the poor quality of their discussion in the pre-writing stages. They commented:

This [the fact that the students did not consistently follow their pre-writing outlines] was maybe because the students could not remember [what they had discussed], as they had not noted the discussions down. Or there was little agreement in the groups in the pre-writing stages. **(Teaching colleague – FGI 2)**

In the first essay, because we did not reach an agreement [in the pre-writing stages], we encountered difficulties in developing our own paragraphs [in the drafting stages]. **(Student KN – RS)**

Besides these two aforementioned reasons including insufficient discussions and lack of discussion notes, Participant 3 in the second focus group interview added that the students' low language proficiency and/or background knowledge of the content could have led to inconsistency in following the outlines. She reported:

In the pre-writing stage, the peers in my group could understand what ideas/content they needed to develop for their assigned writing parts through the wikis. However, when working on the wikis, due to their insufficient background knowledge [linguistic and essay development knowledge], they were unable to clearly express the ideas which had been discussed. Therefore, it looked like they did not follow our group outlines.

(Participant 3 - FGI 2)

The outline for the topic, “Teacher training should last for five years instead of four years” (Figure 6.5 above) is an illustrative example of Participant 3’s reflections concerning the students’ inconsistency due to their level of language proficiency. However, before focussing on the students’ proficiency, the content of the students’ essay will be explained below.

The outline in the pre-writing stage of the essay shows that the students were against the increase in teacher training time despite acknowledgment of one advantage, focusing on the ideas below:

Claims:

- *There is no strong relationship between the quality of education and the time spent.*
- *Wasting time and money of the students*

Acknowledgement: - Students will have more time for practice teaching.

Conclusion: despite the advantage of 5 years, increasing time is not necessary for students.
(Interpret from Figure 6.5)

According to the outline, the students would not support an increase in the duration of teacher training for two reasons: (1) there has been no strong evidence to show that the longer the time for teacher training, the greater the quality of learning, and (2) an increase in training time results in more expenditure and loss of opportunities to find a job. These two “against” points would be raised in paragraph 2 and 3 of the students’ essay. Then in paragraph 4 the supporting point was mentioned (see Appendix 12).

To return to the point regarding the students' low language proficiency and/or background knowledge, as can be seen from Appendix 12, the student writing paragraph 4 was aware that her paragraph supported one advantage of increasing time for teacher training, which is to provide teacher trainees with more practicum. This paragraph was for her to provide the readers with a different viewpoint from the two preceding paragraphs. Below is her paragraph extracted from Appendix 12.

On the other hand, increasing the teachers' training time up 5 years will contribute to improve the quality of students who can meet requirements of the education sector today. We can see that, part of student teaching after graduating but pedagogical skills are still poor which means they will not have the opportunity to be a teacher. Moreover, in real-time vocational training college is too little, not enough to improve pedagogical skills for students. Although adding a year for the teacher's training has some benefits, results do not depend on the issue is long or short time but it depends on the effort of each student oneself and training programmes of the universities. Thus increasing the teachers' training time is not necessary. (A student inconsistency following the outline due to language proficiency- Extracted from the students' essays)

In the paragraph above, the student used “On the other hand” to signal to the readers that she discussed the acknowledged point, which was different from the points in the two preceding paragraphs. However, she could not maintain cohesion and coherence with the previous paragraphs. The paragraph could make the readers misunderstand that the same stance as the previous paragraphs was taken. In the last two sentences of the paragraph beginning with “Although”, the writers could not make it clear that the acknowledged point was deemed as not significant enough to outweigh the disadvantages. This is all to say, the students' writing proficiency levels played a part in the students' consistently or inconsistently following their outlines made in the pre-writing stages.

There was one adjustment to Cycle 2 made in the drafting stage. During the students' cooperative work on the first essays, it was observed that some students posted their parts late, which subsequently influenced the postings of the other students in their groups. The teaching colleague and one student informed the researcher-teacher about this:

In the first essay, some members in some groups did not post their parts in time. This made their peers wait and they could not finish their parts until the last minutes. **(Teaching colleague – SSI 2)**

The first member did not write in time, so it was difficult for the second or third members to continue their parts. **(Student AV – RS)**

In fact, when working through wikis, time management is a big issue for teachers and wiki users (Allwardt, 2011; Judd et al., 2010). To solve this problem, Participant 2 proposed mini-deadlines. She stated:

To solve the problem of late postings, The time for each essay should be two weeks, and time for each student to do his/her part is two days. The student who writes the first paragraph will have to finish his/her part in the first two days. Then the second student can develop his/her part. During this time, the peers can comment on the first paragraph for the first student to make revisions. The students should not post their writing at the last minute. It should not happen that tomorrow is the deadline and the students have to hurry to write their parts today. **(Participant 2 – FGI 2)**

The literature reports on students' similar proposals to Participant 2. For example, Allwardt's students suggested shortening dates for posting timelines so that the writing activities could be broken down with short-term deadlines.

To conclude, in the drafting stage of the first essay, students worked cooperatively, and there was a close link between this stage and the pre-writing stage. If the collaborative discussions in the pre-writing stage were effective, in the drafting stage, students cooperated more effectively. The students' language and/or background

knowledge and posting time also influenced their collaboration. One modification was suggested for this stage relating to the mini deadlines for individual postings.

6.3 FEEDBACK STAGE

Feedback, especially peer feedback, has recently been acknowledged by both L2 teachers and students as a way to improve writing proficiency. Research has been conducted to investigate the positive impact of online feedback on writing quality (Tuzi, 2004; Ware & Warschauer, 2006; Woo, Chu, Ho, & Li, 2011).

If in the drafting stage, the students worked cooperatively by posting individual writing, they worked collaboratively in the feedback stage to provide feedback on their peers' writing. It has been established that one of the difficulties that students with L2 traditional writing backgrounds encounter when learning with wikis is their reluctance to edit, and particularly to delete, other students' (Lund, 2008). In the first focus group interview, the researcher-teacher asked the students whether they liked their peers commenting on their writing by deleting existing parts or leaving comments under their writing parts without deleting what they had written. All of the students in the first focus group interview responded that they preferred the latter. One of the students replied:

I prefer leaving comments under existing writing of the peers in my group:
It shows my respect for writers. **(Participant 4 – FGI 1)**

Considering the students' preferences for not deleting the writing of the fellow students, the researcher-teacher asked the students to feedback to their peers on the "Comments" functions of the pages. In this way, interaction between writers (the students who wrote the texts) and readers (the students who commented on the texts) was established.

Figure 6.8 presents an example of the students' comments under the existing text.

The first thing I want to mention is that there is no strong relationship between the quality of the education and the time we spend on it. As we can see, nowadays, many students do register more courses per one semester in order to finish their education in 2.5 or 3 years, but they still have a nice transcript and a good result while most of students need 4 years to do the same thing. It shows that this is no matter how much time we spend on studying, the essential thing we need to know is how to take advantage of time to learn. 4 years or 5 years is just a number, it does not mean anything because if you have 5 years at school without an orientation or a right attitude in learning, you will not be able to study well. You just waste your time and money when you wait the time goes by for the day you graduate with no effort. Therefore, the time is not the only one which decide the quality of the education, the most important thing is the effort of a student, so no one can be sure that increasing the time of educate teacher will bring a better result.

Comments (4)

T. H. said at 12:45 am on Apr 28, 2013

Everything is ok. but I think "nowaday" should be replaced by "nowadays", "the time of educate teacher" should be replaced by " the time of teacher training"

D. H. said at 10:54 pm on Apr 28, 2013

That's right: I will do this.

I. S. said at 1:08 am on Apr 28, 2013

You have written a good paragraph. I am so impressed with the idea that "there is no strong relationshipon it." Although I have different attitude of time of training, you can convince me. I have some suggestions to help improve your paragraph:

1st sentence: "there is". We should not use such strong word as "no strong relationship", it makes readers feel that you are putting your views on them. Something which can make the expression more neutral like "there is little evidence to show that the longer time we study, the better quality we can get" . And the sentence "you just waste your time" is strong too. Make it neutral please.

Some words need to be replaced, for example, "regist", right attitude in learning" "with no effort"

D. H. said at 10:58 pm on Apr 28, 2013

It's really hard for me. I know all of these words have problem but I don't know how to express the ideas correctly. And the sentence seems to be too long but I don't know how to fix it, too:)).But I will try to rewrite it more better.

Figure 6.8: Students' feedback under the "Comments" function of the wikis

Regarding the focus of the comments, prior to the implementation of the project, the students anticipated that peer comments would help them to improve in both global areas (content and development) and local areas (grammar, spelling and punctuation) of their writing. The following quotes show their expectations:

I hope that when I receive feedback from peers, I can understand more about the ideas that I am developing. I expect them to help me with their comments on grammar, spelling and development of essays. **(Student KL – NAS)**

Receiving comments from peers is important for me to develop my writing skills. During the feedback stages, we can discuss and raise ideas about the organisation, structures, vocabulary so that our drafts will improve. **(Student TP – NAS)**

After the first essay, the data from the wiki pages show that the number of comments on global and local areas was similar: of the 43 comments, 21 were global and 22 local comments.

Table 6.3

Focus of students' comments on the argument essays

Area Types	Global (21)		Local (22)	
	Revision	Non-revision	Revision	Non-revision
Evaluations	0	2	0	0
Clarifications	5	1	4	1
Suggestions	12	0	4	1
Alterations	1	0	12	0
<i>Total</i>	<i>18</i>	<i>3</i>	<i>20</i>	<i>2</i>

In contrast to the data from the wikis, the information from the second focus group interview with the students shows that more comments were made on local than global areas. The following participants stated:

After the first essay, the comments were mostly on vocabulary or grammar. If the students commented on content, they did not usually recommend how to improve it. For example, they suggested the peers not doing “this” or “that” but they could not make it clear what the reasons for their suggestions were. **(Teaching colleague – SSI 2)**

For the feedback part, I saw that the peers in my group often gave more comments on grammar or spellings than ideas. This was because commenting on content/ideas was difficult for us. **(Participant 1 – FGI 2)**

The difference in types of comments explains the contradiction between the wiki data and the students' interviews. As can be seen from Table 6.3 above, suggestion – revision comments accounted for the largest number in the global areas (12 out of 21). In local areas, alteration-revision comments were the largest (12 out of 22). As discussed in Chapter 4, alteration – revision – comments provide exactly how to change or edit writing while suggestion- revision comments point out directions for changes. Participant 3 in the second focus group interview explained why sometimes her directions for changes were not really helpful to her peers:

I did comment on the peers' writing. However, sometimes my comments were not in detail. For example, I just told them there was something wrong with the sentences but I could not tell them how to change the sentences right. **(Participant 3 – FGI 2)**

Here are some examples of suggestion – revision comments in the argument essays.

[Y]you should narrow the general statement, I understand your idea but it is too far from the second sen [sentence], I think it will be ok if you add 1 or 2 sentences between this. This sentence links "many problems" to "teacher training", I mean smt [something] like "improving the quality of teacher training is one of the most". **(Student DH – Argument essay – group 2)**

[I]idea in your body paragraph and An's body paragraph are similar. [A]and i[I] think your first idea and your second idea are also similar. **(Student LQ – Argument essay – group 3)**

It is obvious that the students met more difficulties in editing their writing in accordance with the suggestion – revision comments above.

Meanwhile, it was easier for them to change their writing based on the alteration – revision comments. Below are some examples of this type of comment:

[W]e should use “financial problems” not “money problems.” (Student ND – Argument essay – group 6)

You have some mistake[s], such as, brain’s development, and in the fourth sentence you have to capitalise [the letter]. (Student HT – argument essay – group 4)

Hence, the differences between the nature of the alteration comments and suggestion comments explain why participants reflected that the focus of comments was mainly on local areas. Analysis of the quality of suggestion – revision comments will be made in Sections 7.3 and 7.4.

The adjustment in Cycle 2 of the feedback stages was related to the quantity of comments. It was observed that the total number of comments was insufficient for the peer students to develop their writing. More importantly, there was a considerable difference in the number of comments in each group: the highest number of comments for one group was 12 and the lowest was 2, as demonstrated in Table 6.4.

Table 6.4
Number of comments in the argument essay

Groups	Group 1	Group 2	Group 3	Group 4	Group 5	Group 6
Number of comments (Total 43)	2	10	12	11	2	6

Table 6.4 shows that group 1 and group 5 had the least comments. The students from group 1 and group 5 reflected that this was due to two reasons. First, despite the teacher-researcher’s induction on how to work on the wikis prior to the implementation of the project, some of the students in these two groups had difficulties in setting up their wiki accounts. Participant 2 of group 1 reported that

two members in her group could not get access to their wiki pages. As a result, they posted their writing late, which hindered the peers from giving comments. Second, the researcher-teacher had not stated strongly enough that their essays were to be collaboratively written; hence comments were a necessity for their writing to develop. Accordingly, the students finished their individual writing sections and paid less attention to the peers' parts.

For improvements in Cycle 2, the students' wiki logging frequencies were proposed as one solution to the problem concerning the unequal number of comments among the groups. Participant 5 stressed that the researcher-teacher needed to set up minimum times that each student logged in the wikis. Furthermore, a minimum number of comments for each student needed to be stressed. She recommended:

You [researcher-teacher] should make it clear that the students need to get access the wikis at least twice a week. And they have to give comments on others' writing. **(Participant 5 – FGI 2)**

Accordingly, in Cycle 2, the students were required to access the wikis twice a week, and with each essay they needed to have at least two comments. The data from the wikis show that after the adjustment, the number of comments in the second essay did not increase significantly, but the differences between the quantities of comments among groups decreased. Specifically, group 1 had 6 comments and group 5 received 8 comments in the second essays. More information regarding this adjustment as well as the focus of the comments will be presented in Chapter 7 (see Table 7.3).

In the feedback stage, besides peers' comments, students also received comments from the researcher-teacher. The researcher-teacher commented on the students' writing when seeing few peer comments were given. The total number and areas of comments after the first essay are presented in the table below.

Table 6.5

Teacher-researcher's areas of comments after the first essays

Areas	Global (18)		Local (9)	
Types	Revision	Non-revision	Revision	Non-revision
Evaluations	0	0	0	0
Clarifications	2	0	0	0
Suggestions	15	0	8	0
Alterations	1	0	1	0
<i>Total</i>	<i>18</i>	<i>0</i>	<i>9</i>	<i>0</i>

From Table 6.3 (above) it can be seen that peer feedback focused both on global (21) and local (22) comments. Table 6.5 shows that teacher's provided more comments on global (18) than local areas (9).

The students reported that they preferred to receive and deploy the teacher's comments rather than the peers' comments. One of the student participants in the second focus group interview stated that the teacher's feedback was important to her group, especially when shared understanding among peers did not happen. She emphasised:

I think teacher's comments were useful. Most of the students waited for teacher's comments, especially on issues that we still disagreed with one another. These comments were seen as guidance in my group. **(Participant 2 – FGI 2)**

It can be inferred that Participant 2 preferred the researcher-teacher's to peers' comments because the teacher could suggest more detailed ways to revise their writing than the peers could. In Section 7.3, which reports on the reflections on the completed writing project, detailed analysis on the content of the teacher's and the

students' comments – on, for example, ideas, development or grammar – will further be discussed.

In summary, this section describes participants' expectations and actual activities in the feedback stage. The expectations of the focus of students' comments were different from the students' actual comments. This was due to comments on global areas being mostly the suggestion-revision type. The collated information also shows that increasing the number of comments was an essential adjustment to Cycle 2.

6.4 REVISION STAGE

The revision stage was conducted after individual students had received comments or feedback from the researcher-teacher and their peers. This stage involved the students' consideration and integration of feedback to edit/change their writing. It means that students worked cooperatively in this stage. Prior to the implementation of the project, participants were concerned about cohesion among the individual paragraphs. They expected one face-to-face meeting would be organised for the peers in the revision stages. In this way, the individual paragraphs could be logically developed. One of the students and the teaching colleague commented:

In the drafting stage, it is important that individual paragraphs are logically developed. We may need to discuss with one another to propose linking words, joining or separating sentences so as to create cohesion among paragraphs. **(Participant 2 – FGI 1)**

Each group should consider all feedback that each individual member receives. Then the students should meet face-to-face to discuss how to edit or change in accordance with suggested feedback. The students also need to meet before final essays are completed. **(Teaching colleague – SSI 1)**

However, the participants' expectation that the students meet face-to-face to discuss the comments on individual paragraphs was not possible. Because the students'

learning timetable was already fixed with only one face-to-face writing session per week, the researcher-teacher could not add one more face-to-face meeting. As will be explained in Chapter 7, based on the findings of this study and the literature, face-to-face discussions in the revision stage are a suggested strategy to improve students' collaboration through wikis. Not being able to facilitate a face-to-face discussion in the drafting stage is then considered a limitation of this study in Chapter 8.

Although there were no face-to-face discussions held after the first essay, the students reported positively on the revision stage. They especially emphasised the affordances of wikis and consistency in outlines between the pre-writing stage and revision stage. Two of the students commented:

After writing my part, I could revise it, based on the peers' and teacher's comments, and it might be good. But when my paragraph was combined with the peers' parts, we needed to create logical links among paragraphs. The wikis could help us with this. They could help us to see the parts, which were not logically linked, and then we could have clearer revision.

(Participant 2 – FGI 2)

In my group, we all wrote in accordance with what we had discussed in the pre-writing stage. After each paragraph, we had the transitional or linking words among the individual paragraphs. The cohesion among the paragraphs did not matter much to my group. **(Participant 5 – FGI 2)**

Data from the wikis show that the students employed the comments to refine their writing. Data from the wikis also show that the students deployed the global and local comments to refine their writing. Table 6.6 presents the students' drafts to response to her peers' comments.

Table 6.6

Students' negotiation to revise writing

First draft	As to the first point of view, money plays an important role in life and love. First, everyone needs money to maintain their life. You need money to buy things, both neccessities and desirables, including to create a long-term relationship. For example, if you want to take someone out on a nice date to make an impression, it will probably take a little bit of money. Second, you will need money to take care your family after getting married. People have to deal with many problems when they have a family: paying for water bill, fees for children, and demand for others reasons. We cannot solve them without money. Last, financial can lead to conflict between wives and husband. For any families, money problems mean bigger changes, such as a parent taking on a second job or the family having to move to a less expensive house. When a family has money worries, it's easy to get frustrated and upset-and if you feel that way, you're far from alone. Parents also might be more stressed out than usual.
Peers' comments	Peer 1: I think, In your first sentence, you can say that "I agree that money plays an important role not only with our life, but also love". Peer 2: i think the sentence" we cannot solve them without money" should say that it is difficult to solve all of this problem without money. Peer 3: we should use financial problems not money problems Peer 4: i don't understand the meaning if [of] the sentence" you're far from alone"
Second draft	As to the first point of view, money is important to establish a relationship when two people are in love and to maintain this relation when they get married. You can see that everyone needs money to maintain their life. You need money to buy things, both neccessities and desirables, including to create a long-term relationship. For example, if you want to take someone out on a nice date to make an impression, it will probably take a little bit of money. Besides the above problem, you will also need money to take care your family after getting married. People have to deal with many problems when they have a family: paying for water bill, fees for children, and demand for others reasons. We cannot solve them without money. Moreover, financial difficulties can lead to conflict between wives and husband. For any families, financial problems

mean bigger changes, such as a parent taking on a second job or the family having to move to a less expensive house. When a family has money worries, it's easy to get frustrated and upset-and if you feel that way, you're far from alone. Parents also might be more stressed out than usual.

Below is an example of a student's edited versions to illustrate that the students benefited from the researcher-teacher's comments.

Being parents, must be most of them want their children not only to be reared carefully but also to be educated well. Choosing suitable learning methods for their children before attending primary school is very important. There is an intense debate among parents whose children are going to primary school. Some parents support that their children learn how to read and write at pre-primary school. Others strongly disagree. In my opinion, I strongly support that children should learn how to read and write at pre-primary school. (Student GTT's first draft – Argument essay)

The researcher-teacher suggested adding more explanations on the context of primary education to her writing. The teacher asked: "*Could you please state that parents you are discussing are in Vietnam, not parents in other countries. There are some word repetitions.*" The student refined her draft by adding "*in Vietnam*", but she could not find which words were repeated. Her second draft was refined as follows:

Being parents in Vietnam, must be most of them want their children not only to be reared carefully but also to be educated well. Choosing suitable learning methods for their children before attending primary school is very important. There is an intense debate among parents whose children are going to primary school. Some parents support that their children learn how to read and write at pre-primary school. Others strongly disagree. In my opinion, I strongly support the first point of view. (Student GTT's second draft – Argument essay)

The second draft contained only minor modifications. The researcher-teacher continued to stress that some more revisions were needed. Below is the researcher-teacher's feedback:

I still feel the first sentence is not clear. Consider that the first sentence discusses parents' expectations while the rest discusses the primary education. My suggestion is that you can introduce the primary education right in the first sentence, for example, how important it is. Additionally, you use "strongly disagree" and "strongly support". The adverb "strongly" is repeated. Use other words to replace it please.

In her third draft, the student employed the researcher-teacher's feedback to her writing. Here is her final draft:

In Vietnam, primary education is very important, choosing suitable learning method for children before attending primary school is very necessary. Because parents want their children not only to be reared carefully but also to be educated well. There is an intense debate among parents whose children are going to primary school. Some parents support that their children learn how to read and write at pre-primary school. Others completely disagree. In my opinion, I strongly support the first point of view. (Student GTT's third draft – Argument essay)

Although the content, development and coherence these two examples still need revising, there were considerations to revise writing. This, together with the students' reflections above, supports the findings that in the drafting stage of the first essay, the students considered and deployed the feedback that they received from their peers and teacher.

However, it was also observed from the wikis that a problem occurred in the students' first drafting stage: revisions on local areas (grammar, spelling, punctuation, and structures) were larger in number than those on global areas (content and development). First, among the 43 comments given for the argument essays (see Table 6.3), all the comments on the local areas ($n = 22$), especially alteration type ($n = 12$), were used in revisions. Meanwhile, most of the comments on the global areas ($n = 21$) were not acted upon. Specifically, although the students considered the comments, not all of them integrated the suggestions to refine their parts. For example, one student responded to her peers, "Thank for your comments. I

will try to edit it [her writing part]” (**Student VKN**). However, in her final draft, no changes were made. Some students did not even respond to peers’ comments.

As explained in Section 6.3, the students reported that there were more comments on the local areas (spelling, vocabulary, punctuation) than on global areas (content/ideas or development). They also reported that it was hard to refine their writing based on comments on global areas, especially suggestion types. Accordingly, most of the revisions in the drafting stage were on local areas.

The modification of this stage was related to that of the feedback stage: each student was asked to give at least two comments per essay. This means that the quantity of comments was expected to increase. While the quality of the comments depended on the students’ L2 proficiency, an increase in number of comments was expected to result in more draft revisions in Cycle 2.

To conclude, after the drafting stage of the first essay, the close relationship between the feedback stage and the revision stage was established. Due to comments during the feedback stage mainly focusing on local areas, there were not many revisions with regards to global areas in the drafting stage. This was because the quality of the global comments could not lead to significant improvement in the students’ writing.

6.5 PUBLISHING STAGE

When the students had already finished individual parts/paragraphs, they copied these parts to new pages for their group’s completed essays. These completed essays were required to be illustrated with pictures, music or animations so as to attract potential readers’ attention. This stage required students to work collaboratively.

Prior to the implementation of the project, the participants had reported two different opinions regarding the requirement to use illustrations. Specifically, the teaching colleague and some students believed this was not necessary, but most of the students supported it. Below are the participants' responses.

Here are two "against" views:

The use of illustrations depends on types of writing. For example, if the students are going to write a newspaper article, they need to insert music or pictures to illustrate their writing. However, with essays in this project, the students just need to present them in form of words. **(Teaching colleague – SSI 1)**

An essay with illustrations other than words probably attracts readers' attention. However, it may also distract them if writers over use illustrations. **Student TT – NAS)**

and two supporting points:

An essay with illustrations will easily attract readers' attention and make them feel more excited to read, which helps writing to come closer to the audience **(Student PT- NAS)**

If an essay has words only, this may make readers feel bored. If music or pictures are included together with words, this may attract more readers' attention. **(Student HL – NAS)**

After the first essays, it was reflected that the use of the wikis enabled the students to publish their collaborative writing in a convenient way. Below are the students' reflections:

Publishing with the wikis was easy to do. **(Participant 4 – FGI 2)**

Combining our individual paragraphs to form an essay was easy with the wikis: we did not need to re-write all the individual paragraphs from the beginning. All we needed to do was to copy separated paragraphs and paste them in the final pages. **(Participant 5 – FGI 2)**

However, the students did not include many illustrations: their completed essays were mainly texts. Two of the students explained the reasons why they had not used illustrations:

Like some other groups, my group did not use any illustration in our final essay. After posting the completed essay, we did not usually re-read our work because we thought that we had done revisions for our own parts, and our individual parts were the best parts that we could write.

(Participant 5 – FGI 2)

In my group, one of us created a page for the final essay. Each of us copied our individual parts to the last page so the final essay included all the individual paragraphs. But then we did not read the whole essay of our group. We just pasted our own paragraphs from our individual pages to the group page and that was all we did. **(Participant 3 – FGI 2)**

What actually happened in the publishing stage of the first essay was in contradiction to their expectations. The audience awareness that the students had stressed prior to the implementation of the project was not considered. It was also observed that not much active collaboration occurred. This was due to the influence of traditional pedagogy and late postings. First, as discussed in Sub-section 5.1.3, readership awareness was not emphasised in the class under study. The students did not consider readers except for their examiners or teachers. The impact was still seen when the project proceeded. Second, the late postings as discussed in Section 6.2 meant that the students did not have sufficient time for their final products.

An adjustment was made to Cycle 2 regarding the existing problems of the publishing stage after the first essay. It was decided that the students would make the front page of each essay attractive to the potential readers. This means that instead of using illustrations to complement words in completed essays, the students could illustrate their topic pages. The results of this adjustment will be discussed in Chapter 7.

6.6 SUMMARY

This chapter reported on the implementation of the writing project, reflections on students' collaboration in the first Cycle and their suggestions for modification in Cycle 2. It also reflected on the researcher-teacher's evaluation and adjustment of the participants' expectations to tailor the writing activities of Cycle 1. The findings demonstrate that after the first Cycle, the project satisfied participants' expectations of the affordances of face-to-face and wiki collaboration for shared learning to occur in Cycle 1. In addition, L2 collaborative writing facilitated students' understanding more about processes of writing and raised their awareness of the audiences of their writing. Adjustments for each stage of writing regarding allowing students more authority in learning, increasing quality and quantity of contributions, and considering readers for publishing, made for more effective collaboration in Cycle 2 of the project.

Chapter 7: Reflections and evaluation of the entire project and suggestions for future projects

This chapter discusses participants' reflections on the entire structure of the writing project and addresses research question 3. It focuses on participants' evaluations of each stage of the collaborative writing processes (pre-writing, drafting, feedback, revision and publishing stages). The adjustments initiated by the students and researcher-teacher after the first essays of Cycle 1 of the action research are discussed in terms of effectiveness. The instruments to collect data included (1) the third focus group interview (**FGI 3**) with the selected students, (2) the second semi-structured interview (**SSI 2**) with the teaching colleague, (3) the reflection survey (**RS**) with all of the students, and (4) the data archived in the wikis. Each section of the present chapter begins with participants' overall evaluations of each stage of writing. The evaluations are then compared to or contrasted with the data from the wikis using the analysis proposed in Chapter 4 to evaluate affordances or constraints encountered at each stage of writing. The findings of this chapter address the research questions regarding participants' reflections and effective strategies for collaborative writing. The findings show that the face-to-face and drafting stages were the most effective because they enhanced peer sharing of knowledge through discussions and guided students through the processes of L2 writing. Although the students valued the peer comments in the feedback stage, students' levels of writing proficiency and skills in group work resulted in uneven effectiveness among groups. Adjustments are suggested for future projects.

7.1 REFLECTIONS ON THE PRE-WRITING STAGE

This section begins with the overall evaluation of the project on how each stage of writing could enhance students' writing. It then reports the results of the adjustments to Cycle 2. The section ends with the difficulties that the students encountered when collaborating in each stage.

In general, participants reported the most positive reflections on the pre-writing stages. This was shown through the students' responses to the questions: "How effective was each stage of your writing?" The students selected the pre-writing stages as the most effective, as demonstrated below.

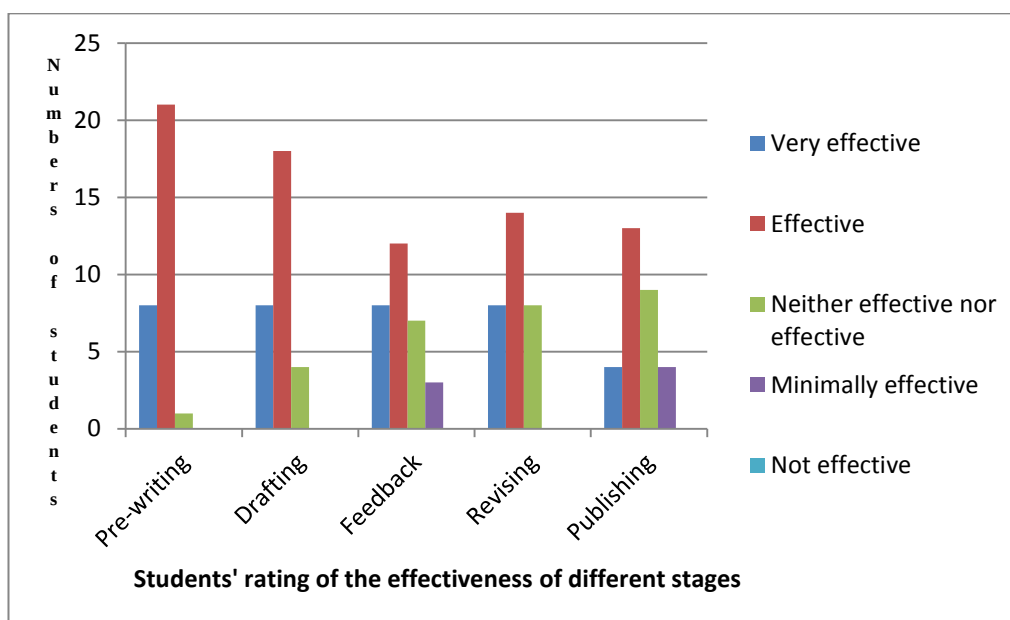


Figure 7.1 Students' rating of the effectiveness of different stages of the project

In the more specific responses, participants indicated that the pre-writing stage was effective in helping them to understand the processes of writing. Specifically, the shared understanding among the students could lead to generation of writing content. Below is an excerpt from one student's reflections:

When discussing in the class, all the members could make their contributions to the writing: choose suitable ideas or reject unsuitable ones. That was why the discussion was effective to me. **(Student BD – RS)**

Among these stages, the pre-writing stages were probably the most effective for us because during these stages, we could raise our individual opinions about the given topics. Then the whole group reached consensus. **(Student LTTV – RS)**

The teaching colleague agreed that the pre-writing stage engaged students in activities to generate content. She emphasised:

I must say that all the activities in the pre-writing stage were necessary to help the students before they started to write: identifying the purposes, audiences, ideas and vocabulary, especially identifying the ideas. In addition, what the students summarised from their discussions could help the teachers to see whether the students could fulfil the goals of learning or not. **(Teaching colleague – SSI 2)**

The teaching colleague mentioned one of the adjustments to the pre-writing stage. As explained in Section 6.1, the students were required to post their outlines on the wikis. In this way, consistency in the students' discussions in the pre-writing stage was maintained in the later stages. In addition, based on these outlines posted on the wikis, the teacher-researcher could assess if the students met the criteria of pre-writing stages as mentioned in Table 4.11. These criteria include:

1. Main ideas that could guide students' individual writing were listed.
2. Development of writing was clearly proposed.
3. Purposes and audience of writing were identified:
 - Who would potentially read their writing?
 - What were their purposes in writing the essays?

Six of the outlines for the cause and/or effect essays were used to assess if the students could identify the ideas, key words and organisation of the essays.

The outlines from the wiki pages indicate that most of the groups could identify the main ideas, structures or vocabulary for their writing, as required in the pre-writing stages. For example, among the six outlines that the groups made for the cause and/or effects essays, four outlines were deemed to fulfil the function of an effective outline. Below are two, one of which discusses the effects of over-population (group 4), and the other the causes of the decrease in the number of students entering teacher training institutions (group 6).

Topic : overpopulation!

1. *Purpose* : show the bad effect of overpopulation and persuade people to help to control this problem.

2. *Reader* : parents,goverment.

3. *Introductory* :

- Overpopulation is a serious problem.
- Current situation : give details.
- The effect of this problem is in 3 main field : economy,enviroment and society.

4. *Main ideas* :

- Overpopulation increase the pressure on the economy,especialy making jobs.
- This problem is also a factor which destroy the enviroment (run out of natural resources).
- Overpopulation lead to many social problems : increase crime,affect to living standard.

5. *Structure*.

- The effect of overpopulation on
- It affect to....
- This phenomenon lead to.....
- The first effect of overpopulation is
- Secondly.....
- As the result,.....

6. *Word*.

phenomenon,problem,field,harm,waste,lack,destroy,effect,affect,condition,standard,chance,resource.

Figure 7.2 An effective outline written by group 4

Pre-writing

1. The purpose of our essay:

An essay give the reason why the number of students entering teacher training colleges decreases.

2. The audience:

Students

3. Ideas:

Point 1: After graduating, most trainee teachers have difficulties finding a position.

- The current number of students at training teachers institutions is big. For example (give example of 1 particular college or university)
- The posts available for new teachers are limited. (give example)

Point 2: Teaching is no longer a promising job

- Low salary compared to other jobs
- Low promotion/ Few opportunities for promotion

4. Word:

- Post, position, job, employment
- trainee teachers, teacher students, new teachers
- teacher training college/ university/institution
- Low/ discouraging salary/ promotion

5. Structure:

- Finding a teaching job is difficult
- Unemployment rate is high

6. Grammar

Present simple tense and Past simple tense

Figure 7.3 An effective outline written by group 6

Although in terms of word usage, expression, grammar and spelling, these two outlines still needed revising, they were considered to be effective, because they helped the students to decide what ideas needed to be developed and how to develop them later. This was supported by one of the students in group 6, and the teaching colleague:

Finding an idea for the essay was a difficult task for me. But when I worked with my friends, it became easier. I found it the most effective when I could develop supporting ideas from the main ideas: how to organise them. This helped me to write more easily at home. **(Participant 4 - SSI 3)**

Among all the skills of L2 writing, identifying ideas might be the most important skill. From my experience, our students are usually not good at identifying ideas. So having their friends or teachers' suggestions in their writing was really helpful for them to work at home. **(Teaching colleague - SSI 2)**

Two groups were less successful in the pre-writing stage because the main content of their essays was not clearly identified. Below is an outline that describes the reasons the students became English majors.

PRE-writing for topic: Why you became the English major?

- 1.The purposes of this essay are to :this essay will show benefit of becoming the students of english major.
- 2.The audience : students , young people may read this essay .
- 3.Idea: Our present has 2 mains points to support this topic:
 - a.Firstly, because english is my favorite subject
 - b. Another reason , for choosing to become the students of English major is that it's useful for me not only now but also the future
4. Words
-students , favorite subject , major , choosing
5. Structure
_another
-firstly
-incontrast
-for example
-moreover
6. Grammar
present simple tense , simple future tense .

Figure 7.4 A less successful outline of group 2 for the cause and/or effect essay

The students who wrote the above outline were aware that they were not successful in the pre-writing stage. In fact, the outline could not provide a frame for the group members to follow, despite the fact that the writing topic required them to write about their own experiences. Below are their reflections:

The discussions in the pre-writing stage were still in debate and we could not reach a consensus on what we were going to write at home, hence the outline was not completed. **(Student PTND – RS)**

In the face-to-face discussion, we did not come up with sufficient main ideas. **(Student DN – RS)**

Despite these two less successful groups, overall, in the pre-writing stage of Cycle 2, the students could identify the main ideas, vocabulary and structures of their essays.

Another modification proposed by the students for Cycle 2 was the change in group members. The students expected that peers who had a close social relationship could work more effectively than the researcher-teacher's selected groups. They claimed that in friendship groups all members willingly participated in group work. This was because all the members knew one another well socially, which made them feel at ease to share with their peers. One student from the reflection survey stated that although all of the groups that she belonged to worked effectively, she preferred the friendship group. She reported:

In the first essay [argument essay], all the members actively made contributions to the group so there was nothing like one or two students dominating the group work. There were no non-participants ... I felt more comfortable working with those who I had a close relationship with as we could discuss and comment more frankly than with those who I did not know well. **(Student AV – RS)**

Another student reflected that shared knowledge between the novice and more capable peers happened more easily than in other groups. She considered:

In my group there were both low and high proficiency levels peers. But the spirit of group working was good so we could work effectively. We often gathered at class or home [outside class hours] to discuss. There is a fact that if you are in groups of many high level students, low level students will not feel comfortable to raise their ideas. They feel how good the high level students work. That is why low level students do not often actively participate in group work. But if you were in the friendship group like us, you would feel at ease to share ideas or comment on the other work.
(Participant 2 – FGI 3)

The students' reflections were collated when the project ended. The teacher-researcher had little evidence to prove that the friendship groups could produce more effective essays than the other groups. However, it can be concluded that social relationships among the students could impact positively on their motivation to

collaborate. The finding aligns with the results of Kramsch and Sullivan (1996) and Tomlinson and Dat (2004), as discussed in Chapter 2. In their studies, the authors emphasised that generally, Vietnamese students prefer a collaborative learning environment where they can establish long-term relationships and consider the class as a family. The evidence here suggests that friendship groups with mixed proficiency levels were effective for the students' collaboration.

In the pre-writing stages of both cycles of the action research, the students encountered the following difficulties: (a) students' lack of skills, (b) unfamiliarity with the writing topics, and (c) limited time.

The first difficulty is students' lack of two important skills: group work and L2 process writing. This was firstly reflected through disagreement in group face-to-face discussions. Below are two comments from students' reporting on disagreement in the pre-writing stage:

The difficulty that we met in the pre-writing meetings was how to reach a consensus from many ideas of the members. **(Student TH – RS)**

In one essay, in the face-to-face discussion, there were many ideas shared and we did not know which ones were necessary. By contrast, in the other essay, the ideas were limited, which made it hard for us to develop the writing. **(Student QL – RS)**

The teaching colleague explained that the students' lack of L2 process writing skills was also the cause of difficulties. She explained:

Identifying main ideas is always a difficulty for our students, not only in this class, but in the other classes as well... When the students [in the class under study] had to identify ideas for their own essays, they could not do it well: they did not know techniques like brainstorming or mapping. They just noted down any ideas came up to their minds and then got stuck with how to develop them. **(Teaching colleague – SSI 2)**

Besides lack of skills, unfamiliarity with the assigned topics also impacted on the students' collaboration in the pre-writing stages. As discussed in Section 6.1, the students reflected that there were some topics about which they had little background knowledge. This was claimed to hinder their generation of ideas. The teacher-researcher considered their reflections and made adjustments in Cycle 2. In Cycle 2, especially in the third essay, most of the topics were related to the students' personal experiences, for example, the topic about reasons why the students became English majors. Topics which the students had already learnt in other L2 subjects were also utilised. For instance, the students had already discussed the effects of over-population in their L2 speaking lessons.

Reflections from the participants show that the topic change was effective. One of the students and the teaching colleague compared the change in topics between the first essay (argument essays) and the third essay (cause and/or effect essays)

The topic that my group was given in the cause and/or effect essay was familiar to us, which made it easier for us to write. **(Participant 4 – FGI 3)**

In the cause and/or effect essays, the topics were familiar to the students ... so they did not have many difficulties in generating ideas. The students could come up with ideas more quickly than topics that they had never met before [in the argument essays]. **(Teaching colleague – SSI 2)**

The data from the students' outlines in the wikis supplement the participants' reflections. As previously mentioned in this section, among six groups, four groups had effective outlines with clearly-identified ideas (see Figure 7.2 and Figure 7.3).

However, it was also observed that there were two outlines considered ineffective although the topics of these outlines were familiar to the students (see Figure 7.4). One of them required the students to write about themselves: to discuss reasons why they became English majors. This is to say, the students' schema knowledge about

topics was accessible to them. For future projects, building in topic knowledge is recommended and can be facilitated in the wiki space set-up.

The third difficulty is related to limited time available to students. The students claimed that the time allocated for the face-to-face discussion was not sufficient to make important decisions regarding their writing. In other words, they lacked enough time to reach an agreement in their groups. This was recounted as follows:

Time in class was only sufficient for the teacher to lecture and little time was left for our discussions. **(Student AH – RS)**

Time for face-to-face discussions was definitely not sufficient for us, especially when we discussed difficult topics. It took us a long time to just come up with main ideas, but we could not identify the supporting ideas. Thus it was vague for each member in terms of what and how we did later through the wikis. An example could be seen from our results in the compare and contrast essay. **(Participant 1 – FGI 3)**

Time limitation in face-to-face meetings also influenced the researcher-teacher's assistance to the students: she could not manage to provide intermediate guidance to all of the groups. The following students commented:

During the face-to-face discussions, the teacher had little time to help all the groups. So we could not make sure if what we were discussing was necessary. **(Student ND – RS)**

There was not enough exchange between the teacher and the groups. As a result, the students could not ensure whether the ideas they generated were suitable or unsuitable for the topics. More of the teacher's suggestions to the groups were necessary for us to have good outlines. **(Student PH – RS)**

To solve the problems of limited time for face-to-face discussions for future projects, the students suggested that students should know writing topics in advance. They could then generate individual ideas before going to class. Accordingly, in face-to-

face discussions, they could spend more time gathering individuals' ideas to make them group ideas.

This section concludes that the adjustments to Cycle 2 were effective in enhancing the students' discussions. The difficulties of reaching a consensus in group work, topic unfamiliarity and time limitation should be considered to improve future projects.

7.2 REFLECTIONS ON THE DRAFTING STAGE

The drafting stage was ranked second in the students' rating of effective stages of collaborative writing. The students highlighted that the multiple drafts could improve their writing, which motivated them. Below are their reflections.

The drafting stage was effective to my writing: I had the chance to practise writing and look at what I wrote and re-wrote it until I felt satisfied.

(Student NTT – RS)

In the drafting stage, I did not have only first drafts but also revised drafts. The improvement between these drafts could be seen. **(Student NAT – RS)**

In addition, the students emphasised that they benefited from the saving and tracking change functions of the wikis. In the second focus group interview, regarding the responses to the publishing stage (see Section 6.5), similar reflections were recorded. In the third interview, the students continued to report that the saving and tracking change functions of the wiki made it easy for them to write multiple drafts. They commented:

In the drafting stage, the wikis were effective to us in the way that they could save our writing parts. It was easy for us to further develop or improve them later. For example, when I finished my part, the peers commented on my work, I could save what I had already written and posted revised versions. I and the peers could read all the drafts. Then we

could compare the changes. Additionally, when we finished our group work, we all could look at completed essays. In this way, we could not only learn from the members in my group but also those from other groups as well. **(Participant 5 – FGI 3)**

Drafting with the wikis was effective: they could help us track changes of our revisions. Also, we could look at the work of other groups. Then we could learn from many students. **(Participant 3 – FGI 3)**

The adjustment to Cycle 2 in the drafting stages was related to the mini-deadlines. As discussed in Section 6.2, after the first essay, the students suggested that to solve the problems of late postings, dates for posting needed to be set for each member in the groups: each student had a maximum of two days to post their parts in turn.

Analysis of the wiki histories shows that this adjustment worked with the class under study: since the application of this adjustment, the students posted their writing in a timelier manner. Two tables below illustrated this claim. Table 7.1 and Table 7.2 present the history of group 3's postings prior to and after the adjustment respectively.

Table 7.1

The history of postings from group 3 prior to the adjustment

Time for drafts				
Essay parts (Students)	First revision	Second revision	Third revision	Fourth revision
Outline (Student HT)	26 th April	29 th April		
Introductory paragraph (Student GTT)	25 th April			
Body paragraph 1	25 th April	26 th April	29 th April	29 th April

(Student NT)				
Body paragraph 2	27 th April	27 th May	2 nd May	2 nd May
(Student TT)				
Concluding paragraph	1 st May	1 st May		
(Student THT)				
Time duration for the argument essay session: Started: 18 April - Deadline 1 st May				

As can be seen from Table 7.1, each collaborative essay session lasted for two weeks, hence the first essay started on April 18th and ended on May 1st. The table also shows that the first posting on the wikis was observed on 26th of April, nearly one week after the start of the session. This means that the students did not have much time left for collaborating. Consequently, they could not complete their essay by the due date.

Table 7.2

History of postings from group 3 after the adjustment

Time for drafts		Second revision	Third revision	Fourth revision
Essay parts (Students)	First revision			
Outline	6 May	9 May	9 May	
(Student HT)				
Introductory paragraph	5 th May	10 th May		
(Student TTT)				
Body paragraph 1	5 May			
(Student THT)				
Body paragraph 2	6 May	6 May	9 May	
(Student NTT)				
Body paragraph 3	5 May	11 May	12 May	14 May

(Student GTT)		
Concluding paragraph	14 May	14 May
(Student HT)		
<i>Time duration for the argument essays: Started: 4th May- Deadline 18th May</i>		

Table 7.2 shows that the students in group 3 managed their group in a timelier manner in the second essay. The first writing was posted one day after the start of the session. The following postings were also made sooner than those of the first essay. As a result, they finished their collaborative work before the due date.

The two tables above reveal that the students did not post their parts in organisational sequence of an essay following introductory-body-concluding paragraph pattern. For example, Table 7.2 shows that the student writing the introductory paragraph (**Student TTT**) finished her work before the student who had been assigned to post the outline (**Student HT**) did. Two opposing interpretations could be made from this. On the positive side, if the students had had an effective discussion for the pre-writing stages, each of them could work on their assigned parts, and then revise their writing in accordance with the feedback they would get. In this way, they did not have to wait for their peers, which could reduce the difficulty of peers' late postings. On the negative side, the students' not working in the sequence of the essay organisation reflects the fact that collaboration was weak or shared understanding did not occur among the students. Instead, group working became the addition of individual separate contributions. This resulted in a lack of coherence among their essays. Further reflections on this issue will be discussed in Section 7.4.

Regarding difficulties in the drafting stages, the students' writing proficiency levels were reported to be the main cause. Writing proficiency included both local areas or

language accuracy (grammar, spelling, vocabulary) and global areas (content and development). The following students stated:

When I wrote my paragraph, I found it was hard to use words in certain contexts. **(Student DH – RS)**

My grammar was not good and I also had difficulties in organising ideas logically in my paragraphs. **(Participant 3 – FGI 3)**

The most difficulty that I met was to write my part logically. My writing was not closely linked. Sometimes I developed my paragraph out of the topic, out of the content that we had discussed. I also made some spelling and expression mistakes. **(Student GTT– RS)**

The second difficulty came from ineffective discussions in the pre-writing stages. As previously discussed, some of the groups did not have effective discussions in the pre-writing stage. Consequently, the students found it difficult to start their individual parts. Below are concerns expressed by the students:

Because in the pre-writing stage, some discussion was not thoroughly made, it was difficult for each member to develop their own paragraph. The ideas were not very logically linked. **(Student TTP – RS)**

Ideas and organisation were not clearly discussed in the pre-writing stage, so when each member wrote his/her own paragraphs, there was an inconsistency happening. **(Student PH – RS)**

In conclusion, this section has reported findings from the drafting stage. It shows that the participants recognised the affordances of the wikis to facilitate writing and redrafting. It also identifies that the students' proficiency, discussions in the pre-writing stages and time management affect the drafting stage. The findings have implications for effective collaborative writing pedagogy, which will be identified in Chapter 8.

7.3 REFLECTIONS ON THE FEEDBACK STAGE

According to the integrated checklist for the feedback stage, Table 4.11, in this stage, the following criteria were evaluated:

- How many comments were given in each type of essays?
- What were the areas of comments: global or local areas?
- What was the focus of comments: evaluations, clarifications, suggestions and/or alterations?
- What were the difference between the students' and the researcher-teacher's comments?

The first sub-part of this section documents the students' comments in the pre-writing stage. Overall, the feedback stage was considered effective. The students reported:

Giving comments or feedback through our wikis was easy and convenient. It also brought back effective results to our writing. **(Student DTH – RS)**

During the feedback stage, each member could do correction for the other members. From that, we could develop completed essays. **(Student BD – RS)**

From the reflections above, it can be seen that the students highlighted the importance of shared knowledge and skills to develop their writing.

However, the feedback stage was evaluated as the least effective among the five stages of the L2 process writing in this project. Below are participants' reflections:

Most of the stages were effective to me. However, the feedback stage was not very effective because some peers' comments were not suitable to my writing. **(Student PTH – RS)**

The feedback stages were not very effective because we did not know how to comment on the other students' writing. Likewise, we did not find out the mistakes or errors to help our peers to improve their writing. **(Student LTQ – RS)**

From the reflections above, although the students highlighted the importance of sharing new knowledge through peers' comments, they were not satisfied with the quality of these comments. Before discussing the quality of the students' comments, the quantity of the comments will be discussed.

Although the adjustment to Cycle 2 meant that each student needed to give a minimum of two comments on their peers' writing, the number of comments did not increase significantly in the second essay as compared with that in the first essay. The number and focus of the students' comments on the second essay are presented in Table 7.3 below.

Table 7.3

Number and focus of the students' comments on the compare and/or contrast essays

Area Types	Global (25)		Local (17)	
	Revision	Non revision	Revision	Non-revision
Evaluations	2	5	1	1
Clarifications	2	0	2	1
Suggestions	11	0	7	0
Alterations	5	0	5	0
<i>Total</i>	<i>20</i>	<i>5</i>	<i>15</i>	<i>2</i>

The students' responses to the questions about the feedback stage confirmed that not many comments were given on the peers' writing:

The feedback stage was not very effective because the members in my group did not give many useful comments or suggestions. **(Student LTTV – RS)**

I often waited for my friends to comment on my writing. But not many came from them. Most of the comments came from the teacher.

(Participant 5 – FGI 3)

Despite the adjustment of mini-deadlines for each student after the first essay, the number of comments did not increase. Both the teaching colleague and students explained that the students had participated in the project voluntarily. Their contributions to the project were not graded or assessed. This resulted in less active participation. The following participants reflected:

If the project had been an obligation with assessment in the class, we might have attended more actively. But this project was voluntary; hence the students felt they were not “forced” to contribute their comments.

(Participant 5 – FGI 3)

There are some voluntary projects that teachers think may be good for students to participate. Due to some reasons, for example, the students are too busy with other projects, the number of participants is small. The writing project was similar to other voluntary projects. When the students were not assessed, they did not participate actively **(Teaching colleague – SSI 2)**

The reflections show the influence of assessment on L2 writing (Sub-sections 2.1.3 and 5.1.2): EL students in Vietnam are motivated to become involved in learning if the end product is graded.

Coming back to the focus of the students’ comments, the two tables below demonstrate the areas, i.e. global or local areas and the focus, i.e. language content or language accuracy, of the comments that the students gave after the writing project.

Table 7.4

Total number of students’ comments after the writing project

Area	Global (63)		Local (52)	
	Revision	Non-revision	Revision	Non-revision
Evaluations	6	8	1	3

Clarifications	9	1	8	2
Suggestions	30	0	14	1
Alterations	9	0	23	0
<i>Total</i>	<i>54</i>	<i>9</i>	<i>46</i>	<i>6</i>

Table 7.4 above augments the finding from the wiki data after the first essay (see Section 6.3), which showed that the number of global comments was larger than that of the local ones. The table also indicates that the number of revision comments was higher than that of the non-revision comments: 100 (54 for global revisions and 46 for local revisions) compared to 15 (9 for global non-revisions and 6 for local non-revisions). Table 7.5 below details the focus of the students' revision comments.

Table 7.5

Focus of students' revision comments after the project

Focus of revision comments		Essay 1	Essay 2	Essay 3	Total	
Revisions	Global areas (54)	Ideas	5	2	3	10
		Development	12	20	12	44
	Local areas (46)	Grammar	2	2	2	6
		Structures	10	8	4	19
		Vocabulary	3	10	7	16
		Punctuation	0	0	0	0
		Spelling	2	1	2	5
			33	41	22	100

The table shows that the students' comments on the development of the essays made up the largest number. This is consistent with Table 7.4 above, which reports that the students' comments focused more on global than local areas.

However, as reflected in Section 6.3, after Cycle 1, the students in the second focus group interview stated that more local than global comments were made. After the project, the reflections were similar. Students commented:

I did not give many comments to the peers... Most of my comments were on grammar rather than content. It was difficult to give comments on the content of the other members' writing. **(Student KN – RS)**

The peers' comments mainly focused on grammar [local areas]. If they commented on content, it was usually difficult to understand and use. I sometimes found these comments were not useful so I could not revise my writing as they suggested. **(Student TV – RS)**

As explained in Section 6.3, the contradiction between the wiki data (Table 7.4 and Table 7.5) and the students' interview reflections occurred because suggestion –

revision comments accounted for the largest number of the global areas, while alteration – revision comments were the largest in local areas. It was obvious that the students found it much easier to revise or edit their writing in accordance with alteration – revision comments, as these comments provided them with specific directions to edit their writing.

The quality of the students' comments depended on the writers' and peers' proficiency levels, which were reflected by the students as being at low levels. Below are reflections on the proficiency of the students who commented on their peers' writing:

When I read the peers' writing, I did not understand the development of their parts so it was hard for me to comment on their parts. Or sometimes when I commented, they did not understand what I wanted to say. It was maybe because our way to express comments was not clear or convincing.

(Student TTP – RS)

There were some writers....I do not mean that I could write better than them, but their writing was terribly bad. Generally, I did not know how to help them except telling them to rewrite from beginning. I did not know how and where their writing needed changing. **(Participant 2 – FGI 3)**

Similarly, the students receiving comments indicated that the peers' low proficiency levels impacted on the quality of the comments:

I found it was difficult to use the comments of the peers. In some cases, I thought my writing was better than their comments. In the other cases, I did not know how to use their comments to integrate in my writing.

(Student TT – RS)

The peers might not understand my comments due to my grammar, vocabulary or background knowledge about the topics were not good enough to help them. **(Student TT – RS)**

I knew there was something wrong in my friends' writing but I did not know how to tell them to change. **(Student NQ – RS)**

The students' limited L2 proficiency was also observed through the fact that they met difficulties in using L1 to comment on their peers' work. This was mentioned by the students:

Using English was difficult for us to comment and receive comments from the other members. **(Student DH – RS)**

I found it was difficult to use English to express in order that my friends could understand and revise their writing. Expressing our ideas in English was not like that when we do it in Vietnamese. It was much more difficult. Sometimes I had to use both Vietnamese and English at the same time.
(Participant 5 – SSI 3)

The teaching colleague's reflections below summarised the points made by both the students who gave and received comments:

The students' writing proficiency levels were the main factor influencing quality of their comments. It was the students themselves in their writing could not write well: they encountered difficulties in word choice or expression. They, of course, could not give effective comments on the peers' writing. **(Teaching colleague – SSI 2)**

In the literature, Guardado and Shi (2007) claimed that as L2 Canadian writers, many of the students in their study did not value peers' comments. They thus ignored these comments in their own revisions as authors or avoided responding to peers to clarify and negotiate meaning. This was because of: (1) the students' uncertainty of their writing proficiency and (2) the influence of culture, specified as discomfort in giving negative comments on peers' writing. In my study, the teaching colleague made a point regarding the influence of a face-saving culture on the students' comments as below:

Some students told me that they were not confident of their comments....
What happened if their comments were wrong or the peers ignored their

ideas? They would rather leave no comments than lose face. **(Teaching colleague – SSI 2)**

The students' data has not provided sufficient evidence to conclude that students' fear of losing face influenced the numbers of the students' comments. However, the teaching colleague pinpointed a cultural factor not identified by the students. Hence, the findings in this section indicate that the students' low levels of writing proficiency hindered them from giving comments to their peers and using that feedback constructively.

The second sub-part of this section discusses the researcher-teacher's comments in comparison with the students' comments. Regarding the quantity of the researcher-teacher's comments, in the compare and/or contrast essays, the teacher gave more comments than she did in the argument essays (the first essays). She continued to focus more on the global than local areas. Also, revision comments regarding the development of the students' writing accounted for the largest number. Table 7.6 and

Table 7.7 on the following page summarise the teacher's areas and focus of the revision comments.

Table 7.6

Teacher's areas of comments after the project

Area	Global areas (52)		Local areas (47)	
Types	Revision	Non-revision	Revision	Non-revision
Evaluations	0	2	0	1
Clarifications	3	0	0	0
Suggestions	42	0	33	0
Alterations	5	0	13	0
<i>Total</i>	<i>50</i>	<i>2</i>	<i>46</i>	<i>1</i>

Table 7.7

Focus of teacher's revision comments after the project

Focus of revision comments		Essay 1	Essay 2	Essay 3	Total	
Revisions	Global areas (50)	Ideas	2	6	2	10
		Development	12	18	10	40
	Local areas (46)	Grammar	0	2	3	5
		Structures	7	9	5	14
		Vocabulary	2	6	5	13
		Punctuation	0	2	2	4
		Spelling	0	0	0	0

Next, the comparison between the students' and researcher-teacher's comments will be discussed. The comparison can be seen through Figure 7.5.

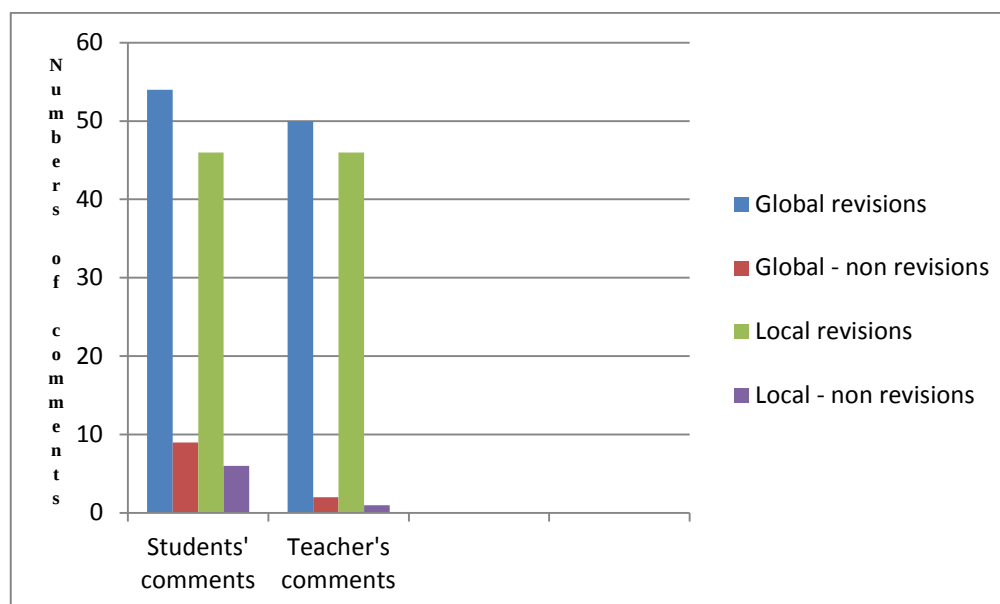


Figure 7.5 Comparison between the areas of the students' and teacher's comments

Figure 7.5 shows that there were two similarities in the areas and focus of comments of the students and researcher-teacher. Both the students and teacher focused more on the global than local areas. Revision comments accounted for a larger number than non-revision ones. Specifically regarding the revision comments, the similarities are presented in two charts below.

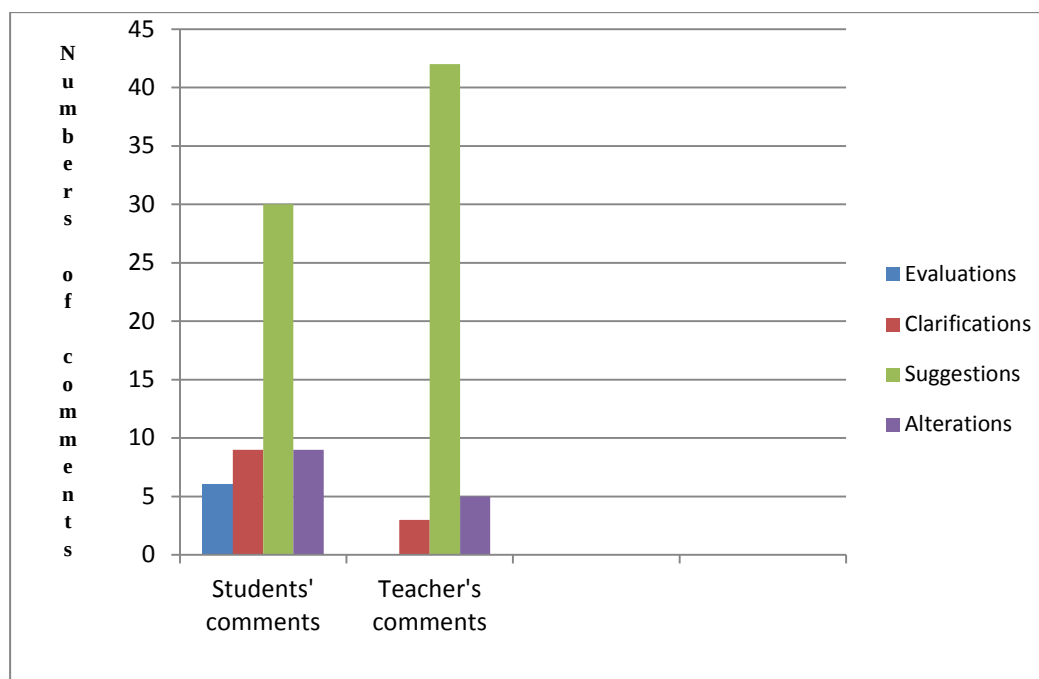


Figure 7.6 Comparison between the students' and teachers' revision comments (1)

Figure 7.6 demonstrates that both the students and the teacher mostly gave suggestion – revision comments.

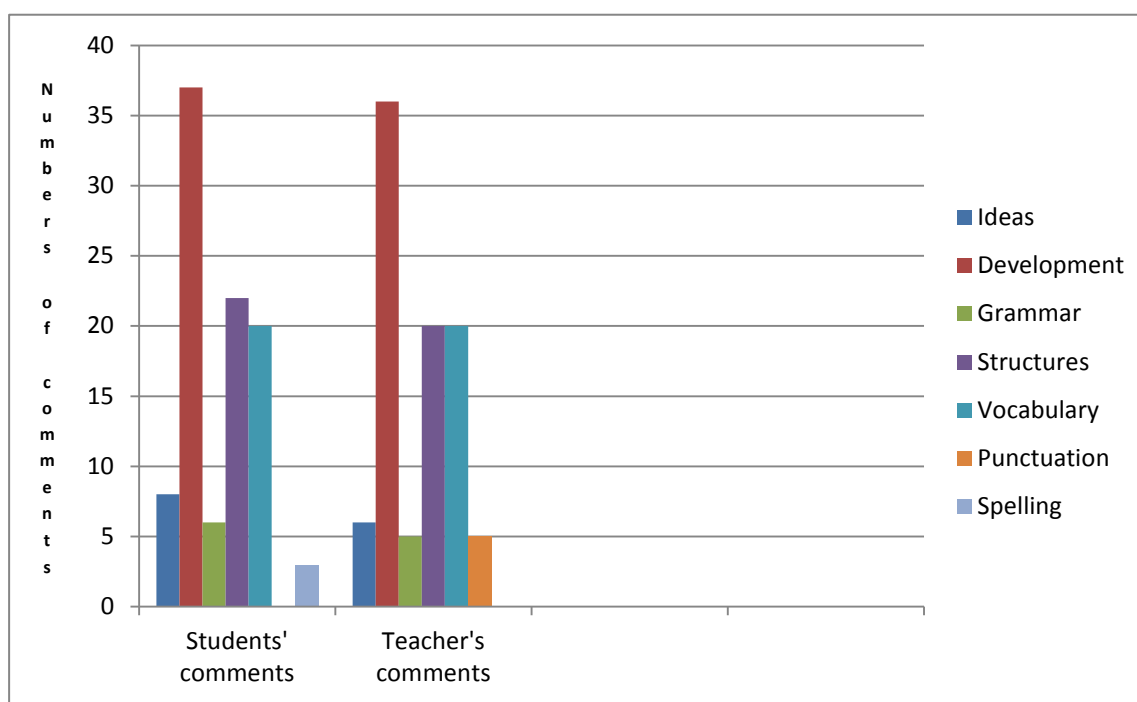


Figure 7.7 Comparison between the students' and teacher's revision comments (2)

The second similarity in the students' and the teacher's revision comments is shown in the above figures. As can be seen, the development of the essays was the focus of both the students' and teacher's comments. The structures and vocabulary comments were ranked the second and third respectively. The only significant difference in the chart was in the comments on punctuation: the students gave no comments on punctuation.

From the four charts above, it can be seen that both the students and researcher-teacher focused more on (1) global than local comments and (2) revision than non-revision comments. In addition, suggestion comments and development of the writing made up the largest number of the total comments.

Although there were similarities, like the reflections after Cycle 1, preferences for the researcher-teacher's comments over the peers' comments were recorded. The following students stated:

I liked that my friends could show me exactly how I could revise or edit my writing. That was why I was quite happy to see the teacher's comments. They were clear to me, not as vague as my peers'. **(Student QL – RS)**

I thought you [the researcher-teacher] gave very useful comments. When we posted our writing, you commented and helped us with revisions or editing. Your comments were what we expected most from you.
(Participant 5 – FGI 3)

To conclude, although the students reflected that they benefited from the peers' comments, and the areas and focus of the students' and teacher's comments were similar, the quality of the students' comments resulted in the feedback stage being evaluated as less effective when compared to the other stages. The students' levels of proficiency should be considered in future projects so that students can collaborate effectively in the feedback stage. This will be further discussed in the next chapter.

7.4 REFLECTIONS ON THE REVISION STAGE

This section reports the findings of the revision stage, emphasising the students' revision behaviour (areas and focus of revisions) after they received feedback. It also analyses the difficulties that the students met when revising their collaborative writing.

The table on the next page presents the students' revision behaviours focusing on two parts: the total number of first and revised drafts and the areas of revisions.

Table 7.8

Number of students' first and revised drafts after the project

Revisions	Essays 1	Essays 2	Essays 3	Total
First drafts	30	34	31	95
Revised drafts	27	30	28	85
Total	57	64	59	180

From Table 7.8 above, two important results can be seen. First, the numbers of drafts including both first and revised ones were similar among the three essays: 57, 64 and 59 in total for essays 1, 2, and 3 respectively. The result indicates that the adjustment in order to increase the number of comments (Section 6.4) did not result in more revisions. Second, the numbers of first drafts were higher than those of the revised drafts: 95 first drafts and 85 revised drafts. This indicates that some students did not revise their writing but finished with the first drafts.

Regarding the areas of revisions, Table 7.9 below shows that there were nearly three times more local revisions (65) than global (21) revisions. Specifically regarding the global areas, only one revision for ideas was made and the rest was for the development of the essays. With the local areas, revisions for grammar, structures and vocabulary were more frequent than those of spelling and punctuation, as indicated in Table 7.12 below.

Table 7.9

Areas of revisions

Areas of revisions		Essays 1	Essays 2	Essays 3	Total
Global	Ideas	0	0	1	1

areas (21)	Development	8	10	2	20
	Grammar	1	10	9	20
Local areas	Structures	5	4	10	19
(65)	Vocabulary	13	3	4	20
	Spelling	0	1	2	3
	Punctuation	0	3	0	3

The findings from Table 7.9 align with the reflections on the feedback stages (see Section 7.3 above). Previously, the reflections show that although the number of global and local comments was similar, the students were more satisfied with local comments than global ones. This was because alteration-revision comments, which showed the students specific ways to edit their writing, accounted for higher numbers in the local areas. Meanwhile, suggestion-revision comments, which provided the students with recommendations only, were more prominent in the global areas. With the students' low levels of L2 writing proficiency, the students who either gave or received the comments stated that it was not easy to comment on or use peers' feedback. The findings are also consistent with the focus of the students' and researcher-teacher's comments, which indicate that there were few comments on spelling and punctuation (see Table 7.5 and

Table 7.7). Most of the comments on spelling and punctuation came from the researcher-teacher.

Regarding the difficulties in the revision stages, the data show that coherence between individual paragraphs was a problem. This was recorded in the following reflections:

Due to the division of paragraphs among the members, words and expressions were not logically and consistently used among the paragraphs.

(Student NQ – RS)

Because each person wrote a paragraph, sometimes all of the paragraphs were not logically linked. **(Student HT– RS)**

Lack of coherence between individual paragraphs has been noted in the literature on collaborative writing. Wheeler et al. (2008) discovered in their study that distributions of writing sections to each individual allowed all the students to contribute to collaborative work. However, the limitation was that the division might separate the individual contributions, and students might read very little of the content created by their peers.

To conclude, the revision stage saw the students' employing peers' comments to edit their own writing. There was an alignment between the results of the feedback stages and the revision stages: more revisions for the local areas were made than those of the global areas. The implication of this finding is that coherence among individual paragraphs should be considered when designing collaborative writing.

7.5 REFLECTIONS ON THE PUBLISHING STAGE

This section discusses the findings of the publishing stage after the writing project. It addresses two important questions in the publishing stage, which are:

- How did students use illustrations in their completed essays?

- What metadiscourse was used to show students' consideration of their audiences?

The section begins with the results of the adjustment to Cycle 2. Following this, the difficulties that the students encountered when publishing their writing are mentioned. Generally, the findings show that students did not encounter many difficulties in using wikis to publish their writing. However, most of their essays were not published as required. On the positive side, analysis of metadiscourse shows that if provided with sufficient scaffolding, students were able to develop an awareness of audiences.

Prior to the implementation of the project, the students anticipated that using illustrations in addition to words was important to attract readers' attention to their writing (see Section 6.5). However, after the first essays, it was reported that few groups used illustrations in their final essays. The students suggested that to improve the situation, illustrations could be used for the front pages of their wikis. After the end of the project, the data from the wikis show that students considered the adjustment. One example from the front page of the wikis demonstrates how students illustrated their front pages.



Figure 7.8: Example of an illustration used in a student's wiki pages

Nevertheless, there is a lack of consensus among the students themselves regarding the importance of using illustrations other than texts to publish their writing. On one hand, the students agreed that using illustrations was important to attract readers' attentions. They indicated:

Publishing stage was important to me. It did not only attract the reader's but also the writer's attention. Final products should be decorated so that they look more attractive. **(Participant 2 – FGI 3)**

I think illustration for the final essays is important for both the pre-writing and post-writing stage. **(Participant 5 – FGI 3)**

The viewpoints above align with the affordances of wikis (Section 0). Wikis can provide opportunities for users to express themselves by using multiple modalities, for example, music, graphics, video, and/or photos in their writing (McPherson, 2006). In this way, writing becomes more of an interactive design process rather than

simply textual presentation. The participants' expectations prior to the implementation of the project also show that illustrations other than words helped writers come closer to readers (see Section 6.5).

On the other hand, not all of the groups had pages with completed essays presented with illustrations. Most of the groups finished their collaborative writing with word-text only products. The participants stated two reasons for this: unrevised parts and individual writing habits. Regarding the unrevised writing, two of the students in the focus group interview reported:

One of the reasons [for not having completed essays published] was that the peers in my group did not revise their parts carefully. There were still mistakes or insufficient development of their writing. So we were not motivated to add illustrations to the texts. **(Participant 4 – FGI 3)**

In my group, I was the person to combine the separated paragraphs from the peers to make them completed essays. There were still many mistakes in the unrevised versions of my friends. That was why I did not want to illustrate for the final essays. **(Participant 2 – FGI 3)**

Besides the reason above, the influence of traditional pedagogy, which focuses on individual texts, could be seen. One student and the teaching colleague mentioned:

My group thought that for the final step, posting the individual writing was what we cared about most. If we inserted pictures or things like that, it would take time and we did not want to do that. **(Participant 1 – FGI 3)**

It was quite natural for the students to think that if they finish their own parts, it was already a relief; hence, posting their own paragraphs was enough to them. They cared less of the group work or to make their essays attractive to readers: what they really want was to finish their parts.
(Teaching colleague – SSI 2)

While it is emphasised in the affordances of wikis that the utilisation of illustrations other than simple words makes wikis an interactive design (McPherson, 2006), not many illustrations were utilised in the students' final writing products.

It is also observed from students' final writing that students did not take advantage of the grammar check function of the wikis: although wikis provided spell and grammar functionalities, some students did not use this functionality. Below is an extract from students' writing (with the spelling mistakes underlined by the researcher-teacher):

The social is more and more developed, demand of career changes day by day, year by year. Amount of students like entering economic fiel more than teacher training. There are two main reasons why the number of students entering teacher training colleges decreases the difficulties in finding a job and the promotion in their major.

The first reason is difficult in finding a job. Several years ago, students who graduated were more and more knotty to have a job and the pedagogical sector must be facing with many difficulties most.... But nowaydays the number of students attended to teacher training colleges is more and more decreasing because they must be face to face with many difficulties such as: much waiting and disappointment. Moreover, There are thousands of students graduating at the same time but only a few hundred of students have a job. In 2012 many provinces have not recruited teacher anymore. It makes the employment oppotunities of a lot of students become more difficult so much and they do not want to attend to teacher training colleges.

As shown in the above extract, the spelling mistakes were underlined in red in the wikis. However, the student did not revise them. This implies that more training on the functions of wikis should be made.

With regard to the metadiscourse, analysis of 18 completed essays on the wikis shows that the students considered their audiences. This was observed through analysis of the completed essays after the project. As mentioned in Chapter 4, based on Hyland and Tse's (2004) model (see Table 4.10), the teacher-researcher divided students' metadiscourse categories into two sub-categories. The first sub-category was the metadiscourse which was previously taught to the students. These include:

- Transitions (develop ideas among sentences e.g., *and, but, thus*, etc.)
- Frame makers (develop ideas among paragraphs, e.g., *First, Second, Finally*, etc.)

- Attitude markers (express writers' attitudes to an argument, e.g., *I agree that, I believe that*, etc.)
- Engagement markers (address readers of the wikis, e.g., personal pronouns, *you* or *we*)
- Self-mentions (refer to the writer(s), e.g., *I/my/we/our/ us*, etc.)

The second sub-category was the metadiscourse that was not previously taught to the students, including:

- Code glosses (help readers to understand functions of ideational materials, e.g., *for example, for instance, such as, in other word*, e.t.c)
- Hedges (reduce writers' commitment to an argument, e.g., *might, could, perhapd*, etc.)
- Boosters (strengthen writers' commitment to an argument, e.g., *it is clear/obvious that, in fact, definitely*, etc.)

The analysis of these two sub-categories in the students' writing is demonstrated in the table below.

Table 7.10
Students' metadiscourse resources to address audiences

Categories	Essays 1 (6 essays)	Essays 2 (6 essays)	Essays 3 (6 essays)	Total (18 essays)
Categories had been previously introduced to the students				
Transition	38	23	32	93
Frame markers	17	18	18	53
Attitude markers	18	1	0	19
Engagement markers	15	50	5	70
Self-mentions	20	96	13	129
Categories had not been introduced to the students				
Code glosses	2	4	6	12

Hedges	0	2	1	3
Boosters	3	13	5	21

The first sub-category in Table 7.10 shows that transitions, frame makers and self-mentions were frequently used. Especially, self-mention personal pronouns (*we*, *you* and *us*) appeared often. Kuteeva (2011) argued in their study that the use of the first person in the plural (self-mentions) is meant to establish rapport with the reader and shows consideration for the audience. Similarly, Myers (2010) proposed a checklist for engaging audiences through the use of personal pronouns (engagement and self-mention markers) to address and make the writer-audience relationship more intimate. Meanwhile, the table shows the less frequent use of the second sub-categories including code glosses, hedges and boosters.

The data collated from the interviews, however, reveal different information from the analysis of metadiscourse. The teaching colleague observed that although each group could identify target audiences for their writing, not all the members could do that. She reported:

In the first essay [argument essay], three groups could identify readers of their essays. But this did not mean that all of the members in these groups were able to do so. With the other groups, they needed the teacher's suggestions. Without the suggestions, it was hard for them.... Similarly, in the second essay, not all of the groups could identify the audiences or purposes of their writing, and not all of the members in these groups could equally point out the purposes, for example, group 3, and they needed the teacher's suggestions. **(Teaching colleague – SSI 2)**

In the third focus group interview with the researcher-teacher, the student participants added that although they could identify who would potentially read their essay writing, the relation between their writing and particular readers was not clear

to them. In the other words, their writing styles were the same despite different audiences. The students reported:

Before the project, what I had cared about most was to have enough ideas and paragraphs in my essays. After the project I was aware of the importance of identifying the audiences and purposes of what I wrote. However, when I wrote, the audiences and purposes were not much reflected in my writing. **(Participant 6 – FGI 3)**

I could identify the potential audiences of my writing in the face-to-face meetings with my peers. For example, for the topic discussing the decrease in number of students who enter teacher training colleges, the audiences were identified as students, teachers, but not workers or the like. However, when starting writing, I saw that whoever the audiences were, my writing style or development was the same. So identifying the audiences was not special to me. **(Participant 5 – FGI 3)**

The teaching colleague agreed with the students on this point. She emphasised that although the students were aware of the need to consider their audiences, they did not know how to highlight this in their writing. She commented:

The students could identify their audiences in the pre-writing stage: they could say who would probably read their writing. Nevertheless, when they started to write, in their essays they cared more about the content than the audience. **(Teaching colleague – SSI 2)**

Here we can see the contradiction between the wiki data and participants' reflections. While the former indicated that the audiences and purposes of writing were considered, the latter did not acknowledge that. This suggests that the students had not been sufficiently scaffolded regarding the use of metadiscourse to consider their audiences. Prior to the implementation of the project, the researcher-teacher had asked the students to list words or structures that they might use, for example, transitions, frame makers or attitude makers. However, the students had not been

informed that metadiscourse was one way to engage readers in their writing. Accordingly, although they actually used metadiscourse in their writing, they did not recognise that. For future projects, more thorough scaffolding of this is needed so that students know how to establish interaction between wiki essay writers and readers.

7.6 PARTICIPANTS' OVERALL EVALUATION OF THE PROJECT AND SUGGESTIONS FOR FUTURE WRITING PROJECTS

This section reports participants' overall evaluation of and suggestions for future projects. The data were collated through the questions about participants' impressions and evaluations of the whole project. The findings show that in comparison with traditional writing, collaborative writing was preferred by participants. Some contradictions between the teaching colleague's and students' reflections were reported. Participants' suggestions for future projects focused on (1) more time for discussion, (2) more teacher scaffolding, and (3) explicit teaching of group work skills.

7.6.1 Participants' evaluation of the project

Although during the project, the students encountered certain difficulties when collaborating, they reflected positively on the project. This was seen through the results of the Reflection survey: only 5 students (out of 30) responded that the project was not very successful, the rest rated it successful or very successful as follows.

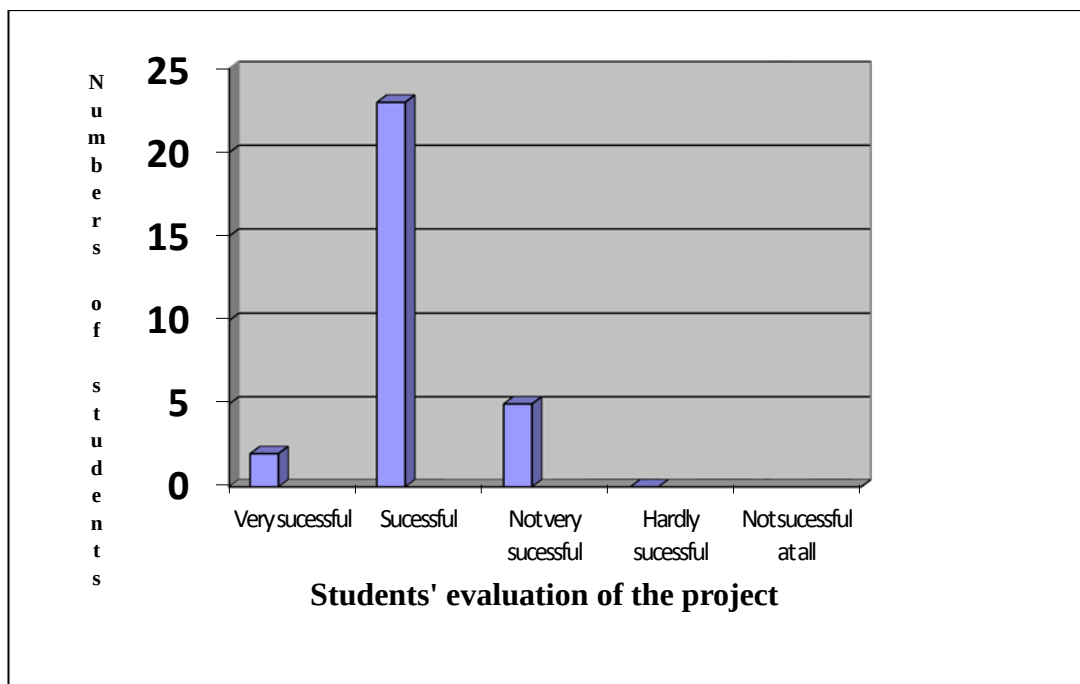


Figure 7.9 Students' evaluation of the project

In the third focus group interview, the students explained that at first they encountered technical difficulties in using the wikis. This was mainly due to slow internet connections. Gradually, the difficulties decreased, and their learning was enhanced: collaboration through face-to-face meetings or wikis offered them interactive platforms. Two students reported:

At the very beginning, the project seemed to be complicated or difficult. However, when I got used to it, I found that using wikis was easy... The project could enhance us into writing. Collaborative writing was more interesting, which was why we did not feel discouraged or difficult as we did when first joining in the project. This was shown through an improvement in our contributions to group work: by the end of the project, the comments had increased. **(Participant 2 – FGI 3)**

I had a very first impression that this project would bring something new to us. And as I expected, the writing project could help us approach a new way of learning L2 writing. Specifically, my skills to use internet application to learn English and my L2 process writing skills improved. For example, thanks to my friends' comments on my mistakes, I could learn a lot.

Although there were some difficulties at first, this project could enhance us in the writing process. **(Student AV– NAS)**

Students' comments show how their writing skills improved through the project. First, their attention to the product writing approach was shifted to the process writing method:

Before the project, I could not distinguish different types of essays. After the project, I could classify them and knew how to write them. **(Participant 1 – FGI 3)**

Before the project, I wrote whatever came to my mind down, unorganised. Now I knew to identify the main ideas before writing. It was definite that when main ideas were found, my essays were more clearly organised. **(Participant 2 – FGI 3)**

Second, when writing collaboratively, the students were more motivated to write when compared to traditional learning:

The project could reach its purposes: I found it more exciting to learn than usual learning [traditional classes]. **(Participant 5 – FGI 3)**

The project was successful in enhancing students to participate in processes of writing. Before attending the project, I and my friends were too lazy to practise writing: we just wrote and left it there for nothing. This project could increase our interest in writing: I read my writing sometimes to revise it based on comments I received. **(Student AV – NS)**

Interestingly, in contrast to students' positive reflections, the teaching colleague reported that the project fell short of her expectations. She reemphasised what she had expected prior to the implementation of the project:

My first impression of the project was hopeful. At the very first, I thought collaborative writing would be a new teaching approach. I had an ambition that the project would probably have a positive impact on the pedagogy as well as students' learning performance. **(Teaching colleague – SSI 2)**

When the project was completed, she noted:

My final impression of the project was a little bit disappointing.... With regards to students' involvement in the project, I did not see much of the students' enthusiastic participation. Of course, they already participated, but there was no real self-awareness to improve writing skills by using the new methodology that the teachers introduced. They just tried to finish their parts so that they had something to post and discuss in due time.

(Teaching colleague – SSI 2)

From the reflections, students and teaching colleague's evaluations of the project were very different. The students' purposes for learning L2 writing (Sub-section 5.2.1) show that they highlighted the processes of writing. In the traditional class, due to limited class contact time and interaction (Sub-section 5.1.1), students actually wrote but did not receive feedback from peers or teachers. Hence, it was important to them that (1) they were asked to write in their L2, and (2) someone read their writing and showed them how to improve it. Meanwhile, the teaching colleague emphasised more on the improvement of students' writing quality, which was assessed through timed exam papers and graded. To her, improvement in students' writing proficiency was the most important outcome in L2 pedagogy. The researcher-teacher reminded her that the purpose of the project was not to substantively improve students' writing proficiency, which certainly would not be achievable after six weeks. Further discussions between the researcher-teacher and the teaching colleague revealed that the teaching colleague considered using face-to-face and wiki collaboration in her future teaching.

With regard to face-to-face collaboration, she commented:

I like the pre-writing stage. For future teaching, I will use the activities in these stages... I may follow all the activities like we did in this stage. What I might care most is to help students identify ideas. After one pre-writing session, all the groups should have a completed outline of ideas, which they will hand in or present in front of all the class. **(Teaching colleague – SSI 2)**

With regard to wikis, although she might not use this collaborative technology in the near future because it would take time to change her teaching pedagogy, she felt that wikis could be used for future L2 writing projects. The following is an excerpt from the discussion between the researcher-teacher and the teaching colleague in the second semi-structured interview.

Researcher-teacher: *Can these kinds of projects be conducted in our teaching and learning context?*

Teaching colleague: *Yes, absolutely. They are suitable to students, especially when they do not have much time in class to practise writing... With wikis, certainly, they can write every day. Even if they just write short paragraphs, it is the way for them to practise and improve writing skills. Little by little, their writing skills can improve.*

To conclude, the findings show that participants were satisfied with the project regarding its enhancement of learners in each stage of L2 process writing approach, despite some of the difficulties that participants encountered.

7.6.2 Participants' suggestions for future projects

This last section analyses participants' suggestions for future collaborative writing projects. Students' suggestions include (1) time management, (2) increasing teacher scaffolding, (3) developing students' group work skills, and (4) allowing student selection of topics for writing. The teacher's suggestions include (1) increasing teacher involvement, (2) scaffolding students' previous knowledge and (3) decreasing teaching workload.

With the student participants, first and foremost, increasing time for face-to-face meetings was recommended. The students reported:

More time for face-to-face meeting is necessary, for example, two face-to-face sessions for each essay. After first sessions, students will write individual parts. If they do not encounter any difficulty, they can publish final essays. Otherwise, for example, if they there have not reached consensus, they can have second meetings to discuss. **(Student HL – RS)**

There should be more time for face-to-face discussion because the ideas, outline and development of essay are important. If thorough discussion is made, the final essays will be better developed. **(Student AV – RS)**

An increase in time for face-to-face learning, however, is impossible in the class under study: the writing programme is fixed by the University. Organising class activities in a timelier manner is recommended. This will be discussed in Section 8.3.

Second, the students suggested that more involvement was required from the researcher-teacher in the students' group work, because the teacher helped groups to reach a consensus:

More suggestions from teachers are needed, for example, our ideas may be not focused so we need you to help us to generalise them. **(Student QL – RS)**

More exchange and discussion among group members and among students and teachers should be made. **(Student BN – SSI 2)**

The students' desire for greater teacher involvement in their discussion was understandable given that the students had little chance previously to write in a group. Teacher scaffolding, for example, in the form of structured outlines, would probably help students to solve difficulties.

Third, training in group work skills was reported to be essential in future projects. The participants especially emphasised students' attitudes to group work.

Need more active participation and effective collaboration among members. Raise the awareness of responsibility and group working.

(Student BN – RS)

Students' attitudes to group work are important. Teachers want that sharing knowledge can help students learn from one another. But students might not think so. They may think that when working in group, they have to share with other students. Or they feel uncomfortable when their friends can have some ideas to share when they do not. **(Teaching colleague – SSI**

2)

Some participants further proposed that group work might be more effective if students could select their group members and group leaders, rather than have them allocated by the teachers. With regards to students' selection of peers, participants explained that they would feel more comfortable working with those they know well:

Students should be allowed to choose their groups so it will be easier for us to exchange, comment or help one another. **(Student HY – NAS)**

Students' self-selection of members in their groups will make them work more effectively because we already have our groups when learning other skill subjects like Listening, Writing, so working together can be easier.

(Student NTT – NAS)

Choosing a leader for each group was suggested to help groups to reach consensus.

There should be a group leader to help groups come to an agreement.

(Student PH – NAS)

Each group should elect a group leader to have a final decision in their discussions. **(Student ND – NAS)**

Finally, participants suggested that students know topics for each genre of writing before a face-to-face meeting:

Topics should be given before the pre-writing discussion so that students can have more effective preparation at home. **(Student KN – NAS)**

Topics should be given before the class time, so students have more preparation in terms of ideas. **(Student BD – NAS)**

Knowing the topics of writing in advance may help students to connect with their ideational schema. In case they do not know much about topics they are going to write about, they can look for references before going to class. They can even suggest changing to more familiar topics.

With the teaching colleague, increasing teacher involvement in students' collaborative activities was recommended:

I like the pre-writing stages. For my future teaching, I may apply the activities in the pre-writing. I may help students to complete an outline in the pre-writing stage. And it is necessary that before students go home, they must hand in to the teacher a detailed outline. And I will use it as the summary of the face-to-face discussion. **(Teaching colleague – SSI 2)**

If it is the case, the teachers can ask the other groups for help. **(Teaching colleague – SSI 2)**

The teaching colleague also suggested that improvement in the knowledge that students had learned prior to the wiki project was important:

This class learnt to write different types of sentences, simple sentences and complex sentences [in previous terms]. But through student writing, their knowledge about what had been learnt was not sufficient. ...and topic sentences, [generating] ideas, sentence connections... The students learnt in Term 1 and 2. In term 3, they learnt with paragraph writing. But [now Term 4] in even a small paragraph, there were many mistakes. **(Teaching colleague – SSI 2)**

Finally, the teaching colleague referred to the context of large classes to explain teachers' potential hesitations to use wikis in teaching. She reported:

Wikis are quite applicable without many difficulties in our teaching and learning conditions. It is simple for students and teachers to follow. However, [in the University] teachers have to teach more than one writing classes and subjects. One class has 30 students, so two or three classes will have 60 or 90. It is hard for teachers to manage with collaboration through wikis... It will be difficult for them to administer or give comments on a large number of students' writing. (**Teaching colleague – SSI 2**)

The teaching colleague's comment on workload reflects her misunderstanding about collaborative learning and affordances of wikis. In contrast with traditional writing, in collaborative writing, teachers function as a facilitator to set up the project and facilitate students' learning, and they are not the only authority in the student learning process. Hence, teachers are not the only ones to give comments on student writing: comments on student writing can come from both teachers and peers. Thus wikis do not offer a platform for teachers to carry out the same activities that they often do in traditional writing classes. Instead, collaborative writing through wikis requires significant changes in teachers' and students' roles and assessment. Suggestions for changes from traditional writing to collaborative writing will be further discussed in Chapter 8.

7.7 SUMMARY

This chapter discussed participants' reflections on the entire L2 writing project. It focused on the affordances for and constraints of collaborative process writing through face-to-face and wiki modes. The participants' overall evaluations of the

project show that participants reflected positively on the project. Some adjustments were made to improve the effectiveness of collaborative writing in a traditional L2 writing context. Further discussions, suggestions and implementations will be reported in Chapter 8.

Chapter 8: Conclusion

This study used action research to investigate participants' expectations of and reflections on the implementation of an eight-week-L2 writing project. Face-to-face and wiki platforms were set up to facilitate teaching and learning. The study also reported on the effectiveness of each stage of the process-genre approach (including pre-writing, drafting, feedback, revising and/or publishing stages) in enhancing Vietnamese students' L2 writing. The study was guided by the conceptual framework which states that in a joint learning environment, low proficiency students can benefit from more capable peers and teachers with the assistance of mediated artefacts (Vygotsky, 1978, 1980), specifically the wikis in this study. Additionally, while it is essential that students' engage in thinking and negotiating to compose when learning writing, teachers' structured instruction regarding genres of writing is also crucial (Hyland, 2003, 2004, 2007).

The findings show that traditional education, represented by the dominance of teacher-led methodology, timed-written exams and a product writing approach, strongly impacted on the L2 writing in the class under study. Accordingly, teacher dominance, exam-oriented pedagogies and unfamiliarity with the processes of writing were observed. This fell short of the requirements of the MoET's policies (1400/QD-TTG, 2008; MoET, 2006, 2014), which require that CLT is the core of ELT in Vietnam as in the context discussion of this study. The findings, therefore, confirm that the implementation of the writing project was largely a positive experience for students as they were able to provide and employ feedback from the peers and researcher-teacher.

This final chapter focuses on how to effectively implement collaborative process writing via face-to-face and wiki modes in L2 writing classes, based on the findings of the study in Chapters 6 and 7. The chapter includes eight sections. Section 8.1 discusses the findings of the study in relation to the research questions. Section 8.2 explains the findings in light of the conceptual framework proposed in Chapter 3. Based on the findings and theoretical perspectives, Section 8.3 suggests specific training and scaffolding strategies for the implementation of future face-to-face and wiki collaboration in the L2 writing context in Vietnam. Section 8.4 describes the implications for teaching and learning of L2 writing, including considerations around assessment. The implications are supported by the literature in the fields of collaborative and wiki writing. Section 8.5 reports on the contributions to teaching practices and research methodology, and Section 8.6 focuses on the contributions of this study to teaching practices and research methodology. Section 8.7 reports on the limitations and suggestions for future L2 writing projects. Section 8.8 describes my personal reflections on the project, and the chapter ends with a summary in Section 8.9.

8.1 FINDINGS OF THE STUDY TO ADDRESS THE RESEARCH QUESTIONS

This section summarises the main findings of the study to address the overarching research question **what strategies using collaboration and technology could enhance students' L2 writing skills?** The main question was divided into three sub-questions, which were:

- 1. What are teachers' expectations of and reflections on the use of face-to-face and online strategies for teaching L2 writing?**

- 2. What are students' expectations of and reflections on the use of face-to-face and online strategies for the learning of L2 writing?**
- 3. What specific teaching and learning stages (pre-writing, drafting, feedback, revision or publishing) can enhance students' participation and engagement in learning L2 writing through face-to-face and online collaboration?**

With regard to research questions 1 and 2, as discussed in Section 1.3 and Subsection 4.5.2, the data about the teachers' and students' expectations of and reflections on the project are difficult to separate. For analysis, these two questions are divided into two parts: participants' expectations (Chapter 5) and participants' reflections on the project (Chapters 6 and 7). The former includes the participants' teaching and learning experience of L2 writing and their expectations of collaborative writing using wikis. The latter includes the participants' reflections on affordances and constraints of collaboration during and after the project.

Concerning participants' expectations, the findings reflected that the L2 writing pedagogy in the class under study preeceeding the introduction of the project was negatively impacted by traditional methods. It was observed that teacher presentation took most of the class time, interactions between teachers and students and students and peers were restricted, and students sought monitoring and feedback exclusively through their teachers. As a result, traditional L2 writing pedagogy focused more on the roles of the teacher than students, and writing performance was mostly assessed through mandated written exams. The influence of the pedagogy was also seen in students' unfamiliarity with strategies for and working together in writing.

Concerning participants' expectations of using collaboration and technology to enhance students' writing skills, at the outset of the project, the participants' responses to the questions about purposes for their L2 writing indicate that more direct strategies for collaborative writing were anticipated in the writing project than in the traditional pedagogy. Both teachers and students claimed that shared understanding among peers was essential when there was restricted class time for interaction around writing content and among students varying in proficiency. In addition, wikis were expected to afford peer negotiations, leading to students' more actively controlling their learning process, as well as a sense of having "genuine" readers for students, which would result in more communicative writing.

The data collated from the second focus group interview with six students and from students' essays archived in the wikis, address the participants' reflections on collaboration in Cycle 1. The student participants evaluated the focus and effectiveness of the exchange between the teacher and peers. The sharing assisted low proficiency students to understand more about writing skills, for example, how to write a topic sentence and supporting sentences or the differences between textual structures of the argument essay and compare/contrast essays. Their understanding also improved around steps such as brainstorming, negotiating or reaching consensus. The students were significantly more motivated and aware of audience when their writing was commented on by peers or the teacher.

The data from the second group interview and students' writing also revealed that students encountered difficulties in Cycle 1. In the pre-writing stage, students lacked collaborative skills – e.g., how to negotiate conflicts – and process writing skills – e.g., how to generate main and supporting ideas, and how to develop content. In the

drafting stage, peers' late posting negatively impacted on students' contributions. In the feedback and revision stage, the peer comments did not always lead to effective revisions due to poor quality regarding vague suggestions and mainly covering local areas. In the publishing stage, illustrations were not effectively utilised. For more effective collaboration and cooperation in Cycle 2, students suggested some modifications, such as allowing students to choose the writing topics and their peers, establishing timelier postings and increasing the number of peer comments, especially global revision comments, in their wiki feedback.

With regard to research question 3 on the effective stages of collaborative writing, in this study, the students worked either collaboratively or cooperatively via five stages of writing (pre-writing, drafting, feedback, revising and publishing). Teacher's more intensive scaffolding was provided in the pre-writing and feedback stages and withdrawn to facilitate students' collaboration in the other stages.

In the pre-writing stage, students collaborated to discuss the outlines including content, organisation, structures and vocabulary that each student used in their own writing later. The teacher provided students with genres of writing by contextualising the writing tasks, providing models of the text type and structuring students' discussion for each essay following Hyland's (2004) suggestions. Students evaluated this stage positively as the novice could learn writing strategies from more capable peers and the teacher as mentioned above. Importantly, the outlines that each group produced by the end of every collaborative face-to-face meeting guided them how to write and what to write when working cooperatively via the wikis. After Cycle 1, the researcher-teacher provided more structured instruction, and students responded

positively on that as explicit guidance helped them to focus on what to negotiate with peers.

In the drafting stage, each student wrote an assigned part of the essays to post in the wikis. Students reported that if in the pre-writing stage they had produced effective outlines, they encountered fewer difficulties in starting their own writing. Otherwise, they needed to use wikis to further generate the content or organisation of writing. After the modification of fixing time for peers' posting in Cycle 1, the students posted their writing in a timelier manner. However, some writing parts were not posted in the sequential order of the essay. For example, the student assigned to write part 2 of the essay finished his/her work earlier than the peer with part 1. This indicated that the joint work was conducted more on an individual than cooperative basis, as required by this stage.

In the feedback stage, students worked collaboratively to provide feedback on peers' writing. The findings of the study show that feedback would be helpful for collaborative work if they could address the global areas of peers' writing, especially the suggestion – revision comments. However, despite larger number of global comments, they were not all effective in providing peers with specific directions to revise their writing. Accordingly, the students preferred the researcher-teacher's feedback to peer feedback. This points to the need to provide students with strategies in giving effective feedback to their peers through comments.

Accordingly, in the revising stage, when students used provided feedback to revise their writing, more revisions on local areas than global areas were made, and some feedback was not addressed. Additionally, one finding in this study also aligns with the literature on wiki L2 writing (Kessler, 2009; Mak & Coniam, 2008): the local

areas covering linguistic accuracy needed more attention from the students because there was a tendency for students to overlook such areas in the peer editing process.

In the publishing stage, the students worked collaboratively to add their revised writing to the group final essays. The data show that because the students had been provided with scaffolding, they were able to use different metadiscourse resources of particular writing genres. Although the students reflected that their writing styles were still the same despite their identification of potential readers, they were at least aware of different genres they needed to use when writing essays to respond to readers' expectations. Because readers were simulated, the students felt it was difficult to target their intended audiences, and consequently the publishing stage was not as motivating as the researcher-teacher expected. In the wiki context, readership could be more "authentic" if, for example, a sister school was deployed as a strategy to provide real audiences outside the immediate context. This is discussed further in terms of "affordances for potential readers" below.

Most student participants reported that they had positive reflections on the strategies of writing approach and would utilise them in their future teaching practice. The teaching colleague stated that she would use face-to-face collaboration in the near future and wiki platforms later. Students, as trainee teachers, reported they would also consider using wikis for their future teaching practices. The participants indicated that the implemented project was successful in enhancing students' participation in collaborative process writing and satisfied some of their expectations prior to the implementation of the project. The positive feedback from participants was in line with the literature on L2 wiki learner attitudes (Chao & Lo, 2011; Elola & Oskoz, 2010; Franco, 2008; Woo et al., 2011).

8.2 FINDINGS OF THE STUDY IN RELATION TO SOCIAL CONSTRUCTIVIST THEORY

This section relates the theoretical framework discussed in Chapter 3 to the key findings. As argued, Chapter 3 highlights the importance of exchanges between low proficiency students and more capable peers and teachers by utilising technology to facilitate L2 writing. This section demonstrates that collaborative process writing in the class under study aligned with these perspectives.

8.2.1 Zone of proximal development and scaffolding perspectives on collaborative writing

As outlined in Chapter 3, the conceptual framework for L2 collaborative writing used in this study is primarily based on Vygotsky's definition of ZPD (1978) and characteristics of collaborative learning (Tinzman et al., 1990). Vygotsky's L2 ZPD is the distance between the students' actual language development levels when working individually, and the potential development levels when collaborating with teachers and more capable peers. Tinzman and colleagues claimed that collaborative learning involves four important characteristics: *knowledge sharing*, *authority sharing*, *teachers' mediation* and *student diversity*. ZPD and collaborative learning characteristics emphasise the roles of teachers and more capable peers to assist students to advance in their learning. The findings of this study show that discussions in the pre-writing stage, comments in wiki stages and the sharing of authority in the class led to participants' positive reflections on collaborative writing.

The findings indicate that for collaborative learning to be effective in traditional L2 writing classes, principles of communities of practice (Lave & Wenger, 1991, 1998) should be considered. The principles state that students' legitimate peripheral participation in a community of practice is necessary (Sub-section 3.2.2). Given the

context of students' variety in language proficiency levels, lack of skills in group work and experience in learning through technology, it was essential for teachers to provide explicit instruction at each stage of writing in this study. In other words, sufficient training or scaffolding must be provided to wiki users before they are able to take more control of their learning.

8.2.2 L2 process-genre writing approach and strategies of writing

This study used the process-genre writing approach to design stages for students to work together. On the one hand, the approach highlights *how* to write by enhancing students' skills via collaborative/cooperative stages of writing. On the other hand, given the context in which students' exposure to L2 linguistic resources was limited, the approach also emphasises *what* to write by teacher's providing genres of writing in the pre-writing stage, and stimulus comments in the feedback stage. The reflections on the stages of writing (Section 8.1 above) demonstrate that the *how* (process) and *what* (genre) supplemented each other to facilitate students' collaborative learning. The genre of writing provided the students with what readers expected them to write, and the peers and researcher-teacher became real readers. Students' negotiation in each stage of writing was easier when structured by the teacher.

8.2.3 Wikis as a collaborative writing platform

In terms of the affordances of wikis for collaborative writing, this study confirms that wikis offer a useful and effective platform for students and teachers to interact: participants did not meet many difficulties in utilising the functions of saving, tracking changes, copying, editing, creating new links or inserting pictures or images in their wikis. The finding is supported by Marzec-Stawiarska (2015) in a study with

an EFL class for trainee teachers: at the beginning of the project, the students felt intimidated, but with practice, they found wikis were easy to operate.

There were two issues regarding the affordances of wikis. First, wikis could not satisfy the students' preferences for authorship. In this study, the students expected that their writing contributions would not be deleted automatically when their peers edited their contributions. That was why the teacher-researcher asked students to create individual pages linked to group pages, and comments were left under students' existing writing. Although the requirement ensured students' writing was not deleted, this made it difficult for students to see their peers' comments, which were at the bottom of the pages. Second, some functions available in wikis were not utilised. For example, although wikis offer live chat platforms for students (through Skype or video), students in this study rarely used these functionalities even though they had been made aware of these during the induction. One of the student participants reported that she used her phone extensively to negotiate the content of their group writing with her peers. It is possible that the cultural practice of "saving face" made the students hesitate to use Skype or videos, which would mean they were criticising each other visibly and directly.

In addition, students' varied levels of English proficiency hindered their ability to negotiate through distance technology. Face-to-face discussions with the support of non-verbal language or Vietnamese might enhance the exchange of ideas. It was also observed from students' writing in their wikis that although the wikis had a spell check functionality, not all students took advantage of this function. Students' overlooking these functionalities suggests that more emphasis on the affordances of

wikis should be included in the students' induction prior to implementation. This could ensure that students realise the potential benefits of the platform.

To conclude, wikis were reported to facilitate collaborative writing by offering simple and interactive platforms for wiki users to communicate. Some functions of wikis, however, were not attractive to participants in this study. Pedagogically, this requires more thorough wiki training. Technologically, and ideally, improvement in wiki platforms, and how students use them, is necessary to maximise their potential affordances.

8.3 COLLABORATIVE WRITING USING TECHNOLOGY CHALLENGES TRADITIONAL WRITING PEDAGOGY

Significantly, the L2 writing project using collaboration and technology challenged traditional L2 writing pedagogy in the class under study in four ways. First, it supported the idea that writing strategies equips students with real-life writing experience with authentic audiences. In daily life, it is often observed that a group of people such as a committee is asked to write together in a project, for example, proposals or reports. Collaborative writing skills are certainly different from those of individual writing. The findings of this study show that the students needed important skills, for example, reaching consensus, and linking individual writing (as discussed below). In the class under study, because the focus of traditional writing pedagogy had hitherto been on individuals, the students were not equipped with these skills prior to the project. The project provided the students with collaborative writing skills such as negotiating in groups to reach consensus or giving and acting upon comments to peers.

Second, the collaborative writing project facilitated a shift in the focus of L2 writing pedagogy from a product to a process-oriented approach. As reflected in Chapter 5, teachers, restricted by a 90 minute session per week in the traditional classroom, could not observe students' learning progress. Instead, they could only assess students' performance through their attendance in the class and a mid-term and end-of-term written exam, which did not allow effective feedback to improve students' writing skills. Collaborative writing in this action research project required both teachers and peers to give and receive comments to and from students throughout the process through face-to-face planning and through the wikis. Accordingly, students received immediate and constant feedback on their writing progress in the wikis, which assisted the students with what they needed to do to revise their writing.

Third, the collaborative writing project challenged traditional teacher-led roles. In the project, the researcher-teacher shared authority with the students so that they could negotiate with her and with their peers on topics, content, and activities around the organisation of writing (Cycle 1) and group selection (Cycle 2). Accordingly, the project addressed the students' varied proficiency levels and their preferences for working in friendship groups.

Fourth, the collaborative writing project raised students' awareness of audiences and purposes of writing, which are important in communicative writing but had often been neglected in the class under study prior to the implementation of the project. In the wikis, students and peers could interact and contribute to the writing and reading of each other's texts. This helped them understand the relationship between writers and audiences. Although the audiences were limited to peers and teachers, students reported that they were more motivated when they had someone "real" to read and

give feedback on their writing. For future collaborative projects, when wikis are open outside the classroom context (as suggested below), students can experience sharing with genuine readers, not only “simulated” readers. This will respond to the Vietnamese MoET’s requirements for L2 writing to be communicative, as discussed earlier. The requirements state that tertiary English major students can use L2 writing spontaneously, fluently and precisely in real life situations.

There were constraints that students encountered during the implementation of the writing project. First, time was limited for both face-to-face and wiki collaboration for both teachers and students. Time constraint was documented in Chapter 2 as a limitation of collaborative writing via wikis. The class under study was no exception, although the researcher-teacher had considered it before the implementation of the project by allocating a significant amount of time for wiki and collaborative training. Time constraints are unavoidable, especially when collaborative writing is new to participants. An increase in class contact time, as participants of this study suggested, is not an effective solution on its own. Managing time in a more scheduled manner as discussed below, and more familiarity with collaborative writing, would be helpful for participants.

Second, students’ writing proficiency levels and skills in group work and L2 process writing varied meaning that exchanges between peers were uneven both in the face-to-face and wiki collaboration. In face-to-face discussions, how to generate content and reach consensus effectively was challenging to some groups, while others could work more effectively (see effective/ineffective outlines in Section 6.1). In wiki collaboration, the students encountered difficulties in showing their peers what specifically they needed to do to revise their writing, which made peer comments not

as highly valued as those of the teacher-researcher. Additionally, some students did not make revisions in response to their peers' comments, as they did not trust their quality. There was also a problem of coherence and cohesion: linking individual paragraphs together for completed "group" essays was not easy for students.

The findings of the L2 writing project indicate that collaborative writing challenged traditional pedagogy in four aspects as discussed above. The constraints suggest that significant changes need to be made in pedagogy so that the shift from traditional teacher-fronted learning to peer-based collaborative writing becomes effective. The next sections will further discuss the relation between the findings of the study and theoretical perspectives and offer suggestions for the implementation of L2 collaborative writing in traditional teacher-fronted contexts.

8.4 SUGGESTIONS FOR TRAINING AND SCAFFOLDING FOR THE USE OF WIKIS IN L2 COLLABORATIVE WRITING PROJECTS

From the findings of this study and other studies in the field, for L2 collaborative process writing to work effectively in the Vietnamese L2 context, the following suggestions for training and scaffolding are proposed. The suggestions are subdivided for face-to-face and wiki collaboration.

8.4.1 Training and scaffolding for face-to-face collaboration

In the literature, Cotterall and Cohen (2003) propose that scaffolding for L2 essay writers involves (1) topics linked to concurrent study themes, (2) a predetermined essay structure, (3) assistance with finding texts and data, (4) staged instruction, focusing on one section of the essay each week, (5) extensive modelling of the composition process, (6) a focus on language and (7) regular feedback from peers and teachers. Because the suggestions for scaffolding in this study are about

collaborative writing, some strategies were similar to Cotterall and Cohen's and some differed. The suggestions below for improved strategies in process writing are based on the findings of the study and my own reflections.

Topics

In this study, some groups reflected that they encountered difficulties when generating ideas for the unfamiliar topics in Cycle 1. However, the teaching colleague and the researcher-teacher assumed that the topics were familiar to the students. The mismatch occurred perhaps because teachers overestimated the students' background understanding about the topics. For future collaborative practices, the teacher could supply some suggestions and students could also make their own decisions when choosing topics. In Cycle 2, the students in this study were allowed to negotiate with the teachers about the topics for their writing, and they found it was easier to generate ideas around their chosen topics.

Lists of possible topics for upcoming essays could also be posted in wikis so that students know them before class time. It would be ideal if students could negotiate with teachers/peers and decide which topics their groups preferred for their writing tasks so as to generate relevant content around the topics prior to face-to-face meetings. Hence, there would be more time in class for other pre-writing activities. More importantly, this could also lead to shared authority between students and teachers, which is one of the goals of collaborative writing.

Structured outlines

The findings of this study show that the effective scaffolding/modelling in the pre-writing stage could significantly reduce the difficulties in reaching consensus that students encountered in later stages. The more structured the outlines in the pre-

writing stage were, the more effectively students worked in later stages (Section 7.2). Some activities that could enhance effective outlines in the pre-writing stage were proposed by students. In this project, the researcher-teacher provided initial questions around the topics, and then students' discussed the detailed frames for what they were going to write. Students' writing of a topic sentence for each paragraph in their outlines is also suggested. Oral group presentation of their outlines, followed by comments from teachers' and other group's may help students to develop effective outlines. However, because class time is limited, group work skills and time management in face-to-face discussion should be considered as discussed below.

Students' group work skills

As discussed, the students' skills to work effectively in groups were developed unevenly. The data reflections show that some of the groups did not know how to reach consensus because there were opposing or too many/few contributions from group members. In addition, there were dominant and passive students in the groups, which meant the group work was not set up or managed as effectively as it could have been.

In the former case, of there being opposing or too many or too few ideas in developing the content of writing, the skills of process writing, such as brainstorming and listing main ideas from supporting ideas, need to be scaffolded for students. This scaffolding is suggested in "Additional resources for students" below. In the case of dominant and/or passive participation, a study by Watanabe and Swain (2007) shows that in face-to-face discussions, dominant/ passive pairs collaborated less effectively than other paired types.

In this study, the teacher-researcher speculated that there were dominant/passive groups because of the diversity in students' language proficiency. However, in the final cycle of the action research project, the participants in the third focus group interview and some students in the corresponding reflection survey explained that peers' attitudes to group work might have contributed to this unevenness. The students proposed that all members in collaborative groups needed to participate actively. The explanation was supported by Storch (2001). She found that in her study of pair work, the differences in language proficiency levels were not necessarily the reason why L2 students did not collaborate effectively. Learners' attitudes to and motivations for working in pairs counted more than proficiency differences. In addition, more familiarity with group processes may be effective, as shown in Cycle 2 when the students were more experienced at group work. The group participation rate was more even in Cycle 2.

In addition, it should be noted that students' preferences for friendship groups are a manifestation of cultural values in Vietnam (Chapter 2). Hence, students should be allowed to choose who they want to work with; instead of having teachers select the groups. This helps to devolve authority from a teacher-centred method to more student-led learning. This L2 writing project study also suggests that a group leader may be needed (Neo, 2003). The group negotiated leader would have responsibilities for distributing work among members, supervising the progress of each stage and/or producing "a more harmonious environment, consequently making their group members more motivated to do their best" (Neo, 2003, p. 471).

8.4.2 Training and scaffolding for wiki collaboration

This section suggests the features of training and scaffolding necessary for students to collaborate effectively via wikis. The features include time management, developing metalanguage for comments, linked additional resources, assessment, follow-up discussions and affordances for potential audiences online.

Time management in wiki collaboration

Posting individual writing according to a scheduled time plays an important part in students' effective collaboration (Allwardt, 2011). Consistent with these findings, this research project shows that autonomous learning affected students' time management: students who posted their writing in a timely manner helped their peers to complete group work, and those who posted their work at the last minute made it difficult for peers to develop joint-writing or give comments on others' texts. The findings of the study indicate that mini-deadlines at each writing stage are helpful in students' collaboration. Each student would be required to post their contributions in a manner that will not negatively impact other students' contributions. For example, if students have one week to collaborate via wikis, the first student needs to finish his/her part no later than one or two days after the face-to-face meeting.

Developing metalanguage for comments

In this study, during the feedback stage of the writing process, the students encountered difficulties with the *focus* of comments: Although global comments on content and development of writing were more frequent than local comments on vocabulary, structures, punctuation and spelling, the global comments did not clearly tell students what they needed to do to improve their writing. Tuzi (2004) suggests that for e-feedback, students should be trained to give and act on effective feedback.

Through this study, I suggest that feedback training should start with teachers' modelling the use of metalanguage for editing and creating appropriate criteria for writing essays. After each essay, examples of effective peer comments can be discussed with the whole class focusing on the metalanguage specifically used in essay writing. Additionally, the use of L1 (Vietnamese in this case) was necessary to provide effective feedback when students' metalanguage and L2 proficiency were not sufficient. This could also motivate low proficiency students.

Linked additional resources for students' linguistic proficiency

Students' levels of proficiency were shown to be an important part in the collaborative writing project. When the project was introduced, students were in Term 3 of the second year of their study: they had already learnt about punctuation, types of sentences and paragraphs, and the development of certain types of essays such as compare and/or contrast essays in English. However, their knowledge about what they had learnt in the previous terms was limited. For example, none of the focus of students' comments was on their peers' punctuation, so there were still mistakes in the final writing products. The reinforcing of metalanguage can be provided via wikis. Teacher-designed reference pages could be linked within the wikis so that students could decide which aspects of writing they need to revise. Wikis archives can show teachers whether students revise the required knowledge or not.

Assessment proposals

The collaborative writing project made it possible for students to gain formative feedback from peers, in addition to teachers: this was new to the class under study. Comments from teachers and peers assisted students to know what they needed to do

to revise and therefore improve their texts. According to Black and William (2009), assessment for learning is a process whereby students are aware of their current strengths and weaknesses, and thus where they are now, and what the next level of performance should be. They will be given feedback that will help them to improve towards attaining the next level. Based on that, I suggest that to identify where the learner is going, teachers of L2 writing should provide students with specific criteria for each type of essay in term of organisation, vocabulary, grammar and conventional structures. These criteria should be discussed with students so that they can understand them and thus be aware of how to achieve them. To identify where each learner is right now, teachers and peers can look at students' writing in wikis to elicit evidence of students' performance. To assist students to achieve the lesson objectives, both teachers and peers can then give meaningful feedback on students' writing.

However, in the class under study and in similar contexts in Vietnam, the use of timed-summative examinations where the only feedback is a grade is still prevalent. Therefore, in the short term, students in the collaborative process writing class will still be required to take mid-term and end-of-term graded writing exams as they usually do. Given this reality, formative assessment conducted across the collaborative writing project could be used to support students to improve performance in a summative writing test, as long as the text types correspond to those in the collaborative phases of the writing project. In addition, it was seen from the L2 writing project that students' negotiation of the topics was an important aspect of student engagement and ownership of the project. Accordingly, if students sit for

timed-written exams, teachers should provide them with opportunities to select from a list of topics rather than assign one set topic for them.

Follow-up discussions after wiki feedback

Face-to-face discussions after wiki feedback are necessary because negotiation through wikis is not always easy due to asynchronous distance and the limitation of L2 users' metalanguage. The students in this study suggested that they would prefer to receive their peers' comments face-to-face after receiving e-feedback to clarify peer comments and directions for revisions. However, follow-up peer meetings may require students to do extra work outside classroom activities. In the long term, when students are familiar with negotiation through wikis, this may result in a reduction in face-to-face follow-up discussions, which could be more practical for students.

Affordances for potential audiences online

As I was involved in the wiki project as both researcher and teacher, I realised that not only the students but also the teachers encountered difficulties in using metalanguage to comment on writing. This is because L2 writers (both teachers and students) certainly encounter difficulties that L1 counterparts do not meet. They need to acquire not only linguistic proficiency but also the "values associated with the nature and functions of English writing that might differ from what they learned in their first-language education" (Guardado & Shi, 2007, p. 458). In addition, in traditional teaching bounded by textbook dependence and graded-exams, L2 teachers themselves do not have many opportunities to write communicatively in L2. Student wiki writing can extend potential readers outside classrooms. For example, teachers can invite or pair similar L2 wiki writing classes in other contexts to join in a writing project as sister classes, who use the wiki as a hub for written and perhaps

multimodal communication. In this way, L2 writing can change from the weak form of CLT with simulated writing to a stronger form with genuine readers in other countries where the common language is the L2 target language. If teachers are interacting online with students, they are also writing in L2 for a public audience.

8.5 IMPLICATIONS FOR L2 COLLABORATIVE WRITING IN VIETNAMESE HIGHER EDUCATION

This study radically challenges traditional pedagogy in Vietnam by engaging students in collaborative process writing in L2 and using new interactive technology. This section discusses implications for teachers, students, assessment and L2 writing pedagogy.

8.5.1 Implications for EFL teachers of writing

As a researcher-teacher, I foresee that this writing project might provide the participants including the teaching colleague and trainee teachers with insights on a new approach to L2 collaborative writing in Vietnam. The findings of this study suggest significant implications for current L2 and EFL writing teachers as well as students who will become teachers in future in a “trickle-down” effect.

For L2 writing pedagogy, this study, first and foremost, highlights that collaborative and process writing can enhance students’ writing skills, as well as their understanding of writing processes. However, this approach should be implemented gradually in a traditional writing context where individual and product writing is still dominant.

For teachers who use collaborative writing for the first time, it may take a significant amount of time to facilitate students’ collaboration in wikis, especially when students are not familiar with the platform and/or metalanguage required for L2 interactions

and comments. In this study, the teaching colleague reflected that, at first, facilitating students through wikis took her much more time and effort than teaching and assessing in traditional classes. This could discourage teachers from employing wikis in their teaching practices.

The implementation of wikis requires significant changes in traditional pedagogy in contexts like Vietnam. Prior to the implementation of the project, the teaching colleague in this study expected that with the facilitation of wikis, she could carry out some traditional activities in class and that the students would follow up on the other activities outside class. The project fell short of this expectation because teacher/student roles and assessment are required to change, and this does not happen quickly. In other words, wikis are not an alternative platform for teachers to carry out traditional teacher-centred writing activities. They offer a radically different way of teaching writing that is more genuinely collaborative.

From my own reflections, teaching through wikis helped raise awareness of the need for improvement in my own professional knowledge of L2 and teaching writing. When giving clear comments to students, which are be saved and published in wikis to many students, teachers certainly need to be more considerate than when giving spoken or written comments to individual students.

It should also be noted that although at first wiki teaching can take time for beginner teachers, gradually teachers can benefit from using wiki technology. For example, students' writing is saved in wikis, which makes it possible for teachers to evaluate what difficulties students encounter and what they need to do to improve their writing. The teaching colleague in this study recommended that teachers could use students' writing in one class wiki as models for other classes. An investment in

using wikis, for her, could be time-saving over the long term and benefit her own teaching practice.

8.5.2 Implications for students

Learning L2 writing through a collaborative process and joint products is certainly different from learning through individual writing. It is especially important that students change their purposes of and approaches to learning L2 writing. Awareness of audiences and writing purposes indicated not only *what* to write but *how* to write. Naturally, writing is not merely for examiners or teachers to grade, but for genuine writers to communicate with audiences. Furthermore, real life writing involves both individual and collaborative work. Hence, it is inferred that students are prepared to change their learning strategies in order to work effectively in wikis. This study highlights the importance of timely participation, positive motivation and effective contributions in the form of global and local comments, all of which are important for developing a common metalanguage and knowledge of L2 writing forms and features.

8.5.3 Implications for assessment

This study concludes that assessment strongly influenced the effectiveness of the writing project: students would have been more motivated if the project was graded. However, the purposes of collaborative wiki writing were not to give feedback through marks or grades but comments to assist students to realise where they were going, where they were at the time of writing and how to achieve learning goals. This appeared to be a contradiction to the existing mandated summative assessment, which is typical across the whole University. While it is not easy to change assessment across the whole system, it is more practical to expect changes in

teachers' and students' perceptions of assessment. They should be provided with professional training to understand the importance of formative assessment in L2 writing so as to take advantage of this type of assessment to improve student writing outcomes.

8.6 CONTRIBUTIONS

This section reports the contributions to teaching practices and research methodology that the study has made. The contributions of the study include the innovation of introducing collaborative and process writing using wikis to engage learners in learning processes in Vietnam.

8.6.1 Contributions to L2 writing teaching practices

Collaborative writing has been widely promoted in L2 learning internationally (Elola & Oskoz, 2010; Franco, 2008). This study and others indicate that collaborative writing through face-to-face and wiki modes can encourage students in traditional EFL settings to engage more actively in L2 writing. Collaborative writing can address four existing issues in traditional L2 classes: limited contact time in large classes, teacher dominance, product orientation and individual writing focus. The significance of this study is that it highlights the gradual shift from traditional learning to collaborative learning through *knowledge sharing*, *authority sharing*, *teacher mediation* and *student diversity* (Tinzman et al., 1990). Collaborative writing highlights the importance of peer comments to provide teachers and students with information about their progress in writing performance. It also supports the introduction of formative assessment to facilitate learning.

For L2 teaching practices, this study demonstrates the necessity for taking up collaborative activities in both face-to-face and wiki modes. It specifies what a

novice teacher should do for the implementation of future collaborative writing projects. By discussing both the affordances and constraints of the project, the researcher-teacher expects to provide practitioners with specific guidelines on what might and should occur in each stage of collaborative writing.

8.6.2 Contribution to research methodology

This study used action research to obtain the data related to teachers and students' expectations, actual activities and reflections on L2 collaborative writing. Action research methodology has been used because effective teaching practice involves planning, acting and reflecting for both teachers and students, which is what this study investigates. In the field of collaborative writing through face-to-face and wiki modes, action research has not been widely used. This study affirms that action research is an effective methodology if teachers aim to bring potential changes to their teaching practice.

The action research in this study followed Burns' (2010) guidelines on action research for language learning, which focused on potential changes and new perspectives on L2 writing in the class under study. The collaboration between the teaching colleague and researcher-teacher is one of the strengths of this study. Being an insider (contributing lesson plans and suggestions before and during the project implementation) and outsider (observing researcher-teacher's facilitating learning), the teaching colleague provided in-depth reflections on the effectiveness and issues of the project. In addition, this study used information from the participants' interviews and wikis to triangulate the reliability of data: as a data source, the wiki data confirmed information provided by the participants in the face-to-face interviews.

The analysis of data, especially the integrated checklist to analyse and evaluate the effectiveness of each stage of writing (Table 4.11), and suggestions for training and scaffolding are two important contributions to the research process. Collaborative L2 writing and teaching L2 writing using technology in Vietnam, both of which were integral to the research design, are very rarely deployed in EFL classrooms.

8.7 LIMITATIONS AND FUTURE RESEARCH SUGGESTIONS

This section discusses the shortcomings of the research and practical suggestions for future studies.

8.7.1 Limitations

The study has significantly contributed to the empirical study of the practices of L2 collaborative writing. However, it has certain limitations. First, in terms of research design, the time between the last stage of Cycle 1 and first stage of Cycle 2 was two weeks, which was a brief period for the participants to reflect on the effectiveness of the adjustments made for Cycle 2. Only six students participated in the reflection after Cycle 1 (the second focus group interview). It would have been more effective if the researcher had been able to collate reflections from the teaching colleague and all of the students after Cycle 1, although this may have made the data sets unwieldy.

Second, the teaching colleague could not participate in the writing project as both observer and teacher as planned in the original design due to logistical and ethical reasons. Regarding the latter, involvement in the project meant that she had to familiarise herself with two complete new strategies: wiki training and facilitating students' collaboration. This required time and effort while she was busily scheduled with different classes. Ultimately, she managed to be the observer to reflect on the researcher-teacher's teaching throughout the project, but not teach herself. Although

she had significant input with regard to her perceptions of L2 writing pedagogy, her reflections on the current pedagogy, and her perceptions of the researcher project's activities, more involvement on her part could have led to deeper reflections on the project.

Third, the students in the first and second-focus group interviews would ideally have been the same. Due to inconvenience of time and logistical reasons, three students in the first focus group interview could not attend the second focus group interview. Fourth, in terms of pedagogy, if the researcher-teacher's scaffolding on specific metalanguage for comments had been provided to the students during the project, the quality of formative feedback might have improved.

Finally, as mentioned in Sub-section 4.5.1 if the translation process had been conducted both by me, as an insider, and by other people, for example, professional translators, the validity of the data would have more objectivity.

8.7.2 Suggestions for future research

The writing project in this study lasted eight weeks, including two weeks for induction. Within this short period of time, the focus of the study was on participants' reflections on and effective strategies for collaborative writing. Future longitudinal studies focusing on improvement in writing quality, collaborative patterns and formative assessment practices are suggested. In addition, the action research in this study included two cycles, each of which lasted three weeks. With longitudinal studies, more cycles of research will help researchers collect in-depth data and improve practices in each stage.

8.8 MY PERSONAL REFLECTIONS ON USING COLLABORATION AND TECHNOLOGY TO ENHANCE VIETNAMESE STUDENTS' WRITING SKILLS

I gained valuable professional experience from implementing the writing project using collaboration and technology and investigating participants' reflections on the affordances and constraints of each stage of writing.

I am fully aware that collaborative writing using technology can enhance teaching and learning L2 writing in traditional-embedded contexts. However, to implement future projects, L2 Vietnamese teachers and students will certainly encounter challenges. These challenges include requirements for (a) shifting from a physical classroom only to a blended environment, (b) shifting from teacher-centred to peer-based pedagogy, (c) mandated summative assessment to include formative assessment and (d) the product approach to include a process writing approach. These changes cannot occur wholesale in the near future or in an individual classroom.

Despite these aforementioned difficulties, I believe that collaborative learning including the process writing approach will become the centre of L2 writing pedagogy in Vietnam. This is because collaborative learning includes (a) a process writing approach that considers writers' cognitive development, (b) formative feedback facilitating students' gaining knowledge and skills not only from teachers but also peers, and (c) a writer-reader relationship that emphasises writing for a purpose. My optimistic belief in the success of future projects is also supported by the MoET's requirements for L2 communicative learning, and its provision of technology multimedia to support teaching and learning. These advantages make the implementation of collaborative writing using technology practical.

As an action research practitioner, I have plans to contribute to professional practices in my University and other universities in Vietnam. I will present the findings of the study to my colleagues at the University, and consider the constraints in each stage. Based on the considerations, new projects with new students will be implemented with the collaboration of colleagues. Similarly, I intend to collaborate with L2 writing teachers from other universities to implement future projects. By doing this, I can investigate how collaborative writing using technology could work in traditional teaching and learning contexts like Vietnam.

8.9 SUMMARY

This study used action research to investigate teachers' and students' reflections and effective strategies through a project using collaboration and technology in a Vietnamese university. The participants in this study include two L2 teachers: the teaching colleague and the teacher-researcher, together with 30 EFL students. The findings show that participants had positive attitudes to the use of collaboration through face-to-face and wiki modes to enhance L2 writing skills in a traditional EFL context. The importance of meaningful exchange between the low and high proficiency students in a face-to-face and wiki community during writing processes was highlighted. Peer collaboration mediated by asynchronous wikis made it possible for more independent, interactive and collaborative learning to occur than if the students had been limited to a physical class only. Collaborative wiki writing extended the boundary of the learning environment, from class space in limited time, to outside class space and asynchronous time. Collaborative writing using wikis also allowed formative assessment to be introduced. Despite existing constraints, collaborative writing is an innovation in traditional Vietnamese teaching contexts.

This study suggests necessary changes with regards to teachers' and students' roles, and to assessment, when applying collaborative practices to writing in second language learning. This study represents a challenge to the entrenched Vietnamese system, which has traditionally relied solely on examinations to assess writing and suggest promising ways forward for EFL teachers in the future in Vietnam.

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Appendices

Appendix 1 QUT ETHICS FOR CONDUCTING THE RESEARCH

	University Human Research Ethics Committee (UHREC) HUMAN RESEARCH ETHICS APPROVAL CERTIFICATE NHMRC Registered Committee Number EC00171
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Date of Issue: 30/1/15 (supersedes all previously issued certificates)

Dear Mrs Thi Huong Giang Bui

This approval certificate serves as your written notice that the proposal has met the requirements of the *National Statement on Ethical Conduct in Human Research* and has been approved on that basis. You are therefore authorised to commence activities as outlined in your application, subject to any specific and standard conditions detailed in this document.

Project Details		
Category of Approval:	Human Negligible-Low Risk	
Approved From:	21/04/2013	Approved Until: 21/04/2016 (subject to annual reports)
Approval Number:	1300000216	
Project Title:	Strategies for developing a collaborative learning community to enhance Vietnamese students' English language writing skills	
Investigator Details		
Chief Investigator:	Mrs Thi Huong Giang Bui	
Other Staff/Students:		
Investigator Name	Type	Role
Dr Anita Jetnikoff	Internal	Supervisor
Dr Lynette May	Internal	Supervisor
Conditions of Approval		

Specific Conditions of Approval:
None apply

Standard Conditions of Approval:

1. Conduct the project in accordance with QUT policy, the *National Statement on Ethical Conduct in Human Research* (<http://www.nhmrc.gov.au/guidelines/publications/e72>), the *Australian Code for the Responsible Conduct of Research* (<http://www.nhmrc.gov.au/guidelines/publications/r39>), any associated legislation, guidelines or standards;
2. Gain UHREC approval for any proposed variation (<http://www.orei.qut.edu.au/human/var/>) to the project prior to implementation;
3. Respond promptly to the requests and instructions of UHREC;
4. Immediately advise the Office of Research Ethics and Integrity (<http://www.orei.qut.edu.au/human/adv/>) if:
 - o any unforeseen development or events occur that might affect the continued ethical acceptability of the project;
 - o any complaints are made, or expressions of concern are raised, in relation to the project;
 - o the project needs to be suspended or modified because the risks to participants now outweigh the benefits;
 - o a participant can no longer be involved because the research may harm them; and
5. Report on the progress of the approved project at least annually, or at intervals determined by UHREC. The Committee may also choose to conduct a random audit of your project.

If any details within this Approval Certificate are incorrect please advise the Research Ethics Unit within 10 days of receipt of this certificate.

End of Document

Appendix 2 NEEDS ANALYSIS SURVEY ON STUDENTS' EXPERIENCES OF L2

WRITING AND THEIR EXPECTATIONS OF COLLABORATIVE WRITING

You are attending an eight week writing project. In this project, you will collaborate with other students to co-write three types of essays: argument, compare and/or contrast, and cause and/or effect essays. You will follow the process writing approach. The pre-writing stage will be conducted through face-to-face meetings. The other stages will be conducted through the foreignlanguagefaculty.pbworks.com page

The purpose of this survey is to gather information about yourself (Part I), your learning experiences (Part II), and your expectations of the coming collaborative writing project (Part III). Please tick or answer the following questions

SECTION 1: PERSONAL DETAILS

Please be noted that your anonymity is assured by detaching this section, and at no point in my thesis your information in this section will be named or published.

1.1 Full name:.....

1.2. Gender: Female Male

1.3. Email:.....

1. 4. Age:.....

1.5. You started learning English at:

Grade 3: ☐ Grade 6: ☐ Grade 10: ☐

SECTION 2: COLLABORATIVE LEARNING EXPERIENCE

2.1 Have you worked ever in pair/ group face-to-face for L2 writing?

Yes ☐ No ☐

If yes, do you think it was useful for your writing? Yes ☐ No ☐

Please explain.....

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2.2 Have you ever worked in pair/group through any online platform (e.g., blog, facebook, wikis) for your L2 writing? Yes ☐ No ☐

If yes, what platform did you use?

.....

Was it useful for your writing improvement? Yes ☐ No ☐

Please explain.....

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SECTION 3: EXPECTATIONS OF THE COMING PROJECT

Goals of writing

3.1 What are your goals for improvement in writing in L2? Please tick in the order of importance

	Most important	Important	Fairly important	Not very important	Not important at all
Content/ideas					
Organisation					
Grammar					
Structures					
Vocabulary					
Punctuation					
Spelling					

Please explain

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Other expectations

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Pre-writing

3.2 How would you expect your process writing will change as a result of your face-to-face collaboration during the pre-writing stage?

	Yes	No	Not sure
You can identify the readers and purposes of writing			
You can generate content/ideas			
You can list important vocabulary and structures			
You can develop the sequences/organisation of the writing			

Please explain

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Other expectations

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3.3. Drafting

How would you expect your process writing will change as a result of your wiki collaboration during the drafting stage?

	Yes	No	Not sure
You can use and/or add more vocabulary beyond those in pre-writing stage			
You can use and/or add more structures beyond those in the pre-writing stage			
You can use and/or add more ideas beyond those in the pre-writing stage			

Please explain.

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Other expectations

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3.4. Feedback

How would you expect your process writing will change as a result of your wiki collaboration during the feedback stage?

	Yes	No	Not sure
Wikis can help you obtain and incorporate useful comments from your peers and/or teacher			
Wikis can help you improve your writing substantively in comparison with the initial drats			

Please explain

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Other expectations

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3.5. Revision stage

How would you expect your process writing will change as a result of your wiki collaboration during the revision stage?

	Yes	No	Not sure

Wikis can help you identify grammar mistakes/errors			
Wikis can help you identify spelling mistakes/errors			
Wikis can help you identify vocabulary mistakes/ errors			
Wikis can help you identify structure mistakes/ errors			
Wikis can help you identify punctuation mistakes/ errors			

Please explain

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Other expectations

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3.6. Publishing stage

How would you expect your process writing will change as a result of your wiki collaboration during the post-writing stage?

	Yes	No	Not sure
Wikis can help you publish your writings integrating with other codes besides texts, for example, using pictures, animations, music, and so on.			
Your writing come closer to real readers			

Please explain.....

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Other expectations

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Thank you for your cooperation

KHẢO SÁT VỀ NHU CẦU CỦA SINH VIÊN ĐỐI VỚI VIỆC HỌC MÔN VIẾT TIẾNG ANH THÔNG QUA HOẠT ĐỘNG HỢP TÁC GẶP MẶT TRỰC TIẾP VÀ WIKIS

Bạn sẽ tham gia vào khóa học tiếng Anh 8 tuần. Trong khóa học này các bạn sẽ cùng các thành viên trong nhóm viết chung một bài viết tiếng Anh sử dụng cách viết theo quá trình (process writing approach). Giai đoạn trước khi viết (pre-writing stage) sẽ được thực hiện qua các buổi gặp thảo luận trực tiếp trên lớp (face-to-face meetings). Các giai đoạn còn lại (drafting, feedback, revising and post-writing stages) sẽ được tiến hành qua trang foreinglanguagefaculty.pbworks.com

Mục đích của khảo sát này là thu thập thông tin cá nhân, (phần I) kinh nghiệm (phần II) và mong muốn của bạn đối với khóa học (phần III). Hãy trả lời hoặc đánh dấu (v) vào các câu hỏi sau

PHẦN I: THÔNG TIN CÁ NHÂN

1.1 Họ tên:.....

1.2. Giới tính: Nam: ☐ Nữ: ☐

1.3. Email:.....

1. 4. Năm sinh :.....

1.5. Bạn bắt đầu học tiếng Anh khi nào?

Lớp 3 ☐ Lớp 6 ☐ Lớp 9 ☐

PHẦN II: TRẢI NGHIỆM CỦA BẠN

2.1. Bạn đã từng bao giờ học môn Viết tiếng Anh bằng cách hợp tác viết chung một bài thông qua hình thức gặp mặt trực tiếp chưa?

Rồi ☐ Chưa ☐

Nếu bạn đã từng học rồi, theo đánh giá của bạn việc hợp tác viết chung một bài bằng cách gặp mặt trực tiếp như vậy có giúp ích cho việc học môn Viết tiếng Anh của bạn?

Có ☐ Không ☐

Xin hãy giải thích lựa chọn của bạn

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2.3 Bạn đã bao giờ học môn Viết tiếng Anh bằng cách viết chung bài thông qua việc sử dụng các ứng dụng của internet (ví dụ, blog, facebook, wikis)?

Rồi ☐ Chưa ☐

Nếu bạn từng học rồi, bạn đã sử dụng ứng dụng nào?

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Trải nghiệm đó có giúp ích cho việc học môn Viết tiếng Anh của bạn không?

Có ☐ Không ☐

Xin hãy giải thích lựa chọn của bạn

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PHẦN III: MONG MUỐN CỦA BẠN

3.1 Mục đích của bạn khi học môn Viết

Mong muốn của bạn khi tham dự vào khóa học môn Viết tiếng Anh của chúng tôi là nhằm cải thiện nội dung nào trong các kỹ năng viết sau đây? Hãy đánh dấu vào các lựa chọn theo tầm quan trọng

	Rất quan trọng	Khá quan trọng	Quan trọng	Không quan trọng lắm	Không hề quan trọng
Nội dung/ ý tưởng					
Kết cấu					
Ngữ pháp					

Cấu trúc câu					
Từ vựng					
Dấu câu					
Các lỗi về chính tả					

Xin hãy giải thích lựa chọn của bạn

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Các kỹ năng viết khác mà bạn muốn cải thiện trong giai đoạn này

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3.2 Giai đoạn trước khi viết (pre-writing)

Bạn có mong muốn việc gặp mặt thảo luận trực tiếp trên lớp (face-to-face meetings) trong giai đoạn trước khi viết sẽ giúp bạn có thể

Mục đích	Có	Không	Không chắc
Xác định độ dài của bài viết sắp tới?			
Xác định mục đích của bài viết sắp tới?			
Liệt kê các ý chính cho bài viết sắp tới?			
Liệt kê các từ vựng quan trọng cho bài viết sắp tới?			
Liệt kê các cấu trúc quan trọng cho bài viết sắp tới?			
Xây dựng được dàn ý cho bài viết sắp tới?			

Xin hãy giải thích lựa chọn của bạn

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Mong muốn khác của bạn trong giai đoạn này

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3.3. Giai đoạn viết nháp (drafting)

Bạn có mong muốn việc sử dụng wikis trong giai đoạn viết nháp có thể giúp bạn cải thiện các kỹ năng sau đây không?

	Có	Không	Không chắc
Sử dụng các từ vựng đã liệt kê trong giai đoạn trước khi viết.			
Bổ sung thêm từ vựng ngoài những từ đã liệt kê trong giai đoạn trước khi viết			
Sử dụng các cấu trúc đã liệt kê trong giai đoạn trước khi viết			
Bổ sung thêm cấu trúc ngoài những cấu trúc đã liệt kê trong giai đoạn trước khi viết			
Sử dụng các ý tưởng/nội dung đã liệt kê trong giai đoạn trước khi viết			
Bổ sung thêm ý tưởng, nội dung ngoài những ý/ nội dung đã liệt kê trong giai đoạn trước khi viết			

Xin hãy giải thích lựa chọn của bạn

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Mong muốn khác của bạn trong giai đoạn này?

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3. 4. Giai đoạn tiếp nhận góp ý, nhận xét của bạn cùng nhóm (feedback)

Bạn có mong muốn việc sử dụng wikis trong giai đoạn này có thể giúp bạn cải thiện các kỹ năng sau đây không?

	Có	Không	Không chắc
Sử dụng có hiệu quả các ý kiến gợi ý của bạn cùng nhóm			
Cải thiện bài viết một cách đáng kể so với bản viết nháp đầu tiên			

Xin hãy giải thích lựa chọn của bạn

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Các mong muốn khác của bạn trong giai đoạn này

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3.5. Giai đoạn sửa chữa lỗi ngữ pháp, từ vựng, chính tả, dấu câu (revising)

Bạn có mong muốn việc sử dụng wikis trong giai đoạn này có thể giúp bạn cải thiện các lỗi sau đây không?

	Có	Không	Không chắc

Lỗi về ngữ pháp			
Lỗi về chính tả			
Lỗi về từ vựng			
Lỗi về cấu trúc			
Lỗi về dấu câu			

Xin hãy giải thích lựa chọn của bạn

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Các lỗi khác mà bạn mong muốn phát hiện và sửa chữa trong giai đoạn này

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3.6. Giai đoạn sau khi viết (publishing)

Bạn có mong muốn việc sử dụng wikis trong giai đoạn này có thể giúp bạn trong các nội dung sau đây không?

	Có	Không	Không chắc
Mình họa sinh động hơn bài viết của mình bằng cách kết hợp với các tiện ích khác như tranh ảnh, hiệu ứng, âm nhạc, video			
Bài viết của bạn đến gần với độc giả hơn			

Xin hãy giải thích lựa chọn của bạn

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Các mong muốn khác của bạn trong giai đoạn này

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Cảm ơn bạn đã tham gia vào khảo sát của chúng tôi

Appendix 3

FIRST SEMI-STRUCTURED INTERVIEW WITH THE TEACHING COLLEAGUE

Teaching colleague experiences of L2 writing and expectations of collaborative writing project through face-to-face and wiki modes	
Opening questions	- Please tell me about the method that you currently use to teach L2 writing - Have you experienced collaborative face-to-face or/and online learning/teaching before?
Question 1	<u>Guided question</u> - What are your expectations of the potential for face-to-face collaboration to enhance students' engagement and participation in the pre-writing stage?
	<u>Probe questions</u> - How can face-to-face collaboration engage students' participation in + identifying the target readership? + identifying purposes of writing? + generating main ideas? + listing structures and vocabulary? + planning the organisation?
Question 2	<u>Guided question</u> - What are your expectations of the potential for wiki collaboration to enhance students' engagement and participation in the drafting, feedback, revision and publishing stages?
	<u>Probe questions</u> - How can wikis help engage the students in + Drafting (use the listed ideas, vocabulary, structures beyond the pre-writing stage) + Receiving feedback (integrate useful comments from peers and teacher) + Acting upon comments (employ comments from teacher and peers) + Publishing (publish the group final essays)

Question 3	<u>Guided question</u> - What are the difficulties that students and teachers may encounter when students participate in collaborative writing through face-to-face and wiki modes?
	<u>Probe questions</u> - What are the potential difficulties arising from + students' resistance to collaboration? + students' dominating a group? + students' wiki usage? + students' adaptation from current learning to collaborative learning?
Ending questions	From all that you have mentioned, do you think that collaborative writing can be successful in the context of our faculty? Is there anything else that you would like to add?

BẢN CÂU HỎI PHÒNG VẤN LẦN 1 VỚI GIÁO VIÊN

Bản câu hỏi phỏng vấn với giáo viên để xác định kinh nghiệm giảng dạy và mong muốn với khóa học viết thông qua hoạt động hợp tác và wikis	
Câu hỏi mở đầu	1. Xin chị hãy cho biết <i>cách thức</i> hiện nay chị đang sử dụng để dạy môn Viết tiếng Anh cho sinh viên chuyên ngành tiếng Anh 2. Chị đã bao giờ tham dự vào việc học hoặc dạy tiếng Anh bằng cách người học cùng viết chung một bài chưa ?
Câu hỏi 1	Câu hỏi định hướng - Chị mong muốn việc hợp tác bằng cách gặp mặt trực tiếp (face-to-face) trong giai đoạn trước khi viết (pre-writing) sẽ thu hút được sinh viên tham gia vào việc viết theo quá trình như thế nào?
	Câu hỏi gợi ý Việc sinh viên gặp nhau mặt trực tiếp trước khi viết sẽ khuyến khích họ tham gia vào các hoạt động sau đây như thế nào? + Xác định độc giả của bài viết + Xác định mục đích của bài viết + Tìm ý chính cho bài viết + Liệt kê cấu trúc cho bài viết + Liệt kê từ vựng cho bài viết + Xây dựng dàn ý cho bài viết
Question 2	Câu hỏi định hướng Việc sử dụng wikis sẽ giúp sinh viên tham gia vào các giai đoạn viết nháp (drafting), nhận xét góp ý bài viết của bạn (Feedback), sửa chữa bài viết của mình (Revising) và đăng bài của nhóm (Publishing) như thế nào?
	Câu hỏi gợi ý Wikis có vai trò thế nào trong việc thúc đẩy sinh viên tham gia vào + Việc sử dụng những ý chính, từ vựng, cấu trúc đã được đưa ra trong giai đoạn trước khi viết hoặc phát triển được thêm từ vựng, cấu trúc so với liệt kê ở giai đoạn trước khi viết + Sử dụng, phát triển những đóng góp, nhận xét của bạn cùng nhóm và của giáo

	viên + Sửa chữa chính tả, dấu câu hoặc ngữ pháp + Giai đoạn sau viết (cho đăng bản viết hoàn chỉnh)
Question 3	Câu hỏi định hướng - Giáo viên và sinh viên có thể gặp khó khăn gì khi học viết thông qua các buổi thảo luận tại lớp cho giai đoạn trước khi viết?
	Câu hỏi gợi ý - Sinh viên không hào hứng với việc cùng nhau viết chung một bài - Có những sinh viên có vai trò áp đảo hoặc nổi trội hơn các sinh viên khác - Lượng thời gian cho giờ gặp mặt - Sinh viên không thể tự đáp ứng yêu cầu của giai đoạn trước khi viết
Question 4	Câu hỏi định hướng - Giáo viên và sinh viên có thể gặp khó khăn gì khi học viết thông qua sử dụng wikis
	Câu hỏi gợi ý - Việc sử dụng wiki để hợp tác của sinh viên - Sinh viên phải thay đổi cách học hiện tại để thích ứng với cách học mới
Ending questions	Từ cuộc trao đổi của chúng ta ngày hôm nay, chị có cho rằng việc hợp tác để cùng nhau viết một bài bằng cách gặp mặt trực tiếp hoặc wiki có thể áp dụng thành công trong điều kiện học của trường ta? Chị có thêm ý kiến mong muốn gì để khóa học sắp tới có thể thành công?

Appendix 4 **SECOND SEMI-STRUCTURED INTERVIEW WITH THE** **TEACHING COLLEAGUE**

Teaching colleague's reflections on the collaborative writing project		
Opening questions	- Please think back to the time when you first started to facilitate this project. What were your first impressions? What was the beginning of the project like for you?	
Question 1	<u>Guided question</u> -To what extent could face-to-face collaboration pre-writing stage enhance students' engagement with L2 writing?	<u>Probe questions</u> - Have you seen any examples of students' engagement and participation in identifying readers/ purposes, generating ideas, listing vocabulary/structures?
Question 2	<u>Guided question</u> - To what extent could wiki collaboration enhance students' engagement with drafting, feedback, editing, and publishing stages?	- How did the students engage and participate in the + drafting (use or/and add ideas, vocabulary, structures listed in pre-writing discussion)? + feedback (obtaining and incorporating constructive comments)? + revision (grammar, structure, spelling)? + publishing (posting their writing)?
Question 3	<u>Guided question</u> - What were the beneficial aspects of the project to you as a L2 writing teacher?	<u>Probe questions</u> - Did your L2 teaching method change significantly in your experience of using face-to-face and/or wiki collaboration?
Question 4	<u>Guided question</u> - What are the weaknesses of the project?	<u>Probe questions</u> - Did our students attend and contribute actively to the project? - Did you have any difficulty following the project? - Was the project appropriate for our current teaching and learning context?

	<u>Guided question</u>	<u>Probe questions</u>
Question 5	- What suggestions would you make for the improvement of future projects?	- What changes with regard to students' collaborative patterns, teachers' roles, syllabus design and project assessment should be made?
Ending questions	To evaluate the project, is there anything that the project did not provide? Will you introduce collaborative learning to future projects? Would you like to add anything further?	

PHỎNG VẤN VỚI GIÁO VIÊN LẦN THỨ 2

Phản hồi của giáo viên về toàn bộ khóa học		
Câu hỏi mở đầu	- Nhớ lại khoảng thời gian bắt tay tham gia vào khóa học. Ấn tượng đầu tiên của chị là gì? Khởi đầu của khóa học diễn ra như thế nào đối với chị?	
Câu hỏi 1	<i>Câu hỏi định hướng</i> Theo chị hoạt động gặp mặt trực tiếp (face-to-face) trong giai đoạn trước khi viết (pre-writing) có thể thúc đẩy sinh viên tham gia vào việc học viết theo quá trình như thế nào?	<u>Câu hỏi gợi ý</u> - Chị thấy sự tham gia của các nhóm sinh viên vào các hoạt động sau đây như thế nào? + xác định độ giả + xác định mục đích của bài viết + tìm ý + tìm vốn từ vựng
Câu hỏi 2	<i>Câu hỏi định hướng</i> Vai trò của wikis trong việc thúc đẩy sinh viên tham gia vào giai đoạn viết nháp (drafting), tiếp nhận đóng góp, phản hồi (feedback), chỉnh sửa (revising) và sau viết (post-writing) như thế nào?	<u>Câu hỏi hướng dẫn</u> Sinh viên đã tham gia vào các hoạt động sau như thế nào? <u>Giai đoạn viết nháp (drafting)</u> + Sử dụng ý tưởng, từ vựng, cấu trúc đã liệt kê ở giai đoạn trước khi viết? + Tìm thêm ý tưởng, từ vựng, cấu trúc so với giai đoạn trước khi viết <u>Giai đoạn tiếp nhận góp ý, nhận xét (feedback)</u> + Khai thác nhận xét, góp ý của các bạn cùng nhóm như thế nào? <u>Giai đoạn chỉnh sửa (revising)</u> + Sinh viên đã tham gia vào việc chỉnh

		sửa ngữ pháp, cấu trúc, chính tả như thế nào Giai đoạn sau viết (post-writing) + Sinh viên đã tham gia vào việc cho đăng bài của nhóm trên wikis như thế nào?
Câu hỏi 3	<i>Câu hỏi định hướng</i> Là giáo viên dạy môn Viết tiếng Anh, khóa học này mang lại lợi ích gì cho chị?	<u>Câu hỏi gợi ý</u> - Phương pháp thực hành dạy học môn Viết tiếng Anh của chị có sự thay đổi nào đáng kể do ảnh hưởng của việc tham gia vào khóa học này? - Lý luận về phương pháp dạy tiếng môn Viết tiếng Anh của chị có sự thay đổi nào đáng kể không?
Câu hỏi 4	<i>Câu hỏi định hướng</i> Theo chị, khóa học này còn hạn chế gì?	<u>Câu hỏi gợi ý</u> - Sinh viên có tham dự và đóng góp tích cực vào các hoạt động trong khóa học không? - Chị có gặp khó khăn gì trong việc làm giáo viên trong khóa học? - Khóa học có phù hợp với đặc điểm và điều kiện dạy và học ngoại ngữ của Khoa, Trường và sinh viên ta không?
Câu hỏi 5	<i>Câu hỏi định hướng</i> Trong tương lai chị có ý định sử dụng khóa học mà sinh viên hợp tác với nhau không?	<u>Câu hỏi gợi ý</u> Tại sao chị có/ không sử dụng - Chị định sử dụng hợp tác trực tiếp hay thông qua ứng dụng của internet? - Ngoài môn Viết tiếng Anh, còn môn nào khác có thể sử dụng phương pháp này

Câu hỏi 6	<i>Câu hỏi định hướng</i> Chị có góp ý gì để cho các khóa học sau này có thể thành công hơn không?	- Theo chị chúng ta cần phải có thay đổi gì về phía sinh viên, giáo viên, thiết kế giáo trình, kiểm tra đánh giá để việc học theo phương thức hợp tác có thể thành công?
Câu hỏi kết thúc	Đánh giá toàn diện về khóa học, có điểm gì mà khóa học chưa thể tạo điều kiện cho sinh viên tham gia vào quá trình viết theo quá trình. Chị có thêm ý kiến gì nữa không?	

Appendix 5

FIRST FOCUS-GROUP INTERVIEW WITH THE STUDENTS

Students' experiences of L2 writing and their expectations of collaborative writing using wikis	
Opening questions	- Please tell me about the method that you currently use to learn L2 writing - Have you experienced collaborative face-to-face or/and online learning/ teaching before?
Question 1	<u>Guided question</u> - What are your expectations of the potential for face-to-face discussion in the pre-writing stage?
	<u>Probe questions</u> - How can face-to-face collaboration engage students' participation in + identifying target readership? + identifying purposes of writing? + generating main ideas? + listing structures and vocabulary? + planning the organization?
Question 2	<u>Guided question</u> - What are your expectations of the potential for wiki collaboration in the drafting, feedback, revision and publishing stages?
	<u>Probe questions</u> How can wikis help engage the students in + Drafting (use the listed ideas, vocabulary, structures beyond the pre-writing stage) + Giving comments (giving useful comments to peers) + Revision (acting upon useful comments)

	+ Publishing (posting final drafts)
Ending questions	From all that you have mentioned, do you think that collaborative writing can be successful in the context of our faculty? Is there anything else that you would like to add?

PHỎNG VẤN NHÓM VỚI SINH VIÊN LẦN 1

Kinh nghiệm của sinh viên trong việc học môn Viết và mong muốn của họ đối với việc học viết thông qua hợp tác và sử dụng wikis

Câu hỏi mở đầu	- Xin bạn hãy cho biết cách thức mà bạn thường sử dụng để học môn Viết tiếng Anh? - Bạn đã bao giờ học môn Viết tiếng Anh thông qua hợp tác trực tiếp hoặc sử dụng mạng chưa?
Câu hỏi 1	Câu hỏi định hướng - Bạn mong muốn việc hợp tác bằng cách gặp mặt trực tiếp (face-to-face) trong giai đoạn trước khi viết (pre-writing) sẽ thu hút được sinh viên tham gia vào việc viết theo quá trình như thế nào? <u>Câu hỏi gợi ý</u> - Việc gặp nhau mặt trực tiếp trước khi viết sẽ khuyến khích sinh viên tham gia vào các hoạt động sau đây như thế nào? + Xác định độc giả của bài viết + Xác định mục đích của bài viết + Tìm ý chính cho bài viết + Liệt kê cấu trúc cho bài viết + Liệt kê từ vựng cho bài viết + Xây dựng dàn ý cho bài viết
Câu hỏi 2	Câu hỏi định hướng Việc sử dụng wikis sẽ giúp sinh viên tham gia vào các giai đoạn viết nháp (drafting), nhận xét góp ý bài viết của bạn (Feedback), sửa chữa bài viết của mình (Revising) và đăng bài của nhóm (Publishing) như thế nào? <u>Câu hỏi gợi ý</u> Wikis có vai trò thế nào trong việc thúc đẩy sinh viên tham gia vào + Việc sử dụng những ý chính, từ vựng, cấu trúc đã được đưa ra trong giai đoạn trước khi viết hoặc phát triển được thêm từ vựng, cấu trúc so với liệt kê ở giai đoạn trước khi viết + Sử dụng, phát triển những đóng góp, nhận xét của bạn cùng nhóm và của

	giáo viên + Sửa chữa chính tả, dấu câu hoặc ngữ pháp + Giai đoạn sau viết (cho đăng bản viết hoàn chỉnh)
Ending questions	Từ những gì mà chúng ta đã thảo luận, bạn có nghĩ khóa học Viết tiếng Anh thông qua việc hợp tác và sử dụng wikis có thể thành công? Còn điều gì mà bạn muốn thêm vào trong cuộc phỏng vấn hôm nay?

Appendix 6

SECOND FOCUS-GROUP INTERVIEW WITH THE STUDENTS

Reflections on students' collaboration and their suggestions for modification in Cycle 2	
Opening questions	1. Think back to when you first started with this project. What were your first impressions? 2. What was the induction of the project like for you?
Key questions	3. What was particular effectiveness of collaboration through face-to-face to your participation in L2 writing? 4. What was particular effectiveness of collaboration wiki modes to your participation in L2 writing? 5. What strategies including pre-writing, drafting, feedback, revision, and publishing could enhance your participation most? 6. Can you list any difficulties relating to yourself, your peers, the teacher/instructor, collaborative techniques that you encountered when collaborating? 7. What are your suggestions for the coming essays?
Ending questions	8. What advice to the teacher would you like to give to improve Cycle 2 of this research?

PHỎNG VẤN NHÓM VỚI SINH VIÊN LẦN 2

Phản hồi của sinh viên về việc hợp tác sau Vòng 1 và gợi ý cho vòng 2	
Câu hỏi mở đầu	1. Nhớ lại một chút về thời điểm khi chúng ta bắt đầu khóa học cách đây 5 tuần. Ấn tượng của các bạn về khóa học này như thế nào? 2. Bạn có ấn tượng gì với phần 2 tuần chúng tôi chuẩn bị cho khóa học bằng cách giúp các bạn làm quen với việc hợp tác viết chung 1 bài trong khi viết và quen với wikis?
Các câu hỏi chính	3. Các buổi thảo luận trực tiếp với bạn cùng nhóm trên lớp đã thúc đẩy bạn tham gia vào quá trình viết như thế nào?
	4. Việc sử dụng wikis đã thúc đẩy bạn tham gia vào quá trình viết như thế nào?
	5. Giai đoạn nào trong quá trình viết (trước khi viết, viết nháp, nhận xét/ gợi ý, sửa bài và đăng bài) có thể thúc đẩy bạn tham gia vào quá trình viết hiệu quả nhất?
	6. Bạn có gặp khó khăn gì về phía chính bản thân mình, thành viên cùng nhóm, giáo viên, kỹ năng hợp tác khi tham gia học Viết trong nhóm với các thành viên trong nhóm?
	7. Gợi ý của bạn cho việc học những bài viết sắp tới?
Câu hỏi kết thúc	8. Để các giờ học tới có hiệu quả hơn, bạn có gợi ý gì đối với giáo viên dạy? Bạn còn mong muốn gì đối với khóa học mà bạn chưa đề cập tới?

Appendix 7
THIRD FOCUS-GROUP INTERVIEW WITH THE STUDENTS

Students' reflections on the entire writing project	
Opening questions	1. Now when you finished the project, what were your impressions? How different were they compared to yours of the middle of the project?
Key questions	2. What was particular effectiveness of collaboration through face-to-face and wiki modes to your participation in L2 writing? What strategies including pre-writing, drafting, feedback, revision, and publishing could enhance your participation most? 3. Are your writing strategies any different because you attended in this project? If so, what stages had you done for your writing before and after the project? 4. Can you list any difficulty relating to yourself, your peers, the teacher/instructor, collaborative techniques that you met when collaborating? 5. You may become teachers of writing after your graduation, will you use or suggest the project to your future students? Why or why not?
Ending questions	6. What advice to the teacher would you like to give to improve future projects? 7. To evaluate the project, is there anything that we missed? Is there anything you came wanting to say that you didn't get a chance to say?

PHỎNG VẤN NHÓM VỚI SINH VIÊN LẦN 3

Câu hỏi phản hồi của sinh viên về toàn bộ khóa học	
Opening questions	1. Khóa học của chúng ta đã kết thúc. Bạn có ấn tượng gì về cả 8 tuần của khóa học không ví dụ với phần viết luận so sánh đối chiếu hoặc phần nghị luận?
Key questions	2. Các buổi thảo luận trực tiếp và qua wikis giúp bạn như thế nào trong giai đoạn trước khi viết? Bạn tham gia chủ động hay bị động trong các buổi này? Bạn thích các buổi thảo luận trực tiếp/ qua wikis này không? Tại sao có hoặc tại sao không? 3. Cách thức viết của bạn có gì thay đổi sau khi bạn tham dự vào khóa học này không? Nếu có, trước đây khi viết bạn thường làm gì và sau khóa học này bạn sẽ tiến hành cách thức viết như thế nào? 4. Bạn có gặp khó khăn gì liên quan đến chính bản thân bạn, bạn cùng nhóm, giáo viên hướng dẫn, các kỹ năng hợp tác khi viết và kỹ năng sử dụng wikis? 5. Sau khi tốt nghiệp bạn có thể trở thành giáo viên dạy tiếng Anh, bạn có định sử dụng hình thức hợp tác trong quá trình học cho học sinh của mình không? Tại sao bạn sẽ sử dụng hoặc tại sao bạn không sử dụng?
Ending questions	6. Bạn có gợi ý gì đối với giáo viên để các khóa học thông qua hình thức hợp tác như thế này có thể thành công ở Khoa chúng ta? 7. Đánh giá tổng quát khóa học, có điều gì mà khóa học chưa đáp ứng được so với yêu cầu và mong đợi của bạn không? Các bạn còn điều gì muốn bổ xung thêm cho cuộc phỏng vấn này không?

Appendix 8

REFLECTION SURVEY AFTER THE WRITING PROJECT

The purpose of this survey is to gather information about your reflections after you attended the collaborative writing project. Please tick or answer the following questions.

I. How effective was each stage to your writing? Please tick the degree that suits you

Stages	Degree of efficiency				
	Very effective	Effective	Not very effective	Hardly effective	Not effective at all
Pre-writing					
Drafting					
Feedback					
Revision					
Publishing					

Please explain

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II. Difficulties that students met during the stages of L2 process writing

Please advise in the space provided what difficulties you met during each stage of writing

1. Pre-writing stage difficulties

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2. Drafting stage difficulties

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3. Feedback stage difficulties

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4. Revision stage difficulties

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5. Publishing stage difficulties

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III. Your suggestions for each stage of collaborative writing

Please advise in the space provided the suggestions you want to make for improvements of future projects

1. Pre-writing stage suggestions

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2. Drafting stage suggestions

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3. Feedback stage suggestions

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4. Revision stage suggestions

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5. Publishing stage suggestions

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IV. Overall evaluation

Please evaluate the project by ticking the option that suits you

This project

Very successful	Successful	Not very successful	Hardly successful	Failed

Should our Faculty arrange future project like this project?

Yes, without any changes	Yes, with minor changes	Yes, with major changes	No	Absolutely no

Thank you for your cooperation

PHẢN HỒI CỦA SINH VIÊN SAU KHÓA HỌC

Mục đích của khảo sát này nhằm thu thập phản hồi của bạn sau khi đã tham dự khóa học tiếng Anh bằng phương pháp hợp tác và sử dụng wikis. Bạn hãy chọn hoặc trả lời các câu hỏi sau.

I. Mỗi giai đoạn trong quá trình viết có hiệu quả như thế nào đối với kỹ năng viết của bạn. Hãy chọn mức độ phù hợp với bạn.

Giai đoạn	Mức độ hiệu quả				
	Rất hiệu quả	Hiệu quả	Không hiệu quả lắm	Hầu như không có hiệu quả	Hoàn toàn không hiệu quả
Trước khi viết					
Viết nháp					
Nhận xét					
Sửa bài					
Đăng bài					

Bạn hãy giải thích lựa chọn của mình

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II. Khó khăn mà bạn gặp phải trong mỗi giai đoạn viết hợp tác

Xin hãy cho chúng tôi biết khó khăn mà bạn gặp phải trong từng giai đoạn viết bằng cách trả lời vào chỗ trống dưới đây.

1. Giai đoạn trước khi viết

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2. Giai đoạn viết nháp

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3. Giai đoạn nhận xét, góp ý

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4. Giai đoạn sửa bài dựa trên góp ý

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5. Giai đoạn đăng bài của cả nhóm

III. Gợi ý của bạn cho từng giai đoạn của quá trình viết tiếng Anh

Xin hãy cho chúng tôi biết gợi ý của bạn cho từng giai đoạn viết bằng cách trả lời vào chỗ trống dưới đây.

1. Gợi ý cho giai đoạn trước khi viết

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2. Gợi ý cho giai đoạn viết nháp

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3. Gợi ý cho giai đoạn nhận xét, góp ý

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4. Gợi ý cho giai đoạn sửa bài dựa trên góp ý

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5. Gợi ý cho giai đoạn đăng bài của cả nhóm

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IV. Đánh giá khóa học

Xin hãy cho biết đánh giá của bạn về khóa học bằng cách đánh dấu vào lựa chọn phù hợp với bạn.

Khóa học này

Rất thành công	Thành công	Không thành công lắm	Gần như không thành công	Hoàn toàn không thành công

Khoa Ngoại ngữ của chúng ta có nên tổ chức các khóa học tương tự như khóa học này trong tương lai?

Nên, và không cần thay đổi gì	Nên với một số thay đổi nhỏ	Nên, với thay đổi đáng kể	Không nên	Hoàn toàn không nên

Thank you for your cooperation

Appendix 9
**SAMPLE ESSAYS AND QUESTIONS TO DISCUSS IN THE PRE-
WRITING STAGE OF ARGUMENT ESSAY**

After read the 3 sample essays below carefully, please discuss in your group the following questions (in about 20 minutes)

1. What is an argument essay?
2. What are the social purposes of each essay: to inform, persuade, entertain, criticize or so on?
3. Who are the potential readers of each essay: customers, producers, workers, students, teachers or so on?
4. What are the main ideas of each essay?
5. How did the writer develop his/her essay?
5. What are the differences among the three sample essays?
6. What are the typical words, structures, grammar, linking words of the argument essay?

ESSAY 1

Some people may think that radio has become out-of-date, and there is no need to listen to the radio for entertainment and news. Do you agree or disagree?

In the past, radio broadcasting was deemed as the most convenient and important resource of information. However, with the emergence of other mass media, there is a perception that radio as a medium will be at stake in the future if it does not undergo any significant change. ***In my opinion, such pessimism is ungrounded.***

One of the main reasons why radio would not become obsolete in the near future is that driving is rife across the world as a way of life. Radio is a regular piece of equipment installed in a car, and to car users, listening to the radio while driving is an effective means of taking full advantage of their time and gathering the latest information, such as news, weather forecast, share markets, and so forth. Increased car use gives radio high mobility and its exposure continues to lead other media. For those people who have no time in watching TV, radio provides immediate and easy access to information. Its continued popularity is also linked to its high affordability. Radio broadcasting is, in general, accessible to the audience with charging no fee.

The advent of other technologies has also sustained the popularity of radio. For example, people can get radio via satellite, the Internet and cable nowadays. There are many other electronic devices such as MP3 and MP4 players, which allow people to listen to the radio more easily and to use it for various entertainments, such as sharing their music collections. Although radio is unable to convey messages with sight and motion as television or Internet does, the improvement in those hi-tech devices will ensure that the radio is able to serve the needs of audiences as it always did.

As indicated above, radio broadcasting has many advantages that are scarcely found in other mass media, either electronic or print. With the developments in technology that enable radio to perform more functions and become more widely available, radio broadcasting will continue to form a very large segment of the mass media.

ESSAY 2

Some people think that schools should select students according to their academic abilities, while others believe that it is better to have students with different abilities studying together. Discuss both views and state your own opinion.

Some people contend that mixed ability classes are more beneficial for children's development than streaming them on the basis of judgment about their academic abilities. **However, from my perspective, I disagree with this contention.**

Admittedly, mixed ability classes provide a better environment for children's all-round development. In such classes, children with different abilities study together and in turn they can learn from one another. For example, a student, who is good at academic study but weak in dancing or painting, can learn how to dance or paint from his peers. In this sense, mixed ability classes allow students to develop their abilities in different subjects instead of only academic abilities.

Despite the argument above, **I believe streaming students brings more benefits to teachers and students.** As for teachers, separating children with better academic abilities from others facilitates effective teaching. This practice helps teachers to control their students more conveniently and easily. Compared with mixed ability in which teacher should consider students' differences when they are using teaching methodologies, streaming makes this situation simpler. To be more specific, students are at the same level of academic ability in a class, and in turn teachers can use the same methodologies for them all. In this way, the narrower the spread of ability in the class, the more convenient the teaching can be.

On top of this, **streaming enables students to learn in an effective way.** According to students' different abilities, they are taught in different ways that are more suitable for them. In the top streams, students use more difficult materials, therefore, they can learn more. In sharp contrast, teachers can explain the material more slowly to those in bottom streams. Under this circumstance, students with different academic abilities can study effectively and efficiently.

In the final analysis, mixed ability classes are beneficial for students' versatile development, but in my opinion, segregating students based on different academic ability is better for both teachers and students.

ESSAY 3

It is said that the fast pace of our everyday life, as a direct result of the rapid development of telecommunications technology and travel industry, has negative effects on individuals, nations and the globe. To what extent do you agree or disagree?

Not surprisingly, many aspects of people's daily lives have undergone considerable changes because of the recent development in technology. It is a particular concern that the pace of everyday life is becoming faster, resulting from the development in cars, air travel, telecommunications technology and the Internet. ***As well as benefits, this trend is to bring problems.***

On the positive side, the fast rhythm of life requires people to enhance efficiency when working and then allows them to enjoy longer leisure time. With the advance in telecommunications, people can make inquire by phone, instead of travelling long distances. Internet access makes it possible for one to perform various tasks without leaving their offices. Even though people have to travel every now and then for meeting business partners, visiting clients in other cities or other purposes, modern transport networks reduce the amount of time they spend on commutes.

The acceleration of the pace of life also implies the expansion of people's circle. In the past, social relationships were limited by physical factors such as geographical distance and low mobility but nowadays, one can travel further and get acquainted with more people with those technological advances, such as railroad, the automobile and the telephone. For instance, the rapid penetration of telecommunications technology has made the mobile phone a key social tool and people rely on their mobile phone address book to keep in touch with their friends.

On the negative side, the fast-paced lifestyle is responsible for the upsurge in lifestyle-related problems. Jobs become demanding and require workers' full commitment, resulting in their depression and pressure. Underneath the façade of continued contraction of official working hours, employees are actually working longer, primarily because fax, e-mail or other communication devices have made them accessible to their supervisors, colleagues and customers after work. They have to respond instantly to voice and email messages from others. Private life has to be scarified.

According to the facts outlined above, the doubts about the negative effects of the acceleration of pace of life are not well-grounded. People now enjoy greater well-being, which is reflected in more quality family time, less travel-related stress and close contact with friends and family members. However, they might have to accept frequent intrusions as a by-product of convenient communication.

Appendix 10

TOPICS FOR ARGUMENT ESSAY WRITING

Group 1: The National Defense Department of Vietnam has proposed a law that all male students must do the military services before they enter university. What are your opinions?

Group 2: Teacher training time should last for 5 years instead of 4 years. Do you agree or disagree?

Group 3: To solve the problem of traffic jams, the Department of Traffic and Transport has proposed that vehicle users must show proofs that they are owners of the vehicles; otherwise they will be fined. What are your opinions on this proposal?

Group 4: There is a debate among parents whose children are going to primary school. Some parents support that their children learn how to read and write at pre-schools. Others strongly disagree. What are your opinions?

Group 5: A Vietnamese boy of seven years old in a TV interview said that he did not want to watch cartoons because “cartoons are worms which may destroy our souls”. To what extent do you agree with him?

Group 6: “No money, no honey”. To what extent do you agree with the saying?

Appendix 11
AN EXAMPLE OF THE TRANSLATION

(FIRST FOCUS GROUP INTERVIEW WITH THE STUDENTS)

Vietnamese	English
Câu hỏi 1: Em thường học tiếng Anh như thế nào?	Question 1: How do you often learn L2 writing?
Sinh viên 1: Trước giờ lên lớp bọn em có được cho tài liệu môn Viết, em sẽ đọc qua tài liệu, xem phần lý thuyết và phần bài tập. Sau đó tìm hiểu những ý tưởng, hoặc những thứ mình cần cho một chủ đề mà mình sẽ học. Trong giờ lên lớp giáo viên sẽ trình bày phần lý thuyết, giảng phần lý thuyết và đưa ra bài tập. Em nghe giảng và phát biểu ý kiến và đưa ra những ý kiến của mình về topic hoặc phần mình đã học.	Participant 1: Before we start writing lessons at class, we will be given the learning materials. I will read through them, look at the theory and exercises. Then I will get some ideas relating to the coming lessons. At class, teachers will present, give us some exercises. I listen to the teachers' presentation and discuss what I understand about the topics or what I have read.
Sinh viên 2: Thường thì trước giờ lên lớp em sẽ đọc qua tài liệu mà giáo viên phát. Trong giờ lên lớp tập trung vào phần ví dụ của cô thì sẽ dễ làm hơn. Những phần nào cô giảng mà không có trong phần tài liệu thì ghi chép lại. Còn sau giờ lên lớp thì có thể tìm hiểu thêm sách hoặc tìm hiểu thêm về những chủ đề mà cô giao cho về nhà	Participant 2: Before class hours, I will read what teachers have given us. During class hours, I listen to teachers' examples, which makes me understand lessons more quickly. What the teachers present, but is not included in the learning materials, I will take notes. After class hours, I will search more materials relating to the topics that the teachers assign as homework.

Sinh viên 3: Trước giờ lên lớp nếu có thời gian thì cô sẽ phô tô tài liệu liên quan đến chủ đề Viết mà mình sẽ học. Em sẽ nghiên cứu tài liệu đó. Trong giờ lên lớp cô giảng lý thuyết bằng cách sử dụng slides về lý thuyết. Cô cũng cho thêm 1 số bài tập liên quan đến chủ đề hôm đó. Có thể làm luôn tại lớp và cô sẽ chữa cho một số bạn làm mẫu cho cả lớp. Năm nay môn Viết cô đã phô tô ra thành quyển, sẽ chi tiết hơn. Lên lớp bài giảng của cô cũng chi tiết hơn.	Participant 3: Before class hours, if teachers have time, they will give us learning materials. I will read them. During class hours, teachers will present with slides. They also give us some exercises. We can do exercises at class or at home. Teachers will give feedback on some of our work. This year, my teacher gave us a book with reference materials, which makes it more detailed. And in the lesson, the teacher's presentation was more detailed too.
Sinh viên 4: Trước giờ lên lớp cô thường phát tài liệu như thế thì em sẽ đọc tài liệu để hiểu rõ hơn. Ngoài tài liệu cô phát em còn tra cứu tài liệu trên mạng để lấy thêm thông tin để mình có thêm ý xong rồi chuẩn bị bài trước. Trong giờ lên lớp thông qua việc cô chiếu slides trên máy chiếu, cô lấy ví dụ cụ thể để chúng em có thể hiểu rõ hơn và sau khi học lý thuyết xong rồi thì cô sẽ đưa ra các bài tập và cô chữa cho một số bạn lên để làm. Từ đó mình tự sửa cho bài của mình.	Participant 4: The good thing about teachers giving us learning materials before class hours is that we have more time to learn about the topics. Besides the materials that the teachers give us, I search the references in internet to get more ideas about the topics before class time. During class hours, the teacher present with slides. She gives us specific examples so that we can understand the lessons more. After her presentation, she asks us to do exercises and give feedback on some students' writing. I can learn from her feedback.
Sinh viên 5: Theo lý thuyết của các bạn là như thế, nhưng em thì thường không chú ý đến việc học môn Viết trước khi lên lớp lắm. Trước khi lên lớp em biết cô sẽ giảng bài tiếp theo nhưng em không chú ý đến việc tìm tài liệu liên quan đến chủ đề đấy hoặc topic đấy. Khi lên lớp cô cho chúng em một số lý thuyết cơ bản về môn Viết và một số topic để viết. Khi cô cho topic để viết em tập trung vào viết theo yêu cầu của cô. Khi gặp khó khăn trong từ vựng hoặc tìm ý, em sẽ hỏi các bạn bên cạnh xong rồi viết. Em cũng thường viết mẫu để cho cô sửa, em thấy cái bước viết mẫu rồi để cho cô sửa giúp em rất	Participant 5: In theory, I will do as what my friends have said. However, in reality, I myself do not care as much as that. Before class hours, I do not read the references that the teacher has given us. At class, the teacher will present and give us some topics to write. I will do what she asks. When I have difficulties with vocabulary or ideas, I will ask my friends for help. I often ask my teacher to feedback on my writing. I think her feedback on my writing is very useful: I can identify what mistakes I often make are. At home, I often do homework but it is not really helpful because no one helps me to

nhiều. Tại vì khi cô giáo sửa xong em nhớ được là em sai những cái gì và em cảm thấy bài của em đúng theo ý của cô giáo hơn và đúng với mẫu của một bài essay hoặc đúng với lý thuyết hơn. Sau khi về nhà em cũng chữa bài tập nhưng việc này không hiệu quả lắm vì chữa bài tập xong không có ai sửa nên cũng không biết có tốt không.	look at it. Thus I do not know if my writing is good or not.
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Appendix 12
AN EXAMPLE OF STUDENTS' INCONSISTENCY IN FOLLOWING
THE OUTLINES

SHOULD TEACHER TRAINING TIME INCREASE TO 5 YEARS?	
National education is always one of the most important matters which is [are] concerned by many people, especially the Ministry of Education. There are lots of difficult problems they need to solve. Recently, there is a question given for universities: should teacher training last for 4 years instead of 5 years? Some people think that it should be done in the future while others prefer it is still fixed as now. I have every reason to think that teacher training should last for 4 years as followed.	Introductory paragraph
The first thing I want to mention is that there is little evidence to show that the longer time we study, the better quality we can get. As we can see, nowadays, students are permitted to do more courses per one semester, so they can finish their education in 2.5 or 3 years. In spite of this, they still get a nice transcript and have a good result while the others need 4 years to do the same thing. It shows that this is no matter how much time we spend on studying, the essential thing we need to know is how to take advantage of time to learn: 4 years or 5 years is just a number, it does not tell us anything. Even you have a long time to learn but if you don't have a positive learning attitude or an orientation, you cannot be able to study well. Therefore, the time is not the only one which decides the quality of the education, the most important thing is the effort of a student.	Against point 1
I think so teacher should not training time last for 5 years instead of 4 years. This is a very waste of time and money. In a year, we have many opportunities for work. Many poor families are not enough to money for their children studying. With 5 years learn, we effortless and overwhelmed with the amount of knowledge students. Teachers can reduce overload, because of the current overload of lectures and students. With 4 years learn, we can get acquainted with the job sooner and more a year experience work. Learn 4 years will reduce learning time and can participate higher education programmes such as graduate, doctoral and masters.....	Against point 2
<u>On the other hand</u> , increasing the teachers' training time up 5 years will contribute to improve the quality of students who can meet requirements of the education sector today. We can see that, part of student teaching after graduating but pedagogical skills are still poor which means they will not have the opportunity to be a teacher. Moreover, in real-time vocational training college is too little, not enough to improve pedagogical skills for students. Although adding a year for the teacher's training has some benefits, results do not depend on the issue is long or short time but it depends on the effort of each student oneself and training programmes of the universities. Thus increasing the teachers' training time is not necessary.	Supporting point
As indicated above, increasing training time and knowledge is good, but in my opinion, there is absolutely no reason to be able to solve the quality of education. Because it is not	Concluding paragraph 360

necessary for students.	
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